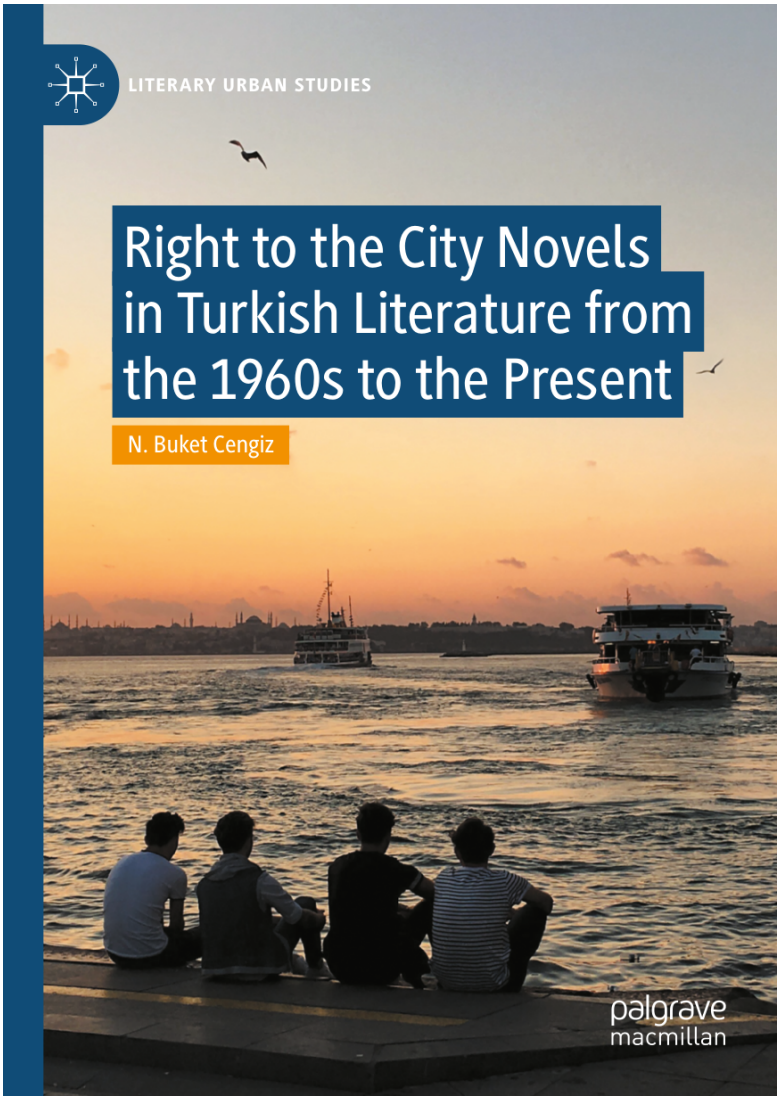
Right to the City Novels in Turkish Literature from the 1960s to the Present

N. Buket Cengiz

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N. Buket Cengiz

p. iii

Right to the City Novels in Turkish Literature from the 1960s to the Present

N. Buket Cengiz Kadir Has University Istanbul, Turkey

p. iv

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To all those who have nothing but their labour in their struggle in the big city

p. v

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p. vii

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Praise For Right to the City Novels in Turkish Literature from the 1960s to the Present

p. xi "The conceptualization of migration and urban integration as an interactive process between the real and the imagined would open up new channels of dialogue between cultural and literary studies and recent approaches to urban studies such as Assemblage and/or Actor Network Theory. On the other hand, the rich interpretive critical analysis and comparisons would produce useful insights and keywords for those who wish to study the same texts with the new tools of digital humanities such as text mining pattern recognition. *Right to the City Novels in Turkish Literature from the 1960s to the Present* will, in all likelihood, be an invaluable reference for all those students who wish to formulate new research questions in urban and cultural studies in general and in the field of migration studies in particular."

—Murat Güvenç, *Director of Istanbul Studies Center, Kadir Has University, Istanbul*

p. xi–xii "N. Buket Cengiz analyses, with refreshing clarity, the extremely dynamic, sophisticated, and impressive representations of rural to urban migrants in modern Turkish novel. The narratological close readings of seven novels, published between the 1960s and 2000s, are enriched with an interpretation based on associations with sociology, political science, history, and urban studies of modern Turkey. Cengiz's clever and satisfying work shows that novelists are not content with simply observing the challenging adventures of rural migrants in Istanbul and representing their experiences in fiction. These novelists also introduce opportunities to millions of citizens, mostly children or grandchildren of these migrants, to seek the possibilities of a more democratic and sharing urban existence. With her book, N. Buket Cengiz offers a qualified interdisciplinary work stemming from literary studies, and invites her readers to imagine a different and liveable city."

p. xii —Erol Köroğlu, *Associate Professor, Department of Turkish Language and Literature, Bosporus University, Istanbul*

Contents

p. xiii **1 Introduction: Right to the City Novels in Modern Turkish Fiction** 1

The Right to the City 5

Right to the City Novels 7

Objectives of the Book 10

The Methodology 13

Organisation of the Book 14

Explanation of the Quotations from Novels 17

Bibliography 19
2 From the Barricades to the City as Art: The Concept of the Right to the City 23
Paris After Haussman 23
The Flâneur 26
Alienation in the Metropolis 27
The Right to the City 31
Citizenship in the Urban Context 37
Bibliography 39
3 Passionate Belongings and Intense Longings: Tracing the Right to the City in Istanbul 43
Istanbul's Complex Phases 44
Urbanisation or Pseudo-Urbanisation? 46
Multiple Urbanities 48
Laying Claim to the City 53
Women: "The Locomotive of Migration" 56
Bibliography 61
4 Istanbul Meets Its New Members: An Overview of Istanbul's History as Regards Migration 65
The 1950s and the 1960s 66
The 1970s 68
The 1980s 69
The 1990s 70
The Late 1990s and the 2000s 74
The Year 2010 and After 77
Bibliography 78
5 Imagining the Migration Experience: A Humanist Approach 81
The Homesick Birds*: An Empathetic Look at the Urbanities of the Future* 81
The Tabula Rasa *Migrant* 86
The Gendered Portrayal of Migration 94
Conclusion 100
Uncle Halo and Two Oxen: A Sarcastic Look at Rural to Urban Migration and Its Discontents 103
'Citizens' Intimidated in the Public Realm 107
Conclusion 112
The Homesick Birds and Uncle Halo and Two Oxen: A Comparative Analysis 113
Bibliography 116
6 Insider's Knowledge: Survival in the Jungle of Istanbul 119
Berji Kristin: Tales from the Garbage Hills*: A Satirical Rebuttal to Normative Urbanity* 119
An Uneasy Encounter: Shanty Community vs the Radical Left 127
Who Is More the Migrant in the Struggle for Survival? 129
Conclusion 133
Heavy Roman(i)*: An Alternative Urbanity in the Dionysiac City* 134
Women of Kolera 139
Cosmopolitan Kolera 141
Conclusion 152

p. xiv

p. xv

Berji Kristin: Tales from the Garbage Hills *and* Heavy Roman(I)*: A Comparative Analysis* 153

Bibliography 159

7 Istanbul's Threshold: Alienation and the Experience of the Periphery 163

On the Periphery*: Existence in the Grim City* 163

The Other Istanbul 168

Life in Taşlıbağ 170

Idling in the City 174

Conclusion 181

It Takes All Kinds*: The Istanbul Forgotten in the* 'Varoş' 183

Urbanity Through Consumption 186

Identifying Kozluk 189

Conclusion 196

On the Periphery *and* It Takes All Kinds*: A Comparative Analysis* 198

Bibliography 203

8 Changing Migrants, Transforming Istanbul: *A Strangeness in My Mind* as a Love Story of a Man and His City 205

Mevlut's Endless Walks 208

A Home in the City 210

Stigmatised Neighbourhoods: Between Fiction and Factuality 212

Men and Women in the City 217

Conclusion 219

Bibliography 225

9 Conclusion: Reading the Right to the City Novels in a New Istanbul 227

Bibliography 238

Index 241

Abbreviations

p. xvii

Birds The Homesick Birds (Gurbet Kuşları)

Hills Berji Kristin: Tales From the Garbage Hills (Berci Kristin Çöp Masalları)

Kinds It Takes All Kinds (İnsan Kısım Kısım, Yer Damar Damar)

Oxen Uncle Halo and Two Oxen (Halo Dayı ve İki Öküz)

Periphery On the Periphery (Kenarda)

Roman(i) Heavy Roman(i) (Ağır Roman)

Strangeness A Strangeness in My Mind (Kafamda Bir Tuhaflık)

CHAPTER 1 Introduction: Right to the City Novels in Modern Turkish Fiction

It was in the autumn of 2010 that I conceived the idea for this book: in the last quarter of the year in which Istanbul was a European Capital of Culture (ECoC). The city was hosting many special events: concerts, exhibitions, film screenings, panel discussions and so on. From outside, everything looked great: Istanbul ECoC-2010 seemed to be in perfect harmony with the city's rising international popularity. Meanwhile, there was another story in progress. While the rents and house prices kept increasing in a rapidly gentrifying city centre, long-time residents were moving out of their homes, historic neighbourhoods such as Sulukule were losing all their identity, and the inhabitants of numerous other neighbourhoods were in anxious expectation of urban transformation projects. This made me think about those who were suffering the most because of the drastic changes occurring as Istanbul was competing in the race to become a global city; namely, the residents of poor neighbourhoods in the city centre, or in former shantytowns which were whetting the appetites of building contractors. p. 1

At the same time, beginning in the 1990s, I was observing the extremely popular nostalgia for a cosmopolitan Istanbul, though one which might be artificial and manufactured. In its adaptation by elitists, this nostalgia targeted rural migrants, with the message that Istanbul was once a much better place prior to their arrival, with a cosmopolitan population comprising a significant number of non-Muslim minorities. As this discourse ignored the fact that Istanbul had actually lost most of its minority population before the arrival of rural migrants in the 1950s, it created the illusion that the rural migrants had pushed them out to make space for themselves.[1] The elitist, anti-migrant adaptation of old Istanbul nostalgia blamed rural migrants for almost all the negative changes in the city, and viewed their presence as something they were in fact not entitled to. p. 1–2

İlay Örs uses "cosmopolitanist nostalgia" as "a generic term" for "the wide array of past-oriented discourses preoccupied with describing Istanbul as a cosmopolitan city" (2018b, 174). Writing in 2018, she explains that "cosmopolitanist nostalgia" starts with the 1980s and continues to exist (2018a, 82). She stresses that while "the new population of Istanbul is also highly varied, this is hardly considered to be a cosmopolitan situation" (2018b, 184). Örs aptly observes that: p. 2

> The new population of primarily "Anatolian," that is, of rural or Eastern background, is resisted to be included among the local Istanbulites; regardless of how many years they may have lived in the city, their inability to link themselves to any of the native communities casts a doubt as to their ability to become properly urban. In other terms, in the eyes of the urban elite upholding these nostalgic representations of the past, the newcomers may not belong to Istanbul for they do not know the ways of the City, they do not possess "cosmopolitan knowledge." (184)

Reflections of nostalgia for old Istanbul had a strong presence in popular culture and the publishing sector. Framed black-and-white photos of old Istanbul were sold everywhere; television dramas set in former minority neighbourhoods such as Çengelköy, Balat and Samatya were received with enthusiasm; books about the city's history as well as monographs on various neighbourhoods were published one after the other to the interest of readers; while eating habits in old Istanbul became an area of gastronomic interest in themselves.[2] Certainly, this is not to claim that all these cultural products adopted an elitist, anti-migrant discourse. We can rather argue that in the zeitgeist there was nostalgia, and some members of society responded to it with an elitist, anti-migrant attitude. p. 2–3

This elitist, anti-migrant attitude takes the form of an Istanbulite snobbism. As İpek Türeli aptly observes, the migrant is the person "in whose mirror image the Istanbulite was construed" (2018, 163). Some argue that, in order to be accepted as an Istanbulite, one's roots must go back seven generations in this city. Cem Behar, calculating the possibility of this mathematically, explains that "in today's Istanbul of ten million we can find around five hundred people 'who are seven generations Istanbulite'" (2009, 52). Indeed, "[Istanbul] is a city of immigrants, with three-quarters of its population born elsewhere" (Öncü 1999, 95), let alone seven generations of ancestors. Ayşe Öncü points out that "the question of who is an Istanbulite is a rhetorical question. A true Istanbulite is a 'myth'" (95). She stresses that "the mythology of an Istanbulite has lost its cultural moorings in the realm of taste and distinction emblematic of high culture, shorn of its connotations of belonging and authenticity. It merely negates and excludes. It thus operates at the level of the everyday, to cut and reshape the living texture of reality into a rigid dichotomy of Istanbulites and immigrants" (98). Below, I will briefly discuss this dichotomy through its central aspects. p. 3

As Murat Güvenç observes, the discourse criticising migrants and migration finds support among migrants as well (2009, 130). The current president of Turkey R. Tayyip Erdoğan, whose parents migrated to Istanbul from Rize, considered implementing an entry visa for Istanbul when he was its mayor (Erdoğan 2013). In a similarly confusing manner, such an exclusionary discourse may also come from the Left. Oya Baydar's article entitled "Istanbul Defeated by the Other", which legitimises the otherisation of migrants in its very title, is a striking example. Baydar gives a

[1] 'Minority' and 'minorities' denote the non-Muslim minority population (i.e., Greeks, Armenians, and Jews).

[2] The following television dramas are worthy of mention: set in Çengelköy: *Süper Baba* (*Super Daddy*) (1993–1997, Dir. Osman Sınav); set in Balat: *Yeditepe İstanbul* (*Seven Hills Istanbul*) (2001–2002, Dir. Türkan Derya); set in Samatya: *İkinci Bahar* (*The Second Spring*) (1998–2001, Dirs Uğur Yücel, Orhan Oğuz and Türkan Derya).

chronicle of rural–urban migration in this article, in addition to urban planning problems deriving from inefficient governance and planning, and concludes that "in the Istanbul of 1997 the principal contradiction is not the class conflict but a cultural conflict in the widest sense" (1997, 79). In Baydar's extremely dichotomous approach, the cultural conflict is obviously between the culture of 'Istanbulites' and 'non-Istanbulites'.

p. 3–4 Jean-François Pérouse explicates this dichotomy between Istanbulites and migrants as follows: "most of the research on Istanbul is extremely selective and thus concealing. These works are fond of persons who lived in the past and empty buildings, and they attack the ugly, contemporary Istanbul which is full of 'rude' people" (2011, 21). Pérouse points out that an inclusive approach to migrants is missing in academic studies (21). So, it comes as no surprise that this is the case in public opinion and discourse as well.

p. 4 Leyla Neyzi also draws attention to the fact that "Istanbul has always been a city of migrants" (2009, 80) and stresses that "'being an old Istanbulite' signifies a culture and life style rather than the time passed in Istanbul" (82). While being an old Istanbulite might be reserved as a signifier for an elite way of life, being an Istanbulite should be enlarged in such a way that it encompasses all the inhabitants of the city. As Sema Erder points out, those who came to Istanbul from other cities of Turkey with their savings and skills and who now live in the city centre have smoothly integrated into the city, and became Istanbulites (2015, 238–240). Since old Istanbulites were never that visible in the city, these migrants soon stopped feeling themselves to be the provincials of Istanbul (240). She adds that "the old Istanbulite is only a historical figure for them. Or she/he is an awkward master who they indirectly hear about from those who have actually had the chance to meet her/him. Today, for them an Istanbulite is anyone who lives, works in this city" (240).

Erder continues by observing that rural migrants and the poor had a very different story from those who came with their savings and skills. Although the former, according to Erder, most of whom lived in shanties, were excluded in the past, today "they have become an important aspect of the city by all means" (2015, 242). Describing them as "those who look at Istanbul from the periphery" (243), she adds: "it can be understood that they do not feel like strangers in the city but they do not see themselves as Istanbulites yet, however, there is no Istanbulite which they perceive as a concrete reality" (243).

p. 4–5 The *My City Istanbul* (*Kentim İstanbul*) project launched in 2003 by the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality is worthy of notice at this point. "During the project, the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality [...] organised sightseeing tours, coffeehouse talks, seminars, panels, and innumerable billboards, books and booklets" (Özbey 2004). As part of the project, photos of famous figures residing in Istanbul but born elsewhere were presented on billboards in the city with the following slogan: "I am an Istanbulite" ("Ben İstanbulluyum") (ibid.). The objectives of the project were "to ensure that inhabitants of Istanbul, feeling a sense of belonging to Istanbul inherit its enormous cultural heritage, [...] lay claim to it, and represent the city while defining themselves with it" (Genar). Related to the project, surveys were made on "urban culture and consciousness of urbanity" (ibid.) which revealed that the number of city inhabitants defining themselves as an Istanbulite was quite low (Özbey 2004; IKSV 2005). Savaş Özbey points out that the project which started ambitiously soon lost its charm, and the tender was not renewed for 2004, and adds: "maybe the starting point of the project was erroneous, more emphasis should have been placed on *the mutual points*, a definition of Istanbulite should have been made based on what is being *shared in this place*" (2004).[3] Similarly, Pérouse argues that, given the social reality of Istanbul, in order to be functional this project should have been designed in such a way that it could bring forth a concept such as: "I am an Istanbulite and a Sivasite; I am an Istanbulite and a Mardinite and so forth" (pers. comm., 8 December 2011). Pérouse's words are inspiring for envisioning an urban identity that overcomes the dichotomy between Istanbulites and migrants. With such an approach, this dichotomy can be challenged, and a more productive discussion can be made around the notion of urbanity with differences, and the possibility of multiple urbanities. Those who do not define themselves as Istanbulites today might be induced to do so in this way. However, they need to be welcomed and embraced by those who look at Istanbul from the centre. As Erder summarises in the most lucid way: "those who see themselves as Istanbulites [...] maybe should give up searching for the nostalgic Istanbulite or one type of Istanbulite from now on and learn to enjoy the variety in Istanbul" (2015, 244). Erder's words bring to mind Richard Sennett, who points out that "society gains equally when people's experience is not limited just to those who resemble them in class, race, or ways of life. Sameness stultifies the mind, diversity stimulates and expands it" (2005, 114).

The Right to the City

p. 5–6 Thus, I decided to analyse these two ongoing phenomena by employing the concept of the right to the city, at the core of which lies a strong reaction against the idea of the city as an exchange value: the anti-migrant discourse of evaluating people's 'eligibility' to live in Istanbul, and the harsh gentrification process threatening a large number of inhabitants in the city.

[3] Both emphases added.

Henri Lefebvre developed the concept of the right to the city in “his first major, and highly polemical book on the city, *Le droit à la ville*, completed in 1967 to commemorate the centenary of the publication of Marx’s *Capital*, and which came out before the events of 1968” (Kofman and Lebas 1996, 6). Lefebvre explains that in cities, in addition to wealth, “knowledge (connaissances), techniques, and oeuvres (works of art, monuments)” are accumulated (1996b, 66). He conceptualises the distinction between “*use value* (the city and urban life) and *exchange value* (spaces bought and sold, the consumption of products, goods, places and signs)” (1996b, 86). The city as *oeuvre* is based on its use value, it is not a product based on exchange value, because “the eminent use of the city, that is, of its streets and squares, edifices and monuments” is not based on production but on pleasure and prestige (66). If we can rescue the city from being a commodity, then we can secure our right to the city, which Lefebvre describes as “a transformed and renewed right to urban life” (158). p. 6

The city as *oeuvre* presents us with the opportunity of experiencing our daily lives as the art of living in the urban context. As Klaus Ronneberger observes, “Lefebvre envisioned the emergence of a new revolutionary subject that would revolt not only against the exploitation of labor-power but against the destruction of its entire living environment” (2008, 135). Lefebvre emphasises that “in the urban context, struggles between fractions, groups and classes strengthen the feeling of belonging” (1996b, 67). He clarifies that “isolated from the city, the proletariat will end its sense of the oeuvre”, thus “urban consciousness will vanish” (77).

Lefebvre explains that to inhabit means “to take part in social life” (1996b, 76) and draws attention to the distinction between “*to inhabit*” and “*habitat*” (79). As Merrifield acknowledges, inhabiting means “a richer gloss on city life, evoking urban living as becoming, as growing, as something dynamic and progressive” (2006, 68). Merrifield then continues to underline urban residents’ needs “of creative activity, for the *oeuvre* (not only of products and consumable material goods), of the need for information, symbolism, the imaginary and play” (147). This would then lead to the emergence of “a new humanism, a new praxis, another man, that of urban society” (150). The right to the city is much more than fulfilled material needs in the urban context. “The right to the city is far more than the individual liberty to access urban resources: it is a right to change ourselves by changing the city” (Harvey 2008, 23). Lefebvre describes the right to the city as “a superior form of rights: right to freedom, to individualization in socialization, to habitat and to inhabit” (1996b, 173). p. 6–7

Yet, none of these are possible if the material necessities are not met. As Peter Marcuse aptly puts it, the demand for the right to the city is “of those who are excluded” and “the aspiration is of those who are alienated” (2012, 31). That means “the cry is for the material necessities of life” while “the aspiration is for a broader right to what is necessary beyond the material to lead a satisfying life” (Marcuse 2012, 31). He explains that “the demand comes from those directly in want, directly oppressed, those for whom even their most immediate needs are not fulfilled: the homeless, the hungry, the imprisoned, the persecuted on gender, religious, racial grounds. It is a demand of those whose work injures their health, those whose income is below subsistence, those excluded from the benefits of urban life” (30–31). He adds that “those superficially integrated into the system and sharing in its material benefits” but unsatisfied in terms of their creative activity and social relationships are the alienated in the system (31). Therefore, “it is a combination of the deprived and the discontent who will lead the push for the right to the city” (33). Marcuse emphasises that the right to the city is “a right on a higher moral plane that demands a better system in which the potential benefits of an urban life can be fully and entirely realized” (34). p. 7

In this context, in the Istanbul of 2010, those who, in Erder’s words, were “looking at Istanbul from the periphery” (2015, 243), who were viewed by the elite as ineligible to live in the city, who had to face more and more challenges to survive in it, could simply be defined as the excluded in Peter Marcuse’s terms. So, who was speaking for them? This question started to occupy my mind. I knew that urban sociologists wrote extensively on them, but I wanted to discover where they were in cultural production, particularly in literature, my field of research.

Right to the City Novels

Amidst nostalgic novels, with their old Istanbulite characters and setting, I wondered about the migrants of Istanbul in modern Turkish fiction. Old Istanbul has always been a rewarding setting and subject for literature, and after the 1990s it became even more popular in that sense. There were numerous books with old Istanbulite characters and its setting. It would certainly not be fair to say that all novels with such characters and setting reflected nostalgia for old Istanbul; yet, some of them did, and interest in them was high. p. 7–8

Nostalgic novels are almost always set in historic former minority neighbourhoods, which is not surprising given the cosmopolitanist emphasis of old Istanbul nostalgia. While offering a list of these nostalgic novels is beyond the scope of this book, the following examples should give a general idea about them. *Bir Küçükburjuvanın Gençlik Yılları* (*The Adolescent Years of a Petit-Bourgeois*) (1979) by Demir Özlü takes place in the second half of the 1960s when rural migrants become more and more visible in the city; it is set in old and prestigious neighbourhoods once populated by minorities, such as Cihangir and Kadıköy. The protagonist is Selim, an Istanbulite petit bourgeois. There is nostalgia p. 8–9

in the book for the Istanbul of the times before the arrival of migrants. However, the narrator also praises the leftist potential of the migrant population. *Geçmiş, Bir Daha Geri Gelmeyecek Zamanlar* (*The Past, Times that Will Never Come Back*) by Selim İleri is a series comprising five novels set in similar neighbourhoods: Cihangir, Kadıköy, the Bosporus and the Princes' Islands. *Mavi Kanatlarınla Yalnız Benim Olsaydın* (*Only If You Were Mine with Your Blue Wings*) (1991) tells the stories of various Istanbulite characters living in the 1950s. *Gramofon Hâlâ Çalıyor* (*The Gramophone is Still Playing*) (1995) is another episodic novel about several Istanbulite characters, set in 1955–1960. *Cemil Şevket Bey*, *Aynalı Dolaba İki El Revolver* (*Mr Cemil Şevket, Two Revolver Shots at the Mirrored Cupboard*) (1997) tells the story of Mr Cemil Şevket, a gay writer, from the end of the Ottoman empire to after the 1980 military coup, through vignettes of Istanbul in those years. *Solmaz Hanım Kimsesiz Okurlar İçin* (*Ms Solmaz, for Solitary Readers*) (2000), with Ms Solmaz, one of the characters of *Mavi Kanatlarınla ...* as its protagonist, looks back at the Istanbul of 1920–1980. *Daha Dün* (*Only Yesterday*) (2008) is the final book of the series. In this novel, Istanbul from the 1800s to 1990s appears through the stories of the characters in the earlier four books. Buket Uzuner's *Kumral Ada Mavi Tuna* (*Blond Ada Blue Tuna*) (1997) is set in Kuzguncuk, a picturesque former minority neighbourhood on the Anatolian shore of the Bosporus. The protagonists are Tuna, Ada and Aras. Ada is a young Istanbulite girl who comes from an elite family. Tuna and Aras, who are brothers, can be regarded as second-generation migrants, as their father had migrated to Istanbul from Bulgaria, and their mother is from Iğdır, a city in Eastern Anatolia. Still, the novel is essentially about old Istanbulites.[4] *İstanbul Bir Masaldı* (*Istanbul Was a Fairy Tale*) (1999) by Mario Levi is set in various minority neighbourhoods of Istanbul and tells the stories of three generations of a Jewish family from the 1920s to the 1980s. In fact, Levi's position as regards nostalgia is ambivalent. In certain respects, as the very title of this novel implies, his tone can be nostalgic, but in other respects he tends to react to nostalgic discourse, particularly to the illusions it offers regarding the minority culture and history in the city.

p. 9 Looking at such novels with old Istanbulite protagonists set in old and prestigious neighbourhoods of the city, I started to wonder if the Turkish literary repertoire comprised significant novels with new Istanbulites—in other words, rural migrants—as their protagonists, set in new and unprestigious areas of the city, namely the shanty towns on its outskirts, or old but poor neighbourhoods with run-down apartments in the city centre. I wanted to track the ways the experiences of migrants building their shanties or renting these apartments entered literary fiction, from the beginning of rural migration to Istanbul up until the present time.

Thus evolved the central question of this book: similar to the ways nostalgic novels spotlighted old Istanbulites, were there novels spotlighting new Istanbulites? Just as the former were implying that Istanbul belonged to old Istanbulites, were there novels conveying the message that Istanbul belonged to anyone and everyone who chose to come and live in this city? In other words, were there novels depicting migrants in Istanbul in a way that is compatible with the concept of the right to the city?

If the answer to these questions was yes, then I wondered about the themes, as well as the formal and stylistic characteristics, of these novels. Did the authors of these novels portray migrants simply as peasants in the city, or as new urbanites? How did they depict migrants' strategies for survival? Did the authors illustrate their migrant characters as potential agents of change in the city for the better? In which parts of Istanbul were these novels set? What type of language and narrative strategies did the authors use?

p. 10 As I started my research, I found that there were novels addressing migrants' experiences in Istanbul in impressive ways. The authors of these works with migrant protagonists focused on various facets of the migration experience. These novels with migrant protagonists could be read as a reply to the nostalgic ones with old Istanbulite protagonists. In the way they encountered anti-migrant nostalgia I was able to find a message compatible with the concept of the right to the city. I decided to analyse a selection of these novels and demonstrate how and why they were harmonious with this concept. In these books I would be tracing, in Peter Marcuse's terms, the cry of the excluded in the urban setting. The right to the city does not mean a simple right to habitat, it means the right to inhabit the city. Yet, the protagonists of these novels were migrants whose right to the city as habitat itself was questioned. Thus, the legitimisation of migrants' existence in the city (i.e., their right to habitat) could be the first step in the fight for their right to the city, the next step being their right to inhabit the city. So, I categorised the works I chose as right to the city novels because of their overall message regarding migrants' presence in the city, their emphasis on the migrants' legitimate presence in the city. Within this legitimisation of the excluded in the city lies the potential of their right to the city in its fullest sense, no matter how utopian it seemed.

[4] In her novel entitled *Istanbullular* (*Istanbulites*) (2007), Buket Uzuner tells the intersecting stories of fifteen characters living in Istanbul. Presenting all these characters as Istanbulites regardless of their birthplace, Uzuner attempts to convey the message that all inhabitants of the city who appreciate its beauty and heritage are Istanbulites. However, due to the extremely stereotypical characterisations, she cannot succeed in reaching this objective.

Objectives of the Book

When we try to benefit from understanding the past in order to change the present for good, the amount of knowledge that works of culture and art can offer is absolutely enormous. Based on the cultural materialist framework, my analysis of the novels with migrant protagonists as a work on the literary, therefore cultural, output in Turkey could help us track the changing perceptions about migrants in the city, and discursive strategies about them, as art reflecting reality. It could also help us tackle the question of how influential these novels were on our perceptions about migrants in the city, as art mediating reality. p. 10

Raymond Williams, back in the 1970s, coined cultural materialism "as a theory of the specificities of material cultural and literary production within historical materialism" (1977, 5). John Higgins defines cultural materialism as "a concept deployed as a conscious alternative and direct challenge to the available Marxist formula" (1999, 41), a concept Williams developed to make a connection between the changes in drama "without recourse to the clumsy metaphor of 'base and superstructure'" (42). Andrew Milner explains that in developing this term Williams separated his route both "from an older tradition of British Communist Marxism" and from the "British version of literary humanism" led by F. R. Leavis (2002, 18). Put simply, Williams rejects the idea that cultural products, as accepted in the sphere of superstructure, are simple results of the base, and he argues that cultural products do not simply reflect reality but also mediate it. p. 10–11

Following Williams's formulation, I argue that, while historical developments in social, cultural and economic life find expression in the themes and formal features of novels dealing with migrants in Istanbul, the ways migrants appear in these works have, to a certain extent, an influence on society's ways of perceiving migrants and their right to the city. While I mainly focus on the former dimension, I also discuss the latter at various points, particularly in the Conclusion. In the present work, which is the first academic book addressing rural–urban migration in the context of the right to the city in literary analysis, departing from all these concerns and issues, I have pursued the following aims. p. 11

First, amidst the discussions on Istanbul as it is changing dramatically, employing the concept of the right to the city in the analysis of the city's representations in the selected novels, I aim to offer a fresh perspective on literary imagination as regards the city. I also hope that this book might motivate readers to move from the literary realm to the factual realm, analyse historical records about migrants' struggles and the stigmatised and/or gentrifying neighbourhoods they have been living in, and question the related clichés and stereotypes; hence its scope—starting from the 1950s and ending in the present day.

In this book, I situate the right to the city novels as a counterpoint to nostalgic Istanbul novels which I regard as a vein within the lineage of Istanbul novels. This can be helpful in making connections between novelists who would seem disparate on the surface, which would be a meaningful contribution to scholarship on the modern Turkish novel. I believe that this work might be relevant to scholars of other countries' fiction as they might find similar patterns in them.

As the population living in cities keeps increasing all around the world, urban life becomes a more and more significant subject in culture and literature. Consequently, analysing the ways urban life enter novels with endless themes, characters and settings reciprocally with evolving formal and stylistic elements is more necessary and meaningful for literary and cultural scholarship today than ever. Neither at the initial stage of my research nor to date have I come across analytical works on the Turkish novel with an interdisciplinary perspective at the junction of literary and urban studies, placing the concept of the right to the city at the centre of the argument. What we have is a limited number of works simply dealing with representations of migration and/or urbanisation in Turkish literature. These are either in the form of articles or unpublished dissertations and theses. Neither have I come across English language books on the connection between migration and the right to the city within the framework of the literature and culture of other countries. p. 11–12

Second, the need for unique paradigms and conceptual approaches in literary urban studies as an evolving subdiscipline was a concern for me in writing this book. Global(ising) cities around the world have a lot in common in terms of migration and urban transformation/gentrification processes they are experiencing. However, this should not lead us to overlook the fact that each city has its own dynamics based on its idiosyncrasies. Analyses of these dynamics within the framework of the literary output related with those cities is necessary for developing unique paradigms and conceptual approaches of literary urban studies. This book is one example of such an effort as I examine the experiences in Istanbul as a globalising city through the ways they enter literary fiction. The book thus fills a gap in the absence of works focusing on Turkish literature within an urban cultural context. p. 12

This approach that juxtaposes the philosophical concept of the right to the city with the nostalgia for old Istanbul can be seen to surpass the framework of internal migration to Istanbul and be adopted to different contexts: internal as well as international migration in other global(ising) cities. Even though it is internal migration I focus on in this book, the fact that "Istanbul has always been a city of migrants" (Neyzi 2009, 80) is at the core of my argument,

making my work relevant to international migration as well.[5] Additionally, the approach in this book can be adopted to cultural products other than literature, such as film; so, it can contribute to cultural studies on a broader level.

The Methodology

p. 13 In the following pages, I analyse seven novels from the modern Turkish literary repertoire. All these novels are set in Istanbul and their protagonists are rural migrants in this city. While I categorise them as right to the city novels in modern Turkish literature, I do not claim that they constitute a genre; instead, I identify them as a vein within the category of Istanbul novels. Again, I do not regard Istanbul novels as a genre here, but accept them as a long lineage of novels in which the city appears as more than just a setting and becomes an integral aspect of plot as well as of central themes. I identify the right to the city novels as a counterpoint to the nostalgic Istanbul novels.

The works I selected for the corpus belong to four eras: the 1960s and the 1970s; the 1980s and the 1990s; the 2000s; and 2010 and after. The authors address various themes including, but not limited to, migrants' urbanisation, their survival strategies and struggle against various exclusion mechanisms, life on the periphery, and the (im)possibility of inhabiting the city for migrants in these novels. In a topic like rural-urban migration, dramatic changes in gender roles also find a place among the authors' concerns. I closely examine themes connected with such changes within the analyses. I analyse and interpret all these themes reciprocally with the formal and stylistic features of the works. In other words, throughout the book I implement a contextual approach without sacrificing the formal dimension. Unlike some studies which adopt a contextual approach at the expense of textual analysis, I emphasise that content and form must be analysed through their reciprocity. In order to accomplish this goal, I implement concepts of narratology in the textual analysis.

p. 13–14 It should be noted that in this book I aim to identify examples of right to the city novels from various eras. Although not all novels set in Istanbul having migrant protagonists can de facto be defined as right to the city novels, I have found that such novels usually address the concept of the right to the city, particularly those where the migrant protagonist does not benefit from substantial savings and professional skills. As discussed above, Sema Erder aptly observes the differences between the two categories of migrants: on the one hand, those who migrate to the city with their savings and skills who can easily integrate into it; on the other hand, rural migrants and the poor who do not possess such savings and skills and look at the city "from the periphery" (2015, 238–243). The nostalgic discourse of longing for the past Istanbul targeted, as might be expected, poor rural migrants. To counter this tendency, I have chosen to focus on novels that foreground the point of view of the rural migrants, especially those with migrant protagonists who look at the city "from the periphery", to borrow Erder's words. Hopefully this book will make a contribution to showing that poor rural migrants have as much of a right to the city as other groups, and will inspire future studies on this question.

Organisation of the Book

p. 14 In Chapter 2 entitled "From the Barricades to the City as Art: The Concept of the Right to the City" I offer a summary of Henri Lefebvre's concept of the right to the city, locating it in historical context. I trace the process from the removal of the working class from central Paris in the nineteenth century to the figure of the *flâneur*; from there to Georg Simmel's discussions on modern urban life; then to the concept of alienation; and finally to the right to the city. Throughout the chapter, I place emphasis on the fact that the city Lefebvre envisions can only be possible with a break from the capitalist economic system.

In Chapter 3 entitled "Passionate Belongings and Intense Longings: Tracing the Right to the City in Istanbul" I analyse the connections between: the urbanisation process of Istanbul as a non-Western experience; industrialisation; mass rural migration to Istanbul that started in the 1950s; and the concomitant informality in housing and employment. I discuss the outcomes of these on the symbolic realm through the urban elite's discrimination against migrants. I also examine the resulting discourse of nostalgia for a semi-imaginary cosmopolitan Istanbul that views rural migrants as the cause of almost all the problems in the city, as well as the lives of rural migrants in shanty houses and their ways of laying claim to the city. Finally, I mention the gender dimension of migration briefly, particularly through women's perception of consumption as a way of urbanisation.

p. 14–15 In Chapter 4 entitled "Istanbul Meets Its New Members: An Overview of Istanbul's History as Regards Migration" I focus on the interrelated dynamics between the following phenomena: the divide between urbanites and rural migrants in the 1950s; economic and social developments influencing rural migrants' integration in the 1960s and the 1970s; the collapse of the radical left with the military coup in 1980; the Amnesty Acts of 1984–1987 that rendered it legitimate

[5] Turkey's role in hosting a substantial number of refugees is important in this sense. According to the UN Refugee Agency's October 2020 update, around "4 million Refugees and asylum-seekers in Turkey including over 3.6 million Syrian nationals and close to 330,000 registered refugees and asylum-seekers of other nationalities" are living in Turkey (UNHCR 2020, 1).

to build up to four-storey buildings on shanty land; the arrival of a substantial number of internally displaced Kurds in Istanbul from Eastern Turkey in the 1990s; the effects of globalisation, accelerating urban poverty and the rise of political Islam in the 1990s and the 2000s; urban transformation and gentrification; Istanbul 2010–European Capital of Culture; and major historical events that have had an impact on the city within the last decade.

Chapter 5 entitled "Imagining the Migration Experience: A Humanist Approach" comprises analyses of the first two novels in the corpus: Orhan Kemal's *The Homesick Birds*, published in 1962; and Muzaffer İzgü's *Uncle Halo and Two Oxen*, published in 1973. In the 1960s and 1970s, a humanistic view by an author who tackles the migration phenomenon from a distance is predominant. In my analysis of *Birds*, I focus on Kemal's progressivist stance about migrants' integration into urban life. Kemal expects migrants to become literate, claim class-consciousness and join the urban population in the ranks of the working class. The novel conveys a clear message on the side of migrants' right to the city as urbanites of the future and as legitimate members of urban society. When it comes to *Oxen*, a novel where the concept of the right to the city is developed through the wider perspective of citizenship rights, I explore how İzgü ridicules the discrepancy between the theory and the praxis of rights under legal citizenship to the extent that citizenship rights become an empty signifier: rights in the urban context and therefore the right to the city appear simply irrelevant within this context. I also discuss İzgü's approach to the urban–rural divide in his novel. The chapter ends with a comparison of the two novels where I argue that while Kemal focuses on the connection between internal migration, urbanisation and the development of the proletariat, İzgü's message is mainly about the ways peasants, particularly those from the east of Turkey, are isolated from the rest of the country: socially, culturally and economically. However, I observe that the two novels have a similar humanistic approach to the migrants in the city. p. 15

In Chapter 6 entitled "Insider's Knowledge: Survival in the Jungle of Istanbul" we have two novels by authors who migrated to Istanbul with their families as infants: Latife Tekin's *Berji Kristin: Tales from the Garbage Hills*, published in 1984; and Metin Kaçan's *Heavy Roman(i)*, published in 1990. In my analysis of the former, a work on an imaginary shanty town on the garbage heaps of an unidentified city which might be Istanbul, I discuss how Tekin, both with the content and the form of her novel, cunningly challenges a progressivist notion of urbanity dictated to migrants. I analyse how she uses an unnatural storyworld and elements of oral culture to put emphasis on migrants' folk culture, and her call for a celebration of alternative urban identities which incorporate this culture. In her novel, Tekin addresses the right to the city through migrants' struggle for basic material necessities. Analysing *Roman(i)*, I attempt to explicate how Kaçan demonstrates that 'non-Istanbulites' can inhabit the city in the Lefebvrian sense. In line with that, the concept of the right to the city enters this novel, which is set in an edgy, idiosyncratic poor neighbourhood at the centre of Istanbul, via the right to live in the city centre. I also argue that this novel proves how 'non-Istanbulites' can and do lay claim to the minority heritage from the hegemony of the elite. In the comparison of the two novels, both based on an insider's perspective, I emphasise that in their use of an authentic language by the narrator, in the former folk language and in the latter slang, both novels abolish the superiority of an urban narrator over migrant characters. However, I argue that, despite this similarity, they provide distinct messages on the struggle for the right to the city and the process of adopting an urban identity. p. 15–16

Chapter 7 entitled "Istanbul's Threshold: Alienation and the Experience of the Periphery" comprises the analyses of Ayhan Geçgin's *On the Periphery*, published in 2003; and Hatice Meryem's *It Takes All Kinds*, published in 2008. In my analysis of the former, I observe that Geçgin addresses the concept of the right to the city both in terms of material necessities and the need for opportunities for socialisation and recreation in the urban setting. I explain that in the novel, which is set in a neglected, grim, former shanty town, Geçgin illustrates how alienation and isolation in the metropolis are related with the lack of opportunities for migrants' social and cultural development. Imagery and atmosphere are the central formal elements Geçgin utilises as he depicts this depressing face of the city experienced by migrants living on the periphery. In my analysis of *Kinds*, a satirical novel addressing isolation among the bleak buildings of a former shanty town, I observe that themes directly related to the right to the city appear in terms of material necessities, particularly the services of the municipality and infrastructure. Another dimension of the right to the city theme in the novel is access, and the lack thereof, to recreational areas and opportunities. In her novel, Meryem intelligently illustrates how migrants, particularly migrant women, perceive consumption as a way of urbanisation, a point I pay due attention in my analysis of the novel. Here, I also argue that Meryem raises the possibility of perceiving the amorphous-looking former shanty towns dismissed as *varoş*, and their poor and mostly uneducated people, as untainted by the stigmatisation and humiliation that pervades public opinion. In the comparison of the two novels at the end of the chapter, I explain that both have periphery at their centre, as a theme and as a setting, therefore themes of alienation and isolation are central to both. p. 16

In Chapter 8 entitled "Changing Migrants, Transforming Istanbul: *A Strangeness in My Mind* as a Love Story of a Man and His City" I analyse Orhan Pamuk's *A Strangeness in My Mind*, published at the end of 2014. Here, I explore the concept of the right to the city as it appears within the theme of informality as a survival strategy of migrants. I also trace the Lefebvrian notion of the city as *oeuvre* in the novel by analysing its sophisticated protagonist Mevlut, for whom the jouissance of strolling through the city as he vends on the streets is more valuable than earning a living. I analyse the novel's message that the right to the city does not simply comprise material necessities, it also includes p. 16–17

the right to experience the city as *oeuvre*. Mevlut the ‘non-Istanbulite’ is in love with Istanbul; in his walks he is full of admiration for the beauty and heritage of the city. I argue that, by developing such a character, Pamuk contests the anti-migrant prejudice. I also point out that with this work Pamuk signals new directions for right to the city novels with themes such as Kurdish involuntary migration, urban poverty, the popularisation of Islamism, globalisation and international migrants in the city, and urban transformation.

p. 17 In the final chapter entitled “Conclusion: Reading the Right to the City Novels in a New Istanbul” I briefly compare the novels regarding their elaboration of the migrants’ legitimacy in the city theme, as this legitimacy is a prerequisite for their right to the city. I make this analysis over two axes. First, migrants’ urbanisation, since they are expected to adopt an urban identity and integrate into the city in certain ways in order to be regarded as a legitimate member of it. Second, their survival strategies which can either be informal strategies, political participation and clientelism, or urban movements. I observe that the novels realistically depict informality as the predominant one among these strategies. In this chapter, I also include a brief explanation on the ways the novels in the corpus influence the public perception of migrants.

Explanation of the Quotations from Novels

p. 17–19 I have translated all the excerpts from Turkish sources myself, including the novels, apart from *Hills* and *Strangeness*. While doing so I simply had the objective of rendering their content on the lexical level; I did not include the rural accents of protagonists in the translations. I regard the information I give on the style of the novels, explaining whether a rural accent is heard in characters’ speeches, as sufficient in this sense. The only exception to this is the two instances within the analysis of *Roman(i)*, where I signal the rural accent in brackets, as it determines the content of the conversation (Fig. 1.1).



p. 18

Fig. 1.1 Districts of Istanbul (*Source* Maximilian Dörrbecker (Chumwa), *Districts of Istanbul*, 31 May 2020, Wikimedia Commons accessed 21 July 2020. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Map_of_the_Districts_of_Istanbul.png)

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p. 1

CHAPTER 2 From the Barricades to the City as Art: The Concept of the Right to the City

p. 23 To be able to understand Henri Lefebvre's concept of the right to the city, which constitutes the framework for the analysis of the novels in the following chapters, it would be meaningful to first go back to 19th-century Paris and discuss the emerging consumerism at the time, then proceed with the transformation of the city by Georges-Eugène Haussman and then address the Paris Commune of 1871. This will render it possible to discuss concepts such as *flânerie*, the urban–rural divide, alienation and disorder in the city, and lead the way to the twentieth century, to the Paris uprisings on the eve of which Lefebvre developed the concept of the right to the city. After a discussion of the concept with references to contemporary debates and interpretations, the chapter ends with a brief argument on citizenship as regards the right to the city.

Paris After Haussman

p. 23–24 World exhibitions were an important symbol of the emergent consumerism in Europe in the nineteenth century. Walter Benjamin describes them as "places of pilgrimage to the commodity fetish" where "the exchange value of commodity" is glorified (2006, 36). These exhibitions, Benjamin observes, "propagate the universe of commodities" (37). Arcades were another phenomenon of consumerism in the urban setting at the time. The ones in Paris were predominantly opened in the late 1830s (30). "The arcades are a center of commerce in luxury items" (30) Benjamin notes. He acknowledges that the dream image "is afforded by the commodity per se: as fetish" and adds that "such an image is presented by the arcades" (41). However, the pleasures of consumerism experienced in these glamorous places soon faced a sudden halt. The 1848 economic crisis was felt drastically in Paris which led to a revolt in 1852 organised by "unemployed workers and [...] bourgeois utopians" (Harvey 2012, 7). Although the revolt was suppressed, it led to Bonaparte's seizure of power with a coup in 1853 (7). Bonaparte appointed Georges-Eugène Haussmann as the Prefect of Paris and its environs. Haussman's task was "to help solve the surplus capital and unemployment problem by way of urbanization" (7).

p. 24 Benjamin explains that "[Haussman] wanted to make the erection of barricades in Paris impossible for all time" (2006, 43). He designed the streets significantly wide to prevent protesters creating barricades and getting new streets built "to furnish the shortest route between the barracks and the workers' districts" (44). Employment opportunities in these construction projects, together with the iron fist held over the working class, brought the stabilisation that Bonaparte desired (Harvey 2012, 7). The drastic changes implemented by Haussman turned Paris into a different city. Benjamin stresses that, as a result of the increasing housing costs, the proletariat was pushed into the suburbs (43). This was part of a multi-dimensional plan:

> Haussmann tore through the old Parisian impoverished quarters, using powers of expropriation for supposedly public benefit, and did so in the name of civic improvement, environmental restoration, and urban renovation. He deliberately engineered the removal of much of the working class and other unruly elements, along with insalubrious industries, from Paris's city center, where they constituted a threat to public order, public health and, of course, political power. (Harvey 2012, 16)

p. 24–25 For about fifteen years this new Paris was "the great center of consumption, tourism and pleasure—the cafes, the department stores, the fashion industry", and in this new urban way of life consumerism escalated (Harvey 2012, 8). The glorious days of consumerism, however, were not to last forever without reaching a breaking point. After another economic crisis, followed by a war with Germany ending in defeat, stability dissolved and the Paris Commune was formed in 1871 (8). As Benjamin acknowledges, "the Commune puts an end to the phantasmagoria holding sway over the early years of the proletariat" (2006, 44). Indeed, at the roots of the Commune were not only "a nostalgia for the urban world that Haussmann had destroyed (shades of the 1848 Revolution) and the desire to take back their city on the part of those dispossessed by Haussmann's works" but also socialist aspirations (Harvey 2012, 8).

p. 25 Marshall Berman explains that in the Paris created by Haussman, the poor were pushed out of the centre, but paradoxically this made them more visible: "the physical and social transformations that drove the poor out of sight now bring them back directly into everyone's line of vision" (1988, 153). This was so because once the old medieval slums were destroyed "the self-enclosed and hermetically sealed world of traditional urban poverty" became visible (153). In the streets of Haussman's Paris people from all walks of life now encountered each other (151).

Referring to Charles Baudelaire's poem "Eyes of the Poor" from *Paris Spleen* (1869) Berman observes that "the manifestation of class divisions in the modern city opens up new divisions within the modern self" (1988, 153). In this poem, two lovers suddenly encounter a poor family looking into the cafe they are sitting at, which creates disparate feelings in them (153–154). Berman notes that maybe the narrator in the poem, who empathises with the poor, is actually divided within himself; perhaps with one part of his heart, he, like his partner, wishes that these poor people should be "out of sight and out of mind" (154). If this is the case, then we can read the poem as a manifestation of how "the contradictions that animate the modern city street resonate in the inner life of the man on the street" (154).

Berman continues with an analysis of “Loss of a Halo”, another poem from the same book. He explains that “the archetypal modern man, as we see him here is a pedestrian thrown into the maelstrom of modern city traffic” (1988, 159). The setting of the poem illustrates the chaos embedded in the interaction among the people in the boulevard, including pedestrians and drivers (159). “In order to cross the moving chaos” writes Berman, “the man in the modern street” has to organise his motion within the crowd “not only with his legs and his body, but with his mind and his sensibility as well” (159). He explains that “the difference between the modernist and the anti-modernist [...] is that the modernist makes himself at home here, while the anti-modern searches the streets for a way out” (162). The modernist’s belonging to the streets has its ultimate manifestation in the figure of the *flâneur*. p. 25–26

The Flâneur

Walter Benjamin acknowledges that in Baudelaire’s work Paris became “the subject of lyric poetry” for the first time (2006, 40). Benjamin perceives Baudelaire as an “allegorist” and stresses that his gaze “as it falls on the city, is the gaze of the alienated man” (40). According to Benjamin “it is the gaze of the flâneur” who “still stands on the threshold—of the metropolis as of the middle class” (40). He explains that neither the metropolis nor the middle class “has him [the *flâneur*] in its power yet” (40). This figure of the *flâneur* does not feel he belongs to either of them, “in neither is he at home” (40). Therefore, “he seeks refuge in the crowd” (40). p. 26

Keith Tester explains that for the *flâneur* “the arcades of Paris before Haussman” had a particular importance” because “they were public spaces which were protected from the circulations of the city” (2006, 15). These arcades were “something between a street and an intérieur” (Benjamin 2006, 68). They functioned as a remedy for the *flâneur*’s boredom living in “a sated reactionary regime” (68). Benjamin describes them as “the transformation of the boulevard into an intérieur” (68). “When the arcades were demolished, the *flâneur* was thrown into the way of circulation” (Tester 2006, 15); in other words, the streets. As Benjamin explains: “the street becomes a dwelling place for the flâneur; he is as much at home among house façades as a citizen is within his four walls” (68). The *flâneur* in his endless strolls in the city has the opportunity to observe the city from moment to moment.

According to Tester, “the precise meaning and significance of *flânerie* remains more than a little elusive” (2006, 1). He asserts that “the figure, and the activity, of the *flâneur* is essentially about freedom, the meaning of existence (or the lack of a meaning of existence) and being-with-others in the modern urban spaces of the city” (8). Tester also identifies a “greyness of the historical specificity of the *flâneur*” (16) and explains that “the *flâneur* certainly occupies the specific times and places of nineteenth-century Paris, but that Paris is itself made important because it is an expression of modernity” (17).

In the Baudelarian sense, *flânerie* is “the activity of the sovereign spectator going about in the city in order to find the things which will occupy his gaze and thus complete his otherwise incomplete identity; satisfy his otherwise dissatisfied existence; replace the sense of bereavement with a sense of life” (Tester 2006, 7). Tester, based on his analysis of Sartre’s *Nausea* (1938), observes that in the Sartrean variant of the *flâneur*, however, “public spaces can be places of an immense existential fear” (10) and the *flâneur* becomes “the victim rather than the prince of his own freedom” (10). He adds that Sartre uses patterns of *flânerie* “to try to say something about metropolitan existence in and of itself” (10). Tester finds a similar assertion in Robert Musil’s seminal work *The Man Without Qualities* (1954), which he wrote between 1930 and 1943. According to Tester, in the beginning chapter of the work, “devices of *flânerie*” are connected “to global problems of existence in cities” (10). As he points out, similarly to Baudelaire and Sartre, the city life Musil describes is the one outside, such as “public spaces, movements and rituals” (11). However, “Musil’s streets are much, much *noisier*” and he “brings the figure into the twentieth century” (11). Tester observes a further significant point in Musil: “At exactly the moment when Musil generalises the *flâneur* and turns him into a generic rather than a Parisian figure, the *flâneur* begins to disappear. The idle and considered strolling and observing which is the essence of *flânerie* has become doubtful in universal Vienna” (12–13). This is so because against *flânerie* “there is the problem of traffic” and also “the mysteries of the city could well become just banal and boring”; finally, “domination of rationality and of an order which is imposed on the city” renders *flânerie* “less and less likely” (13). p. 26–27

Alienation in the Metropolis

Georg Simmel’s famous essay “The Metropolis and Mental Life” (2002) written in 1903, about four decades after Baudelaire’s *Paris Spleen* (1869), is another seminal text on the changing mental states of the individual in the urban setting of modernised life. In his essay, Simmel explains that in the city there is “swift and continuous shift of external and internal stimuli”, something which does not exist in small town and rural life (11). Coupled together with “the tempo and multiplicity of economic, occupational and social life” in the city, this results in “the intellectualistic character of the mental life of the metropolis” as distinct from that of the small town, where “feelings and emotional p. 27–28

relationships" are prevalent (12). Consequently, the metropolitan person behaves rationally rather than emotionally as "the depths of the personality" become hidden (12). Added to that are the relations based on the money economy in the city through obligatory forms of interaction such as consumption of goods and services (12). The intellectualistic mind state is enmeshed with the money economy (12). Within this context, according to Simmel, "the citizen of the metropolis is 'free' in contrast with the trivialities and prejudices which bind the small town person" (16). In the metropolis, a "type of culture which has outgrown every personal element" exists (18). Simmel contends that in the city there is an abundance of "stimulations, interests and the taking up of time and attention" which makes "life infinitely more easy" (19). However, he adds that "all these impersonal cultural elements and existing goods and values [...] suppress peculiar personal interests and incomparabilities" (19). Therefore, in the urban context, for the protection of what is personal, we need an extra emphasis on our "extremities and peculiarities and individualizations" (19).

p. 28 Simmel traces this "atrophy of individual culture through the hypertrophy of the objective culture" (19) at the core of the writings of individualists, like Friedrich Nietzsche, who fiercely criticise the urban way of life. However, as Simmel observes, such writings find a considerable number of urban readers "as the saviours of their unsatisfied yearnings" (19). He concludes that in the city we should be able to harbour the idea of "'the general human quality' in every individual" imposed in the eighteenth century and the "qualitative uniqueness and irreplaceability" of the individual advocated by the Romantics, and resolve the conflict between them (19).

As Peter Saunders acknowledges, in this essay Simmel outlines the fundamental outcomes of "the growth of the division of labour in modern societies" as follows: "it fragments and segmentalizes social life" (2005, 58); it "reinforces the self-consciousness engendered by an increase in size [...] because, in a highly differentiated society [...] [the individual's] own unique personality is the only constant factor", and "the development of the division of labour in society fosters an alienation of individuals from the cultural world which they have created" (59). In other words, while this essay is a significant analysis of the freedom and independence that the urban way of life brings to the individual, it also tackles the problem of alienation, albeit by not referring to it as alienation. Simmel points out that the individual tends to get mentally lost while living as part of the huge population in the city, distanced even from her/his very self, and therefore needs to remember and observe what is personal and unique about herself/himself.

p. 29 The urban–rural divide in Simmel's essay is a major topic in urban theory. However, as Alimia et al. point out, "urbanity itself is a relational term. In an overwhelmingly rural context, even a smallish town can have urban properties" (2018, 3). Similarly, Saunders reminds us to be careful about the urban–rural divide and the concern with population size in our approach to the question of urbanity, stressing that we need to consider the size element together with "a wide range of culturally variable phenomena" (2005, 74).

Similar to Simmel, British scholar Raymond Williams develops his analysis of alienation through the urban–rural divide against the background of the economic system. He argues that "unalienated experience is the rural past and realistic experience is the urban future" (1975, 298). As Karl Marx outlines in the *Economic & Philosophic Manuscripts of 1844*, in the capitalist system "the worker is related to the product of his labor as to an alien object" (2009, 29). Marx explains that "the more powerful becomes the alien world of objects which [the worker] creates over and against himself, the poorer he himself –his inner world– becomes, the less belongs to him as his own" (29). He goes on to stress that "labor is external to the worker [...] in his work therefore he does not affirm himself but denies himself, does not feel content but unhappy, does not develop freely his physical and mental energy but mortifies his body and ruins his mind" (30). In line with this understanding of alienation, Williams invites us to pay attention to "the real processes of alienation, separation, externality, abstraction", both in the country and the city, stressing that in order to be able to achieve that we must try to comprehend "the history of rural and urban capitalism" as well as the "experiences which in many millions of lives are discovered and rediscovered, very often under pressure" through authentic relationships, and that this can illustrate "what the real deformation may be" (1975, 298).

p. 29–30 Richard Sennett's observations about disorder in the city as not necessarily a negative situation is worthy of mention at this point, as he offers unique perspectives on the potentiality of this disorder in confronting alienation. Referring to Friedrich Nietzsche's *The Birth of Tragedy* (1967), Sennett explains that Dionysiac rites "could be practiced best among strangers: the drinking, dancing, and fucking is more intense if no one knows who you are or where you come from" (1992, 238). According to Sennett, "dislocation, deconstruction, disorientation: these words can describe a frenzied, Dionysiac city" (238). He explains that "difference, discontinuity, and disorientation ought to be of ethical forces which connect people to one another" (226). These forces would then lead to "the ethics of difference, the moral value of exposure to others, the creative act of disorientation, recall the experience of sympathy, as it was championed in the Enlightenment" (226). Sennett accepts a deconstructionist connotation in his stress on difference but draws attention to the humane dimension in his approach which would not be celebrated by deconstructionists (225).

p. 30 Melvin Seeman outlines "five basic ways in which the concept of alienation has been used" (1959, 783). The first one of these is powerlessness. Seeman puts Marx's conceptualisation of alienated/estranged labour in this category, stressing that this is the most widely used meaning of alienation in the literature of the time (784). At the core of this

variant lies the feeling that one has no control over certain aspects of one's life (784). Seeman describes the second variant of the concept as meaninglessness, which "is characterized *by a low expectancy that satisfactory predictions about future outcomes of behavior can be made*" (786). He explains that "the third variant of the alienation theme is derived from Durkheim's description of 'anomie,' and refers to a condition of normlessness" (787). In such a case, Seeman explains, the individual would incline to think "that socially unapproved behaviors are required to achieve given goals" (788). The fourth category in Seeman's list is about isolation: "the alienated in the isolation sense are those who, like the intellectual *assign low reward value to goals or beliefs that are typically highly valued in the given society*" (789). He defines the final variant of alienation as self-estrangement. He describes this with reference to Erich Fromm's description in *Sane Society* (1955) as "a mode of experience in which the person experiences himself as an alien. He has become, one might say, estranged from himself" (Fromm quoted in Seeman 1959, 789). Seeman explains that "alienation from the self" is in fact a metaphor, "what is being postulated here is some ideal human condition from which the individual is estranged" (790). He adds that "to be self-alienated, in the final analysis, means to be something less than one might ideally be if the circumstances in society were otherwise—to be insecure, given to appearances, conformist" (790).

It is impossible not to observe that the urban dimension is the thread that ties together all these five variants of alienation lucidly outlined by Seeman. All these forms of alienation are experienced in the urban context, a fact which takes us to Henri Lefebvre's observation that "urban alienation contains and perpetuates all other forms of alienation" (2003, 92). Indeed, "Marx's concept of alienation played a leading role" in almost all of Lefebvre's writings (Goonewardena et al. 2008, 128). Kanishka Goonewardena et al. explain that "Lefebvre's elaboration of alienation deals with the 'will to abstract' manifest in capitalist-industrial rationality, which he explicates most forcefully with reference to urbanism" (128). As Benjamin Fraser contends, Lefebvre achieves a "recalibration of the notion of alienation" with the "economic, political, social, philosophical" dimensions, together with the "urban" dimension "above all else" (2015, 43). For Lefebvre, "the ubiquitous alienation of everyday life, and particularly that of life in urban areas, thus paradoxically makes it possible for radical coalitions to form" (49). That sort of alienation was evident in Paris in the late 1960s when Lefebvre wrote *Le Droit à La Ville* (*The Right to the City*). As Harvey observes, "Paris from the early 1960s on was plainly in the midst of an existential crisis. The old could not last, but the new seemed just too awful, soulless and empty to contemplate" (2012, x). He adds that he finds it "highly significant that The Right to the City was written before the Irruption (as Lefebvre later called it) of May 1968. His essay depicts a situation in which such an irruption was not only possible but almost inevitable" (xi).

p. 30–31

The Right to the City

At the core of the concept of the right to the city lies Lefebvre's vision which went against the idea of the city as exchange value. As Christian Schmid points out, in a capitalist system it is inevitable that "the city itself, urban life, becomes a commodity" (2012, 55). He describes this as "the commodification of the urban" (55). This commodification process is central to Lefebvre's concept of the right to the city, which he develops against the organisation of urban life based on the exchange value of the city. As a result of the dominance of the exchange value, the majority of inhabitants of the city are deprived of living a fulfilling urban life, thus Lefebvre advocates for a transformation towards the use value of the city.

p. 31

Lefebvre draws attention to the fact that in cities, in addition to wealth, "knowledge (*connaissances*), techniques, and *oeuvres* (works of art, monuments)" are accumulated (1996, 66). For him, the city as *oeuvre* corresponds to its use value as opposed to the *product* which is its exchange value. According to him, "the eminent use of the city, that is, of its streets and squares, edifices and monuments" is not based on production but on "pleasure and prestige" (66). In art, he sees the capability of creating "structures of enchantment" (173) and asserts that the bourgeoisie "replaces the *oeuvre*, by the product" (75). He emphasises that "those who retain this sense of the *oeuvre*, including writers and painters, think and see themselves as 'non-bourgeois'" (75). For a transformed society, where a completely different sort of city and urban life can exist, the dynamics of art and philosophy must also be transformed as "the future of art is not artistic, but urban, because the future of 'man' is [...] in urban society. [...] art and philosophy must reconsider itself in relation to this perspective" (173). At this point it is crucial to remember that "the notion of an oeuvre is not only equated with artistic practice but signifies all activities of self-realization or collective self-management (to which Lefebvre referred as autogestion)" (Ronneberger 2008, 135). As Klaus Ronneberger acknowledges, "the declared goal of [Lefebvre's] intellectual project was, above all, a 'revalorization of subjectivity' and the quest for spaces that allow for autonomy and creativity. The concept of the oeuvre plays a central role in this context; it is intended to replace the much narrower, Marxian concepts of labor" (135). Therefore, only if the city is no longer a commodity to make profit from can the right to the city, which Lefebvre describes as "a transformed and renewed *right to urban life*" (1996, 158), be realised.

p. 31–32

Lefebvre explains that we need "an integrated theory of the city and urban society, using the resources of science and art" for this, and adds: "only the working class can become the agent, the social carrier or support of this realization"

p. 32

(158). He reminds us that "in the urban context, struggles between fractions, groups and classes strengthen the feeling of belonging" (67), and, referring to the suburbanisation of the working class, he acknowledges that "isolated from the city, the proletariat will end its sense of the *oeuvre*", thus "urban consciousness will vanish" (77). Ronneberger lucidly explains how Lefebvre articulates his expectations from the working class, together with the importance he attaches to subjectivity:

p. 32–33 Lefebvre believed that his critique of economistic ideologies—which was directed against an excessively narrow concept of production and a notion of class struggle that was restricted to the factory—contained important implications for the conceptualization of revolution. With the complete urbanization of society, the industrial proletariat found itself in the midst of a process of dissolution that also undermined its role as the agent of transformation. Lefebvre introduced inhabiting (habiter) as a new subversive category: this refers to a realm that is essential to everybody but becomes increasingly deficient for its users as social space is integrated ever more directly into processes of capital valorization. On this basis Lefebvre envisioned the emergence of a new revolutionary subject that would revolt not only against the exploitation of labor-power but against the destruction of its entire living environment. (2008, 135)

p. 33 In line with such a standpoint, Lefebvre stresses that to inhabit means "to take part in social life" (1996, 76) and draws attention to "the reduction of 'to inhabit' to *habitat*" in Paris during its urban transformation after World War II, when "all perceptible, legible urban reality has disappeared: streets, squares, monuments, meeting places" (79). The concept of inhabiting signifies "a richer gloss on city life, evoking urban living as becoming, as growing, as something dynamic and progressive" (Merrifield 2006, 68).

As Andy Merrifield observes, "a loss of inhabiting is a political, social, and aesthetic loss" (68–69). In short, the city as *oeuvre* is the very opportunity of turning our daily lives into the art of living. Merrifield reminds us that "downgrading *inhabit*, reducing it to a mere *habitat*, signifies a loss of the city as *oeuvre*, a loss of *integration* and *participation* in urban life" (69). This would be "to denigrate one of humanity's great works of art—not one hanging on a museum wall but a canvas smack in front of our noses, wherein we ourselves are would-be artists, would-be architects" (69).

According to Lefebvre "urban life suggests meetings, the confrontation of differences, reciprocal knowledge and acknowledgement (including ideological and political confrontation) ways of living, 'patterns' which coexist in the city" (1996, 75). Based on this elaboration of urban life, he clarifies the distinction between the use value and exchange value as regards the urban question: "*use value* (the city and urban life) and *exchange value* (spaces bought and sold, the consumption of products, goods, places and signs)" (86). The city and urban life as use value are built on social connections, class struggle and labour. Lefebvre associates the "images of effort, of will, of subjectivity, of contemplation" with the city (87).

p. 33–34 As Lefebvre points out, in addition to "anthropological needs which are socially elaborated", such as safety and security, social connections and personal space, urban residents have needs such as "the need of creative activity, for the *oeuvre* (not only of products and consumable material goods), of the need for information, symbolism, the imaginary and play" (147). The right to the city includes access to opportunities for meeting such needs where "a new humanism, a new praxis, another man, that of urban society" will emerge (150).

p. 34 According to Lefebvre, "the *urban* can only be confined to a strategy prioritizing the urban problematic, the intensification of urban life, the effective realization of urban society" (132). With "the effective realization of urban society" he means the "morphological, material and practico-material base" (132). In sum, what Lefebvre means by *the right to the city* is something much larger in scope than meeting material necessities in the city. It is a right to a new type of city in an entirely different system. "The right to the city is far more than the individual liberty to access urban resources: it is a right to change ourselves by changing the city" (Harvey 2008, 23).

Nonetheless, there is a tendency of conceiving the right to the city simply as changes to rehabilitate urban life as it exists within the current socio-economic system. The *World Charter for the Right to the City*, first presented in 2004 at the Social Forum of the Americas, in Quito, Ecuador is one such case.[1] Enrique Ortiz defines the scope of the document as follows: "formulation and promotion of a World Charter for the Right to the City has the end purpose to build an instrument both universal and compact which may be adopted by the United Nations System, the regional human rights systems, and governments, as legal instrument or at least basic reference in the definition and adoption of the Right to the City as a new human right" (2006). The Charter defines the right to the city as "the equitable usufruct of cities within the principles of sustainability, democracy, equity, and social justice" and describes it as "the collective right of the inhabitants of cities, in particular of the vulnerable and marginalized groups" and stresses that "all the civil, political, economic, social, cultural and environmental rights which are already regulated in the international human rights treaties" are included in this right (2004, 2). Rights thus listed, under the umbrella of the right to the city, are

p. 35 rights to work in equitable and satisfactory conditions; to establish and affiliate with unions; to social security, public health, clean drinking water, energy, public transportation, and other social services; to food, clothing, and adequate

[1] From here onwards, the Charter.

shelter; to quality public education and to culture; to information, political participation, peaceful coexistence, and access to justice; and the right to organize, gather, and manifest one's opinion. It also includes respect for minorities; ethnic, racial, sexual and cultural plurality; and respect for migrants.

The [...] right to development, to a healthy environment, to the enjoyment and preservation of natural resources, to participation in urban planning and management, and to historical and cultural heritage. (2)

Looking at this list, one cannot ignore the impossibility of the implementation of these rights within the current capitalist economic system where the city is a commodity; in other words, in Lefebvre's conceptualisation, where the city's exchange value rather than its use value has any meaning. In the system we live in, where the city is the locus of economic rent creation (i.e., capturing speculative gains without any productive investment), proposing all these rights simply sounds unrealistic.

Margit Mayer aptly describes the right to the city as "less a juridical right, but rather an oppositional demand, which challenges the claims of the rich and powerful" (2012, 71). Confirming that the rights in the Charter would improve the conditions of city inhabitants, she draws attention to the fact that "unlike the Lefebvrian notion of the right to the city" these rights would only render possible "inclusion in the current city as it exists" but "do not aim at transforming the existing city –and in that process ourselves" (74). Indeed, we should not forget that Lefebvre defines the right to the city as "a superior form of rights: right to freedom, to individualization in socialization, to habitat and to inhabit" (1996, 173).

Goonewardena et al. draw our attention to the fact that Lefebvre, in *Everyday Life in the Modern World* (1984), makes the following call: "let everyday life become a work of art! Let every technical means be employed for the transformation of everyday life!" (quoted in Goonewardena et al. 2012, 98). As Goonewardena et al. observe, both in that work and in *The Urban Revolution* (2003) Lefebvre emphasises that "there can be no social(ist) revolution without an urban revolution, no urban revolution without a social(ist) revolution, and neither without a revolution in everyday life" (98). Referring to documents such as the Charter list above, Goonewardena et al. stress that "Lefebvre's concept of *the* right to the city must be understood –not as another addition to the self-contradictory liberal-democratic list of 'human-rights,' but rather the right to a radically different *world*" (98). p. 35–36

In a similar fashion, Peter Marcuse explicates the practical dimensions of the right to the city reciprocally with its overarching philosophical dimension. The demand for the right to the city, he asserts, is "of those who are excluded", whereas "the aspiration is of those who are alienated", thus "the cry is for the material necessities of life" while "the aspiration is for a broader right to what is necessary beyond the material to lead a satisfying life" (2012, 31). He explains that "the demand comes from those directly in want, directly oppressed, those for whom even their most immediate needs are not fulfilled: the homeless, the hungry, the imprisoned, the persecuted on gender, religious, racial grounds. It is a demand of those whose work injures their health, those whose income is below subsistence, those excluded from the benefits of urban life" (30–31). Marcuse describes the alienated as "those superficially integrated into the system and sharing in its material benefits" but unsatisfied in terms of their "creative activity" and "social relationships" and those who feel "guilty perhaps about an undeserved prosperity, unfulfilled in their lives' hopes" (31). He concludes that "it is a combination of the deprived and the discontent who will lead the push for the right to the city" (33). p. 36

The rights mentioned above, for instance in the Charter, can be seen as what Marcuse defines as "the necessities for a decent life" which "must have priority" since "they are immediate, indeed existential, needs" (34). On the other hand, Marcuse, like Goonewardena et al., urges us not to forget that at the core of the concept of the right to the city lies the struggle for a different world; he clarifies that: "the right to the city is a demand for a broad and sweeping right, a right not only in the legal sense of a right to specific benefits, but a right in a political sense, a claim not only to a right or a set of rights to justice within the existing legal system, but a right on a higher moral plane that demands a better system in which the potential benefits of an urban life can be fully and entirely realized" (34). Some might call this utopian or unrealistic; but the argument around this is beyond the scope of this book. In any case, it might be useful to remember that Lefebvre always found utopias inspiring.

Citizenship in the Urban Context

Before closing the chapter, a brief discussion on citizenship might be useful. As Joe Painter observes, considerable debate has taken place on citizenship in the related scholarship since the 1980s (2005, 4). One dimension of these debates, he adds, is the meaning of citizenship "as full membership of society" through which "cultural recognition and respect, economic and workplace rights, and social welfare rights as well as the conventional emphasis on civil and political rights" are supposed to be implemented (4). He draws attention to the "mismatch between de jure citizenship (legal membership) and de facto citizenship (social practices)" with reference to the empirical proof demonstrating "that de jure citizens frequently find it difficult to access the benefits of citizenship in practice while others who are p. 37

technically non-citizens can sometimes acquire substantial (though perhaps legally unenforceable) social, cultural and even political rights”(5). Similarly, Saskia Sassen underscores the fact that “legal citizenship does not always bring full and equal membership rights”(2003, 49). “The position of different groups within a nation-state”, as Sassen observes, has considerable impact on the implementation of their citizenship rights (49).

Painter reminds us that “there is no universally accepted definition of ‘citizenship’” but “a variety of competing normative models” which are “liberal individualist models; communitarian/civic-republican models; radical pluralist/dissident models”(2005, 10). In the first model, the citizen is “free to engage in lawful private relationships of all kinds, but under no obligation to undertake or promote public activities”(10). In the second model, as Painter observes, “full engagement in public life, with an emphasis on participation in debate and decision-making” is expected. Departing from Jurgen Habermas’ s analysis of the public sphere, Painter describes the third model in relation to “competing publics, plural identities and disagreement of ethical values”(11). He explains that “radical pluralism’ s stress on the active negotiation of social diversity, autonomous action to meet wants and needs, and the legitimacy of vigorous dissent, combine to enlarge the room for the active making of cities by citizens”(15). While this model is the most compatible one with the objective of reaching to “enhanced and meaningful participation in the context of social diversity” it requires a well-functioning and dynamic urban public realm (15).

p. 38 Sassen sees a parallel between the medieval and modern global cities as in both of them “new forms of political subjectivity, such as citizenship, are being constituted through [political] practices”(2012, 90). She emphasises that the locus of this action is the city which itself is partly constituted through these dynamics (90). “Far more so than a peaceful and harmonious suburb” she observes, “the contested city is where the civic is built”(90).

p. 38–39 While Sassen points out the similarity between the medieval and modern-day city in terms of political subjectivity, she does not overlook the unique nature of current urban experiences. In an earlier article, she explains that although “citizenship originated in cities, and cities played an important role in its evolution”, the city of our era—as the place where “new types of citizenship practices” as well as “new types of incompletely formalized political subjects” are developed—has its own unique dynamics (2003, 58). She contends that the “current local city government” system is also different from “earlier notions of citizenship and democracy described for ancient and medieval cities in Europe”(58). Today’s relationship between the city and city dwellers, argues Sassen, is more in line with Lefebvre’ s understanding of “the city as oeuvre”(58). In other words, the inhabitants of the city have the responsibility and the power to claim their city as a place to inhabit. Within this context, Sassen attracts attention to “the importance of agency”(58). She explains that, “while Lefebvre found this agency in the working class in the Paris of the twentieth century”, she “find[s] it in two strategic actors—global corporate capital and immigration—in today’s global cities”(58). As she aptly observes, “today’s citizenship practices have to do with the production of ‘presence’ by those without power, and a politics that claims rights to the city”(58). In global cities, Sassen acknowledges, “the disadvantaged can engage the new forms of globalized corporate power” and also “the growing numbers and diversity of the disadvantaged in these cities under these conditions assumes a distinctive ‘presence’”(61). She explains that being powerless does not necessarily mean being invisible or impotent, because while the changing dynamics in global cities lead to “new structurations of power” they also result in “operational and rhetorical openings for new types of political actors that may have been submerged, invisible, or without voice”(61). In today’s global cities, as she explains, there is “a distinction between powerlessness and the condition of being an actor, even though lacking power”(62). She describes the latter as “presence” and adds: “in the context of a strategic space such as the global city, the types of disadvantaged people described here are not simply marginal; they acquire presence in a broader political process that escapes the boundaries of the formal polity”(62). Her examples of “the struggles against gentrification [...] struggles for the rights of the homeless” and “demonstrations against police brutalizing minority people”(62) in the United States are relevant for global(ising) cities all over the world. In the globalising world, the struggle for the right to the city is at the centre of our lives even if we are not aware of it or do not take part in it as agents, thinking that we are powerless. From the day Henri Lefebvre conceptualised the city as *oeuvre* to our day, structures of power have been evolving. Yet, the potential of city inhabitants as agents to transform the city from being simply a place of habitat to a place to inhabit also evolves and expands with new forms of solidarity.

p. 39 The next chapter is on this long story of those without power and their attempts at claiming their right to the city in the context of Istanbul, upon the mass rural migration from the 1950s onwards.

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p. 23

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CHAPTER 3 Passionate Belongings and Intense Longings: Tracing the Right to the City in Istanbul

For a meaningful discussion on the experiences in Istanbul we have to understand the city's urbanisation through its unique dynamics and differences from Western processes. Peter Saunders, referring to Iván Szelényi (1981), reminds us of the "strong tendency in much of the work conducted through the 1970s to take western capitalist cities as the paradigm of contemporary urbanism, and to ignore variations both between capitalist and non-capitalist (Third World or eastern European) societies, and within different western capitalist countries" (2005, 148). Similarly, Elizabeth Wilson underscores the need for refraining from an "ethnocentric and oversimplified" view, ignoring "the differences among various third-world countries and their cities" (1991, 122). She adds that "it is also ahistorical to lump all third-world cities together", as many cities of the Middle East for instance are older than Latin American cities which are older than many African cities (122).[1] p. 43

In their research based in selected North African and Middle Eastern Muslim cities, Alimia et al. emphasise that they search for "a multidisciplinary perspective of understanding urbanity" that refrains from understanding it "as a simple measure of metrics" (2018, 3). They point out that "it is doubtful if there exists one universal model of urbanity" and try to answer "why there appear to be multiple types of urbanities that vary over time and space" (3). Saunders seems to have an answer to that question as he explains that "the meaning of urbanism will differ over different times and places as different interests struggle to realize the expression of their own values and aspirations" and concludes that "there can thus be no generic concept of urbanism" (2005, 148). p. 43–44

Similarly, Saskia Sassen argues that the term "urbanity" is "charged with a Western sense of cosmopolitanism of what public space is or should be" (2005, 1). She acknowledges that "there are kinds of urbanity that do not fit with this very large body of urbanism developed in the West" (1). She gives the example of Shanghai, where people gather together in the evenings to play cards, and contends that "the notion of public space as we have developed it out of a Western European context might not help us read a city such as Shanghai, or perhaps even Mexico City, in ways that are very useful" (1). Sassen offers the term "cityness" instead of "urbanity" in order to "detect urbanities that may be constituted in very different ways" (1). She aims to arrive at a conceptualisation where possibilities such as "what to the Western eye might look like urban sprawl" could be examined in a way not "limited to, certain urban forms", since "there are more possibilities" (2). p. 44

Istanbul's Complex Phases

It is a well-known fact that "urbanization in the Third World has not been accompanied by concomitant economic prosperity as it was in western nations" (Hay 1986, 72). Therefore, as Wilson points out, we have to overcome "the underlying presumption that urbanisation must always follow the same path –that taken historically by western cities in the industrial period" (1991, 122) for a meaningful analysis of third-world cities. p. 44

In 1976, Turkish scholar Kemal Karpat, chair of the Middle East Studies Program at the University of Wisconsin at the time, wrote a seminal book on shanty housing in Istanbul, based on extensive fieldwork in three shanty towns in the city. In this work, Karpat makes an in-depth analysis of Istanbul's urbanisation in comparative perspective with other third-world cities, with references to Middle Eastern, African and Latin American experiences. His framework and explanations successfully refrain from the shortcomings of a narrow view of urbanisation based on Western-centrism. p. 44–45

Karpat stresses that "the traditional city in the third world, especially the Muslim, had little in common with the 'ideal' Western city of Max Weber. Its political and economic life was different from that of the countryside, although its cultural and religious life was not" (2009, 31). He explains that the planners of the Muslim cities aimed at presenting "the material and moral conditions necessary for the *umma* (community of God) to attain perfect virtue" (31). Karpat goes on by underscoring that in the nineteenth century, with its craft production, the Muslim city could not survive in the face of "the political and economic influence of the industrial, market-oriented economics of the West" (32). However, he adds that at this conjuncture various Muslim Middle Eastern and North African cities had an opportunity for urban growth, making use of their geographical location on trade routes (32). As a result of this, "a new dichotomy between village and city in the Islamic countries" emerged based on the "priority to economic interests conceived not as part of a cultural-religious system, but strictly as market relations" (32). Karpat asserts that consequently "the old cultural and social harmony between village and city was broken", and these cities, either in the Muslim or non-Muslim third world, ultimately acquired similar characteristics (32). "These cities were not manufacturing centers, did not possess industry and high technology, communication, and fixed capital, and could not provide outlets for specialized education and scientific investigation; in comparison with Western cities, they were not centers of innovation and of high concentration of skills" (32). p. 45

[1] In the following pages, as in Wilson's work, "the term 'third-world' is used as a familiar, although unsatisfactory shorthand" (1991, 121).

Karpat explains that after World War II, as a result of political and economic developments, these cities started to bring in "the technological and the cultural and scientific features associated with industrially advanced countries" (32). Thus, "the third world 'city' was compelled to become a new or a modern city by following a special evolutionary path of its own, and eventually by acquiring some technology" (32). As a result of this, these third-world cities changed from being "the primate and parasitic and orthogenetic cities" to "generative and heterogenic cities – that is, the modern multifunctional cities" (33).

p. 45–46 Özgür Orhangazi acknowledges that, while in the 19th-century Ottoman era industrialisation was very limited, this began changing in the Turkish Republic, which was established in 1923. He emphasises that at the height of the rural–urban migration in the 1950s and the 1960s industrialisation was rapid in various cities of the country, particularly in Istanbul (pers. comm., 14 May 2020). Karpat describes "rural migration and urbanization and their by-product – the migrant, or squatter, settlements" as the intrinsic components of Turkey's "modernization" (2009, 7). Tansı Şenyapılı's summary of this process is worth quoting at length:

p. 46 In the fifties, a migration of unprecedented volume consisting mainly of unskilled, illiterate, former villagers hit the cities. Yet, in that period, neither the investments nor the industry nor the service sectors were sufficiently developed. Therefore, urban economic space was not ready to accept and employ them. Slowly towards 1955, under the influence of inflationary economic policies and emphasis on show-case type urban investments, employment opportunities appeared in the marginal sector for gecekondu [shanty] labour and jobs opened in the service sector for educated middle class women. (1981a, 207)

Under such conditions in the city, the status of the rural migrant became a widely discussed topic. Below, these discussions are analysed with references mainly to Kemal Karpat and Mübeccel Kıray, two leading sociologists of Turkey in the 1970s who wrote extensively on migration.

Urbanisation or Pseudo-Urbanisation?

p. 46 Mübeccel Kıray, in an article she wrote in 1972, asserts that "people living in shanties are by no means peasants any longer" (2007b, 98). Yet, she adds, since the country industrialised very slowly, and became organised even more slowly than that, "this population which had to leave its land behind do not find the chance to gain an industrial-urban identity, and work in random, small, non-producing service works" (98). She emphasises that the number of "plausible industrial jobs" is limited; however "none of these people work in agricultural production, so they are no longer 'peasants'" (98). She recommends the use of "pseudo-urbanisation and pseudo-urbanite" since "relationships involved in economic production and the vocations in the city are so amorphous, and this amorphousness has been ongoing for so long, that the shanties and craftsmanship have become an important aspect of urban life" (99).

p. 46–47 Karpat, referring to the concepts of "*urban peasants*" and "*pseudourbanization*" which were coined to emphasise that third-world urbanisation was not accompanied by industrialisation, warns us not to judge third-world cities with "elitist or Western concepts of urbanism" (2009, 20). While acknowledging "overcrowding and insufficient economic development" in these third-world cities, Karpat contends that the standard of living in them is high compared with life back in the villages (2009, 20). For the Turkish context, Tansı Şenyapılı explains this as follows: "men work less, women in general do not work, children benefit from education and other urban services" (1981a, 213).

p. 47 Additionally, as Orhangazi explains, in the case of Istanbul, from the 1950s onwards there *was* industrialisation in the city, yet the number of industrial jobs *was not sufficient* to cover the employment need of the high number of migrants (pers. comm., 14 May 2020). Karpat explains that in Turkey migrants who could not find employment in "the newly established industries" in the cities either worked in the service sector or "secondary (industrial) sector" which functioned on inexpensive labour; or else they made their income as street vendors (2009, 22). He adds that in third-world cities there was a need for "unskilled and low-paid workers" and rural migrants served as a source of inexpensive labour to small enterprises (22).

As Karpat acknowledges, motivations behind the rural–urban migration were not limited to better income and higher living standards; "a sense of cultural and historical identification with the city" was also present (27). Karpat observes that residents of third-world countries perceive the city "as a superior form of existence" and adds: "The high status attached to life in the city – *şehir, madina, polis*, or *urbanismo* – is a deeply engrained element in the cultures of Asia, Africa, and Latin America. The term *madaniyyat* – that is, civilization – in the Muslim culture derives from *madina*, or city" (244 n. 47).

Karpat describes the mass rural–urban migration in Turkey as the outcome of "basic permanent structural changes" unlike temporary migration waves (33). The rural dimension of Turkey's structural changes was not limited to the mechanisation of farming, as various dynamics in the countryside emerged at different decades of migration (Yıldırmaz 2017, 71 – 99). According to Sinan Yıldırmaz, overlooking this fact is common in the works of urban studies as

“researchers do not pay attention to what happens in the countryside, but focus mainly on the developments and the transformation in the city” (98).

Karpat explains that if the structural changes in the country were not permanent, but a temporary case, then “the city [Istanbul] might have assimilated the newcomers by absorbing them into its prevailing structure and rigid urban culture” (2009, 33). The phenomenon described perfectly by Karpat as “rigid urban culture” is at the core of the Istanbulite versus non-Istanbulite divide discussed in the introductory chapter. p. 47–48

After explaining the historical dynamics, and economic and structural changes thereof, Karpat describes the third-world cities in Muslim countries as predominantly “compris[ing] to a degree both the features of the traditional Islamic and European cities, along with the folk culture, community feeling, natural attitudes, pragmatism, and materialism of the countryside” (33). He adds that when a massive number of rural migrants dwelling in squatter settlements joined the urban population, most of the Middle Eastern Muslim cities changed significantly, “losing their traditional elitist features” (34). He reminds us that this is a two-way process. While acknowledging “the role played by rural migration on urbanization in the third world” Karpat draws attention to the “transforming impact of the city on the migrant” (34). As Sassen observes, “the daily dynamics and interdependencies of life in the city contribute to the making of an urban subject, as distinct from an ethnic, religious, or racialized subject” (2017, 35). This urban subject is a highly different person from the rural migrant at the stage of his/her arrival at the city. “The city has a profound changing effect on the migrant, especially in occupational habits, organizations for social and political actions, family size and relations, levels of aspiration, and values related to communication” (Karpat 2009, 34). Karpat further stresses that “this change occurs in large measure because the city itself is being transformed by industrialization, technology, and political action. This situation can be described as ‘modernization’ for the city and ‘urbanization’ for the rural migrant” (34). In the case of Istanbul, the elite establishment was highly resistant to accepting migrants as new members of the city who are an inevitable element of its modernisation process. As Karpat acknowledges, “the newcomers have imposed on the city their own outlook on society and the world, often to the outraged dismay of old urbanites” (2009, 32). As shanties spread in Istanbul, rural migrants living in them were scorned as peasants in the city by these established members. p. 48

Multiple Urbanities

As Sassen observes, “in cities we can see the making of new subjects and identities that would not be possible in, for example, rural areas or a country at large” (2013, 214). With the inherent potential of the urban experience to transform its inhabitants, the migrant in the city becomes a new person through various stages of adaptation. “The integration of migrants and squatters into city –in other words, their urbanization” (Karpat 2009, 230) is an issue widely discussed; and as Bo Grönlund points out, who is an urbanite is “too vague and too complex” (2007, 112-02) an issue to have a simple answer. Based on migrants’ informal employment and housing strategies, Tansı Şenyapılı describes them as a marginal population. She argues that they “are not integrated in terms of cultural and social relations” but that they succeed in being part of the “economic and physical space [...] making use of rational solutions” (1978, 44). Wenfei Wang and Cindy Fan, in their article about the integration of rural migrants in China, divide integration into three categories: “economic integration”, “social/cultural integration” and “identity integration” (2012, 733). What T. Şenyapılı points out in the above quotation is that migrants in Istanbul, at the time she writes, are not integrated socially or culturally or in terms of identity; while in terms of finding ways to survive economically, and of creating a place to live, they manage their lives through their informal solutions. p. 48–49

It is a widely accepted argument that the strategies which allow migrants to survive in the urban environment do not enable them to culturally and socially integrate. This brings the impossibility of integration in terms of identity, according to this view. T. Şenyapılı stresses that working in a job which is accepted as urban is not sufficient for integration, the migrant also needs “income that [...] is sufficient to participate in urban life” (1978, 38). Önder Şenyapılı describes economic hardship as a barrier to adaptation to life in the urban context (1981b, 101). According to him “when peasants move to the city they are accepted as ‘urbanites’ since their labour becomes urban and they live in the city but, they are not ‘urbanites’ in the real sense”, and he describes them as “urbanizing peasants” (128). He adds that if “urban activities (or non-agricultural activities) in the city” and jobs that are “consistent, healthy, and bringing sufficient income” increase, then this process of urbanisation will also gain momentum (128). p. 49

Karpat, who describes the urbanisation of migrants as “specific processes of individual and collective sociopolitical and psychological acculturation” (2009, 137), has a more optimistic perception of integration. According to him, while “the village culture and modes of organization” are protected by migrants in the city, “the migrant adapts himself to urban conditions and gradually changes his physical living and cultural outlook” (138). Karpat summarises this process as follows: “the term *urbanization* encompasses both the migrant’s ‘integration’ through occupational change and gradual adoption of physical and cultural aspects of urban life and the city’s adoption of some elements of folk culture” (138). Based on the fieldwork conducted in three shanty towns of Istanbul in 1968, Karpat draws p. 49–50

attention to migrants' interest in "contact with the city and desire to know its inhabitants" as "a significant part in their urbanization" (150). "The established city population, however, showed no apparent desire to know, and integrate with the squatters [migrants living in shanties]" (155). He adds that even those members of the established population who accepted the inevitability of migration due to economic and social reasons did not refrain from a hostile discourse against migrants whom they viewed as a negative impact on the urban atmosphere (155).

p. 50 Until the migrant is assimilated she/he is faced with the risk of alienation in this unfamiliar, difficult and sometimes hostile environment of the city. Karpat contends that while the "economic and occupational integration" process "is the response to *marginality*", "*assimilation* [...] is one remedy for *alienation*" (43). Within such a context, for the migrant, the shanty town acquires a meaning much more than simply a neighbourhood; as Karpat aptly observes, it becomes "a 'rural' enclave in the city" (36). "The communal life provides the squatter with a sense of psychological security and belongingness, as well as group identity, which is his rationale for accepting the supremacy of the community" (128). He refers to Andrei Simić (1973) who observes that "problems of alienation on the part of the migrant are balanced by continuing participation as part of a village-based kinship network, while new ties are gradually created in the urban community" (quoted in Karpat 2009, 246 n. 69). As the quote elucidates, new connections and networks in the city do not emerge overnight, but over time, step by step. In other words, integration is a long-term process. That is why, for the migrant, the support mechanisms that the community offers are of crucial importance in order not to lose direction and integrity during the challenging task of adaptation. Karpat concludes that "the attachment to the communal culture, the sense of belongingness stemming from it, and the security achieved through ownership, prevent the squatters' psychological disintegration and alienation, and indirectly facilitate their integration into the urban environment" (232).

p. 51 Alienation due to the absence of solidarity networks can lead to nihilism in the urban setting. Malcolm James, for instance, brings attention to the "racialized and territorial acts of nihilism, in their virtual and physical manifestations" in outer East London in "the absence of alternative narratives of working-class or cosmopolitan solidarity" (2015, 712). This was not the case in the Turkish context. As explained above, there was a certain cosmopolitan solidarity in the shanty towns. As Kıray acknowledges, various sociological research demonstrates that "alienation and anomie did not emerge" in the migrant communities of Turkey (1982, 173–174). The complex structure that renders multiple versions of urbanity possible also functions as a revetment against alienation, anomie and nihilism.

It might be useful to briefly mention arabesk (arabesque) at this point, a musical style and subculture which was popular in shanty towns. Musically, it was regarded as a degenerate form of folk music (Stokes 1992, 92). It was seen as amorphous with Arab influences, hence the name arabesque, and its lyrics were criticised for being fatalistic. As Martin Stokes explains, "association of arabesk with the *gecekondu* links the music with an image of an urban lumpen proletariat dislocated and alienated through the process of labour migration" (108). He adds that this music was received as "a message of alienation from the periphery of Turkish urban society" (120). However, in arabesk "the language of migration, the south-east, and the *gecekondu* provides an idiom in which people are able to identify and present problems, difficulties, and frustrations in their own existence" (132).[2] Similarly, Meral Özbek criticises the tendency to identify arabesk with alienation (2002, 20–21). Özbek, noting that from the 1960s until the end of the 1980s this music went through various stages (23), explains that "arabesk music in the 1960s was not a manifestation of 'incongruity with the environment' of rural migrants in the cities, on the contrary it was a successful manifestation of their compatibility with the environment, their way of finding a way to survive" (27). Stokes identifies two central tenets in the early phase of arabesk: "rural-urban migration and a class awareness which cut across 'vertical', regional identities" (126). Stokes stresses that arabesk was "a music of the city and for the city" (1992, 1).

p. 52 Traditional folk music of Anatolia, a central component of oral culture which the rural migrants brought with them to the city, was always popular among migrants, during and after the heyday of arabesk. Inevitably, folk music was also influenced by the migration phenomenon. Aslı Kayhan describes the 1970s as "the period of transition from the traditional bard to the socially concerned modern poet-singer" and identifies it as "in effect a natural consequence of mass migration" (2014, 157). She concludes that "the task of narrating the destiny of the Anatolian person now settled in the city lies with the bards, who themselves partake of that same story" (157).

As discussed earlier, the anti-migrant discourse was intertwined with Istanbulite snobbism and nostalgia for a cosmopolitan past. If this mentality were replaced with an emphasis on the fact that Istanbul had always been a place of migration, then migrants could develop a stronger attachment to the city. Then, the dichotomy between urbanites and rural migrants would dissolve and we would perceive the urban population as comprising of urbanites and those who are becoming urbanites (i.e., migrants at different stages of their urbanisation process). Yet, this concept of urbanity should be flexible and not rigid. When migrants' integration is complete, their urbanity will most probably include elements of their folk culture. Surpassing elitism and a rigid, normative understanding of urbanity means embracing these

[2]Migrants not only from the south-east but all regions of Anatolia listened to this music. Stokes here refers to a certain phase in arabesk where singers from this region dominated the scene.

elements as the richness offered by the diversity in the city. Such an inclusive approach would welcome alternative urbanities.

Before closing this argument, it might be useful to refer to Karpat once again, who identifies four stages in the urbanisation of the rural migrant in Turkey. "The first phase is marked by the adoption of urban dress and some urban habits as preparatory steps toward assuming city views and attitudes" (2009, 139). Karpat stresses that the change in clothes takes a longer time in women migrants than in men due to their limited contact with the urban environment (139). In the second stage, the migrant starts using the available "city facilities [such] as water, electricity, and transportation, and also of regularly buying his food and clothing in shops" (139). In the third phase, he/she tends "to establish relations with other city people" based on the "new self-image modelled on urban forms that he considers superior or ideal" (139). Karpat observes that in the final stage of the urbanisation process the migrant reaches "full-identification with the city" now feeling that "he does not belong to the village but to the city" (140).

The ways migrants become urbanites in the city is a major theme in the seven novels of the corpus, as their analyses in the coming chapters demonstrate. "Change in the traditional culture among migrants seems to occur not as a sudden break with the past, but as a slow assimilation of the urban influence, and also adjustment of the folk culture to it" (40). Welcoming alternative urbanities which incorporate folk culture elements is central to the argument in this book as opposed to the elite's rigid perception of urbanity. Erman, writing back in 1998, explains that "as the result of the growing consciousness about diversity and ethnic identities in the world, a critical approach to the question of 'who and what is urban?' is developing. This has the potential of freeing the definition of an urbanite from the monopoly of the Republican elites" (1998a, 542). This perfect clarification of the issue by Erman resonates with Sassen's observation that "the definition of urbanity through subject and setting does not simply happen; it frequently comes out of hard work and painful trajectories" (2012, 85). Such a path goes through empathy. As Richard Sennett acknowledges, "though the word *empathy* is a modern one, this act of vision is dictated by the peculiar conditions of city life" (1992, 233). In the long history of the rural–urban migration in Turkey, empathy was a scarce virtue most of the time.

p. 53

Laying Claim to the City

Through informal ways of occupation such as vending and informal housing such as shanties migrants lay claim to the city. Asef Bayat describes such strategies as a form of street politics (2012, 119). Bayat, in an article where he searches for a way out of the dichotomy between "elite rule and subaltern's failure" (110) in times of neoliberal urbanity, stresses that the left sees the "neoliberal city [as] a lost city" where subalterns do not hope for better lives and "where the ideal of the right to the city is all but vanished" (117). While agreeing with various aspects of these arguments, Bayat draws attention to the need for surpassing "categorical dichotomies as passive-active, or win-lose" and examines "what possibilities the neo-liberal city may unintentionally furnish for subaltern struggles" (119). He defines streets as "indispensable asset/capital" for subalterns where they can "subsist and reproduce economic as well as cultural life" and regard them as a form of street politics (119): "street vendors who spread their business on the pavements, poor people who extend their lives onto the sidewalks, squatters who take over public lands, or protestors who march in the streets are all involved in street politics" (120).

p. 53–54

Bayat defines their strategies as "encroachment" (120), as well as "quiet encroachment of the ordinary" (2013, 80). He explains that "the reclamation, by the poor people, of public space through encroachment, stretching out, functioning, and subsisting constitutes an expression of street politics, while simultaneously feeding into and accentuating the political street. In other words, through this encroachment, the dispossessed are constantly engaged in struggles in and about the urban space" (2012, 120). This quiet encroachment of migrants in their struggle to survive in the city appears in this or that way in almost all the novels analysed in the following chapters. Encroachment on land by building shanties for shelter, or memories of this experience, appear in all of them. Vending on the streets, which is another form of quiet encroachment, has always been an important phenomenon in the lives of migrants since it is a means of self-employment in the city where job opportunities are scarce. These two phenomena, together with the self-organised 'public transport' of migrants in the form of the share taxi (*dolmush*), appear in the title of a book on their encroachment in the city: *Dolmuşlu, Gecekondulu, İşportalı Şehir* (*The City with Share Taxi, Shanty, and Vendor*) (Tekeli et al. 1976).

p. 54

That said, migrants' politics is not limited to street politics; they are also involved in 'politics as we know it'. Karpat explains that politics and political action have an important function in the integration/urbanisation process of migrants in shanty towns (2009, 43). He describes "political organization and action in the squatter settlements" as "by far the most dynamic form of interaction with city and national governments" (43). Migrants establish organisations under the banner of the Society for Settlement Improvement in order "to protect the property, develop the community, and secure the basic urban facilities such as water, electricity, and bus service from the city authority" (43). Additionally, they are aware of their power as voters in elections, which is instrumental in accessing these facilities (43). For them, choosing a party and supporting it has great importance "not only as channels of communication and pressure on

p. 54–55

authorities but also as mechanisms for integration into the city" (43). Karpat adds that migrants in shanties are usually criticised for being opportunistic in their political moves (43). Indeed, Mübeccel Kıray describes "clientelism" as an important survival strategy of migrants (2007c, 185). For Karpat, the situation labelled as migrants' opportunism is an inevitable result of "hostile attitudes on the part of the police, city residents, and occasionally the press" (2009, 43) that they encounter. They seek solutions to their problems by "uniting and rapidly developing organizational skills and a sophisticated, pragmatic view of politics" (43–44). Karpat describes migrants' capability for collective action and its connection with their integration into the city as follows: "Their struggle for survival as a community and as individuals in the city eventually creates habits of collective action, a sense of communal and civic responsibility. Political groupings and associations became also inadvertently channels of communication through which the squatters gradually define their new urban identity and relate themselves to the outside world, on the basis not only of tradition but also of rational decision and interest" (44). As this observation elucidates, engaging in political processes is integral to migrants' urbanisation.

p. 55–56 Karpat argues that migrants in shanty towns did not possess "hate and aversion toward the system, as romantic revolutionaries had speculated and hoped for" (44). Consequently, he adds, radicals were not successful in mobilizing shanty dwellers "for violent and radical action" (44). Şükrü Aslan, on the contrary, describes the 1970s as times when the radical left had support in shanty towns and stresses that there were even various shanty towns established by radical left groups as an implementation of their belief in the right to housing (2004, 85). As Aslan acknowledges, the number of such neighbourhoods was around twelve. Additionally, the left had members and organisations in other shanty towns which they did not control (email to author, 2 July 2016). Kıvılcım Ertan explains that the "shanty movements" which should be regarded as "housing movements" were part of the "urban movements" which flourished in Turkey in the 1970s (1999, 126).[3] The experiences Aslan explains fall into this category. Notwithstanding these experiences, Karpat's analysis that the dominant tendency in shanty settlements was not towards radicalism as much as it was towards democratic participation is valid on the macro-scale. Karpat emphasises that radical ideologies "can find acceptance in the settlement if the normal channels for demand satisfaction and political participation are closed to squatters" (2009, 200). This is the moment when the rural migrant in the city discovers a potential that would be unknown to him/her back in the village. In Sassen's words, "the city, and especially the street, is a space where the powerless can make history, in ways they cannot in rural areas" (2013, 213). The neighbourhoods Aslan refers to are good examples of this sort of history making, yet these experiences were not predominant in the case of Istanbul.

p. 56 Apart from a few exceptions, quiet encroachment, rather than participatory politics and urban movements, enter the novels analysed in the following pages. Neither migrants' capability of taking direct action through participatory politics, nor their potential to build urban social movements, appear as a theme or message in these books. In other words, almost none of the works in the corpus stresses the fact that migrants as agents can actually fight for their right to the city under the umbrella of participatory politics and urban movements instead of simply confining themselves to quiet encroachment.

Women: "The Locomotive of Migration"

p. 56 In this final section of the chapter, the focus is on the gender dimension of migration. At this point, we should remember that in Turkish rural society "women are under male control" and "have very low status and power", a situation enhanced by Islamic influences which have added to the power of patriarchy (Erman 1997, 264).

As Tahire Erman aptly observes, women's roles do not find much place within the considerable amount of research made on third-world urbanisation and migration (263). Erman acknowledges that "women are assumed to be merely passive movers, following their husbands, fathers or sons to the city", and adds that, in fact, "women play a much more active role in migration than depicted in mainstream migration literature" (263).

p. 56–57 While Erman, writing in 1997, criticises the fact that "most of the sociological research on migrants has been carried out with 'the heads of the household,' which usually means husbands or fathers" (263), Karpat's research, dating back to 1968, was one which did not have this blind side, and in the fieldwork which he conducted in three shanty towns in Istanbul the number of interviewees were more or less the same: 467 women and 482 men (5). Based on the data of this research Karpat contends that women predominantly had positive feelings for having moved to Istanbul (130). He asserts that in addition to better living standards and physical conditions, for women, migration was also an escape from close contact with in-laws (131). Together with this positive attitude about being in the city, however, women expressed an intense resentment about their inferior position on the social scale in the urban setting (131). This might well be connected with women's greater capacity for awareness and expression of their feelings than men possess, a subject beyond the scope of this work. Karpat also adds that "the differences of outlook, style of living, and level of

[3] Ertan divides the social movements in Turkey into two main groups: (a) the urban movements of the 1970s: municipality movements (participatory and democratic municipalities based on the civil society framework such as the İzmit and Fatsa experiences); shanty movements; and environmental movements with an urban focus (125). (b) New social movements from the 1980s onwards: environmental movements with a wider ecological scope and agenda (126).

aspiration showed much sharper variation among the *gecekondu* [shanty] women than men" (131). He observes that women in the shanty towns demonstrate "an unusual sense of independence in wanting to have a say in the choice of their future husbands" (153). He also underscores their preference "to marry men from the city because of their urban upbringing, which made them well mannered and respectful of women" (153).

Similarly, Erman, based on her fieldwork among migrant women in Ankara, the capital of Turkey, states that "Turkish migrant women have a strong preference for the city" (1997, 267). During the early era of migration in Turkey, she notes, men migrated to cities first, and then their wives followed them; however, after a while "the majority of migrants started moving to the city as families" (264). Based on the data of her research conducted in the late 1990s, Erman stresses that women were not always simply following their husbands to the city but in some cases were initiating the migration process (268). Her research also reveals that there were cases where the woman of the family was more active than the man in getting the family settled in the city, using connections and skills for creating income opportunities (268). She concludes that "when compared to the hard, unacknowledged labor of women for their husbands and the husbands' families in the village and the control extended families and the village community have over women, especially over daughters-in-law, city living is preferable for Turkish peasant women" (270). p. 57

In the migrant families, the number of women working outside of home is relatively low (Kıray 1999, 170; Erman 1997, 265). Mübeccel Kıray asserts that in the first wave of migration in the 1950s, migrant women predominantly did domestic work while in the following decades they found jobs in low-paid unsecured jobs at places like workshops and warehouses (1999, 170). Among the second-generation migrant working women in Istanbul, employment as factory workers was widespread (171). Migrant women also engaged in domestic production such as sewing and knitting (171). Kıray emphasises that the income made in such ways resulted in serious transformations in the balances between men and women in families (171). Despite that, as Kıray observes, "these jobs keep migrant women's labour at a rate much lower than it should be" (171). She adds that migrant women favoured factory work, as this presented a life outside of home, and the second-generation women aspired to being teachers or white-collar workers, which first-generation women would never be able to dream of (171). p. 57–58

During the early phases of migration, the literacy of men but not women increased; however, this changed after a while; in second and third-generation migrant populations, girls became more successful than boys in their studies (172). Migrant women supported and motivated their daughters to get a good education as this could lead the way to a white-collar job and/or marriage with a white-collar or small entrepreneur husband (172). Kıray asserts that even when a woman's education does not lead to employment it has positive effects on her parenting and interaction with family members (173). In 1981, referring to a survey conducted in 1976, T. Şenyapılı expresses her expectation that the literacy levels of male and female shanty dwellers would be equal in the short term (1981a, 202–203). She also notes that girls' "increased education is concentrated at the primary and high school levels and not at the college or university level" (203). p. 58

As Erman acknowledges, "living in the city, usually in independent nuclear units, increases women's autonomy by making them responsible for organizing domestic life. They are given (out of necessity) greater responsibility in administering the urban household" (1997, 270). Kıray analyses this role of migrant women within the framework of consumption dynamics in the city as regards migration, stressing that "in the urban economy the migrant is above all a consumer. The woman is the person who implements this" (1999, 173). She contends that "for the migrant family, 'consuming like urbanites' is the first condition of being an urbanite and women organise this" (174). She explains that the migrant woman divides consumption into two categories. In the first category, for products visible to others she practices conspicuous consumption; while in the second category, for the products seen only by the family members she holds the consumption at the lowest minimum (174). She adds that the migrant woman gets a lot of information and inspiration about consumer products and styles from television adverts (175). In addition to television, as T. Şenyapılı observes, "magazines that relate romantic love stories through pictures" are an important influence on migrant women (1981a, 204). She defines consumption as "the only channel for integration offered by the urban society, willingly and completely" to the rural migrants living in the shanty towns (206). She emphasises that the migrant woman living in the shanty "more than her husband, is sensitive to integration into urban life and is therefore open to consumption stimulants and relevant consumption norms" and therefore "pushes for acquisition of real estate, consumer goods, modern gadgets and is tolerant towards children who want to follow the latest urban fashions" (213). p. 58–59

In the city, migrant women have more freedom in raising their children than they would do in the countryside as the husbands are mostly at work and the elderly are left behind in the village (Kıray 1999, 175). They are also successful in making and maintaining neighbour relations (175). As Kıray acknowledges, the migrant woman is also in charge of organising social relations with relatives and fellow migrants from the same place of origin. She adds that the migrant woman encourages her adolescent daughter to adapt to city life, with the intention she might give her permission to go out and supply her with extra pocket money secretly from her husband and neighbours (175–176). In conclusion, "the migrant woman in the city goes through an active adaptation process and influences the second generation" (177). p. 59

As Wilson acknowledges, “although women, along with minorities, children, the poor, are still not full citizens in the sense that they have never been granted full and free access to the streets, industrial life still drew them into public life, and they have survived and flourished in the interstices of the city, *negotiating the contradictions of the city* in their own particular way” (1991, 8).[4] As explained above, some migrant women were fortunate enough to have industrial jobs while others worked as domestic helpers or performed domestic production. In any case, they had a completely different life than they would do back in their villages. Simon Parker’s explanation of these women’s reclaiming of the public space, “negotiating the contradictions of the city” to borrow Wilson’s phrase, is worth quoting at length:

p. 60 For working-class women, or women from the less affluent social classes, the street was much more of a communal space, or even a feminised space, to the extent that adult males were either at work or enjoying the closed world of the public house or bar. This left public amenities and markets as well as the street itself as a mostly female domain during the working week. Therefore, it is important when discussing the “gendering of the urban landscape” not to assume that this means “the masculinisation” of city spaces, and to remember that the urban experience varies quite markedly depending on women’s social and ethnic/cultural identity as much as it does for men. (Parker 2004, 144)

Parker’s observation is very much valid for the rural migrant women in Istanbul who do the shopping for their family, walk their children to school, have vivid relations with their neighbours, and so forth. That said, we should not overlook the fact that integration and urbanisation is more challenging for women than for men. As Erman observes, “while migrant women do not have anything but their housing environment and their kin and neighbors as the basis for their self-identities, migrant men have their occupations and occasionally inter-actions with the more established urbanites at work, as well as their interactions with the established parts of the city as the basis for feeling themselves to be urbanites” (1998a, 550). The case would be different for migrant women who have formal jobs, but they are only a small minority.

p. 60–61 Migrant women constitute a highly heterogeneous category based on economic, social, cultural, ethnic and religious background resulting in tremendous differences in their adaptation processes, struggles with patriarchy and the consequent freedoms they manage to gain. In the city, “some have become ‘initiating’ in the face of the demanding conditions and challenges the city provided and have gained some power and a strong sense of self in the family; some enjoy less demanding lives, yet lack that kind of power; some have worked hard in the family but still lack the power the initiating women enjoy; and still others struggle to break away from traditional gender roles” (Erman 1998b, 159). Life in the city is a difficult test for migrant women: they battle with changing roles and responsibilities within their family life, striving to protect delicate balances. These changing roles and new responsibilities of women is a major dynamic in the migration phenomenon. As Fatmagül Berktay points out, “during survival in the city after migration, women become the locomotive” (2019, min. 93). Berktay stresses that “women are and have been more resilient in the struggle with poverty and disadvantage” (ibid.). Indeed, women have a tremendous role in keeping their family together through the sea change they face upon migration.

p. 61 Berktay adds that “women’s demand for the right to the city corresponds to the demand for the right to the city by all those who are oppressed and exploited” (2019, mins. 22–23). In the analysis of the seven novels in the following pages, we will address thematic elaborations of this fact as well as other issues about migrant women through the female characters in the works.

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[4] Emphasis added.

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CHAPTER 4 Istanbul Meets Its New Members: An Overview of Istanbul's History as Regards Migration

This chapter comprises a brief history of Istanbul after the 1950s in the context of migration to the city, particularly mass rural migration starting in the 1950s, and related topics such as the migrants' integration into urban life and old Istanbulites' perceptions about them. p. 65

Eric Jan Zürcher, at the beginning of his book *Turkey, A Modern History*, accents the inevitability of periodisation while studying history, and divides the 1950s to 1990s period in Turkey's history as follows: "the rule of the Democratic Party, 1950–60; the second Turkish Republic, 1960–80 and, the Third Republic: since 1980" (2004, v). This chapter loosely adopts this periodisation, together with Tahire Erman's periodisation regarding studies on informal shanty housing (*gecekondu*) in Turkey: the 1950s and the 1960s; the 1970s and the early 1980s; the mid-1980s and the mid-1990s; and the late 1990s (2001, 984).

Istanbul was the capital of the Eastern Roman Empire from ad 330 until 1453 and the Ottoman Empire from 1453 until 1923. As the city became an important centre of commerce and trade in Europe during the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, its cosmopolitan character grew even stronger (Keyder and Öncü 1993, 14). Since the imperial palace and administration were located in Istanbul, a significant number of Westernised upper-class Muslims inhabited the city, which contributed to its cosmopolitan atmosphere. Until World War I, the city had a significant minority population comprising Greeks, Sephardic Jews and Armenians (14–15).[1] According to the 1885–1886 census, as of 1886, Muslim Turks constituted only 44 per cent of the city's population which was around one million (Toprak et al. 1997, 201). p. 65–66

A series of events following World War I provoked the minority population's decline in Istanbul. While the 1923 population exchange between Greece and Turkey excluded Istanbul's Greek minority, in the period between the World Wars a substantial number of wealthy non-Muslim families and foreigners who no longer felt safe and secure in the country emigrated (Keyder and Öncü 1993, 15). After the Kemalist regime made Ankara the capital of the Turkish Republic, Istanbul, which "became the symbolic vestige of decadent Ottoman cosmopolitanism [...] was marginalized not only politically but also culturally" (15). However, after World War II, as a result of the dynamics in Turkey's international political and economic relations, Istanbul became the "growth pole" of the expanding economy (16). p. 66

The 1950s and the 1960s

Between 1950 and 1970 private manufacturing enterprises spread in Istanbul and "51 percent of total employment in Turkish private industry" was located in the city (17), which created a considerable need for labour. Additionally, in the second half of the 1950s, Adnan Menderes, the prime minister of the time, launched an extensive urban transformation project, with disastrous effects on the city's historical and cultural heritage, which turned the city into a massive building site and created demand for labourers, including unskilled ones. p. 66

Sema Erder describes the past and the present Istanbul as "a destination for migrant populations, changing and cosmopolitan in its composition" (1999, 161). She points out that, until the 1950s, the Muslims, and the minorities (i.e., Armenians, Greeks and Jews) who were not only the religious but also the ethnic minorities of the city, comprised the urban population (161). As Erder observes, after the 1950s Istanbul's population went through two major changes almost simultaneously. On the one hand, the minority population declined. On the other, the city received two major waves of migration: Turkish migrants from Balkan countries benefiting from international agreements and rural migrants from Anatolia became the new members of the city (161). p. 66–67

The first phase of the minority population's decline in the city resulted from the Wealth Tax imposed in November 1942 aimed at those who had profited from the war. Implementation of the Wealth Tax law was scandalous: "the small non-Muslim communities, [...] were subjected to rates ten times higher than those of Muslims" (Zürcher 2004, 199–200). With the shameful and devastating Riots of 6–7 September 1955 against the Greeks in the city, where some members of the Armenian minority were also attacked, and the 1964 expulsion of Greek citizens from Turkey the city forfeited a significant portion of its minority population. p. 67

Where migration to the city is concerned, since migrants from the Balkans had settled in Istanbul under the supervision of public authorities their reception was unproblematic, which was not the case for rural migrants who had tried to find their own ways to survive in the city: these Anatolian migrants were "peasants" in the eyes of the old urbanites of the city (Erder 1999, 161), who regarded "their mode of arrival, occupation of land, construction of housing, search for employment, and style of life [...] as alien" (162). This led to the discourse of the "peasantization of cities" and an "urban-peasant divide" (161). As Erder observes, rural migrants who were seen as a homogeneous group were expected to integrate into urban life by "changing [their] life styles" (162). Until the 1980s, the characteristics of this

[1] 'Minority' and 'minorities' denote the non-Muslim minority population(i.e., Greeks, Armenians, and Jews.

integration was a heated debate for journalists and scholars who criticised those who could not successfully integrate into the urban culture (162). Migrants' integration was the focus of discussions on urban problematics (162).

p. 67–68 The majority of rural migrants lived in shanty houses. The word for a shanty in Turkish is *gecekondu*, which means built overnight. Shanty settlements started to appear by the end of the 1940s, as "a non-market solution for those who were excluded by the formal housing market as well as the state" (Işık and Pınarcıoğlu 2001, 112). In the first era of the shanty phenomenon, migrants built their shanties "on the Treasury land on the periphery of the city" (113). As Oğuz Işık and Melih Pınarcıoğlu observe, during this era, shanty settlements did not cause a serious conflict owing to two factors. The first was "*multi-stage migration*" (114) which enables the migrant to maintain his financial and social ties with his hometown and go back for a while, and bring his family to the city after he is established, which reduces the trauma of migration (115). The second factor was the structure of land ownership. In Turkey the state owns the largest share of land in and around cities, which is called the Treasury land (115). At the first stages of migration, as migrants occupied pieces of the Treasury land for building shanties, the state preferred to remain "a silent collaborator" in the process (115). Işık and Pınarcıoğlu also stress that a common hometown origin network was another key characteristic of the early era of shanty life (117). As Çağlar Keyder points out, since the state was not acting as a welfare state in practice, newcomers in the city were supporting each other to a certain extent through "kinship and neighbourhood reciprocity" (2005, 127).

p. 68 Erman finds considerable changes in the way shanty dwellers were perceived in the four periods mentioned above. She asserts that in the 1950s and the 1960s they were seen as "the rural Other" (2001, 984). In those years, they were viewed as having arrived in the city with their rural culture and regarded as peasants. Thus, "under the influence of [modernisation] theory, Turkish scholars expected the assimilation of rural migrants into the modern urban society" (985). This approach dominated public opinion as well as the institutions of urban planning and organisation.

Keyder's analysis summarises the 1950s and the 1960s in a lucid way. He acknowledges that through Menderes's developmentalist vision Istanbul was seen as the locomotive of the "political economy of national development" (2010, 180). In the city where the population "doubled from the 1950s to the 1960s", Keyder notes, growth was characterised by a lack of order and planning since "shantytowns developed where it was easiest to occupy and to build, [and] industry was located where it was easiest to pollute" (181). This was the picture of the city as it reached the end of the 1960s.

The 1970s

p. 68 In the 1970s, shanties started to evolve from an inevitable solution of poor migrants to their housing problem to "profitable commodities" (Erman 2001, 986), as some shanty owners started renting or selling them. This era also coincides with the interest in upmarket housing in the suburbs of the city, which increased the value of the land outside the city centre. Despite that, the ruling parties did not act against shanty builders, as these were the years of leftist activism and shanty dwellers were potential supporters of the left (987). Erman adds that, in the 1970s and early 1980s, shanty dwellers were perceived as "the disadvantaged Other" (984) in shanty studies.

p. 69 Overall, until the 1980s, as Erder explains, migrants' presence in the city did not really cause a problem. Migrant men worked hard for low wages, while their wives were useful as helpers in middle and upper-class homes. "For politicians they were a potential store of votes to be tapped, and for government officials they were 'people' less demanding than citizens" (1999, 162). Yet, the city was by no means a bed of roses, neither for migrants nor for the old Istanbulites. Keyder describes the Istanbul of the 1970s as "a grimy, unkempt, and dark third-world metropolis", stressing that in the city, which had a total population of around four million inhabitants by the middle of the decade, even upper-class areas had infrastructure problems and "gloomy facades" (2010, 181). The departure of more Greeks from Istanbul as a result of Turkey's invasion of Cyprus in 1974 added to the claustrophobic atmosphere in the city in that decade.

The 1980s

p. 69 After the 12 September 1980 military coup which brutally repressed the leftist movement of the country, a new government was formed. The new Prime Minister Turgut Özal swiftly introduced liberal economic policies. Erman stresses that these policies had serious negative effects on the majority of the population: migration to large cities increased while "unemployment rates and hence social discontent" climbed (2001, 987). She adds that, as distribution of income changed to the detriment of the poor in those years, discontent accelerated among "the economically disadvantaged strata, particularly among rural migrants in the city" (987). In the meantime, the Amnesty Acts of 1984–1987 rendered it legitimate to build up to four-storey buildings on shanty land. This resulted in "the commercialization of *gecekondus*, which could be interpreted again as the government's 'bribing' those who suffered the most for their liberal policies" (987).

While apartment blocks started to replace former shanties, shanty housing lost its initial meaning and function as shelter, and turned into a source of profit as "the 'apartmentalisation' of gecekondus became a widespread phenomenon" (987). Yet, not all shanty dwellers were able to profit from their houses. As Erman notes, in the 1980s, while some of them were becoming rich, others were suffering from "increasing deprivation" (987), hence her description of the perspective in shanty studies between the mid-1980s and the mid-1990s as "'the urban poor Other(s)' versus 'the undeserving Other(s)' and 'the culturally inferior Other(s) as sub-culture'" (984), implying a separation between shanty dwellers. As Erman observes, this process brought forth a social and cultural clash between the newly rich migrants and the urban elites. According to her, in the 1980s and the 1990s it became clear that "rural migrants/*gecekondu* people [could] rapidly jump up to a higher economic stratum" and also "shape the city by creating their own ways of life and sets of values" —and there was a world of difference between their life styles and values and those of the "modernising urban elites" (987). Some former shanty dwellers moved into apartments carrying "their own culture" to their new spaces (987). Erman defines this era as the stage when "rural migrants/*gecekondu* people" were regarded as the "the culturally inferior Other as sub-culture" (987). In conclusion, the split in society took on a more complex and multi-dimensional form than a simple "urban-peasant divide" in the 1980s (Erder 1999, 162). Additionally, from the middle of the decade onwards the city's face started to change in line with the process of its globalisation (Keyder 2005, 128), a phenomenon examined below.

p. 69–70

The 1990s

Social, economic, cultural and political life in Istanbul in the 1990s, especially after the mid-1990s, was marked by three interrelated phenomena closely related to migration and migrants in the city: the arrival of internally displaced Kurds in Istanbul; globalisation, urban poverty and social exclusion; and the rise of political Islam.

p. 70

As the guerrilla attacks of the Partiya Karkeren Kurdistan (the Kurdistan Workers Party) (PKK), fighting for the Kurdish national movement against the Turkish Republic since the 1980s, intensified and took the form of a low-intensity war, the state started to evacuate Kurdish villages in order to stop the villagers supporting the guerrillas. Together with other policies and enforcements which made life in the area unbearable, an estimated two to three million citizens were internally displaced (Çelik 2005, 980), which is described by Cihan Ahmetbeyzade as an "internal diaspora" (2007, 161). The inrush of a substantial number of Kurds from the eastern parts of the country into its (mostly western) metropolises, especially in the second half of the 1990s, was different from their earlier economic migration. If we consider economic migration as 'voluntary', then we can call the migration in the 1990s 'involuntary'. Bediz Yılmaz argues that although this type of migration is usually addressed as "*forced migration*", the term "*involuntary migration*" would be more suitable since it covers those who migrated from evacuated villages as well as those who migrated "due to various reasons connected with the conflict environment" (2008, 135).

p. 70–71

Deniz Yükseker lists the problems triggered by this internal displacement in the 1990s as follows: "urban poverty, lack of access to education and health services, lack of social security, unemployment, and discrimination within urban spaces" (2007, 256). The Kurdish population living in the countryside who made their living through agriculture and stock breeding did not have the opportunity to compete in the job market in urban centres, as they did not have the necessary education or job experience. Moreover, unlike economic migrants, internally displaced Kurds did not have the benefits of multi-stage migration. Their housing conditions were very poor, they could not adequately feed themselves, and their children mostly did not have the chance to go to school (264). Yükseker adds that in the case of internal displacement "traditional solidarity networks" were not functional, as most of the relatives were also poor and they were also internally displaced (264). Additionally, building a shanty was not an option for the internally displaced Kurds in Istanbul since they did not have the financial means to build them in the few areas left in the city where this could have been possible. Thus, they either rented shanties with no infrastructure or apartments in run-down neighbourhoods. Some of them could purchase such housing if they had the opportunity to "sell their livestock or some of their property just before displacement" (265–266).

p. 71

Internally displaced Kurds did "informal and irregular jobs" such as "periodic work as street peddlers or as construction workers" while some of them worked as "seasonal agricultural labourers"; some children worked on the streets selling "tissue paper and bottled water", some women worked in "childcare or housecleaning", while a considerable number of "the teenage daughters worked in garment workshops" (267–268). Collecting and selling raw material also provided some informal income (Çağlayan et al. 2011, 23).

Many internally displaced Kurds did not have the necessary language skills to communicate in Turkish. Additionally, as a result of the escalating hostility against Kurds in public opinion in response to the PKK's guerrilla war and terror attacks, internally displaced Kurds in the cities experienced discrimination. As Yükseker observes, one of the results of internal displacement was "being subject to discrimination in urban spaces" which led to social exclusion (2007, 257). As discussed earlier, rural migrants faced prejudice due to stigmatisation as peasants, yet Kurdish migrants experienced a double prejudice both for being Kurdish and for being peasants (274). Hamza Aktan emphasises that as the Kurdish

p. 71–72

neighbourhoods struggled with poverty, they became isolated, a situation which pushed both Kurds and Turks away from a common mental ground based on empathy (2012, 64–65). Consequently, in the Istanbul of the 1990s, social exclusion was an important societal problem.

p. 72 Urban poverty in Istanbul, which was seriously aggravated by the neoliberal economic policies of the Özal era in the 1980s, increased with the effects of globalisation in the 1990s. This resulted in the social exclusion of the poor, a large portion of which comprised internally displaced Kurds in the city. Istanbul had a key role in Turkey's efforts to connect with a globalising economy after the 1980s (Öncü 1997, 57; Keyder 2005, 124). In the 1990s, the economy of the city was changing towards "informality" and "deindustrialization" (Keyder 2005, 128). The service sector mostly replaced manufacturing in the city and the modus operandi of the working class changed visibly: now fewer workers could join unions, while many of them did not even have "formal social security arrangements" (129).

In this process, Keyder observes, those new to the city were not able to benefit from hometown and kinship relations in order to find jobs or make social connections. Economic inequality deepened and poverty became easily noticeable in the city in the 1990s (124). As Keyder points out, "polarisation", a valid term for the globalising cities of the first world, is not sufficient to explain the case in the globalising cities of the third world such as Istanbul where "exclusion" is experienced concomitantly with "polarisation" (128). Keyder defines "social exclusion" as "a failure of social integration at economic, political and cultural levels", and notes "failures in the welfare regime and [...] the lack of cultural integration" as important catalysts of this phenomenon (128).

p. 72–73 Thanks to populist policies, migrants who built shanties were somewhat tolerated by the public until the 1990s when they started to be regarded as "invaders of public property and beneficiaries of unfair privilege" (130). In the absence of the shanty, now the newcomers to the city had no other chance than renting, and what they could afford were grim places in remote parts or in run-down neighbourhoods of the city (130). Keyder describes the former official approach to shanty housing, which enabled migrants to solve their housing needs, as the most effective of the non-formal dimensions of the welfare regime during the entire developmentalist era (131). Keyder aptly observes that the disappearance of shanty housing and related mechanisms played a major role in the emergence of social exclusion, since migrants who could not build a shanty anymore had to live in an isolated way, or even become homeless (131). Similarly, Işık and Pınarcıoğlu assert that to be able to comprehend the dynamics which led to the emergence of urban poverty in Turkey we need to understand "the evolution of the shanty phenomenon" (2001, 103). As discussed above, the migration process as well as the ethnic, social, economic and cultural background of migrants were other important factors in the emergence of social exclusion (Keyder 2005, 131).

p. 73–74 In such a context, the Left, having lost most of its power with the 1980 military coup, could no longer be influential among migrants in shanty towns on the outskirts of the city, or in the poor neighbourhoods in the city centre. This paved the way for the emergence of a new influence: political Islam. As Cihan Tuğal explains, "the Islamist party started to appeal to a rural-to-urban immigrant population after the 1980s—due in part to its social justice agenda as well as to the repression of the Left, the previous carrier of that agenda" (2009, 430). He adds that, as the provincial bourgeoisie became powerful and started to conduct more business in big cities, "in the 1990s the party also got votes from metropolitan centers" (430). Tuğal stresses that this made "the connotations of 'the urban' [...] to be more positive" for Islamists, and defines the agenda of the Islamist party at this stage as the "reconquest of Istanbul" (430). In the 1989 local elections, Islamists took two periphery municipalities of Istanbul, Sultanbeyli and Arnavutköy, while in 1994, their candidate R. Tayyip Erdoğan became the mayor of Istanbul. Analysing the impact of this development in the context of Istanbul, Tuğal draws attention to the fact that there were two tendencies within the Islamist party at the time: those with "more neoliberal tendencies [...] argued that after its 'conquest' Istanbul would be more integrated with the world", while the others "wanted to see the termination of the elitist exclusion that had kept the masses on the borders of cities" (431). He explains that Islamists managed to win shanty votes owing to their skills "in mobilizing various kinds of squatter networks" (431). He also attracts attention to the debut of "a new religious middle class", albeit a much smaller community than the residents of shanty towns (431). Consequently, "a gradual Islamization of cities" (431) was inevitable.

p. 74 Tuğal explains that political Islam's approach appealed to various "classes within rural-to-urban immigrants", while it managed to aid the poor in some ways (431). Political Islam managed to find "an answer to the desire to find one's place in the city and articulating the shared populist reaction against the urban center and the urban elite" (431). Tuğal defines "two elements [which] were central to the Islamist construction of the urbanizing subject: being in need of guidance (being 'lost') and being different from the elite" (431). To a significant extent "Islamism [...] gives marginal settlements and rural-to-urban immigrants a new sense of identity" (436). As Tuğal observes, the Islamist party "cultivate[s], explore[s], and shape[s] the new popular imagination" while it "builds itself on the identities and self-organizing capacity of the immigrants as much as it shapes these" (436). Tuğal stresses that "Islamist politics actually comes in when existing immigrant identities and communities risk remaining parochial and weak" and adds: "Islamism, rather than simply support and include immigrants' subjectivities and communities, transforms the city through interacting with them, but also redefining them" (436).

The Late 1990s and the 2000s

As Keyder asserts, "problems of human rights, equal citizenship and recognition" are experienced in municipal politics wherever the new urban poor is concerned (2005, 133). He draws attention to the fact that, after the 1990s, the media adopted a discourse hinting that a sort of unrest was growing in shanty towns (133). These were also the years when shanty towns started to be called *varoş* in a pejorative manner. *Varoş*, which is the Turkish version of the Hungarian word *város*, literally means a neighbourhood on the periphery of the city. In Turkey, it is "a label that artificially defines low income settlements as a homogenous space and in recent years has carried a robust exclusionary potential" (Demirtaş and Şen 2007, 87). In line with these developments, Erman describes the image of people living in shanties as "the threatening/varoşlu [*varoş* dweller] Other" in the late 1990s (2001, 984). Keyder points out that the mainstream media presents "the demand for full citizenship rights (civil, political and social)" as the outcome of cultural difference with a primarily class-based and secondarily ethnic edge, "overlaid with the modern/traditional divide" (2005, 133). Therefore, as he observes, when people cannot modernise, they are blamed for holding too much onto their traditional culture and values, while the "absence of mechanisms of incorporation" (133) are not mentioned. Additionally, those who are in the richer echelons or in dominant positions create the illusion that poverty is "an individual problem of a transitory nature" and that support through charity mechanisms can be sufficient to fight against it (133). p. 74–75

The earthquake in Istanbul in 1999 almost ended migration to the city (Keyder 2005, 125), while the impact of globalisation and neoliberal policies continued in the 2000s. In February 2001, a major economic crisis led to a significant increase in unemployment. In 2002, Justice and Development Party (AKP), a party with Islamic origins which describes itself as conservative democratic, formed a single-party government. The AKP government carried out various reforms "which made the integration of the economy into global networks of capital flows more stable" (Keyder 2010, 182). According to Keyder, the neoliberal AKP was well aware of Istanbul's potential for business and investment, so the government's next step was preparing the city for its new role. Istanbul was to attract foreign entrepreneurs as well as tourists; thus, new glamorous offices and residences, as well as "hotels, cultural centers, congress venues, museums and restaurants", were being opened (182). Consequently, the urban transformation of the city accelerated. The Mass Housing Administration (TOKİ) found ways to clear away all remaining shanties in the central parts of the city with a wide scale of excuses "such as protection of heritage, absence of earthquake preparedness, environment and creation of green zones" (182). Residents of shanties in these "rehabilitated" areas found themselves in the mass housing of TOKİ in remote parts of the city (182). They suffered from serious problems related to their new residences, such as high monthly maintenance charges, strict rules and isolation. p. 75

Gentrification became an important issue in the city during its globalisation as old neighbourhoods turned into objects of desire for investors (183–184). Meanwhile, Istanbul's historical landmarks, cuisine and expanding cultural life started to receive increasing interest from all over the world (184). It was the new hip city for foreign travellers and a fertile land for international entrepreneurs.

Nostalgia for old Istanbul, as discussed in the Introduction, was a growing phenomenon in the 1990s. Keyder points out that Istanbul, like other cities competing to become global, had to promote its historical heritage. While the classicists wanted to emphasise Istanbul's Byzantine identity, those sympathetic with the Islamist culture preferred to present it as "the Islamic city of the devout [...] promised to the believers" (185). Eventually, the secular elite and those with Islamist leanings found a common ground: "the Ottoman capital of many cultures" (185). This emphasis on the cosmopolitan aspect of Istanbul as the Ottoman capital resulted in an "exceedingly popular trend of nostalgia tak[ing] as its reference point a certain idealized representation of Istanbul in the late 19th century" which appears in "novels, articles and scholarly projects, and in the everyday discourse of Istanbulites" (Örs 2002, 134). İlay Örs emphasises that "a yearning towards an idealized multicultural coexistence" and its symbols emerged as a reaction to the changes in the city's social fabric, concomitant with the arrival of rural migrants (135). As mentioned in Chapter 1, Örs describes this as "cosmopolitanist nostalgia" (2018, 174). Rıfat Bali, tracking the nostalgic discourse particularly through its manifestations in the popular media, aptly observes that in the 1990s there was a considerable number of journalists who thought that Istanbul had lost its character and identity, and lamented its minority heritage in their writings (2002, 142). p. 76

Since this nostalgia covers not only the Ottoman but also the early Republican Istanbul before mass rural migration, it ignores the fact that the minority population had in fact declined from the establishment of the Turkish Republic in 1923 until the rural migrants' arrival in the 1950s. In other words, as those who adopt this discourse juxtapose the disappearance of the cosmopolitan minorities with the appearance of rural migrants in the city so do they create the illusion that these rural migrants pushed out Istanbul's minorities to make space for themselves. Migrants' rental of run-down apartments in former minority neighbourhoods, which had been dilapidating since they were vacated by their original residents who were the members of the minority population, subliminally motivate people to accept this illusory correlation between the disappearance of minorities and the arrival of rural migrants as reality.[2]

[2] One of the severest urban transformation projects in the city was launched in one such area, Tarlabaşı, and is currently still in progress.

The Year 2010 and After

p. 77 The outcome of Istanbul's globalisation peaked with the celebration of Istanbul 2010—European Capital of Culture. As Asu Aksoy points out, the 2010 Initiative Group expressed concern about the negative impact of gentrification on the lower socioeconomic strata during the preparations for the celebrations (2012, 94). Aksoy adds that cultural heritage was damaged as a result of the urban transformation activities in the historic areas of the city (95). Controversial urban transformation projects, particularly those carried out in Sulukule and Tarlabaşı, have been the subject of fierce debate. As a result of these projects, the Romani people lost their homes in Sulukule. A similar process was experienced in Tarlabaşı, a former Greek neighbourhood, where Romani and Kurdish people as well as African migrants without residence permits lived (105). As a consequence of the transformation which began in 2005, and took effect in 2010, most of the apartments in Tarlabaşı got emptied. In the meantime, a renewal project in the historic neighbourhoods of Fener, Balat and Ayvansaray was launched in 2006. In addition to these historic central areas, urban transformation activities were conducted in shanty towns on the outskirts of the city, such as Fikirtepe and Ayazma, to make their land available for massive gated community projects.

p. 77–78 In relation to globalisation, Turkey started to receive foreign migrants as early as the 1980s, and "its migration profile has changed from the massive emigration of the 1960s and 1970s to extensive immigration during the 1990s and 2000s" (İçduygu 2014, 9). As Ahmet İçduygu explains, "the first part of the 2000s has witnessed immigration flows from four different categories: (1) irregular labour migrants; (2) transit migrants; (3) asylum seekers and refugees and (4) regular migrants" (5). Unsurprisingly, the majority of the foreign migrants in Turkey resided in Istanbul. The nature and size of the international migration to Turkey changed drastically with the Syrian Civil War as Syrian refugees started to flee to Turkey from April 2011 onwards. According to the UN Refugee Agency's October 2020 update, around "4 million Refugees and asylum-seekers in Turkey including over 3.6 million Syrian nationals and close to 330,000 registered refugees and asylum-seekers of other nationalities" are living in Turkey (UNHCR 2020, 1). As of October 2020, RASAS (Refugees and Asylum Seekers Assistance and Solidarity Association), referring to the official numbers declared by the Turkish Ministry of the Interior, announced the number of registered Syrian refugees in Istanbul as around half a million which corresponds to 3.3% of the city's population (RASAS 2020).

p. 78 Istanbul's rising popularity as an emerging global city lasted throughout the first half of the 2010s. However, various terror attacks in 2016 as well as the 15 July military coup attempt in the same year resulted in a sudden decline in the city's attractiveness as a centre of tourism and investment. After four peaceful years free of terror attacks this downward trend came to an end, and a touch of positivity was added with the election of a social democrat mayor, Ekrem İmamoğlu, after twenty-five years with conservative mayors. Thus, the city entered the second decade of the 2000s with a degree of optimism about recovering its image and attraction potential.

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CHAPTER 5 Imagining the Migration Experience: A Humanist Approach

p. 81 It is possible to categorise *The Homesick Birds*, published in 1962, and *Uncle Halo and Two Oxen*, published in 1973, as examples of the first phase of the Istanbul novels with migrant characters, where an urban narrator talks about rural migrants.[1] Kemal's central message in *Birds* is that migrants will urbanise as they become members of the proletariat. On the other hand, in *Oxen*, İzgü does not focus on rural migrants' future in the city, but on the discrimination and isolation peasants, particularly those from the east of Turkey, face, by painting a picture of it through their experiences in the urban context. However, the two novels offer rich ground for comparison with their similar humanistic approach to the migrants in the city.

The Homesick Birds: An Empathetic Look at the Urbanities of the Future

p. 81–82 The word *gurbet*, a direct equivalent of which is difficult to find in English, means a place, or being in a place, which causes homesickness. The title of Orhan Kemal's novel *Gurbet Kuşları*, published in 1962, literally means birds of *gurbet*. The title compassionately implies the struggle of those trying to survive under harsh conditions away from the safety of home. Gönül Dönmez-Colin, referring to the film bearing the same title as the novel, offers 'The Birds of Nostalgia', 'Migrating Birds' and 'Birds of Exile' as options for the English translation, and makes her preference for 'The Birds of Nostalgia' (2008, 58). The translation of the title we offer here is: *The Homesick Birds*. Although the title has the connotation that the novel is about more than one migrant, this is mainly a book focusing on only one, Memed and his story of growing up and maturing in Istanbul. However, Kemal does not spend much time on Memed's psychological dynamics: he develops Memed's inner world mainly through his migration story. Thus, his experiences in the novel seem to be representative of migrants in general as the title implies.

p. 82 Published in 1962, *Birds* reflects the mentality of the 1950s and 1960s, which Tahire Erman describes as a period when rural migrants were seen as "the rural Other" (2001, 984). The novel's message is clear: rural migrants will urbanise as they become members of the proletariat. Becoming literate is a crucial step of this process, a prerequisite for becoming cultured working-class individuals and claiming class consciousness. Kemal's outlook in the novel can be defined as a Marxist variant of the republican elites' prescription for rural migrants' urbanisation. Seeing migrants as "the rural other", as Erman observes, dominated the shanty studies in the 1950s and 1960s, the very period in which Kemal wrote this novel. Erman adds that this "structural-functionalist-modernist" perspective led to a "structural Marxist explanation" in the 1970s and early 1980s (1992). The shortcomings Erman finds in this Marxist explanation are, unsurprisingly, present in *Birds*: a complete rejection of "rural values and communal existence in the city" (992) and the inability to appreciate the possibility of rural migrants' alternative "ways of thinking and living" (993). Throughout the novel, the protagonist is a person whose development is based on the extent to which he can adopt urban values, while what he brings from his rural background does not seem to contribute to his identity whatsoever.

p. 82–83 In *Birds*, Kemal defends the rights of rural migrants; as discussed below, he does this mainly by speaking *for them* rather than *making them speak*. Kemal places migrants' right to habitat at the centre of this defence, in line with Lefebvre's description of the right to the city as "a superior form of rights: right to freedom, to individualization in socialization, to habitat and to inhabit" (1996, 173). Throughout his novel he conveys the message that migrants as citizens of the country have the right to live in whichever city they want, and that there are both push factors and pull factors for migration. Material necessities such as the right to housing are themes in the work that are also directly related to the right to the city. With a humanist approach, Kemal welcomes migrants as the urbanites of the future, advocates for their right to the city, and puts particular stress on their right to be regarded as legitimate members of the city by the old urbanites. The tone of the narrative voice which reflects empathy for migrants is a central element of the novel's messages. Implementing double-voiced discourse, as explained below, the narrator simultaneously presents anti-migrant sentiments and contests them. The narrative voice also has an authoritative tone that emphasises Kemal's expectations of migrants' integration into urban life through becoming enlightened members of the proletariat.

p. 83–84 *Birds*, which is set in the 1950s during the Democratic Party (Demokrat Parti) government when Adnan Menderes was in power, opens with the Kurtalan train, which departs from the remote town of Kurtalan near Siirt, a city in south-eastern Turkey, entering the Haydarpaşa train station in Istanbul.[2] This is a landmark of the city, the most prominent feature of the iconography related to migration from Anatolia to Istanbul. The imagery in the setting is worthy of remark: the train station is a place in-between, it is neither Istanbul nor not Istanbul, very much in line with the limbo position of migrants being between the rural and urban. After a brief description of the station and the people there, the third paragraph starts with the following sentence: "'The homesick birds' were getting off from the backmost wagons of the train, dark and skinny. They had neither someone to meet them, nor had most of them a suitcase or

[1] The narrator who is an urbanite and whose narrative voice indicates this fact.

[2] The Democratic Party was a right-wing political party that ruled the country from 1950 to 1960 when it was overthrown by the 27 May 1960 military coup.

a handbasket, not even a duvet" (Kemal 2010, 3). In the first sentence, we hear what Mikhail M. Bakhtin describes as "the refracting discourse of a narrator" (1981, 324). Bakhtin explains that this type of narration is an example of "double voiced discourse" where "there are two voices, two meanings and two expressions" (324). Here, there is the voice of Istanbulites who are unhappy with the migrants' arrival, who see them as "dark and skinny"; and then there is another voice which is in conflict with this approach, which rejects it with disapproval. Here the adjectives "dark and skinny" suggest that the narrator has a negative perception of the migrants' appearance. But in fact, the word choice here reflects the elitists' perception of migrants. The tone of the sentence that follows it uncovers this hidden meaning. The narrator employs this technique of double-voiced discourse in various parts of the novel, the examples and significance of which are discussed below.

The narrator continues with double-voiced discourse in the passage: "With their defeated, bewildered, embarrassed, scared faces looking around, with their socks whose greens, yellows, purples and reds are dirty, scratching themselves harshly, having spread out on the wide concrete of the train station with the lukewarmness of cattle, with the crowd, among the crowd they were slowly drifting out to the exit gate of the station" (Kemal 2010, 2–3). This sentence includes an elitist voice despising migrants and another voice that lays bare and ridicules its hostile attitude. The paragraph is followed by a couple of insulting comments from urbanites against the migrants: p. 84

"Look at these bears!"

"I swear they are a herd!"

"Every day, every day. I wonder why these animals are scared of their villages?" (3)

The narrator explains that the migrants do not realise that they are being insulted and even if they did they cannot reply to these insults, and adds: "all with that lukewarmness of a herd they found the exit gate" (3). The analogy between animals and rural migrants in this narration, akin to the words of the urbanites insulting the migrants in the station by calling them "bears", appears as yet another example of the double-voiced discourse: that becoming an urbanite will be an utterly challenging task for the rural migrant; and that urbanites have a strong prejudice against them is clear in the opening passage of the novel.

On the fourth page of the book, the narrator focuses on Memed, one of the migrants who leaves the Kurtalan train and takes the Haydarpaşa-Sirkeci boat. Over the next four pages, Memed's first hours in the city are described in detail. He is the reflecting character of the chapter, and as the examples below indicate, Kemal introduces his inner world with the use of narrated monologue mostly echoing past conversations about Istanbul held back in his village. In these pages, Memed remains an anonymous migrant. When the narrator eventually gives his name, it is not in the form of a name and a surname but as he is called back in the village: İflahsızın Memed, which means Memed, son of Yusuf the Incorrigible.

In this early part of the novel, through past dialogues echoing in Memed's mind, the narrator presents the migration phenomenon as an outcome of peasants' perception of Istanbul as a dreamland and underlines their eagerness to be there. As Everett S. Lee points out, there are factors that attract migrants to the place where they migrate to and factors that repel them from the place they leave (1966, 50). In the peasants' dialogues we hear in the passage, the situation in rural Anatolia (i.e., the push factors for migration), which provides almost no other opportunity to peasants than searching for jobs in big towns, is slightly overshadowed by the depiction of their enthusiasm about the Istanbulite dream (i.e., the pull factors). In the free indirect speech of anonymous migrants, the narrator explains what the dreamland offers: "There were many jobs in roadbuilding, demolishing, building in Istanbul. One could feed himself, even send money back home" (Kemal 2010, 2). But then he adds the situation in the villages: "instead of being in the village, working at whoever's fields for three days, playing craps around the walls for five days" (2). With this explanation that in the village men are unemployed most of the time, the narrator aims to balance the depiction of the push and pull factors. However, after that, again using free indirect discourse, he continues with migrants' dreams about free women in Istanbul, yet another pull factor: "Women whose faces resemble roses when they smile with bare arms and legs" (2). p. 85

The narrator continues with the imaginary speech of migrants as they arrive: "In the end we've also come. Where are women whose faces resemble roses when they smile? Where are trams, taxis, share taxis, buses?" (2). Again, these words slightly reinforce the impression that the pull factors are stronger than the push factors. After that we hear about the prestige of the Istanbul experience back in the village: "Those who manage to go by hook or by crook were coming back changed after a couple of months. With their combed hair [...] outfit arranged from Tahtakale, they were walking about in the village, talking about Istanbul with enthusiasm in village coffeehouses, boy circles" (2). This sentence is problematic, since generally for migrants it would not be financially possible to go back to their villages for a break within a couple of months. Leaving this detail aside, the sentence is important as it reflects the prestige of the Istanbul experience for the peasant, and the status it ensures him or her back in the village; another example of pull factors outweighing the push factors for migration.

The Tabula Rasa *Migrant*

p. 86 Moris Farhi describes Orhan Kemal as "the voice of the voiceless" (2009, 130) and similarly Çimen Günay-Erkol argues that Kemal "turns down the volume of the author/narrator and usually lets his characters speak" (2014, 8). Certainly, Kemal creates a space for the voice of the voiceless to be heard. However, to what extent he does this by enabling us to hear characters' voices and to what extent by speaking for them is an important question.

Orhan Koçak's description of Kemal's characters as "semi-mute" (1997, 106) seems to be a provocative gesture since he is an author celebrated for his powerful use of dialogues in his novels. Koçak's insight provides a perfect point of departure for a scrutiny of narrative voice and characters' voices in *Birds*. The theme of language and literacy within the context of rural–urban migration is closely related to this discussion.

It is quite explicit that the novel, parallel to the modernist approach to the migration phenomenon in the 1950s, as explained in Chapter 2, values urban society over rural, and in line with that places the written culture of urbanites above the oral culture of rural people. Therefore, literacy and the use of 'standard' Istanbul Turkish appear as important themes throughout the book. Before discussing these themes, it would be useful to analyse a couple of points related to the motif of language in the novel.

p. 86–87 In the opening chapter of *Birds*, Kemal introduces the motif of language through dialogues between peasants who have seen Istanbul and those who have not: "Istanbul so impossible to describe. Its taxis, dolmushes, trams, buses, ferries... If someone asked 'What is a ferry mate?' then they would laugh into their sleeves and answer 'In words they are impossible to describe!' and leave it at that" (2). Those who have seen Istanbul do not have the words to talk about it to those who have not, since the latter do not possess the concepts to enable them to comprehend it. This situation resonates with Ludwig Wittgenstein's famous comment: "to imagine a language is to imagine a form of life" (1986, 8). This impossibility of describing Istanbul in words is repeated various times in the novel (4, 11). Lack of language has a central role in migrants' vulnerability in their encounter with urbanites' hostility. In the book, aggression against migrants first appears via words, in the form of plain verbal insult, and migrants are shown not to possess the language essential to defend themselves, for they cannot respond using the same tool: "Far from being angry, giving a reply, making mention of citizenship, freedom of travel, giving replies that would silence those who speak nonsense" (3). They simply do not own the very concepts which would enable them to reply.

p. 87 Unsurprisingly, on the other side of semi-muteness, we see the effort to claim a false identity through language. Gafur's use of the anti-migrant Istanbulite rhetoric is the best illustration of this: "Labourers, sharecroppers are pouring into Istanbul. Istanbul is no more Istanbul. They are dirtying, polluting all Istanbul" (23). This is a striking example of the dominated one's effort to gain symbolic capital by adopting the discourse of the dominating one. In another instance, Gafur makes the following comments about migrants: "'Instead of coming here, [he] should have gone to Çukurova like his father. They think Istanbul's streets are paved with gold. Istanbul's streets, squares have become full of beggars all!' He laid his eyes on the clerk, a genuine Istanbulite as he knew, to see the impression of his words. However, it was futile, they did not make any impression" (43). These sentences have a humorous function in the novel, as nobody would take Gafur's words seriously, when he is so obviously a rural migrant.

Kemal problematises linguistic emptiness as part of a larger cultural emptiness in his novel where he depicts the illiterate peasant who comes to the city from the village as a completely empty page, a *tabula rasa*. This is because he places a written culture above an oral culture. He almost does not perceive oral culture as culture at all, as he makes clear in the way he depicts Memed's inner world. He depicts what Memed brings from his rural culture as only what is wrong with his perceptions of urban life, based on what he has heard from those who have been in the city, such as prejudice about urban women. Kemal portrays neither Memed nor other migrants with a distinct rural culture of their own: they do not possess even a slight wisdom passed through folk tales and other products of oral culture. When we hear idioms and phrases of folk language in the speeches of migrants in the novel they are frequently pseudo-idioms which suggest opportunism: "hold a candle to the devil, fake it' til you make it!" (23) is one example; "kissing a hand will not make your mouth dirty!" (27) is another.

p. 87–88 In the novel, Kemal does not address the rural man's pride except the importance migrants attach to humiliation in front of women, as discussed below in the section on gender. Kemal's migrant characters do not have the feelings and longings that being disconnected from nature and the soil would create in a rural person. For instance, shanties are in fact places where migrants reclaim their attachment to the soil, as they grow vegetables and flowers in their gardens. This aspect of the shanty phenomenon never finds expression in the book.

p. 88 In the passages of the novel which are set in the village, Kemal does not depict the atmosphere of the place. Here, he simply presents a coffeehouse where a group of men speak about Istanbul with the implication that those in rural Anatolia only dream of escaping from there.

Throughout *Birds*, Kemal portrays the rural migrant as mostly blank in terms of virtues, with few exceptions such as Kastamonulu and his father's support of Memed, or the solidarity between Ayşe and Hatice, with the proviso that

Ayşe's friendly feelings for Hatice are prone to change if a slight conflict of interest arises.[3] Kemal depicts rural migrants mostly as opportunistic and selfish people trying to survive in the city. He does not address cases of conflict where migrants' struggle in the city leads to inevitable compromises from the norms of virtue. Kemal employs the good migrant–bad migrant opposition as the basic framework in his novel: when Memed, the good migrant in the story, becomes stronger in the city, having become literate and mastered bricklaying, he finds the courage to refuse to join the Democratic Party, declining to behave in an opportunistic manner. In brief, throughout the novel, Kemal portrays rural migrants in terms of what they do not have but the urbanites do, but conversely never with what they have and the urbanites do not.

In line with this stance, in the novel, literacy is the first step to becoming an urbanite. In the first chapter, on his first day in Istanbul, Memed fantasises about learning how to read and write, as he can now find the opportunity for this in the city. At this stage, his main motivation for learning to read and write is the eligibility this will ensure for doing his military service above the lowest rank. As time passes he starts to enjoy reading newspapers and even books. Newspapers and books keep appearing as a motif in the novel, emphasising literacy's significance in the process of becoming urbanites. There are numerous instances where Memed is reading, or he is envied or criticised for reading. Two connected instances of this leitmotiv are worthy of notice: in the first instance, Memed tries to understand a sentence in the newspaper about freedom of the press. The sentence includes an Ottoman word, the meaning of which Memed asks Hacı Emmi (Uncle Hadji), a cunning religious man who is in charge of the place where Memed stays with other bachelor migrants (171). This is an example of what Bakhtin calls an "inserted genre" and which he describes as: "letters, found manuscripts, retold dialogues, parodies on the high genres, parodically reinterpreted citations" (1999, 108). In this instance, the high language of a respectable newspaper enters the novel as an inserted genre (the sentence is repeated on page 175). Memed's question is followed by Hacı Emmi's furious tirade about the evilness of reading the Latin alphabet instead of the Arabic one (171–172). Here, the idea of "authoritative discourse" which has to be simply accepted without questioning, such as "the authoritative discourse of religious dogma, or of acknowledged scientific truth" (Bakhtin 1981, 342–343) enters the novel. Thus, the moment of Memed's confusion when trying to read a serious newspaper is followed by the discourse of religious dogma cursing him for reading the Latin alphabet. Here, religious discourse is presented as an obstacle to literacy, therefore against the urbanisation of migrants. p. 88–89

Memed's feelings about Gafur change dramatically when he discovers that Gafur is not literate but just pretends to be. Gafur is extremely sensitive about this issue, and one of the main reasons he avoids Memed at the beginning is the possibility of this truth being revealed. The issue of literacy also plays a major role in the collapse of his father Yusuf's image in Memed's eyes. After various conflicts the father and son face, Memed complains to his wife "I've never known that my father was this ignorant" and adds "he is illiterate yet pontificates" (270). It is an important point that the son's respect for his father, which is one of the main paradigms of the feudal family norm, is destroyed in the process of urbanisation over the issue of literacy. What would happen if Yusuf was portrayed as an illiterate but wise man? This would certainly bring a more complicated equation to the story. However, combining ignorance and illiteracy in the characterisation of Yusuf seems to fit the superiority of the written culture over the oral in the novel. The interpretation of the conflict between Memed and his father arising in Istanbul should obviously not be limited to the Oedipal complex. As mentioned above, Memed's respect for his father deteriorates after witnessing his ignorance, and Yusuf's arrogance is magnified as a result of the insecurity he feels because of his illiteracy and of having never been to Istanbul before. The conflict points out the weakening of feudal values in the urban setting. In a narrated monologue Yusuf thinks about the changes in his son: "Has he become an urban man? Probably" (285). He defines his son's behaviour, which he finds disrespectful, as "urban style manners" (285). The conflict accelerates as Yusuf tries to put pressure on Memed to recruit him for the Democratic Party, and attempts to slander Ayşe. Subsequently, the young couple rent a shanty and move away from the place where they were living close to Yusuf. That marks the end of Memed's relationship with his father, a move which would not be so smooth if they were living in a rural setting. p. 89–90

If literacy is the first condition of claiming an urban identity, speaking in the standard dialect is the other. Memed starts dropping his rural accent after his transformation in Istanbul, and he even corrects his father's accent (269). Ayşe dreams that her children will speak like "children of Istanbulites" (307). Clerk Hilmi corrects Hüseyin's accent (43). Hüseyin's wife Nermin, who despises the way he speaks, also corrects his accent (55). The symbolic value of accent is a significant theme in the novel. p. 90

The satirical edge of *Birds* comes to the fore in depictions of Hüseyin, a ridiculed portrait of the corrupt supporter of the ruling Democratic Party. Hüseyin is a man from an Anatolian village who comes to the city to work and rises up in class, owing to various unethical deeds. His wife Nermin who has married him for his wealth and political connections is an urban woman who is in search of status and despises everything rural about her husband, particularly his accent. She aggressively yet hopelessly corrects his accent, who makes no effort to do so. Hüseyin believes that accent does not have importance as long as communication is possible. On the other hand, Ayşe, who also speaks with a rural accent, has a burning desire to be able to speak in the way urbanites do. In the novel Kemal stresses that speaking in standard

[3] Kastamonulu means a person from the city of Kastamonu. Instead of a name this character is referred to by this nickname.

Turkish is a prerequisite for claiming an urban identity and Ayşe, whom he portrays as a good migrant who wants to become an urbanite, takes this issue seriously. She wants to change the way she speaks and even if she cannot adopt standard dialect, she is sure that her children will. It should also be noted that, since Hüseyin is a parodied character with his manners and his outfit of an aspiring urbanite, his accent comes to the fore as a comic element, while in the characterisation of Ayşe or Memed, the rural accent does not call for humour.

p. 90–91 Orhan Kemal's following words, taken from an interview, on the use of rural accents in his works are worth quoting: "just because one day our people will come over differences of accent and will speak in ideal Turkish, I cannot suppose that they already do so" (quoted in Bezirci 1984, 59). Kemal says that the novelist or the short story writer should not be "correcting the wrong way of speaking" (59) of his characters and adds: "when the turn of speech comes to him/her [the author] outside of dialogues, s/he will give the most correct and the best example of his/her language. Doing this s/he can both show the current situation of his/her language and s/he answers the question of how it [the language] should be" (59). As this excerpt indicates, Kemal regards rural accents as wrong, and the good migrants which he creates in the novel think this way too. They do their best to be able to drop their rural accent and speak like urbanites, while those who stay as peasants in the city have neither the will nor the capacity to be able to speak in the standard dialect.

p. 91 The distinction between good and bad migrants is manifest in their ways of earning money as well. The following passage depicting a coffeehouse of rural migrants is worthy of attention in this regard:

Porters with huge moustaches, builders, yoke porters who have not been able to adapt to Istanbul for years despite being in Istanbul, in a part of it such as Beyoğlu; yogurt, vegetable vendors in elegant neighbourhoods such as Şişli, Nişantaşı, Maçka, Osmanbey [...] They have not adapted to Istanbul but, with the glint in their eyes, with the delight in their huge moustache they have grabbed Istanbul's shrewdness maybe much more easily than genuine Istanbulites, opened accounts in banks. Among them there were building janitors, middlemen for houses and shops making more money than estate agents, maid commissioners, sipping their tea with pleasure. (180–181)

p. 91–92 This passage has an anti-migrant stance and there is no evidence of a double-voiced discourse. However, since the overall message of the novel is not anti-migrant, we can interpret such a passage as a manifestation of the good migrant–bad migrant opposition. The narrator's word choice for neighbourhoods such as Şişli and Nişantaşı as "polite", rather than for instance "wealthy", is also noteworthy: he seems to stress the cultural capital of the inhabitants of these places and the established urban culture there. "Genuine Istanbulite" is a phrase which belongs to the anti-migrant rhetoric, and is almost an empty signifier as discussed earlier. The narrator's use of such a phrase makes the rural migrant the other of the Istanbulite. However, when we analyse the passage against the background of the novel's overall messages, we can infer that the narrator's negative attitude is about bad migrants since commissioning for houses, shops and maidservants are parasitic ways of earning money. In this passage, it is possible to detect a common ground with elitists; however, this harmony with elitists is valid only where bad migrants are concerned. Unlike elitists, throughout the novel Kemal does not perceive and represent rural migrants as a homogeneous category, and he has a positive approach to good migrants who will eventually constitute the working class and adopt urban values.

p. 92 Another aspect of the good migrant–bad migrant opposition entails migrants' perception, or the lack thereof, of the beauty and heritage of the city. Memed's first job at a building site is at the demolition of Balıkpazarı. This historically significant area, famous for its fish shops and *meyhanes*, was demolished in 1955–1956 for the Unkapanı–Eminönü road as part of the aggressive urban transformation project launched by the Menderes government.[4] Salim Çonoğlu argues that, in the novel, migrant labourers do not have a sense of the cultural value of the structures which they are demolishing (2008, 153). To a certain extent this is true; but the theme is not limited to that. The following lines of narrated monologue, for instance, illustrate Memed's appreciation of the city. At one point in the work he thinks of his hometown and compares it with Istanbul: "But this Istanbul [...] The beauty of Kadıköy was something different. Pretty mansions, gardens, trees, girls, women with colourful short dresses around the trees" (197). Memed's feelings are in contrast with the widespread anti-migrant argument that migrants cannot appreciate the city's beauty and heritage. By contradicting this generalisation through Memed's case, Kemal does not intend to convey the message that all migrants can appreciate the city's beauty, but uses the motif to make a comparison between migrants: there are migrants who do appreciate the beauty of the city, and there are those who do not. A good example of this approach is the following passage where Gafur walks out of the building site one night, frustrated by having heard of Memed's hard work learning to read and write:

He left the building site. Outside the sky was full of stars, Istanbul under the sky was stretching out like a folk song, like a soft folk song!

He did not see it. He walked in through the engraved iron door of the mansion, closed the door. (135)

p. 93 Similar to Gafur, Hüseyin, another bad migrant, does not have any emotional connection to Istanbul. He longs for his village, as he expresses openly: "if they give me the streamside, the shade of the walnut on the streamside, they

[4] Meyhane is a traditional restaurant in the Balkans and the Middle East that serves raki and wine with meze.

can keep their Istanbul, this mansion and this wholesaling job!" (276). He repeats similar words on page 279 as well, all of which emphasise his detachment from Istanbul, and implies that he will never be an urbanite. However, it is also an interesting detail that this is the only instance in the book where Kemal addresses a rural migrant's longing for nature. In line with the novel's overall progressivist approach, here, missing the soil seems to be connected with the inability to adapt to urban life.

Put simply, in the novel the comparison between migrants in terms of their perception of the city environment functions as a counter-argument to the homogenising 'non-Istanbulites' discourse. Kemal points out that migrants cannot be accepted as a homogeneous category in their relationship with the city: some migrants appreciate the beauty and heritage of the city, some of them do not.

In his novel, Kemal tends to portray the good characters as purely good and the bad ones as purely bad. This is an example of the dichotomist approach Jill Twark describes as a characteristic of socialist realism: "the negative characters existing solely to be rejected, and the 'positive heroes' to be emulated" (2007, 16). Throughout the novel, Kemal places migrants who will adapt to urban life and become a part of the working class opposite to those who will remain as peasants in the city and will try to earn money in parasitic if not unethical ways. There is only one instance in the book where this opposition becomes invisible: the migrants' stance regarding the Riots of 6–7 September 1955.

The Riots of 6–7 September 1955, briefly mentioned in Chapter 4, appears in the work as a recurring motif. At the time of the riots Ayşe and Memed are living in their shanty. The narrator does not give any information about the riots; the reader receives only limited information about it through the comments of the characters. Although no character in the novel actually participates in the riots, they benefit from the looted goods, owing to the extremely low prices they are sold for. The goods looted in the riots appear frequently in unexpected moments (123, 124, 143, 156, 178, 179, 180, 304, 310), coming to the fore as a motif connected with various concerns of the novel. In the riots, organised groups attacked the shops of the Greek minority, as well as other non-Muslim minorities (i.e., Armenians, and Jews) along the way, and looted their goods. In the book, the characters' unawareness of the riots is combined with their insensitivity to it. Kemal does not employ the good migrant–bad migrant opposition on this issue. He does not introduce bad migrants participating in the riots, and good ones damning it. Instead, he creates a position in-between, and presents migrants' insensitivity about this shameful event. For instance, when Ayşe thinks that they also should have bought some of the looted goods, she is not really aware what has happened; yet, there is also insensitivity, as she does not really question why and how the goods have become so inexpensive and whether purchasing them would be ethical. p. 93–94

The Gendered Portrayal of Migration

A particularly challenging dimension of the rural–urban migration phenomenon in Turkey both for migrants and urbanites was the clash of values and perceptions regarding gender. Kemal is not indifferent to this aspect of the migration process and develops various themes around it in *Birds*. p. 94

In the novel, not only urban women but also men become the target of prejudice based on extremely patriarchal, feudal values. The migrants' approach to urban men in this sense is part of their general prejudice that urbanites are not trustworthy and honest people. There are instances where the migrants claim that urban men do not feel jealous about their wives, such as Ayşe's following comment: "all urban men are cuckolds" (280).

The novel's stance regarding sexual codes is not based on the divide between urbanites and rural migrants but between moral and immoral: only immoral characters are open to free sexuality, usually with a profit rather than genuine passion being its motivation.

Another point regarding gender and migration is the feudal notion of pride. As mentioned above, Kemal never portrays the rural migrant as a man of pride. In the novel, the migrant is sensitive about his pride only when he is humiliated in front of women (7, 11). Pointing out this humiliation, Mehmet N. Gültekin argues that migrant males' "perception and evaluation of events is [...] based on gender rather than class" in *Birds* (2007, 239). Gültekin's claim is somewhat exaggerated; however, it is true that gender based notions have a significant role in migrant males' interpretation of life in the urban context.

Kemal addresses the clash between Istanbulite women and male migrants at a couple of instances in the novel. We hear urban legends about women which circulate between migrants as early as the second page: "then there were broads in Istanbul. [...] they were easily giggling to whoever comes along, and following whoever makes a gesture" (2). "If you are a laddie and youthful, horse is yours, girl is yours" (73). Double-voiced discourse in this narration of anonymous migrants' thoughts is not difficult to spot: the narrator presents migrants' dreams about urbanite women while simultaneously implying their irrationality in a humorous way. p. 95

Feride Çiçekoğlu, in her book entitled *Vesikalı Şehir* (*The Prostitute City*), where she traces how the city has been identified with prostitution in cinema, argues that "the image which gave Istanbul's cinematic face an identity [...]

was being a prostitute" (2006, 18). Kemal seems to have an ambivalent position in this respect. On the one hand, he refrains from developing a chaste peasant woman–unchaste urban woman opposition, as in his novel he portrays various rural migrant women as unchaste. On the other hand, all the female urban characters in the novel are unchaste: Nermin, as well as her friends Fifi and Mari.[5] In other words, the book includes only unchaste urban women, but both unchaste and chaste rural migrant women: Pervin is 'loose' and Ümmü gets seduced by Gafur, who regards this 'accomplishment' as his revenge on Memed, the female body being a power domain between men. There is also a reference in the book to the close relationship between the concept of chastity and its potential use against women. Kemal depicts, with a powerful psychological depth, Ayşe's fear and despair when Gafur threatens her with slander regarding her chastity (315).

p. 95–96 Obviously, in a comparison between the portrayals of urban and rural women in the novel, not only the quantity of loose and chaste characters, but also their significance in the work matters: Kemal constructs urban Nermin and migrant Ayşe as opposites, but there is no such character pair in the book among men. In the very first instance that Ayşe joins the story, the narrator explains that she does not reveal the secrets of Nermin, whose house she cleans, since "she was only a poor migrant" (110) with no parents and only an uncle who never calls her. After Ayşe's brief conversation with Hüseyin, we become familiar with her inner world through a narrated monologue (111–113). In her thoughts, Ayşe criticises Nermin for being unfaithful, and tells her, in her fantasy, that Nermin's husband, who is a well-built strong man, is better than her lover. As the narrated monologue continues, we are introduced to the other good peasant woman in the novel, Hatice, who views Nermin as a slut. Nermin replies to this, in Ayşe's fantasy, that it is Hatice herself who is a slut. Ayşe's response is a passionate tirade about the impossibility of calling Hatice a slut. She responds to Nermin, in her mind: "even if one wipes harlotry on Hatice it would not get smeared on her" and adds what a supportive family woman Hatice is, without whose support building the family shanty would have been impossible, and that she is a perfect housewife and a great cook (112). Nermin is an adulteress, and with Ayşe as a maid in the mansion, she never cooks or does housework. Therefore, while Kemal constructs the immoral urban woman–moral rural migrant woman opposition over Nermin and Ayşe, for Ayşe, this opposition appears between her boss Nermin and her friend Hatice.

p. 96 A subtle detail attracts attention within this equation. The good rural woman as a migrant is a great example of the second category in Elizabeth Wilson's formulation of women's presentation in the city: "woman is present in cities as temptress, as whore, as fallen woman, as lesbian, but also as virtuous womanhood who triumphs over temptation and tribulation" (1991, 6). In the novel, Kemal seems to pay particular attention not to enmesh the narrator's voice with that of male migrants when they comment on urban women and men. In the instances which are quoted above, he employs double-voiced discourse to separate the narrator's opinion from that of the characters. However, when the reflector is Ayşe and the subject is womanhood, it is difficult to draw a line between the opinions of Ayşe and those of the narrator who seems to celebrate her purity and curse Nermin as a slut.

p. 96–97 If the first tremendous step in Memed's life subsequent to his migration to Istanbul is learning to read and write, the second one is meeting Ayşe. The structure of their relationship and the way the two characters are situated inside this relationship is significant in terms of the novel's messages about the link between gender and urbanisation. At the beginning of Ayşe and Memed's relationship, Kemal seems to suggest that feudal gender roles can change as a result of the urban experience. Having been in Istanbul for a long time gives Ayşe confidence, whereas being inexperienced in the city makes Memed shy and embarrassed. The narrator's first definition of Ayşe attributes male qualities to her: "looking more like a man rather than a woman with her big hands, big feet and [...] face" (110), while Memed is described in feminine terms as he first meets her: the workers in the building site all go to Hüseyin's mansion's yard to fill a jug, but it is only Memed who asks for permission, "feeling shy like a young girl" (191).[6] Ayşe delays her response as her boss does, and only speaks after walking down the stairs, a symbol of her feeling of superiority over Memed. She likes Memed's timid way of behaving as he enters the yard and walks to the fountain: "she liked his ways, his embarrassment like a girl" (191), and when they make eye contact she feels excited. They have a short conversation, with Ayşe asking the questions and Memed responding. Ayşe is impressed: "Ayşe was staring fascinatedly with her face resembling a boy with her thick, black eyebrows" (193), and in line with this masculine expression she tells him to come to fill the jug from now on instead of his fellow builders at the site. She thinks that since he is new to the city he is pure, but after a while he would "get used to the city and its people" (194–195), change and start flirting with girls like Pervin. The line of thought in Ayşe's mind is akin to what men think about migrant women, that they would lose their chastity and start flirting around in the city. The introduction of the relationship between Ayşe and Memed in the novel ends with these reverse gender roles.

p. 97 This relationship is initiated by Ayşe. The narrator does not comment on this, while Veli, one of the characters, reacts as follows: "The boy does not have any blame. The girl got her hands on him!" (229). As this relationship progresses and gains greater importance in the novel, Kemal seems to get confused about what to do with Ayşe being so dominant, primarily because she is more experienced in the city, and how to balance this situation and put the gender

[5] Fifi sounds like a nickname, while Mari is either a Greek or an Armenian name.

[6] Such a description is repeated on a later page as follows: "Ayşe's rough face reminding of a man's" (188).

roles back in their places. As a solution, he gives Memed a powerful position by turning him into an object of desire for Ayşe. As her feelings for him grow stronger his image gets transformed for her and therefore for the reader. Ayşe's daydream below is a good example of this transformation.

Memed and Ayşe are the only characters in the novel whose fantasies and daydreams constitute a major part of their characterisation: Memed's fantasies mostly appear in the first half of the novel, where he dreams about the prestige that the Istanbul experience will provide him back in his village, while Ayşe's fantasies are mainly about Memed, marriage and having children. In her daydream, Memed covers Ayşe's mouth as part of a joke and she holds his wrist: "But thick wrist, a thick male wrist, a strong male wrist. [...] mighty male palm calloused because of holding a trowel, and carrying bricks holds the girl's wrist and twists it, takes the girl under him" (203). As the narrator explains Ayşe's fantasy, in his narrative voice we can feel a tone praising male physical power and regarding it as more than simply physical: the use of the adjective "mighty", rather than for instance 'strong', attributes psychological power to physical strength. Thus, Kemal brings the gender roles back to their usual places. In the rest of the daydream, Ayşe's wrist starts hurting and Memed eventually lets it go, but does not show any affection after hurting it. It is striking to see the transformation of Memed's image from a timid boy with feminine qualities into a highly masculine, almost a macho man within only nine pages. p. 97–98

After spending a short time flirting, the couple face a crisis when Memed reveals his plan to invite his family from the village to live with them after they get married. Ayşe eventually accepts the plan and the couple get married. There is an interesting detail regarding the narration of Ayşe and Memed's relationship: the couple's wedding appears as an ellipsis in the plot. As Gerard Genette explains in *Narrative Discourse Revisited*, ellipses which are "breaks in the temporal continuity" occur when an event happens in the story but is not narrated, so the reader infers the development from implications (1980, 51). After Ayşe and Memed's conversations about marriage and their plans, we suddenly notice that the couple have got married, since Memed introduces Ayşe to Yusuf as his daughter-in-law at the Haydarpaşa Train Station. While Kemal writes *Birds* with realist aesthetics, his decision to hide the significant event of marriage in a gap is rather meaningful: traditionally in Anatolian culture, a girl is requested from her parents by the parents of the groom. Since Ayşe is an orphan, Memed's father could have requested her from Hüseyin, her boss, at least symbolically. There is no conversation between Ayşe and Memed discussing this issue, or the procedure of their marriage ceremony; and eventually the wedding itself does not appear on the discourse level. We can interpret such a gap in the plot as an implication of the liberty a migrant woman surviving on her own in the city enjoys. p. 98

Füsun Akatlı points out that "the image of the 'woman worker' was introduced into our literature by Orhan Kemal" (1981, 229). Earlier in the book, when Memed is a novice migrant, we learn his views on women's working via a narrated monologue: "if a girl's father, brother is alive she should not work at all" (81). After a while, Memed gets married to Ayşe who is a working woman and an orphan, so the novel is safe from a conflict in this respect. But, if having a father or a brother is enough reason for a woman not to work, why is having a husband not? After the couple move into their rented shanty, Ayşe works at a factory for a while, then as they start building their own shanty, she stops working at the factory and takes daily cleaning jobs. Obviously, Memed's views on the issue of women's working become transformed, but Kemal refrains from addressing this transformation openly and prefers just to imply it. p. 99

Towards the end of the novel, the narrator explains Ayşe's daily routine before she has to quit work, in order to guard their semi-built shanty as follows: "While her husband was putting up walls all day in building sites with a trowel in his hand, she was running to her work in the early hours of the morning up until yesterday. After working at the factory until the evening, on to the woods to be cleaned, laundry of singles to be washed of the houses in Bakırköy, Yeşilyurt, then home, her husband's feet, dinner, then that sleep" (359). This daily routine is significant in terms of exhibiting the limits of women's liberation in the city; even if a woman works outside the home, inside the household her role as a housewife remains unchanged. While on the surface the narrator sounds neutral as he describes this routine, through his double-voiced discourse we can feel the criticism of the fact that when Ayşe comes back from work her shift at home starts while her husband gets a rest. Akatlı argues that Kemal is the first author of the Turkish novel to depict female workers' double-oppression, as workers and as women (1981, 229). Kemal accentuates this oppression in *Birds* as well: Ayşe will never question why she has to do the housework after coming home from work instead of sharing it with her husband. As long as her husband is faithful and trustworthy, and keeps all his money for household expenses, Ayşe will be content. The excessively romantic style in Ayşe's narrated monologues about her dreams of married life with Memed and the narrator's descriptions of her feelings draw attention to this ideologically infiltrated sense of romanticism, which makes women accept their subversive gender roles.

The passage in the book where Memed's father, sister and brothers arrive in the city is the only instance where Kemal illustrates the arrival of a female migrant in Istanbul. After Memed and Ayşe meet his family at the Haydarpaşa Train Station, they arrive at the mansion of Hüseyin and Nermin. Memed's sister Ümmü looks around and sees girls of her age in their mini-skirts and short sleeves, so she removes her headscarf after a little hesitation. Ayşe praises her by saying: "Exactly. This is Istanbul, girl" (264). The way Ayşe stresses that they are in Istanbul sounds like she proudly invites her sister-in-law to urbanise. When Ümmü removes her scarf, Yusuf does not react at his daughter's abrupt change of style, and in the subsequent pages there is no reference to a conflict between the father and his p. 99–100

free-spirited daughter who starts having an affair with a shopkeeper. Kemal avoids addressing their potential dispute, which is not surprising since in his book he does not dwell on the obstacles migrant women face in their urbanisation.

Conclusion

p. 100 In the fifteenth chapter of *Birds*, the reader has a feeling of déjà vu. The narrator explains how every week trains bring new rural migrants to the Haydarpaşa Train Station, with some of the same phrases and sentences he used in the first chapter of the novel. He depicts the atmosphere at the train station just before the arrival of yet another train from Kurtalan. Since this is a crucial passage regarding the novel's messages about the migration phenomenon and a lucid example of the narrator's use of double-voiced discourse, it is worth quoting at length:

> Like those arriving earlier, this [the mid-morning train] too will arrive, park itself on the platform, and out of it will come dark, skinny, charmless "homesick birds", with no one in their best suits, coats and trilby hats waiting to meet them and they will stand there staring in amazement at the grand buildings of the Haydarpaşa Station with its high roof so magnificent to the unfamiliar, creating intimidation, even fear in the stranger. These were people whom the big city didn't like, even hated. They were disfiguring even dirtying Istanbul with their outfit, wild stares. Citizens etc. they were, they did not have the right to sicken Western tourists who were coming reluctantly, they cannot, they should not. The government should take it seriously, issue a law, and should not let them in the big city! This ugliness, this rust and this dirt, could be our "National shame"; then it should be our "National task" to keep this shame in the countryside, pushing it back to the countryside when it moves from there!

p. 101 "Homesick Birds", all unaware of this, were flooding into Istanbul with "Mid-morning trains" from Haydarpaşa to Istanbul wagon after wagon, boat after boat, camion after camion, even though they look at Istanbul not with their eyes but with their ears, noses or who knows maybe with the napes of their necks, as they drink the water, breathe the air, eat the bread of Istanbul they were developing, learning how to look with their eyes, how to comb their hair, how to read and write, trying to resemble Istanbulites.

> Were they resembling? Even though the newcomer "homesick birds" were not, those who are one generation after them, especially if they go to school, did not resemble their parents, but Istanbulites. (247–248)

As in the first chapter, in describing the migrants the narrator uses the adjectives of "dark" and "skinny" here, again as an instance of double-voiced discourse.

In this passage, as the only time in the book the narrator openly declares his point of view about rural migrants in the city, the novel's central message becomes clear: if migrants' children find the opportunity of education they will become urbanites. The word "resemble" is crucial here. Probably, the educated children of migrants who *resemble* Istanbulites will never be accepted as Istanbulites by the old members of the city. Kemal is not that much concerned about this as he is with migrants' process of urbanisation. He simply stresses that the educated second-generation migrants will succeed in becoming urbanites. He does not problematise whether those who resemble Istanbulites should be accepted as such.

p. 101–102 As quoted above, in the first chapter of the novel when migrants, one of whom is Memed, get off the train at Haydarpaşa, none of them can respond to the insults of the Istanbulites (3). After the time he has spent in the city, when Memed is at Haydarpaşa once again, this time to meet his father and siblings, "urbanites" (261) insult migrants in just the same way. Memed's reaction is completely different this time, when a man calls them "bears": "'Bears are like you,' he said. 'What is bearish about us?'" (261). The insulting men explain to Memed that their comments are not meant for him, a remark indicating that Memed does not look like one of the rural migrants who have just arrived in the city. Memed tells the men that they cannot make such comments to others either. He has claimed language within the time he has been in the city, so his response now is just the opposite of his silence when he first arrived. The narrator explains the incident with a tone of praise: "And he repeated what Kastamonulu once said to the city men with a burst of spleen: 'They are children of this country as much as you are!'" (261). This is the moment when Memed reaches Kastamonulu's level: a migrant who is aware of his rights as a citizen, and who possesses language to express this. As discussed earlier, the narrator explains in the first chapter that migrants are not able to say anything about "citizenship, freedom of travel" (3). Kemal introduces this theme on the third page of his novel and completes it after almost 260 pages with Memed's furious reply to hostile Istanbulites as he defends his legitimacy in the city, in other words his right to the city.

p. 102 In *Birds*, Kemal manages to be the voice of the voiceless to a certain extent. If he developed Memed's inner world more deeply in its entirety with what he brings from his rural background, then the voice of the voiceless would be louder in the novel. Raymond Williams discusses the "positive identification of intuitions of nature and the values of shared work with human depth" (1975, 203) that he finds in the Thomas Hardy novel, *The Woodlanders*, published in 1887. Such a dimension is lacking in *Birds* where Kemal appreciates the urbanising aspect of Memed's identity while he ignores its rural aspect altogether.

The dominant imagery in the novel is of a city in the process of demolition. The extensive urban transformation project implemented by the Menderes government resulted in the destruction of historical heritage and the depopulation of various neighbourhoods in Istanbul. Migrants supplied the labour force for this, while building their shanties in different areas of the city. Kemal conveys a positive message about shanties throughout the book. In the final chapter, the narrator tells about the demolishing of the shanty town where Ayşe and Memed live with sympathy for shanty dwellers: "They were demolishing. They were demolishing without compassion for human labour, pinched and scraped, cultivated by the light in the eyes of human labour" (372). Kemal makes his message on the right to housing clear through the emphasis he puts on the inevitability of the shanty as shelter for migrants. He ends his novel by illustrating the demolition of a shanty town, with depictions of migrants' desperation about losing their homes, as well as their determination to survive in the city. The last sentence of the book, belonging to Ayşe, represents this determination in the best possible way: "Stand up man stand up. We will build again, we will build a new one!" (372). Her words echo the famous adage: the nest is made by the female bird. Full of will and determination, these words have a symbolic value promoting women's power, and their potential to be fulfilled in urban life. The ending of the book is very much in line with Fatmagül Berktay's description of women as "the locomotive" of migration (2019, minute 93). In *Birds*, which he wrote at an early stage of the mass rural-urban migration in Turkey, Kemal accentuates migrants' right to habitat in the city. The issue of symbolic violence against migrants is an important theme in this work. Kemal does not problematise the rigid, normative understanding of urbanity, he simply encounters the anti-migrant rhetoric of elitists with the good migrant-bad migrant opposition. In his novel he suggests that, for a legitimate existence in the city, migrants must urbanise and the good migrants will succeed in doing that. As he proposes literacy and education as the key to urbanisation he does not dwell on the correlation between economic and educational inequalities. Consequently, he somewhat attributes too much significance to the capability and will of individual migrants in their urbanisation and integration into the city, and their struggle against exclusion mechanisms.

p. 102–103

Uncle Halo and Two Oxen: A Sarcastic Look at Rural to Urban Migration and Its Discontents

In Muzaffer İzgü's *Halo Dayı ve İki Öküz* (*Uncle Halo and Two Oxen*), published in 1973, a young boy called İdiris, the only son of Halo the protagonist, returns home in an Anatolian village upon completing his military service, around the mid-1970s. When Halo embarks on a journey to go to Istanbul to work until he has earned enough money to purchase two oxen, İdiris finds himself as his companion. The way of migration here is unique, since the main intention of Halo and İdiris is not migration but to work in Istanbul temporarily. However, as İdiris stays in the city, the novel becomes a migration story, at least partially. The humorous title of the novel gives the reader a hint about the story, as an ox is a symbol of farming and peasantry. Halo is in Istanbul only to earn the money to purchase two oxen. Throughout the book, his fascination with oxen, the way he dreams and talks about them, all exaggerated for humorous effect, underlines the profound difference between his ambitions and those of the migrants in the city.

p. 103

In his novel, İzgü approaches the concept of the right to the city through the wider perspective of citizenship rights. Accentuating the grave shortcomings with equal citizenship in Turkey, the novel, albeit indirectly, exhibits the remoteness of the right to the city in a country where even fundamental rights can easily be violated. The divide between the East and the West of the country, the exclusion of citizens living in the East and their inability to claim their rights in the 1970s come to the fore as major themes of the novel. İzgü does not perceive urbanisation as an ideal in his book and conveys the message that living in harmony with nature can be much more fulfilling for some persons than an urban life.

p. 103–104

The novel written in the realist tradition is a bittersweet social satire. The political objects of satire in the novel are the issues of rights in Turkey, the discrepancy between the official discourse and the reality of citizenship practice in the country, and the cruelty of the police and the military. İzgü also places in the book an indirect critique of the social and cultural gap between the East and the West of the country, cultural deprivation, and discrimination against the people of Eastern Anatolia. In *Oxen*, the moral objects of satire are: the loss of dignity in the struggle to survive, particularly in the urban context; prejudice against migrants and the poor; the sex drive being some men's Achilles heel and women's manipulation of it; and disloyalty among family members. İzgü, indirectly mocks in the novel men's obsession with physical power. Although İzgü does not explicitly suggest an alternative or a solution to the ills of society, he invites us politically to change our perception of state-citizen relations, and morally to be humane in societal and familial relations. Utilising humour skilfully throughout the book İzgü manages to avoid sounding didactic.

p. 104

The novel begins with the following sentence: "Who said it, who called it is unknown, but the name of this village is Mescitli" (İzgü 1974, 5). The narrator explains that under the snow it takes six days for the villagers to reach the town centre, whose name he does not disclose. He explains that in this village it snows until May, even June; so we can infer that this is the easternmost corner of Anatolia. While this is not an idyllic picture of rural life, with the challenges of a remote landscape with harsh climatic conditions mentioned, we can feel the unique charm of the place: "everywhere becomes pure white, until May, until June" (5). The villagers are entrapped during this cold winter not only in their village but also in their houses; however, they are grateful just to have enough to survive: "if there is bulgur soup [...]

no butter no salt in it but nice and warm"; "fortunately we've got our turf, we've got our goat, may God give patience, strength to those who are out in the cold" (6).

p. 104–105 After briefly describing the village, the narrator depicts a long winter's night in one of the village houses. The family members sleep in the same room, sharing beds, and they are deprived of proper heating. The residents of Mescitli live in destitution and the family whose story we hear is no exception to that: due to the cost of gas, turning the gas lamp on is a luxury they keep for special occasions. Through various details like this, the narrator emphasises that the living conditions in the village are extremely poor. Despite that, the mood in this opening chapter of the novel is cheerful. The narrator stresses the strength villagers take from oral culture in this isolated rural location: in the long nights of winter, grandfather's war memories commingle with grandmother's fairy tales, which have been told to the members of the family over and over again, far too many times (5). Throughout the chapter, the narrator's sympathetic stance towards the villagers, and his perception of life in this village as very hard yet quaint, are clear and lucid.

p. 105 There is similar compassion in the narrator's tone as he explains the hardships Halo and İdiris endure. The narrator's sympathetic approach continues for Halo throughout the book, while it ends for İdiris at the point where he deserts his father in Istanbul. After this event, in a neutral tone, the narrator leaves the decision to the reader whether or not to pity İdiris for his senselessness. Halo is old, honest and chaste; while İdiris is young, dishonest and prurient. The humorous characterisation of Halo caricatures male obsession with physical strength: he takes inspiration from his late father who had once climbed up to the top of the mountain in the village as an elderly man, a triumph even for youngsters.

İdiris is born following four girls, which would render him extremely precious in his family, since this is an environment where families favour their sons over their daughters; however, this is not a point addressed in the story. His fixation on sexuality, implied in the early parts of the novel, foreshadows future events that will determine the direction of the pair's fate in the unfriendly environment of Istanbul. It would be difficult to define the character pair of Halo and İdiris as a binary opposition, since İdiris appears as part of Halo, a child he has to take care of rather than an adolescent on the brink of adulthood. Yet, it would be sensible to comparatively analyse their character traits and behaviours.

p. 105–106 For Halo, Istanbul only means an immense market where he can sell his labour until he earns the money to purchase two oxen. For him, his time in Istanbul is only a temporary shift of hard work for a specific purpose. He is not interested in the city but rather intimidated by it. He spends all of his time on the building site where he works and stays. İdiris is curious about the city. However, his interest is limited to the women he encounters as he wanders the city, and in seedy places such as brothels or shady nightclubs which he glimpses from outside.

p. 106 İzgü employs the technique of exaggeration in the characterisation of both Halo and İdiris. However, he invites his readers to laugh *with* Halo rather than *at* Halo; while to laugh *at* İdiris not *with* İdiris. While he depicts the former with sympathy he ridicules the latter, especially through his sexual frustration, and turns him into a caricature. As Jill Twark observes, "sympathetic humor is used to demonstrate sympathy with its object", and creates the atmosphere "to laugh *with* the target" (2007, 15). This is the case where Halo is concerned. The difficulty Halo faces when he tries to understand what a Public Employment Office is (109–110), which creates sympathy in the reader, is followed by a description of İdiris's voyeurism and sexual fixation. Similarly, in the passage set at the train station (131–140) discussed below, İzgü juxtaposes his sympathy for poor migrants with the repulsion that İdiris's sexual fixations cause. This is a central dynamic throughout the novel: Halo creates sympathy and İdiris creates disgust; which is a version of the good migrant–bad migrant opposition. It is noteworthy that, in this novel, the good migrant is the one who eventually goes back to where he comes from.

While in the novel İzgü mainly employs the methods of conventional social satire, in ridiculing İdiris he approaches dark humour. He portrays him as a character preoccupied with sexuality, with no aims in life and no ethical values; in brief, no inner world other than sexual obsessions. İdiris's thoughts and deeds related to sex, which İzgü ridicules in a highly humorous way, are hilarious, yet with a disturbing aspect. Additionally, in dealing with sexual frustration, he crosses over to the sphere of a taboo subject, which is another trait of dark humour. Unlike conventional social satire, dark humour does not offer solutions; but rather, accepting the inevitability of the negative, it offers humour as a tool to cope with the awful truth. The case with İdiris is in line with this position: İzgü regards the disturbing behaviour of some migrant men who are mesmerised by urban women's appearance and attitude as inevitable, and offers humour to cope with this reality.

p. 106–107 That said, the way İzgü ridicules İdiris carries elements of conventional social satire as well: it is possible to see a criticism here calling for an alternative. In the way İzgü satirises rural men's encounters with the liberated women of the city, he is somewhat cruel to be kind to rural migrants; by showing them their parodied image through İdiris he seems to aim at an improvement in their behaviour. İzgü's standpoint is in harmony with urbanites' dilemma about the inconvenience some migrant men cause for urban women: disgust, and to a certain extent acknowledgement of the factors at the basis of the problem.

The theme of İdiris's fixation about urban women constitutes the gender aspect of the migration phenomenon in *Oxen*. İzgü does not address the changes in the lives of migrant women in his novel, he simply implies that they learn to be selfish, sometimes cunning, in the city like men do. p. 107

'Citizens' Intimidated in the Public Realm

Throughout the book, İzgü utilises humour as if trying to soften the prejudice against migrants where they are in a position to disturb urbanites in the story. When it comes to the instances of migrants' victimisation, he is in a sober mood and highly realistic. Both approaches serve as a call for empathy for migrants. p. 107

İzgü develops the theme of the right to the city by locating it in the wider context of citizenship rights, with the message that in a country where people lack their sense of worth as citizens, and are unaware of even their fundamental rights, implementation of the right to the city can only be a utopia. Inevitably, the public realm comes to the fore as a central motif in the novel, connected with the theme of citizenship rights and the absence thereof. Since an argument on the public realm is outside the scope of this book, in this discussion the public realm is simply regarded as "the parts of a village, town or city (whether publicly or privately owned) that are available, without charge, for everyone to see, use and enjoy including streets, squares and parks; all land to which everyone has ready, free and legal access 24 hours a day" (Cowan 2005, 312).[7]

In the novel, İzgü satirises the way the state terrorises its citizens by its institutions and representatives. Illustrating how people from an unprivileged background feel constantly threatened by the military and the police, and are intimidated in the public realm, he stresses the discrepancy in citizenship practices based on socioeconomic and ethnic differences. He depicts Istanbul as a place with an unwelcoming atmosphere where the magnificence of state institutions amalgamates with the hostile attitudes of city inhabitants. p. 107–108

The first stop of Halo and İdiris's journey is the nearest town. In his sixty-three-year-long life, Halo has been to this town only a few times. Apart from one time in his childhood, each of these visits has been due to a reason connected with the military, a detail worthy of attention. The first one of these was when he enrolled for his five-and-a-half-year-long military service, in which he fought against the Sheikh Said Rebellion (50).[8] p. 108

In fact, at that time military service as a gendarme would last three years. The narrator does not explain why Halo's took almost twice as long. His second time in town was when he had to join the army as a reservist. In the other two experiences, he was taken there by the gendarmes, once as a witness and once for an interrogation about a hidden bandit. During the latter, Halo was beaten by the gendarmes for three days: "Uncle Halo saw gendarmes all his life, because he had been beaten by gendarmes quite a lot. Especially once, when he was taken to the town for the bandit, they gave him a beating for three days" (57). The seemingly neutral narration here hints at a double-voiced discourse: the unquestioning approach of the narrator to the event in fact emphasises how unquestioningly Halo experienced it. When it comes to İdiris, similarly, his only memories of the town are stopping there on the way to and from his military service (51).

Characters' names such as Halo, Haso, Mamo and Gülo, and the village's geographical setting, accentuate the possibility of Mescitli being a Kurdish village, a potentiality İzgü never elucidates in the course of the novel. Additionally, the Kurdish vocabulary includes the word *halo* which means uncle. Another important detail is the enigma about the city Mescitli belongs to. Usually, when people ask each other where they are from, they give the name of the city which their town and/or village is nearest to. Interestingly, in the novel, whenever asked this question, Halo gives only the name of his village, Mescitli, but never the name of the city, and in one incident, he becomes irritated by a man who, understandably, asks this of him:

- Where do you hail from? he asked. p. 109

- Mescitli...

- Where is that?

Uncle Halo twisted his head as if saying "What's it to you man!" while he put in the car the big chunk of soil on the tip of his shovel. (153)

In fact, there is a village called Mescitli in the İspir county of Erzurum (İspirin Köyleri). If this is not simply a coincidence İzgü is not aware of, the village in the novel would be this village. Erzurum is one of the easternmost cities of Turkey with a considerable Kurdish population, therefore it is highly possible that this village is a Kurdish one, hence the novelist's choice not to reveal the name of the city to hide the fact that Mescitli is a Kurdish village.

[7] Cowan notes that the concept is "also called *public domain* and *public space*" (312).

[8] This was a rebellion that started "on February 13, 1925, [as] the first major Islamic rebellion against the secularizing reforms of Mustafa Kemal Atatürk, [which] broke out in the Kurdish-populated provinces of Turkey" (Şeyh Said Rebellion).

This would make even more sense considered together with Halo's fear of state agencies, since such a fear is greater where Kurdish people are concerned, particularly in the 1970s when the novel is set.

p. 109–110 Upon learning of the price of the hotel in the town, Halo and İdiris decide to spend the night in a park, as a result of which they are taken to the police station by the watchman. This encounter with the police brings back to Halo's mind the bad memories of his three-day-long experience with the gendarmes. After this failed endeavour to use the park, which is the first public realm they attempt to enjoy, they find themselves in the second: the coffeehouse. As Halo gets offended by the aggressive jokes of the men in this place he frightens them with his fists, and the pair leave triumphantly. The next day they come across another park, but do not find the courage even to go and sit on one of the benches: "you never know, maybe it is forbidden to sit as well" (68) says Halo. "There is no saying which part of the city is forbidden, which part is free. You go and sit, then comes someone, here comes a penalty for sitting. That's why, let's go up this slope" (68). The narrator comments: "no one knows, maybe Halo was running away from the city atmosphere, town atmosphere from the very first day" (68). The use of inverted syntax invites a feeling of empathy from the reader in this sentence which implies that the city, even the town, is a battleground for a peasant, and also stresses once again that for Halo and İdiris, at this stage of their journey, even such a small town is an intimidating place. This is very much in line with Alimia et al.'s point on the relationality of urbanity as they stress that "in an overwhelmingly rural context, even a smallish town can have urban properties" (2018, 3). In this passage, the object of satire is the cluelessness of peasants about their rights as citizens of the country.

p. 110 The pair arrive in Istanbul, via Ankara, obtaining two consecutive rides from lorries. Their journey includes instances where they feel humiliated for being poor peasants from the East, as well as numerous interesting first experiences such as seeing women wearing makeup, crossing the road on the highway, paying to use a toilet and seeing the sea. The narrator's tone is full of affection as he tells about these instances, which in turn creates sympathy in the reader, while he retains humour through the technique of exaggeration.

When Halo and İdiris arrive in Istanbul, they start seeking labouring jobs. In their quest, they are recommended to go to the Public Employment Office. Halo feels intimidated by the idea of a state office:

- Office? What sort of a place is that?

- It belongs to the state, it finds jobs for you...

- Does it have a manager at the top?

- Of course there is...

- Forget it son, we can't go to such places with managers and all that, we get scared... (109–110)

For Halo and İdiris, the public realm brings fear not only of officials, but also of anyone who has some sort of social and economic power. On one occasion, the father and the son are in Sirkeci, sitting on the pavement and watching the sea in fascination. At that point, a car tyre comes to a halt on İdiris's duvet. Halo and İdiris are afraid to ask the driver, who is also enjoying the view with his girlfriend, to move the car slightly so that the duvet can be freed, since the driver seems like a wealthy man (124).

At the end of their first day in Istanbul, Halo and İdiris start searching for a place to stay for free, since even the cheapest hotels are over their budget. Upon the recommendation of a vendor, they arrive at the waiting room of the Sirkeci Train Station to spend the night indoors. This train station scene, which is prolonged for nine pages (131–140), is one of the two definitive passages in the work elaborating the theme of peasants' anxiety caused by state agencies and the public realm.

p. 110–111 Halo's reaction as he enters the train station incorporates various themes of the novel. As they enter the station, Halo sees the train wagons and concernedly says: "oh my, son, this place belongs to the state, walk on tiptoe" (131). When Halo is about to fall asleep at one of the seats of the station's waiting room, the man in the next seat warns him about the rule which forbids sleeping at the station. In response to Halo's surprise, he adds: "this is the decision of the government". The narrator emphasises that the enforcement of these decisions has a stronger impact on people like Halo: "once the ban is the government's ban, one would surrender to the verdict, especially those like Uncle Halo" (132). Once again, there is a call for empathy regarding the symbolic violence faced by the poor and the uneducated. Soon, the station official comes in and wakes all those who have fallen asleep on their seats. He stresses that if they fall asleep again they will be thrown out of the station. As this official repeatedly comes into the room to wake these poor men, most of whom are not passengers, Halo starts to think that he is a "duty sergeant" (137), a remark reflecting the vague borders between the state and the military in rural people's minds in those years, a perception which was even stronger for the residents of Eastern Turkey, namely the Kurds, the largest ethnic and linguistic minority in Turkey.

p. 111–112 The second, even more striking moment in the story with this theme of peasants' anxiety caused by state agencies and the public realm is the incident of the letter from the city council. After Halo and İdiris start working on a building site, they stay in one of the semi-constructed buildings on this site. One day two council agents present them with an official document. The pair go to the coffeehouse and ask a man wearing a tie to explain the content of the letter to

them, a detail revealing that they are illiterate and that they perceive a tie as a symbol of education. The man explains that the letter orders those staying in the unfinished building to go to the municipal offices. Halo and İdiris are terrified. The narrator explains with great sympathy the pair's confusion and fear caused by this letter. As they are on their way to the hall the next morning, they think that the city council is a person. They eventually find the hall but are scared to go in: "they could not enter at first because of the magnificence of the building" (225). The door keeper of the hall makes fun of Halo as he shows him the paper asking whom he needs to see. They are also reprimanded by a man at the building for not knowing that they have to take their hats off. As they finally manage to contact the related official, they learn that the letter has been written because they are staying on the building site, as the official tells them: "that place is not suitable for a citizen to reside, this report was written because of this" (229). The conversation between Halo and the official is an instance of powerful satire: Halo finds this order incomprehensible as he compares the site with the living conditions back in his village. The sharp contrast between the official discourse on the state's concerns about its citizens' health and safety versus the reality of rural Anatolia creates an almost absurd atmosphere in this dialogue.

Conclusion

The novel's ending is based on an amusing situational irony: when Halo contemplates going to Istanbul to earn the money to purchase two oxen, three fellow villagemen ridicule him for considering such a plan given his age. Bound and determined to prove they were wrong, Halo attains his goal. When he comes back to his village, however, all three men are dead; thus, the story ends in a way Halo has not anticipated at all. p. 112

In the book, Halo, the decent character, goes back to his village from Istanbul. İzgü portrays all the characters staying in the city with a degree of negativity. Murtaza, a friend of İdiris from military service days, whom he comes across in Istanbul, pretends that he is being supportive, yet he is in fact a traitor. Murtaza's wife, and her sister whom İdiris eventually marries, are also selfish and highly unlikeable characters, if not traitors.

İdiris, depicted as an unvirtuous person, is one of those who stays. With the encouragement of Murtaza and his wife he gets married to an older woman with children, as an 'unfair deal', and once he gains experience of the city he ensures that his widowed sister with children gets married to a young and inexperienced migrant in Istanbul. İdiris who is a naive rural migrant when he first arrives in Istanbul learns to be selfish in the city, and changes his position from the manipulated to the manipulator, at least on this issue. Additionally, the migrants in the book who stay in Istanbul do not make an effort to become urbanites. Their only motivation to stay is the living conditions that are better than those in their villages. They do not question their habits or values within the context of the city. İdiris loses his dignity in Istanbul, the city takes his positive feudal values from him, such as respect for his father, but does not give him any urban values in response. In other words, once he loses his traditional values in the city he lacks values altogether, as he is not able to replace them with new ones. Through all of this, the novel provides a firm criticism of migrants in this city.

As Saskia Sassen points out, the implementation of citizenship rights is closely correlated with "the position of different groups within a nation-state" (2003, 49). In *Oxen*, İzgü focuses on this discrepancy between citizenship rights on paper and in practice, together with the hostility migrants face in the city. He develops the theme of citizenship through the motifs of state and military offices with their officials, and the vague borders between them as perceived by 'citizens on paper'. Anna Secor, in her article about the citizenship practice of Kurdish migrants in Istanbul, reminds us that "cities, as prime sites of 'public space' and encounter, are significant locales for the performance of citizenship in daily life" (2003, 149). İzgü emphasises in his work how cities, as the locus of public space and encounter, reveal that citizenship rights in daily life are almost a myth in Turkey, especially in the years in which the novel is set, and particularly where people of Eastern Anatolia are concerned. p. 112–113

İzgü addresses the various sorts of symbolic and economic violence migrants face in the city as he skilfully depicts the ordinary man's struggle in an environment where hostility is multifaceted. Halo and İdiris never question the humiliation they face, and the non-committal narrative voice mimics their obedience throughout the novel. Giving a realistic portrayal of the shortcomings of fundamental rights in his novel, İzgü artfully demonstrates that the right to the city is not even on the horizon for a certain type of 'citizen' of the country. p. 113

The Homesick Birds and Uncle Halo and Two Oxen: A Comparative Analysis

p. 113 In *Birds*, Orhan Kemal perceives migrants among his potential readers. He presents the novel's protagonist Memed as a role model for migrants; it is a book which migrants can read and get inspired by. On the other hand, in *Oxen* the protagonist Halo is only a temporary migrant, and the second major character İdiris is far from being a role model.

In terms of characterisation, whereas in *Birds*, akin to a *Bildungsroman*, Memed's development can be traced, in *Oxen* there is no such character development: Halo is already an old man, and the city does not alter his outlook on life. His son İdiris, who could have been a perfect example of character development in the city, does change after he comes to the city, but not in a positive way; he simply learns to be selfish to survive in the city. Contrarily, in *Birds*, Memed's transformation based on growing up and maturing is synchronous with his adoption of an urban perspective.

p. 113–114 İdiris's inability to develop his personality in Istanbul is in line with *Oxen*'s central message: scepticism about the opportunities migration can offer for a fulfilling life. Additionally, while in *Birds* Kemal emphasises the liberating potential of urban life not only for men but also for women, İzgü does not address the gender aspect of migration as an opportunity for women in *Oxen*.

p. 114 In *Birds*, as Memed starts to adopt an urban identity, following the steps of another migrant, Kastamonulu, he becomes aware of his rights as a citizen of the country. First and the most visible of all, he claims the right to live in whichever city of his country he prefers. Owing to this awareness, he becomes able to contest the hostility of urbanites against rural migrants. Thus, he first manifests his new identity as a member of the urban society through his confidence in the public realm. On the other hand, neither Halo nor İdiris ever comes close to defending himself against the antagonism of urbanites since they never feel themselves as equal citizens with rights.

Since individuality is an important element of urbanisation, and becoming an individual requires independence from parents, the father–son relationships in the two novels must be evaluated within this context. In *Birds*, Memed comes to Istanbul on his own and manages to survive in the city, which makes his father Yusuf jealous. Unlike Yusuf, Memed becomes literate and keeps his dignity in his struggle in the city. Memed thus gains independence from his father and becomes an adult. In *Oxen*, as İdiris cuts his ties with his father he becomes dependent on new people. Even so, the dissolution of family ties in both novels implies a varying degree of tendency for individuality in the urban setting.

Birds is a novel with a message about the interrelated dynamics of rural–urban migration, urbanisation and the development of the proletariat. The focus of its setting is the city. *Oxen*'s message is mainly about the ways rural people, particularly those from Eastern Anatolia, are isolated from the rest of the country: socially, culturally and economically. Accordingly, although it is predominantly set in the city, it is more of a road novel at the end of which the protagonist goes back home while his companion stays in the new place (i.e., Istanbul). The titles of the two books reflect their focuses clearly: *The Homesick Birds* is about migrants who find a new home in a faraway place, while *Uncle Halo and Two Oxen* is mainly the story of Halo, who goes to the city only to stay there for a short while, with no intention of migrating. In *Birds* Kemal emphasises the inevitability of rural–urban migration in the process of the structural changes in the country. İzgü addresses the extremely difficult living conditions in the villages of Eastern Anatolia in *Oxen*; however, he does not offer rural–urban migration as its remedy.

p. 115 While in *Birds* there are scenes set in various districts of Istanbul, in *Oxen* the setting is mainly the building sites where Halo and İdiris work, accentuating their limited connection with the city. In *Birds* the social and historical background is constantly stressed, particularly with reference to the Democratic Party government, in line with a conception of migrants as potential actors in the social, political and cultural life of the country. The absence of such connections in *Oxen* is compatible with İzgü's portrayal of migrants as unaware and uninformed people isolated on building sites where they work. In *Birds*, Memed is forced to support the Democratic Party, which he is able to reject but not without a cost. Gafur, one of the major characters, uses his ties with the Democratic Party to get Memed and Ayşe's shanty demolished. On the other hand, in *Oxen* politics is never a part of the characters' lives. *Birds* was written only a year after the 27 May 1960 military coup which overthrew the Democratic Party government and brought in the most democratic constitution in Turkish history, while *Oxen* was written two years after another military coup, that of 12 March 1971, which brought in a brutal regime, particularly for the Left. This might also be a factor in the latter's apolitical atmosphere, which reflects the zeitgeist of the times.

The right to housing is a major theme in *Birds*, underscored in the shanty demolition marking the ending of the novel. In *Oxen*, İzgü indirectly addresses the housing issue as Halo and İdiris live under difficult conditions on the building site where they work. He simply acknowledges that not all migrants are fortunate enough to live in a shanty. The dwelling of migrants on building sites also illustrates their existence in the city as transitional. In *Birds*, Memed also lives on a building site in the first phase of his time in Istanbul while Ayşe lives in a mansion as a maid. The development which marks their existence in the city as permanent is building their shanty.

p. 115–116 The two positions of the two works on the oral culture of the countryside as opposed to the written culture of the city, and rural migrants' 'lack of culture' thereof, are disparate. In *Birds*, rural migrants are a blank page to be filled

with what they can gain from the written culture and a way of life in the city. In *Oxen*, at the beginning of the novel, İzgü presents rural people's oral culture *as culture*: "grandfather's war memories" and "old women's fairytales" (İzgü 1974, 5) imply a distinct way of life in the heart of nature which he poignantly depicts. As discussed in their analyses, while in *Birds* Memed's village in Sivas, whose name is not given, is illustrated as a grim place, in *Oxen* the village of Mescitli is described with an idyllic charm despite the extremely harsh climate and living conditions. Within this context, it might be possible to argue that *Oxen* is, even if not intentionally, compatible with an anti-modernist discourse which prefers a nature-friendly life in the heart of nature to the benefits of industrialisation and urbanisation.

Neither in *Birds* nor in *Oxen* Alevis are ever mentioned. In *Birds*, the word "Kurd" is uttered in one instance (Kemal 2010, 121), while in *Oxen* it is completely absent. In the eras where the two novels were written, referring to a Kurd would be similarly risky, so Orhan Kemal's was a courageous gesture. That said, *Oxen* might also be regarded as a brave work for its time, since it is open to be read as the story of two Kurdish men in Istanbul. p. 116

The potential contribution of city life to migrants' development as individuals is central in *Birds*. When migrants become literate, read newspapers and books, adopt the standard dialect, and change their various habits, they will be urbanised members of the city as part of the working class. They will be aware of their rights, including their right to the city, and able to fight for them. *Oxen* is mainly about the state–citizen relationship. The characters in the novel know that they have obligations as citizens, but they are not aware of their rights. This is the primary concern of the work, while the migrant's struggle in the urban context and his or her right to the city is secondary. In this work, the hostility of the state, rendered through its public officials, outweighs the hostility of urbanites against rural people; while in *Birds*, the hostility migrants experience is limited to that given by the urbanites.

In sum, Kemal presents city life as an ideal within the reach of the rural population of the country in *Birds*, while in *Oxen* İzgü has a somewhat cynical perspective regarding the opportunities an urban lifestyle might offer to rural migrants who cannot even feel themselves as citizens with certain rights.

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CHAPTER 6 Insider's Knowledge: Survival in the Jungle of Istanbul

Both Latife Tekin's *Berji Kristin: Tales from the Garbage Hills*, published in 1984, and Metin Kaçan's *Heavy Roman(i)*, published in 1990, are novels based on an insider's perspective. They can be regarded as examples of the second phase of the Istanbul novel with migrant protagonists, where either the first or the second-generation migrant author writes about life in Istanbul as experienced by migrants and their families. The narrator in each of the two novels uses authentic language: folk language in *Hills* and slang in *Roman(i)*. Consequently, there is no superiority of an urban narrator over migrant characters in these novels. Notwithstanding this similarity, there are considerable differences between the two novels in terms of their approach to the struggle for the right to the city and the process of adopting an urban identity, which serve as a fertile ground for comparison. p. 119

Berji Kristin: Tales from the Garbage Hills: A Satirical Rebuttal to Normative Urbanity

Latife Tekin's second novel *Berci Kristin Çöp Masalları* (*Berji Kristin: Tales from the Garbage Hills*), published in 1984, is about the birth and growth of an imaginary shanty town called Çiçektepe (Flower Hill), in the 1970s, on the garbage heaps of an unidentified city described as "neighbourhoods in the area known as the city's garbage hills, including Flower Hill" (Tekin 2004, 70). Tekin explains that *berci* means a shepherd girl, which also symbolises purity (Özer 2005, 63). In the novel, Kristin is the name of the first prostitute in the shanty town. Thus, the title refers to the transformation from being a *berci* to being Kristin (63–64). p. 119–120

Upon its publication, researchers and commentators as well as readers automatically regarded the work as being set in Istanbul. For instance, when Semih Gümüş mentions that the novel is about a shanty town, he parenthetically adds that it is "of course in Istanbul" (2011, 128). However, there is no concrete fact in the book proving that Flower Hill is in Istanbul. Readers tend to associate the setting with Istanbul primarily because the city was the locus of migration, and secondarily because Tekin migrated to Istanbul with her family from the Anatolian city of Kayseri, when she was a child. p. 120

The novel is set in an imaginary Turkish city which receives migration, and which, as the following excerpt demonstrates, is on the coast: "the committee explored the far reaches of the city for three days and found a flat hilltop which overlooked the dazzling blue sea from among the pines" (151). This hilltop they find, in their search for a place to build their shanties on, might as well be in another migrant-receiving coastal city such as İzmir, Adana or Mersin. The question then arises as to why this city is undisclosed in the novel. It is probably more than a simple authorial decision to enable the novel to be associated with all migrant-receiving cities rather than one of them. By keeping the city anonymous, Tekin seems to accentuate the disconnectedness between rural migrants and the city they live in: isolated in shanty towns, being in this or that city does not make much difference in their lives.

At the İstanbullu Olmak (Being an Istanbulite) conference in 2012, Arus Yumul stressed that in all the surveys about being an Istanbulite, migrants are asked if they have ever seen places such as the Bosporus or the Topkapı Palace; but we never ask ourselves if we have ever seen places like Sultanbeyli or similar so-called *varoş* parts of the city. Yumul, referring to Richard Sennett, emphasised in her talk that "city is a place to meet with differences". Sennett defines such encounters as the interaction of differences (1989, 83–84) and sees them as the quintessential urban experience since the city must be "a place where those who are unlike find some sense of mattering to each other" (84). In the novel, the interaction of differences in the city is minimal. Migrants living in the shanties in Flower Hill never go to see the Bosporus or the Topkapı Palace, and inhabitants of the city's central areas do not visit Flower Hill. The city in which Flower Hill exists remains a mystery for the reader akin to the way it is a mystery for this shanty town's people. As Hande Tekdemir aptly observes: "Tekin succeeds in putting the shantytown at the centre, but fails to provide a holistic image of the city. However, this seeming flaw in the text is precisely what Tekin seeks in her fiction. She decentralizes the urban setting and looks at the peripheries. These liminal sites are mentally and physically very loosely (and sometimes never) connected to the city in which they are located" (2011, 48). p. 120–121

As discussed below, in *Hills* Tekin develops certain themes directly related to the right to the city based on the search for basic material necessities. She problematises the urbanisation of rural migrants challenging a rigid normative understanding of urbanity. Implementing elements of oral culture in the form as well as in the content of her book she celebrates the folk culture of migrants and calls for an appreciation of alternative urban identities which incorporate this culture. p. 121

The novel opens with the following sentence: "One winter night, on a hill where the huge refuse bins came daily and dumped the city's waste, eight shelters were set up by lantern-light near the garbage heaps" (15). First, people picking over garbage on the hills notice these shelters. After them, the *simit* sellers at the top of Rubbish Road hear about them.[1]

[1] A *simit* is a Turkish bread ring encrusted with sesame seeds, also known as a Turkish bagel.

p. 121–122 Poor people doing various jobs and migrants temporarily staying with relatives arrive at the hill to build shanties; 100 are built in one night. However, after a couple of days, the shanties are demolished on official order. A child named Sırma who thus loses her home falls ill because of her despair and Güllü Baba heals her with his prayer (11–12), an event which introduces the magical realism of the novel.[2] Soon after the demolition, the shanty dwellers start rebuilding their shanties using the garbage from the plate factory. Depictions of shanty dwellers' tragic experiences as they strive to survive are infused with a magical aspect as in the following example: "three babies died, weary of cold and destruction, and took wing to heaven before the very eyes of the wreckers" (22). Due to the deficiency in the materials the new shanties are so small that they fly away in the wind; consequently, people on the hill lose their shelters once again. Thus, they decide to pick over the garbage on the hill and sell it in order to earn money for purchasing material to build the shanties anew.

p. 122 Implementing the technique of defamiliarisation, Tekin illustrates building and demolition of the shanties in a unique manner instead of repeating realist depictions.[3] Such a formal trait invites the reader to attempt to view the shanty issue through a perspective different from the mainstream perceptions on the issue. This formal gesture also enhances the sensation that the narrator is a person from the hill. She seems to be a member of the community who feels the need to create a magical world in order to be able to handle the difficulty of narrating the shanty town's grim reality. Tekdemir's clarification on this is worth quoting at length:

> It [magical realism] is locally adapted in order to represent the otherwise unrepresentable. Magical realism becomes an apt technique for filling in the gap between real life and its representation in language. There is a parallel between how the migrants survive in the modern city and how the author [...] manages to give them voice in writing. The harsh reality of the city seeps into their magical view of the world and the subsequent mixture furnishes the community with the power to survive. (2011, 42)

In the very first chapter of the novel, depicting the development process from a couple of shelters to a shanty town, Tekin makes it clear that she will tell about life in Flower Hill through an unnatural storyworld. As Alber et al. describe it, "an unnatural storyworld contains physical or logical impossibilities that concern the represented world's temporal or spatial organization" (2010, 116). The unnatural storyworld of the novel almost functions as an allegory of the 'unnaturalness' of urban life for rural migrants, inviting the reader to view the urban setting through the eyes of these rural migrants for whom the events and phenomena in the city are totally unfamiliar if not incomprehensible.

p. 122–123 Murat Belge, referring to Tekin's first novel *Dear Shameless Death* (1983), points out that Tekin, similar to Yaşar Kemal, tries to bring the mind and the heart of peasants to the pages of her novels, and adds that the mindset and outlook on life of peasants are difficult to grasp with the rationalism of a Westernist-progressivist stance (1994b, 223). Such an attitude which Belge identifies in Tekin's first work is present in *Hills* as well. Belge's point is a compact clarification of a complex issue: Tekin's position against a normative understanding of urbanity, in other words with the way migrants are expected to urbanise in the manner dictated by the establishment, is at the core of the novel. This is actually part of the problem which Meral Özbek describes as Turkish cultural modernisation's failure to "consider regional, class-based and ethnic differences" since it does not implement "a pluralist cultural policy" (2002, 40).

p. 123 Although discussed in earlier chapters, it might be useful to mention once again that, as Tahire Erman observes, in the 1950s and 1960s there was "a structural-functionalist-modernist explanation" in studying the shanty dwellers who were expected to urbanise in the city (2001, 992). Erman notes that such an approach gave way to a "structural Marxist explanation" in the 1970s and early 1980s (992). However, the Marxist perspective could not refrain from carrying various misconceptions of the former perception. First of all, "it play[ed] down the negative attitude of the modernisation approach to the persistence of rural values and communal existence in the city" (992) and "there was no attempt to focus on the experiences of rural migrants or to present migrants as individuals who were entitled to their own ways of thinking and living" (993). Tekin cunningly criticises the shortcomings of the Marxist perspective as regards the urban problematics: Flower Hill community's encounter with the members of the radical left is an important theme in the novel.

Tekin presents her criticism of the elite establishment and the radical left as regards the urbanisation of rural migrants in an innovative way, not only through the content but also through the form of her novel. The dialogues in the book are in the form of reported speech in which we hear words and expressions of rural people. The originality of the work is, however, the implementation of folk language *by the narrator* as well. She utilises words from folk speech and her sentences are short and always in the simple past tense, echoing oral culture tradition. Consequently, the narrator sounds like a person from the Flower Hill community. Eliminating the superiority of an urban narrator over migrant characters in the novel, Tekin contests a monist perception of urbanity that disregards pluralism and alternative ways of becoming urbanites.

[2] Güllü Baba (Father Güllü) is a blind man who is believed to be a holy person with supernatural powers.

[3] "Defamiliarization refers to the artist's and critic's attention to the 'devices' and formal elements of literary creation. The purpose of art, in this view, is to impart the sensation of things as they are perceived, not as they are known. Perception, moreover, becomes an aesthetic end in itself, with a focus on the reading process" (Lorman 2012, 343).

The characteristics and narrative forms of the oral culture tradition appear throughout *Hills*. For instance, in line with oral tradition, the narrator refers to natural events to imply the passing of time; such as the use of snow to indicate winter. Narrative forms such as folk songs and folk poetry have a central place in the novel. For example, in the first chapter, the birds flying over the newly built shanties sing the following song: p. 123–124

Wee wee rooftops, / Won't you wing with me? Drop the babies' cradles / And fly away free. Fling us out a wee one, / Wee, wee, wee! (18) p. 124

In the second chapter, the men of Flower Hill invent a game and play it while singing a song:

Oh Wind, / My eyes keep running, my poor knees shake, All the time my shoulders ache, / My arms can't lift, my fingers chill, One of us must leave this hill. (34)

In the third chapter, we hear two songs from Güllü Baba (40–41). All these songs are in the form of *türkü* which means a Turkish folk song. In some instances, it is the characters who sing/recite these songs and short poems, in others it is the narrator. On the first page of the fourth chapter a worker sings the following song:

Ding Ding, Dinga Ding, / Out on strike the chemists went, Keep it going, Dinga Ding, / By the factory bloomed a snow-white tent. Keep it going, Dinga Ding. (48)

After two paragraphs, we hear another song, this time within the narration:

By the factory bloomed a snow-white tent, / Keep it going, Dinga ding, But the wind blew up and away it went. / Keep it going, Dinga ding. (49)

With such references, Tekin conveys a powerful message regarding the culture of rural migrants in shanty towns. Since they are not educated and do not have access to the written culture of the urban context, urbanites regard rural migrants as cultureless. Tekin contests this prejudice by making their oral culture visible in her novel. She demonstrates that migrants in the city who are semi- or fully illiterate are not deprived of culture; rather they do possess one which is their oral culture. Tekin constantly emphasises the oral culture at the centre of life in Flower Hill; in the novel there is even one open reference to the very concept. When Lado, a member of the Flower Hill community, decides to write a novel about the shanty town, the narrator makes the following comment: "Lado's adventures remained as the finest examples of the squatters' oral tradition" (129). p. 124–125

Güneli Gün describes Tekin's language as built on the legacy of "her own past in the Anatolian hinterland but also from the language of the Turks' Central Asian nomadic past, of tales, boasts, rumors, laments, riddles, ditties, gossip, exaggerations, jokes, adventures told around a campfire" (1993, 886). *Hills* is a work where "all the forms of [Tekin's] unique, highly metaphoric, and wryly nonrepresentational language" come together (Seyhan 2008, 171). With such a style, as Saliha Paker points out, Tekin manages to write the novel with "'a language of the deprived', one that gives expression not only to their way of life but also to their outlook on life, perception of reality, sense of humour and dreams" (2004, 12). In short, Tekin presents her critique of the prescription of urbanity and the urban-rural divide not only in the content but also in the form and style of the novel. Enmeshing folk speech with the standard dialect, and bringing folk literature via inserted genres into a modern narrative in *Hills*, Tekin suggests a perspective critical of what Erman defines as the "structural-functionalist-modernist" approach of the 1950s and 1960s, as well as the "structural Marxist explanation" in the 1970s and early 1980s (2001, 992), through the very aesthetics of her book. Tekin, celebrating *urbanities rather than urbanity* invites sympathy for rural migrants' alternative lifestyles in the urban context as well as for their survival strategies, some of which are despised by the elite and criticised by the Left. p. 125

Tekin addresses individualisation in the urban context in line with this perspective: in *Hills* there is no character development to speak of; each chapter has its major character(s) who might or might not reappear in the following chapters. Murat Belge stresses that *Hills* was "a brand new novel with its structure: it did not have a centre in the usual way, and characters forming the centre" and adds: "in a way, the protagonist of the novel was the shantytown which was the subject of the novel" (1994c, 224). Semih Gümüş regards this experimenting with character as a defect of *Hills* (2011, 129). He describes the characters who appear in different chapters of the book as "too far away from being literary personalities" since they do not bear "growing personality traits" and argues that "they remain as a detail, as literary elements" (129). Similar to the plot structure of the work, which does not proceed to a climax and conflict, the characters in it do not bear character development patterns which evolve into an epiphany. The protagonist of the novel is Flower Hill, a point which Gümüş agrees with as well (129). This stylistic decision enables Tekin to accent her stance on individualisation: "although there are [...] numerous characters in Tekin's novel, they are all subservient to a communal rather than an individual voice" (Tekdemir 2011, 45). As Tekdemir aptly observes, "each and every voice does not speak up for him- or herself [...] but is rather represented by collective identity of the shantytown dwellers" (45). p. 125–126

The dwellers of Flower Hill live in a close-knit community; they do not search for opportunities of individualisation within the crowds of the city. Yet, this should not necessarily form an obstacle against their (own way of) urbanisation. p. 126

As Gilbert and Gugler observe, “there is not one urban life style distinct from a rural way of life but a variety of lifestyles unknown in the village community” and “some urbanites lead encapsulated lives, nearly as if they were in a village community, but others strike out [...] become individualists” (1987, 124), and people in Flower Hill seem to prefer the former to the latter. Tekin’s decision to not develop individual protagonist(s) is compatible with this preference. Doing this, she once again underlines her openness to multiple urbanities, this time through her approach to the correlation between urbanisation and individualisation.

John Berger, in the Preface he wrote for *Hills*, explains that in the novel the “shanty-town community becomes the centre of the world, holding the stage” (6) and defines “rumour” as “the story-teller” of the novel (7). Indeed, throughout the book there is an endless repetition of new words of mouth (*laf*) that spread around Flower Hill; with each of them a new concept enters the shanty town. However, these concepts always get transformed on their journey and start to bear new meanings: word of mouth, or rumour as Berger calls it, is the basic element of communication among the shanty community, as well as of their (mis)communication with the extremely unfamiliar urban culture whose codes they are trying to decipher. In the novel, we see the clearest manifestation of this (mis)communication in the Flower Hill inhabitants’ encounter with the radical left.

An Uneasy Encounter: Shanty Community vs the Radical Left

p. 127 The novel is set during the highly political era of the 1970s which ended with the 1980 military coup. During the 1970s, the Left was able to find support in shanty towns. In those years, various shanty towns were established by radical left groups which believed in the right to housing (Aslan 2004, 85). As Şükrü Aslan acknowledges, the number of such neighbourhoods was around twelve. Additionally, the Left had members and organisations in other shanty towns which they did not control (email comm., 2 July 2016). Tekin’s approach to this fact in the novel can be analysed under two headings: (1) the Hill folk’s encounter with the unionised workers of the factories on Rubbish Road and their strikes; and (2) their struggle for the right to the city.

Tekin addresses the Hill folk’s encounter with the proletariat through their relationship with the strikers and therefore the unions. In Chapter 4, the workers in the medicine factory on Rubbish Road go on strike. The Hill folk try to make sense of the strike; some of them believe that the strikers have supernatural expectations. They speculate on the meaning of the union: “while everyone was asking one another what ‘The Union’ (sendika) meant, Güllü Baba explained that the name derived from the word ‘box’ (sandık)” (53). After a while, the Hill folk write down their wishes such as “work, roads, buses and schools” (54) on pieces of cloth and put them next to the banners. They talk extensively about the factory, and as new words such as “class” start to circulate they are left perplexed: “The Flower Hill folk heard that the workers of Rubbish Road were a ‘class’, and that the Union would appropriate the factories on their behalf. Rumour spread that the workers had a power that could shake the world, and after Kara Hasan had explained the writing on the picket line banners, an epidemic of stories broke out in the community along with legends about the factory owners, the songs and customs of the workers, and things unimaginable” (55). After a while, the Hill folk find at their doorsteps leaflets about the strike; they question why the striking workers left these instead of a proper conversation, which annoys them.

p. 127–128 Eventually, the chemical factory workers end their strike, but the number of unionised workers in the factories on Rubbish Road keeps increasing. Meanwhile, the new manager of Mr Izak’s factory makes the working conditions even worse, and workers occupy the factory. After the occupation is over, the squatter factories era comes to an end with various questions in the heads of the Hill folk. The imam of Mr Izak’s mosque claims that the strike is against God’s will, while Mr Izak disappears. In these two chapters on the exploitation of workers and class struggle, the worlds of the workers and the Hill folk seem to be disparate. We learn that the watchmen at the factory are from the Hill folk (97). It is not clear whether among the workers at the factory there are any members of the Hill folk; it can be inferred that there are none.

p. 128 When Mr Izak opens a new fridge factory ten young men from Flower Hill start working there. After a short while, factories producing sham products are opened one after the other in Flower Hill, and the Hill folk find jobs in them.[4] They earn money but due to the toxic materials they start to develop sores, just as Güllü Baba had once predicted in the very early days of the shanty town. In Chapter 13, during the strike factories era, there is a protest by the workers of the fridge factory where ten men from the Hill folk are employed. As the Hill folk hear the slogans of the protesters, rumours spread that the protesting workers do not have homes and plan to attack the shanties in order to take them from their owners. Another rumour surfaces that these workers will assault those who do not participate in their protest.

In all these encounters between the Flower Hill people and the leftist workers there is emphasis on the lack of communication between the two groups. Notwithstanding that, some members of the Hill folk sympathise with the leftist workers, while some of them are prejudiced against them. In any case, Tekin depicts the language of the Left as

[4]The three eras of industry in Flower Hill are the squatter factories era, the sham factories (which produce sham products) era and the strike factories era.

unfamiliar to the rural migrants living in shanties, since they are not yet members of the working class. Employment at the sham factories or textile workshops on Rubbish Road does not automatically make workers from Flower Hill class-conscious members of the proletariat. For this they need to be at factories where unions are powerful. In the absence of these conditions, the communication between rural migrants and leftist workers is minimal. Rural migrants strive to make sense of the unfamiliar world of leftist workers regarding strikes and protests; hence all the rumours, with reference to supernatural events, about all these alien ‘things’ such as unions, strikes and banners.

When it comes to the Hill folk’s struggle for their right to the city, we see that it is clearly separate from the urban social movements of the times. The main thread of *Hills* which connects the seemingly separate chapters to each other is the Hill folk’s fight for their right to the city, with one issue after the other within this scope. The first battle of the Hill folk is the battle for the right to housing. After that comes their struggle for other needs: a place of worship and the services of the municipality such as water and electricity, public transport and a school. The Hill folk build their own mosque and school. To request a public bus service, they make an official application, but with no result. For water and electricity, they enlist the *mukhtar*’s help.[5] p. 128–129

In each of these struggles the Hill folk are on their own, they do not get any guidance or support from the members of the radical left, although there is a large number of leftists in the area who work at the factories on Rubbish Road. In the novel, there is no reference to the influence of radical left groups on the shanty dwellers’ struggle for their right to the city. Using an unnatural storyworld, Tekin depicts realistically what Kemal Karpat describes as the distance of shanty dwellers from the “hate and aversion toward the system, as romantic revolutionaries had speculated and hoped for” (2009, 44). Karpat explains that although at various moments they collaborated with the radical left, shanty dwellers were predominantly inclined to democratic participation rather than radicalism (200). In *Hills*, Tekin addresses this fact not only as the shanty dwellers’ preference but also as the radicals’ inability to develop a mutual language with them. p. 129

Who Is More the Migrant in the Struggle for Survival?

Tahire Erman stresses that, primarily owing to “the emergence of identity politics in Turkish society in the mid-1980s”, shanty dwellers in academic studies were “no longer exclusively seen as a homogeneous group based on their common rural origins. Instead, they were seen as comprised of diverse sub-groups based on their different ethnic and sectarian backgrounds” (2001, 993). As clarified above, Latife Tekin’s awareness of and preference for a pluralist perspective on urbanisation is central in *Hills*, which was written in 1984. With her novel she was close to “diversity and difference rather than to similarity and uniformity”, which Erman describes as an approach emerging in shanty studies after the mid-1980s (993). p. 129

Rural migrants from ethnic groups such as Kurds or Romani people, or sectarian groups such as Alevis, were subject to a double hostility by urbanites in the city: first because of their rural background, second because of their ethnic and/or sectarian background. Ethnic and sectarian differences could also lead to discrimination among migrants. This issue appears in the book within the chapters about the Romani people and Alevis. p. 130

As mentioned earlier, the narrator sounds like an insider of Flower Hill. As Ayten Sönmez points out, both in Tekin’s first novel and in *Hills*, “the narrator most of the time creates the impression that she/he is a part of the collectivity” (2004, 29), and adds that in these works there is not “an outsider gaze from above which categorises, maps, putting itself in the centre” (30). Within this context, the narrator does not make an effort to balance the discriminating discourses and prejudices of the Flower Hill people and this, unfortunately, results in the reproduction of discriminating discourses at certain points of the novel.

Furthermore, there are various choices in the plot structure and character construction which are in line with discriminating discourses. For instance, the leader of the mafia which rules Flower Hill is Kurd Cemal; and apart from this evil man there is no other Kurdish character in the novel. The owner of the factories in Flower Hill which pollute the area with industrial sewage is Mr Izak whose name implies that he is Jewish, and he is the only minority character in the book.[6] Azade Seyhan agrees that Mr Izak’s characterisation is in line with the “greedy Jew” stereotype (2008, 175).

Tekin’s attitude to Romani people is also worthy of discussion. Towards the end of the book, Flower Hill becomes divided into two: the Hill folk give the name “Foundation Hill” (Vakıf Çiçektepe) to the original Flower Hill, while they call their new place “Unity Hill” (Birlik Çiçektepe) (155). They try to dwell in both places for a while, and eventually the majority of them move to the latter collectively. The narrator explains that “after some time the gypsy way of life overshadowed the squatters who lived on Foundation Hill. Fragments of the gypsy language passed into the squatters’ slang” (158). Once the place becomes dominated by the Romani people, it becomes a centre of drugs p. 130–131

[5] A *mukhtar* is the officially appointed head of a village or a neighbourhood.

[6] ‘Minority’ and ‘minorities’ denote the non-Muslim minority population (i.e., Greeks, Armenians, and Jews).

and prostitution. Thus, the story of Foundation Hill reproduces the dominant discriminating discourse about Romani people.

p. 131–132 Tekin has a similar tendency regarding Alevis. The fifteenth chapter starts with a snowy Ramadan day when someone in Flower Hill throws a Ramadan drummer out of the neighbourhood.[7] Rumours begin circulating that the man who did that was "Kızılbaş" (126). Kızılbaş can be a pejorative word for an Alevi when used by a non-Alevi person and depending on the context.[8] One would expect that, in the novel, the use of this word would be limited to dialogues, with the word Alevi used in narration instead. Surprisingly, this is not the case: both the Hill folk *and the narrator* refer to Alevis as Kızılbaş. When the upset Ramadan drummer comes back with his friends, they play music in front of the Alevis' shanties in order to disturb them. The narrator has a sarcastic tone about the Alevi tolerance while telling about this event: "The man who had cursed the drummer panicked and boarded up his door and window. Demonstrating the famous Kızılbaş tolerance he lay sweating under five layers of quilt, taking refuge in daydreams" (127). Eventually, there is a fight over this issue, and afterwards neighbourhood dwellers form groups based on their hometown villages. Thus, the separation among migrants based on sectarian differences evolves to include division based on regional differences as well. Consequently, the Alevis of Flower Hill take control of the only coffeehouse of the shanty town. At this point of the chapter, in a digression, the narrator tells a story about an Alevi *dede* (elder).[9] The narrator tells about "elders who circulated the huts begging for handouts of money and gifts" (127) and explains that one of them "brought along an impressive stick to beat the Kızılbaş who did not observe their duties" (127–128). The narrator adds: "for a time they wandered about appearing at people's doors hoping for handouts" (128). This story, the purpose of which is completely unclear, simply creates a negative impression about Alevis. Acknowledging such "questions of representational bias" in the novel concerning Romani people and Alevis, Azade Seyhan thinks that at least the former "are portrayed as unjustly persecuted yet talented and colourful people" (2008, 175), and regards the book's stance towards the latter as harsher.

p. 132 Despite all that, it would be unfair to argue that Tekin deliberately reproduces discriminating discourses and prejudices in her novel because it is not only the holy Alevi men she portrays sarcastically with emphasis on their manipulation of people's respect, but the muezzin in the novel who is a Sunni holy man is also a fraud (147–148).[10] The novel includes passages which depict the prejudice of the Hill folk against the Romani people when they first arrive: Hınık Ahlas's (Honking Ahlas) long speeches about them (110–111) are a parody of widespread prejudices against the Romani citizens of the country. Similarly, the rumours circulating among the Hill folk (125–126) ridicule the urban myths about the traditions and worshipping habits of Alevis. All things considered, Tekin can be criticised for being insensitive in her novel on issues of discrimination rather than deliberately being discriminative.

When it comes to women of Flower Hill, a sarcastic look at patriarchal society can be felt in the novel. In the fifth chapter we meet "Fidan of Many Skills [Tirintaz Fidan] who gave the women of the community 'Evening Classes' in the arts of the bed" (60). As the women of Flower Hill become enlightened by this woman about sexuality, they learn that it is not only men but also women who can obtain sexual pleasure: "for every new thing the women learned from her they took a beating from their husbands" (63). Consequently, Çöp Bakkal's (Garbage Grocer) wife complains to her husband that she has never had sexual satisfaction; however, her husband reacts aggressively and the subject is instantly closed (64–65). In the eighteenth chapter, a cinema is opened in Flower Hill, and the women are influenced by the lives they see in the films:

p. 132–133 [Women] shed many a tear on the roads until they discovered that the film stars had not really died, but once the tears were dried the young girls started to go about with bare arms and legs like film stars and the women cast off their headscarves. Fired with the desire for pleasure after Tirintaz Fidan's night lessons, women now clung to their husbands' hands and feet begging for love. They trembled and swooned with upturned eyes and uttered strangled sobs at not being loved, but their men who were gambling their lives away in the coffeehouses brought them back down to earth with a beating. (146)

p. 133 As these two motifs with a dark brand of humour demonstrate, the novel has the message that urban life might have an emancipatory influence on women; however, they would be inhibited from making progress by the men in their lives. Tekin also addresses, briefly but effectively, the theme of attempting urbanisation through consumption, a tendency particularly strong in women: "One of them [tradesmen] managed to sell a set of liqueur glasses to every woman on Flower Hill and from another tradesman all the squatter women bought red net curtains" (142).

[7] A Ramadan drummer is a man who, during the Ramadan month when Muslims fast, walks the streets playing his drums in order to wake them for *sahoor*, the early breakfast after which fasting starts.

[8] "Alevism is a branch of Shi'a Islam that is practiced in Turkey and the Balkans among ethnic Turks and Kurds" (Alevism).

[9] An Alevi *dede* is a holy man, highly respected by Alevis.

[10] A muezzin is an officially appointed man who recites the call to prayer from the minaret in a mosque.

Conclusion

In this book with an insider's perspective Tekin brings a fresh outlook to the representation of the migration experience in Turkish literature. The world of migrants living in a shanty town is a colourful one in the novel, depicted within an unnatural storyworld. This storyworld implies that, similar to the way migrants feel confused when confronted with the lives of urbanites, urbanites also become confused while encountering the lives of migrants; and as migrants try to understand urbanites, urbanites should try to understand migrants. If the city is the locus of an "interaction of differences" (Sennett 1989, 83–84), this interaction cannot be made possible simply by the efforts of the newcomers to the city; it should be reciprocal, with urbanites also trying to understand migrants. p. 133

Hills offers criticism of a rigid, normative understanding of urbanity. Unlike *Birds*, where Kemal, with a modernist/Marxist stance, stresses that the route to urbanisation goes through proletarianisation, in *Hills* Tekin refrains from a prescription for urbanisation and simply hints at the possibility of alternative urbanities, multiple ways of urbanisation which can incorporate elements of rural culture. She manages to convey this message not only through her novel's content but also through its very form which embraces the oral culture of rural migrants.

In *Hills*, Tekin constantly emphasises the ongoing battle between labour and capital. Workers rise against the owners of the factories they work at, and the Hill folk have their own struggle against capitalists: when the garbage owner tries to stop them picking over his garbage, when the factory owners poison them with toxic industrial sewage, and when they eventually do not want garbage around their neighbourhood. However, their struggle against capitalists is not integrated with the class struggle of the workers. Similarly, the Hill folk's fight for the right to the city is not incorporated into urban movements. In both of these processes they are on their own, isolated from the Left, because their encounter with it is simply an experience of confusion and a lack of communication. p. 133–134

The potential of the Hill Folk's encounter with the Left is not fulfilled in terms of their fight for the right to the city. It is not fulfilled in terms of their urbanisation either: while proximity with workers creates for them a bridge to urban culture through the culture of the urban working class and the radical left, they cannot utilise this bridge due to their lack of communication with the members of the Left. Tekin depicts these unfulfilled potentials mainly as resulting from the Left's inability to find a mutual language with rural migrants. p. 134

Life in the novel seems to take place in three spheres. The first one is Flower Hill the shanty town. The second is the sphere of the factories on Rubbish Road with its leftist workers. The third is the city space which almost never appears in the novel, except for a couple of visits by the Hill folk to the civil authorities. Tekin illustrates the condition of migrants in the city semi-metaphorically: they are paralysed between the urban sphere which rejects them and the working class they cannot communicate with.

At the centre of the novel lies "respect for plurality", as described in the World Charter for the Right to the City's list (2004, 2). With its thought-provoking perspective and daringly innovative style, this novel, included in the reading lists of sociology courses in the 1980s (Özbay 2009, 67), continues to be regarded as one of the most unique works addressing the issue of rural–urban migration in modern Turkish literature.

Heavy Roman(i): An Alternative Urbanity in the Dionysiac City

Metin Kaçan's debut novel *Ağır Roman* (*Heavy Roman(i)*), published in 1990, acquired cult status over time, which was reinforced by the suicide of its author in 2013. The novel is set in Kolera, a poor multicultural neighbourhood in the city centre which is a thinly disguised representation of Dolapdere and neighbourhoods adjacent to it. The title of the book comprises a double entendre: it literally means heavy novel, which is also a homonym for slowly/heavily played Romani music. In line with its title, the work is unique with its soundscape. Kaçan creates this soundscape with the use of auditory imagery, as well as by including events connected with music in the story. Therefore, there is a constant description of sounds in the novel and music is always to the fore. The goblet drum, an instrument highly popular among the Romani people in Turkey, is the main constituent of this music. Fatih Özgüven makes the following observation on the book: "Metin Kaçan caught something very significant about the city in 'Ağır Roman', the music of the city [...] That was the music of neighbourhoods we were not that familiar with, true. Yet, rather than content it was rhythm" (quoted in Köksal 2013). Kaçan also employs olfactory imagery repeatedly in his novel. With these two formal elements, he illustrates the reality of the Kolera neighbourhood in line with Saskia Sassen's following observation: "neighborhoods in the same city can exude very different auras, sounds, smells, choreographies of how people move through that neighborhood, and who is welcome and who is not" (2013, 217). Herkül Millas describes *Roman(i)* as a work where "poetic atmosphere and essence is predominant" and where "humour and satire, romanticism and empathy are felt in every moment" (email comm., 21 September 2016). In the novel, set in the 1970s (Arslan 2009, 122), the concept of the right to the city appears not in terms of material necessities but in terms of inhabiting the city in the Lefebvrian sense. In the novel, through the characterisation of the protagonist Gıli and the neighbourhood of Kolera as the setting, Kaçan conveys the message that the right to live in the city centre belongs p. 134–135

not only to the rich but also to the poor. Additionally, challenging the elitist hegemony in claiming the cosmopolitan heritage of the Istanbulite identity, he emphasises that the minority heritage can be a central element in the culture of poor neighbourhoods that are stigmatised as deteriorated.

p. 135 At the beginning of the novel, the narrator depicts Kolera as a colourful place where the eternal battle between good and evil continues. The way this topos appears in the introductory chapter is reminiscent of mythical stories. Kolerites live happily under Sado's wings until evil men kill him and attempt ruling the neighbourhood. Sado leaves Gıli as his heir.

p. 135–136 The novel might sound discriminatory about migrants at first as the narrator derides the migrants living in Kolera who look, behave and talk in the way they would back in their villages. Yet, the narrator in fact has an unselective approach: one can be a Greek or Assyrian who was born in Kolera, or one can arrive there as a migrant like many of the Kolerites: as long as the migrant adapts to life in Kolera she or he is welcome as a Kolerite.[11] As Sırma Köksal observes, Kolerites "were poor, uneducated, lumpen; yet they were urbanites" (2013, 3). The narrator who is a Kolerite does not regard a person as a 'peasant' simply because this person has a rural background; only those who act like they are still in the village are labelled as peasants by Kolerites and therefore denied the Kolerite identity.

p. 136 Very early on in the novel, we understand that language is the fundamental condition for adopting Kolerite identity. This language is Kolerite slang. Literary critic and poet Adnan Özer, bosom friend of Metin Kaçan, describes Kolera as "a geography of *language* and action" and adds that "in the mysticism of the poor neighbourhood [*kenar mahalle*] it corresponds to 'Âlem'" (1990, 33).[12] Özer aptly observes that this "âlem makes its criticism of the worlds on whose periphery it is" (33). "Âlem" is a word with multiple meanings and it is impossible to find its English equivalent that would encapsulate all of its meanings. Primarily, it means universe, world. It means a realm as well, with a mystical connotation. It also has the meaning of drinking and/or dancing and singing and/or getting high like a carousal, revelry, but not necessarily in a noisy way.[13]

Slang is not only the language of Kolerites but also of the narrator, which shows that he is one of them. Kolerite slang includes words from the languages of its inhabitants from various ethnic and religious backgrounds. Thus, the narrator describes the neighbourhood community as "the revellers of Kolera speaking eight languages" (Kaçan 1999, 62). In an interview, the author of the novel provides the following explanation: "the origins of the slang language I use are Russian, French, Greek, Kurdish, English, Romani, Spanish, Bulgarian, Italian" (Kaçan 1991, 14). Hulki Aktunç acknowledges that "the etymological weight of the 'Heavy Romani' slang (the slang used extensively in and around Kasımpaşa) is Romani" (1991, 13). As Refik Durbaş points out, Kaçan himself also creates some words of Kolerite slang (14).

p. 137 The narrator defines the peasants based on the way they (cannot) speak: "peasants who cannot put two words together and speak" (142). Lacking Kolerite slang and lacking the Kolerite identity are correlative. As Aktunç observes, "it is possible to divide the characters of 'Heavy Romani' into two as those who understand/those who do not understand the slang" (1991, 13). Peasants of the neighbourhood might attempt to speak the slang, an effort which does not gain the sympathy of Kolerites; the narrator describes them as "dummy peasants trying to speak the slang" (42) at one point. Since peasants cannot grasp Kolerite slang, they cannot comprehend the events taking place around them on certain occasions. A good example is their confusion when Gıli promises to avenge an attack on Tina, his girlfriend, who is a prostitute living in Kolera: "Gıli promised revenge in the most comprehensible way according to the customs of Kolera. Somebody explained this to the peasants and the softa!" (105). "*Softa*" literally means "someone associated with the religious activities of a Turkish mosque; especially: a beginner in theological studies" (Merriam-Webster Dictionary Online). In Kolerite slang *softa* is a derogatory term describing a member of a group who, like the peasants, are denied Kolerite identity: the Islamist bigots. The experience in the wedding is a perfect illustration of the peasants' and the *softas'* isolation in Kolera. The following passage is another vivid example of the peasants' isolation; and in this instance, the Kolerites' effort to involve them in the revelry is also worthy of note:

When the bride and the groom passed on to the "have a long-lasting marriage" stage, Kolera's talented musicians started to make their original instruments weep. After darbuka player Fish Ayhan said "bro here live peasants too; let's play something that will sound nice to them as well. Gabies do not get Romani style. For instance, we can play 'don't go my crane, don't go' in our way". He made his goblet drum speak with his magical fingers and by distorting the track started to play in the language both sides would understand. (102)

p. 137–138 Here the Kolerites approach the peasants in a friendly, if a little patronising, manner. However, if a peasant does not know her/his place, then this might be recalled to her/him in an unpleasant manner, as in the case when Tina is walking back home from the wedding where she was attacked by her former pimp, in the arms of two Kolerite women: "One

[11] Assyrians are Christian people also known as Syrians, Syriacs, Chaldeans or Arameans.

[12] Emphasis added.

[13] *Âlemci*, a word used frequently in the novel, is derived from *âlem*, based on this meaning of the word. However, as the quote from Özer implies, the novel tends to infuse the three meanings of *âlem*. Therefore, the word *âlemci*, although translated as reveller here, in fact has a much richer connotation than that.

of the peasant women who feels she has rather matured on the streets shouted out [in a rural accent] ‘What time is it?’ When the shrewdest of the babes, without looking at her watch, replied in mesmerizing foxiness ‘mallet past six’, the peasant woman blushed a deep red and went inside” (105). “What time is it?” in a rural accent demonstrates that this woman has a long way to go to become a Kolerite despite her illusion of having done so. “To have matured on the streets” is a perfect way of describing the process of becoming a Kolerite, and as the passage implies, it is a challenging one.

Another striking example of Kolerites’ perceptions of the peasants is present in Acem Baba’s (Father Acem) poem. Inspired by Gıli’s transformation, he writes a poem about being a *bitirim*:[14] p. 138

Our youngster is recognized from afar

We are carrying a concealed piece under our arm

Whatever you say our peasant friend

Our breaths are counted from pre-eternity!

Why should our lives be wasted? (116)

Acem Baba is a poet who feels himself close to *bitirims* in terms of his outlook on life. In his poem, he makes it clear that they do not care about the peasants’ disapproval of such a lifestyle.

The Kolerite identity is an urban identity that does not follow the prescriptions dictated by the elite establishment; it is an alternative urbanity which has its own conventions. The standard dialect prescribed by the establishment as a prerequisite of being an urbanite is replaced with Kolerite slang in Kolera. Just as migrants in Istanbul who cannot speak in the standard dialect are regarded as peasants, those who cannot speak Kolerite slang are regarded as peasants in Kolera.

Aktunç stresses that “the greatest slang treasure of a language is born and bred in the metropolis of that language” (2015, 383). In the novel, the emphasis on Kolerite slang as an urban language implies the urbanity of Kolerites, which is an alternative urbanity. Kolerites rescue the authority to decide who is an urbanite and who is not from the hands of the elite hegemony: being an urbanite is an issue of being able to adapt to the way of life in Kolera, and language is both a condition and a symbol of it. In the novel, Kaçan accents this with the narrative voice (i.e., with form), as well as by problematising the issue of slang as a major theme (i.e., with content). p. 138–139

As illustrated in the examples above, in the novel both peasant men and women are rude, ignorant and highly different from Kolerites. The differences between the Kolerite women and the peasant women are even more striking. p. 139

Women of Kolera

For the men in Kolera it is easier to adapt to urban culture than women, whose connection with the streets, with life outside the home, is minimal. The differences between Ali and İmine is a perfect manifestation of this gendered dimension of urbanisation in Kolera. In order to freely have sex with prostitutes living in Kolera, Ali keeps his wife at home by scaring her about the city. While Ali and his sons Gıli and Reco are Kolerites, İmine, although not categorised as a peasant, is frequently associated with rural culture. For instance, after Sado gets killed, seeing Gıli in despair, she sings for him a “funny nursery rhyme which she learned in the village” (32). The nursery rhyme, which serves as an inserted genre in the Bakhtinian sense, accentuates the influence of oral culture in Kolera and in the novel. On the following page, İmine uses incense sticks to rescue Reco from the evil eye. The detailed description of this somehow shamanistic ritual emphasises İmine’s belief in the supernatural, stemming from her rural culture. At another instance the narrator describes her scissors as “the big carpet scissors she brought from the village” (20), once again implying her rural background. p. 139

After Ali and İmine move to a rich neighbourhood, İmine starts wearing makeup and speaking like urban middle-class women. Kaçan does not illustrate İmine’s ‘urbanisation’ as a progression with successive stages. On the contrary, this change appears rather as a comic element, since at the stage when İmine adopts urban manners she also loses her sanity. In this sense, in the book Kaçan does not offer an argument regarding how migrant women living claustrophobic lives in Kolera can adopt an urban identity.

When it comes to the liberated women of Kolera who are not ‘captive’ at home, it is a completely different story. The excerpt below, introducing this as an important theme already on the second page of the novel, is worthy of discussion:

As the sun was wriggling through the clouds, the reveller women of Kolera started conversing like lions with car repairers, carpenters and turners in front of their houses, which looked like they would fall down with a shoulder p. 140

[14] Translating this slang word as a street rowdy or a hooligan would not do justice to it since it also includes the connotation that a *bitirim* adopts a certain code of honour.

charge. Meanwhile, they started preparing filters for the craftsmen, whose hands were shaking as they were welding, to smoke their joints more grandly. Some peasant women were watching from the window like prisoners, since they were frightened by the scary stories about the neighbourhood told by their husbands. (10)

p. 140–141 “Reveller women” means women who are involved in nightlife. These women might (have) work(ed) as prostitutes, B-girls, singers or dancers in bars; they might also have (had) connections with drug dealers.[15] This is not certain. What is certain is that they enjoy alcohol and marijuana. Later, we hear the phrase “respectable senior sister revellers” (94). The narrator does not refer to all reveller women as “respectable senior sister revellers”, this is a more prestigious category. Reveller women are strong and respected women who are practically equal to respected men. When a serial killer appears in the later pages of the novel, these reveller women and *bitirims* are the only ones who have the courage to be out on the streets (94). In the above passage, the narrator uses the praising simile of “like lions” to describe their way of having a conversation with men. The paragraph also draws attention to their supportive behaviour towards men, since they help them by preparing their joints. The final sentence of the quote elucidates the wide discrepancy between them and peasant women. A point should be clarified here: “peasant women” might include all women who are indoors, like İmine. In other words, women whose husbands are Kolerites may also belong to the peasant women category. The relationship of İmine and Ali is such a case. The narrator does not categorise İmine as a peasant, but puts emphasis on her rural background; while her husband Ali seems to be a Kolerite man. This is so, because for men in Kolera various ways of being out on the streets of the neighbourhood exist. As implied in the paragraph, they can be car repairers, carpenters or turners and so on. These men, however, tell their wives to stay indoors. Because unlike the case with men, multiple ways of being out on the streets of Kolera are not available for women. So these women, staying at home, remain as peasants while their husbands, out on the streets, transform into Kolerites, adopting an urban identity.

p. 141 Halfway through the novel, Puma Zehra, a former B-girl who is a highly respectable woman in Kolera, decides to dedicate herself to educating the “ignorant women of Kolera”: “she would make them break the cruel rules of the men’s world” (60). The narrator explains that these women’s husbands cannot react to Puma Zehra’s visits to their homes. “Ignorant women” seems to define women with a rural culture whose husbands are Kolerites. In other words, Kolerite men’s wives are not peasant women but they are ignorant women. After Puma Zehra educates these women they start acting like *bitirims* within a very short time and start hanging out in the underground coffeehouses: “they have become regular clientele of the coffeehouses to which even men would enter faint-heartedly after thinking more than twice” (60), and become perfect gamblers. Late at night they walk on their own in the streets, ridicule the rough guys who attempt to disturb them. They refuse to have sex with their husbands if they do not fancy it. Such a transformation of women solely as an outcome of Puma Zehra’s guidance sounds like an element of humour based on exaggeration. Thus, similar to İmine’s story, once again, Kolera’s isolated women’s transformation appears as a superficially addressed comic element.

To sum up, Kolera has a considerable number of women who are strong and respected, and not a step behind the men. These are not mundane housewives; they have a unique lifestyle. However, when it comes to the migrant women who are isolated in their homes and spend their lives as housewives, connecting with the neighbourhood they live in, and therefore with the city, is almost impossible. Living in an edgy place like Kolera makes life more difficult for them compared with the women who live in ordinary poor neighbourhoods where they can safely go out. Kaçan accentuates the condition of Kolera’s women isolated indoors, but does not elaborate on their possibilities of adapting to an urban life. He does not offer the Kolerite identity to them and puts them away as ignorant women without properly problematising their situation.

Cosmopolitan Kolera

A. Ömer Türkeş describes Kolera as "a neighbourhood at the heart of Istanbul, yet very far away from it" (1999, 118). In line with Türkeş, Yıldız Ecevit views Kolerites as "people who, despite living in a metropolis of culture, cannot establish a connection with that culture" (1991, 13). Although she praises the novel, Ecevit cannot avoid reproducing an elitist and prejudiced discourse, which is also present in Türkeş's remark. To begin with, what is the culture of Istanbul? It is not clear what Ecevit means by "a metropolis of culture". If she means elite schools, exclusive social circles, then, true, the people of Kolera cannot connect with that culture. Or, if she means being a part of the arts in the city such as opera, theatre or art exhibitions, in that case it is also true. However, connecting with culture is not such a simple and definite issue. In terms of Raymond Williams's definition of culture as "a whole way of life" (2001, 11), for instance, Kolerites are closely connected with the culture of the metropolis in which they live, maybe more than many of those who go to the city's prestigious schools and follow the arts, as discussed below.[16] p. 141–142

In Kolera people from various religious and ethnic backgrounds live together. As mentioned above, Kolerite slang includes words from different languages used in the neighbourhood. Michael Hess explains that Romani people are called "*şopar*" in the novel, which is the Romani word for "boy" (1998, 57). He adds that "besides the Roma there are Romani speaking Greeks (Rum), Syrians (Süryani), Armenians (Ermeni) and Jews (Yahudi). In contrast to the Romany, they are identified explicitly by their ethnic names. While Jews occur once and in passing, the three other groups mentioned play an important role throughout the whole book" (58). p. 142

At the beginning of the novel, a conflict between the members of the Greek minority and the *softas* of Kolera takes place. Sitting on a chair in front of the shop, Gıli witnesses the *softas*' attack on the Greek community going to their church. The description of the event emphasises the narrator's sympathy for the Greeks and his hatred for the *softas*. "The rich and the softa crew who intervened in anything happening in Kolera didn't feel good until they were hurting the Greeks, who were going to their church in their spotless outfit unhindered" (15).

Herkül Millas draws attention to the realism in the work regarding minorities and praises the author Metin Kaçan by comparing him to Sait Faik, the pre-eminent short-story writer of Turkish literature, famous for the unforgettable non-Muslim characters in his works: "He, like Sait Faik, perceives Greeks accurately. And accepts them: Tina, carpenter Mimi, worldly Eleni" (email comm., 21 September 2016). In the novel, there is particular emphasis on the fact that minorities and migrants from Anatolia live together in Kolera. This emphasis contests the nostalgic discourse which (almost) suggests it was the rural migrants who pushed the minorities out of Istanbul. A memory from Gıli's childhood is a good illustration of the cosmopolitan heritage which is a fundamental aspect of life in Kolera: "Salih, in his infancy, when he was slowly mastering walking, climbed up the bell tower, and hanging his bare feet down the tower gazed into space" (16). Kolera is a place where the cosmopolitanism of Istanbul is still alive. p. 142–143

By making minorities visible, Kaçan emphasises that Kolerites have a culture of their own which is an amalgamation of all the cultures of the neighbourhood, and this is an urban culture. The opposition between Kolerites on the one hand, and the peasants and the *softas* on the other is one of the central issues of the novel as Kolerites include all the inhabitants of the neighbourhood except the peasants and the *softas*.[17] With endless references to the concept of Kolerites, Kaçan lays emphasis on neighbourhood identity and cosmopolitan solidarity. p. 143

Towards the end of the novel, there is a small-scale pogrom in the neighbourhood under the influence of a war that is not named.[18] In this event, the *softas* and the peasants attack the *covinos*[19] and push them out of Kolera. The passage depicting the event is worth quoting at length:

Shicers, who start in the first light of the morning to realise the trick plans they prepared the night before, staring dirtily at the faces of *covinos*, scattered seeds of torment. Tradesmen who were fraternal with *covinos* until yesterday turned into chameleons for the sake of goods and chattels.

Covinos, leaving Kolera with their small suitcases under protection of the bitirims, wore their shoes out on the dark roads of the future. When they looked, as they were going, at the neighbourhood to which they had given their lives, they saw clothes freed from their ropes, plaster fallen down from the building and fishes hung out to be dried flying in the air! p. 143–144

Those who went through the buildings and goods of *covino*s for mere chickenfeed threw their honour and fixer mentality up in the air. And peasants who are normally unable to string two words together, finding the injustice done p. 144

[15] "A woman employed by a bar, nightclub, etc., to act as a companion to male customers and induce them to buy drinks" (www.dictionary.com/browse/b-girl).

[16] "We use the word culture in [...] two senses: to mean a whole way of life –the common meanings; to mean the arts and learning –the special processes of discovery and creative effort. Some writers reserve the word for one or other of these senses; I insist on both, and on the significance of their conjunction" (Williams 2001, 11).

[17] As Hess observes, in addition to the peasants and the *softas*, "the 'coppers' [zarbolar]" are also "continually denominated with derogatory denominations" (1998, 59). There are no policemen living in the neighbourhood, at least none that the reader knows of.

[18] Sultan B. Arslan argues that this undefined war might be an allusion to the 1980 military coup (2009, 122).

[19] *Covino* comes from the Italian word *giovane* meaning young. In slang it means a Christian (Aktunç 2015, 75).

to the *covino*s right, approved of the softas of Kolera using words they had long saved: [in a rural accent] “What are you saying man, it is too late now! That’s just the way it is.” (142)

Kolera, with its non-Muslim residents, carries the identity of Istanbul before it lost its minorities. It is a melting pot of people from different religious and ethnic backgrounds: non-Muslims, the Romani people and migrants from various parts of Anatolia. At the beginning of the novel the narrator describes Ali, Gıli’s father, as “Yıkıkköprülü Berber Ali” (Ali the Barber from Yıkıkköprü) (10) and explains that “he could never be separated from this neighbourhood which he had seen during his military service; and then moved away from his fellow townspeople and settled in Kolera with his wife” (14). As mentioned earlier, migrants in Istanbul usually dwell in neighbourhoods where people from their hometown live. Under the spell of Kolera, Ali rejects the comfort zone of his hometown community in the city. Moving to Kolera is an important leap forward in his urbanisation. Inhabitants of the neighbourhood like Ali who are able to adapt to Kolera are all Kolerites. A Kolerite is an urbanite: one cannot be a Kolerite and a peasant, or a *softa*.

p. 144–145 Hess argues that “the identification of Kolera with the Dolapdere quarter is placed beyond any doubt by the mention made in the novel of the Polish poet Adam Mickiewicz” (1998, 56).[20] While Kolera seems like the fictional version of Dolapdere, it is inspired by several neighbourhoods adjacent to it as well. Kaçan clarifies this as follows: “the place I refer to as Kolera in the novel actually includes the neighbourhoods such as Tophane, Kasımpaşa, Dolapdere, Yenişehir, Kurtuluş, Balat and Fatih” (Kaçan 1991, 14). The author himself, a man from Dolapdere, created Kolera as a reflection of these neighbourhoods’ cosmopolitan character. Doing that, he rescues the cosmopolitan image of the city from the old Istanbul nostalgia of elitists, and demonstrates that the cosmopolitan fabric can be present in an area looked down on as a poor neighbourhood, or even stigmatised as deteriorated.

p. 145 Kolera is much more than a place where people simply dwell. This can best be perceived through Henri Lefebvre’s concept “to inhabit”, which he explains as “to take part in a social life, a community, village or city. Urban life had, amongst other qualities, this attribute. It gave the right to inhabit, it allowed townsmen-citizens to inhabit” (1996, 76). Lefebvre explains that the city, “with its streets and squares, edifices and monuments”, should primarily be used for “*la Fête* (a celebration which consumes unproductively, without other advantage but pleasure and prestige and enormous riches in money and objects)” (66). Kaçan poignantly illustrates this pleasure as felt by Gıli who lives in one of the poor neighbourhoods regarded by the elite as disconnected from the city. His obsession with historical buildings is a perfect example: “He was a building freak. Daydreaming while gazing at buildings with oriel windows and ornaments and inlaid iron doors of stone buildings was his occupation” (35).

The narrator’s anger and disappointment in the following statement is similarly related to the appreciation of the city as *oeuvre*: “When the general elections approached, the ruling party, in order to win votes, phonily asphalted the streets and threw dust in the voters’ eyes. And good old cobblestones of Kolera Street were swallowed up in the horrible asphalt” (50). The resentment about the transformation of Kolera’s outdoor cinema into a car park is an indication of his attachment to the city as *oeuvre*: “softas collaborating with the chief who rules the underground world, and making a bargain with the foundations, rented the site occupied by the cinema for ninety-nine years, and used it for the rich pimps’ cars in those beautiful places” (63).[21] The charitable foundation in possession of this place uses it for profit, although it is intended for public good, infringing on the right to the city of the residents who once enjoyed this outdoor cinema as a locus of access to culture and entertainment.

p. 145–146 In the narrator’s discourse, the city space is divided into: poor neighbourhoods, one of which is Kolera; rich neighbourhoods; and the city. The narrator describes Kolera as a poor neighbourhood (*kenar mahalle*). This can be a derogatory term depending on the usage; in the novel, it is not; on the contrary, it has a positive connotation. In the following depiction, for instance, growing up in a poor neighbourhood implies a potential maturity through hardship: “Tina, she was the most hot-blooded of the poor neighbourhood girls who had grown up with three olives and a quarter loaf of bread” (124). A poor neighbourhood comprises a unique way of life; in the narrator’s description, some events are “typical poor neighbourhood incident[s]” (123). The narrator puts emphasis on Kolerites’ extensive knowledge of life and regards them as being wise, while he perceives the residents of the wealthy areas as superficial people. In this comparison, standard school education does not mean anything, it is the school of the streets that counts. The knowledge of the streets gained in the poor neighbourhood is priceless as it cannot be acquired anywhere else. Therefore, the narrator describes the customers bringing their cars to Hamit’s repair shop as “getting free knowledge about life on the periphery” (56). Kolerites perceive these outsiders negatively. The following description of the narrator is a good example: “one of those boors who have come to Kolera to buy drugs” (108).

p. 146 The message about rich neighbourhoods is simple: with adequate finances anyone can move and integrate into a rich neighbourhood. With the money Ali earns by dealing drugs he and İmine do that, and İmine instantly transforms into a middle-class woman. This detail is an indicator of the novel’s message not only on rich neighbourhoods but also on the entire upper-class way of life: education and background do not have any significance; anyone with sufficient

[20] The renowned Polish poet lived in Dolapdere at the very end of his life in 1855 and died of cholera there. The historic house where he lived and died is now a museum.

[21] The “foundations” here mean the Directory of Foundations, the legal authority which is in charge of estates belonging to charitable foundations.

finances can become a member of the upper class. However, in the poor neighbourhood one needs knowledge of the streets and courage. In other words, in *Roman(i)* Kaçan appreciates the cultural and social capital of Kolerites, which can only be gained on the streets of Kolera, while he understates the cultural and social capital of the upper classes, whom he seems to perceive as possessing nothing but money. Consequently, he tends to equate the elite, the nouveau riche and people with dirty money with each other in his novel.

In the book, places other than poor neighbourhoods and rich neighbourhoods are described as the city, implying the city centre. Kolerites are connected with the city centre, there is no dichotomy between Kolera and the city, as discussed below. The dichotomy is between Kolera the poor neighbourhood and the rich neighbourhoods, as depicted in the following examples. The first television in Kolera is the one which Fethi steals from a rich neighbourhood. The narrator describes it as the one Fethi "ripped off from one of the rich neighbourhoods" (58). After the serial murderer Taner is killed, the narrator says: "If Taner's dice throw was a double six everything would have been different. Maybe he would be living the life of a dummy in one of the rich neighbourhoods" (122). At another moment, he makes the following comment: "Gıli would stop by the rich neighbourhoods where Imine lives to claim lives" (135). p. 146–147

The reader notices the connection between Kolera and the city centre at the very beginning of the novel. In the first chapter, when the officials come to Kolera to catch unregistered workers, the bosses tell their apprentices to disappear for the day, so Orhan and his friends go to the movies: "Fox Orhan, together with his workfellows in oily clothes, with calloused hands, but only rudimentary knowledge of life, made his way to the cinemas in the heart of the city" (23). The area in the city centre with movie theatres is Beyoğlu; however, the narrator prefers to call it "the heart of the city" rather than by its name. Similarly, when the narrator explains that "softas, to celebrate winning the match, went to the arcade and sat down for drinks" (66), it is most likely that this arcade, whose name we do not learn, is Çiçek Pasajı.[22] p. 147

The novel is almost entirely set in Kolera, and when the characters go to Beyoğlu, the narrator refers to this place as the city, although in fact it is within walking distance of Kolera. The first time the reader witnesses Gıli outside of Kolera is in his early days as a *bitirim*, after he and his friends extort money in the chief's gambling den: "Gıli and his friends dispersed to the stomach of the city with the bonus cash they screwed the chief out of" (85). We read this adventure of Gıli and his friends in the third part of the book in a two-page long, highly amusing passage. They first go into a bar where some elderly gay men, who are interested in young boys, buy them beers. Gıli and his friends respond to these men's sexual advances by attacking them, and they break glasses and plates. The narrator sums up their adventures: "four cronies were talking about how they avoided getting fucked in the perfumed streets of the city" (86). After that they go to a brothel: "breathing in the smell of the perfume they entered the central knocking shop of the city" (86). Here Gıli has sex for the first time in his life, and steals the prostitute's fancy slippers (earlier in the novel his mother wants to purchase fancy slippers but cannot afford them). The narration continues as follows: "When Gıli arrived at the knocking shop's door which opens onto the city with his friends, he laughed like a dog until his guts ached" (87). The passage ends when they come back to Kolera: "the four cronies came down screamingly to Kolera after fooling around in the streets until dogs invaded the city" (87). Gıli throws the slippers onto his parents' balcony, and with a few tears in his eyes walks to the gambling den to spend the night. In this passage, although it is obvious that where Gıli and his friends go to find the brothel is a street in Karaköy, a street where all the brothels of the city are, once again the name of the place is undisclosed, the narrator simply refers to it as the city. p. 147–148

Another point worthy of notice in this context is Reco's (Gıli's brother) socialisation outside of Kolera. With depictions such as "his friends from outside the neighbourhood" or "his knowledge gained from the outside world" (55), the narrator emphasises the distinction between Kolera and the world beyond it. He explains the moment of Reco's departure from Kolera as follows: "wrapping his books and tapes up in his jacket he set off to meet the friends he made outside Kolera" (66). Here, his books and music tapes indicate his interests. Eventually, he returns to Kolera to open a cartoon library which appears almost as a topos: a person from a poor place eventually comes back home to contribute to his people via education, culture and the arts. Unfortunately, Kolera does not welcome Reco warmly when he returns: "leaving the newspaper he worked for, he ran to find the soul which he had left in the street. Reco ran to Kolera for nothing, he did not know that a soul which is left for a long time will never come back to the body" (138). As he walks in the streets of Kolera, drunken poets are reciting their poems loudly, the Romani people are saying funny words. However, Reco is no longer able to hear them. p. 148

Kolerites seem to regard their neighbourhood as a self-sufficient world where they do not need the knowledge or the culture of the rest of the city. Although Kolera is connected with the city centre, descriptions such as "youngsters who put on Fethi's clothes went up to the heart of the city and put on airs around the loaded dickheads" (48) or "in Kolera's asphalt road extending to the heart of the city" (127) imply Kolera's identity as a self-enclosed unity. In one example, the centre of the city and its rich neighbourhoods somewhat overlap when the narrator describes Ali and İmine's new house as "the house at the centre of the city" (134). However, there is a fine detail here that might be worthy of mention: in all instances where the narrator talks about the city, like the examples above, he calls p. 148–149

[22] Flower Arcade: a famous historic arcade with *meyhanes* and restaurants on the Istiklal Street in Beyoğlu.

it *şehir* (city) or *şehrin göbeği* (heart of the city): this is the city centre which the Kolerites have a close connection with, mainly Beyoğlu, the heart of the nightlife and culture and arts which is within walking distance of Kolera. In the instance where the city outside of Kolera means rich neighbourhoods, the narrator uses the word *kent* rather than *şehir* (127). Both words mean city; however, *şehir* is a more colloquial word than *kent*. Such a word choice might be in line with the argument above: *şehir* seems to be suggesting the city with its poor neighbourhoods as well, while *kent* seems to have the connotation of the urban space belonging to the rich and the elite.

p. 149 In brief, Kolera is a world unto itself, but it is an Istanbulite world that is closely connected with the city centre, particularly with Beyoğlu, the heart of the nightlife as well as culture and arts. Kolera's gates are open to those who want to go out but not for those who want to come in. Outsiders might come to Kolera to have their car fixed or to buy drugs, but they cannot be a member of the Kolera community.

Kaçan's success in illustrating Kolera's unique identity is crucial to his achievement of challenging the deteriorated neighbourhood discourse. This discourse renders run-down, poor neighbourhoods prone to harsh urban transformation projects serving the interests of capitalists. The issue of crime inherent in this discourse leads to the stigmatisation of neighbourhoods such as Dolapdere, Tarlabaşı, and Sulukule. Politicians and officials present these places as hubs of crime in order to create an excuse to launch urban transformation projects in them. With the support of the mainstream media, this leads to a widespread prejudice against these places. In *Roman(i)*, Kaçan contests this stigmatisation by realistically creating Kolera, based on Dolapdere and adjacent neighbourhoods, where different types of people, including criminals, live together.

The following passage depicting an ordinary morning in the neighbourhood is worth quoting at length in this respect:

Night, howls of the sea, whinnies of horses, screams of morphine addicts in crises slashing themselves with razors gradually became morning.

While the sun was rubbing its sleepy face towards roofs on the horizon, B-girls worn out in bars hit Kolera one after the other. The giant door of the shipyard opening stridently, like a crocodile's mouth, caught the workers who set off from the metal streets. Meagre, dark and dry children in the metal streets pushed up the shutters of the workshops they work at angrily as if they have all agreed to do so simultaneously. (22–23)

p. 149–150 Obviously this place is not a hub of crime. Although some outcasts such as morphine addicts or B-girls live here, the passage demonstrates that workers on the docks, shopkeepers, apprentices and so forth live and/or work here. The narrator presents them all as the people of Kolera without any prejudice against any of them, free from hierarchy. He illustrates the neighbourhood of Kolera as a place which enfolds people from different walks of life, none of them excluded. This way of presenting Kolera as the fictional depiction of heavily stigmatised Dolapdere and the adjacent neighbourhoods is a response to the discourse that stigmatises them in order to justify harsh urban transformation projects for full-scale gentrification of these neighbourhoods.

p. 150 *Roman(i)* was written twenty years before one such violent urban transformation project, which was launched in the Dolapdere-Tarlabaşı area in 2010, supported by the deteriorated neighbourhood discourse. With a wide array of characters enabling a vivid picture of the area in the guise of Kolera, the novel is a cry against the stigmatisation of so-called deteriorated neighbourhoods. Kolera is an arena of multiple colours where the good and the evil live side by side. Kaçan does not associate the evil with those involved in petty crime or drugs in his novel. The mafia, corrupt officials and the police who abuse their power for their own interests, and those who collaborate with them, are the embodiment of the evil. In Kolera and in the novel, crime is not the criterion of being good or evil, the honour code is.

As opposed to the discourse which stigmatises places like Kolera solely as hubs of crime, Kaçan underscores the heterogeneity of the Kolerite community. In fact, for many Kolerites, crime in the neighbourhood is as scary as it would be for inhabitants of the quiet parts of the city, as many passages depict "streets which the good people of Kolera would not dare to go into" (30); "Kolera's good people would not dare to walk in the daytime in the streets where these faceless men were wandering at night" (40). The story of barber Ali's life in the neighbourhood is also a telling example of that. As noted very early in the novel, Ali gets drawn to Kolera when he is a young boy on military service, and eventually moves there as a married man. His life there is not painless: "in order to defend himself from pillheads, psychos, freeloading rowdies, and at the same time to be able to get a toehold in Kolera, he was battling with his life in his hands" (14). When in front of his shop he sees the blood of men killed by the chief's men, Ali comes to the end of his tether: "these are not places where proper people would live" (34) he yells. However, only when his wife loses her sanity can he eventually make the final move to leave Kolera. It is a place that is difficult to live within yet more difficult to live without.

p. 151 The narrator lucidly describes Gıli's feelings about Kolera: "a neighbourhood like this was impossible to leave despite everything" (106). His brother Reco's departure from the neighbourhood is an event in the novel that implies Kolera's addictiveness and indispensability: "When Reco approached the edge of Kolera his feelings were mixed. Separating from the people of the neighbourhood who made laughing and living impassionedly a part of their life, touched him badly" (66).

The narrator constantly accents the unique identity of Kolera and its people. The first time he tells about a night in the neighbourhood, gamblers arrive at Orso's coffeehouse, which has a secret top floor for gambling; the police chase prostitutes while marijuana smokers dance and have fun. Thieves make cats jump onto carpets to steal them, Ali catches them under his balcony and the narrator comments: "for those living in the neighbourhood such incidents were nothing but midnight fun" (20). As the following excerpts demonstrate, the use of auditory and olfactory imagery, a central feature of the novel, has an important function in Kolera's depiction of this characterful and edgy neighbourhood: "Kolera's children who have grown up in the shade of broken syringes" (15); "Kolera's streets with the sounds of knives, dice and seductive screams" (55); "the smell of paint thinner, burned tyres, paint that is always in Kolera" (43); "Kolera's streets with the sound of the darbuka" (71); "Kolera's tough night and day life" (98); "bell chimes from the church filled the air mixing with a soft odour of marihuana and the sound of the azan" (13); "the regular hammer beats of the smiths, junk dealers and 'emperors' dispersed into the air like the sound of a good quality darbuka" (23).

As mentioned in Chapter 2, Richard Sennett explains that Dionysiac rites "could be practiced best among strangers: the drinking, dancing, and fucking is more intense if no one knows who you are or where you come from" (1992, 238). In Kolera, however, Dionysiac rites are carried out even though the people know each other very well. Kolera is a unique version of Sennett's Dionysiac city. At the same time, it is yet another poor neighbourhood where people from all walks of life live together and try to survive on their labour. As Herkül Millas observes: "one would think it is a cruel place, but it is not; if need be, almost everybody 'nobly' embraces the one who needs help" (email comm., 21 September 2016). In short, Kolera carries much more in its bosom than the pejorative concept of deteriorated neighbourhood suggests. The novel, countering stigmatisation by emphasising this fact, is a loud cry for the right of the poor to inhabit their neighbourhoods in the city centre.

Conclusion

At one point in the book, the narrator tells us that "neither in Kolera, nor in other peripheries of the world was there someone who would dare to say a word to Puma Zehra" (60). "Other peripheries of the world", a poetic phrase of the author, is laden with meanings: a poor neighbourhood appears in the novel as a way of being, a world unto itself. At another moment, the narrator describes Fethi as "the only person in Kolera with healthy and shiny teeth" (34), poignantly implying Kolerites' poverty. The novel has numerous examples of such articulations depicting the lives of people in the poor neighbourhood of Kolera. Such lives have been depicted in modern Turkish novel by authors such as Orhan Kemal. What makes *Roman(i)* unique is the way the narrator presents himself as one of the inhabitants of the poor neighbourhood by narrating in Kolerite slang.

p. 152

As discussed above, the work boasts such a vivid and colourful variety of characters that it could only be written by an insider. In his novel, Kaçan positions all the characters as indispensable parts of the life in Kolera. In his last interview, he makes the following comment: "As a person who grew up in Dolapdere, I have never ever judged or humiliated either homosexuals, or murderers, or religious bigots, or prostitutes. For me they all had a story to tell. They were all people who set off with beautiful stories at the beginning. Accepting them as they are, not judging them were among those things living in Dolapdere has taught me. Most of these people, in time, became my friends" (Kaçan 2012, 11). "Having not looked down on any of them" is an important description here, underscoring what Kaçan has achieved in his work. As discussed above, throughout his novel Kaçan underlines the contrast between migrants who have adapted to an urban way of life and those who have not. He has "not looked down on any of them, judged any of them", that is true. However, the opposition in the novel, between Kolerites on the one hand, and the peasants and the softas on the other, could sound like a means of judgement, had it appeared within another context. It does not appear as a judgement in *Roman(i)* because Kaçan posits the route to becoming an urbanite as a road open to everybody: one does not need to have parents who were born in the city to be an urbanite, neither a good school education nor a petit bourgeois social circle: one has to appreciate the diversity in the city to be an urbanite; this is the message Kaçan conveys between the lines.

Kaçan depicts a poor neighbourhood of Istanbul as a place where differences meet without the feeling of nostalgia for old Istanbul, in a manner opposed to an elitist attitude. In this respect, the following words of the author from the same interview are worth quoting at length:

p. 153

The people, events, streets I tell about, I would like to tell about, all of them have Istanbul in the lead role. Istanbul is a stage where my characters exhibit their talents. A grand stage that loves, hates, opens its bosom and at the same time excludes. Dolapdere, where I spent my childhood, was in a way a microcosm of Istanbul for me. Murderers, thieves, migrant families, Armenians, Greeks all of them were there as large as life, in a way impossible to deny; they were accepted and at the same time excluded, otherised. (Kaçan 2012, 11)

Unfortunately, this Dolapdere will be just a memory in the very near future. It is fading out of sight with the urban transformation project that is gentrifying the area with an incredible intensity and speed. At the end of *Roman(i)*

no member of Ali's family is in Kolera: he has left the place, his wife lives on her own as a mad woman in a rich neighbourhood, Reco has long departed from Kolera, and Gıli has committed suicide. The beautiful cobbled streets of Kolera are covered with asphalt, and the outdoor cinema has been transformed into a car park. The grim ending of the book seems to foreshadow the ruthless urban transformation that is now destroying the city, particularly neighbourhoods like Dolapdere. The author's suicide in 2013, following the footsteps of his idiosyncratic protagonist, makes this painful picture darker.

As stressed throughout the analysis, in *Roman(i)* Kaçan surpasses the material needs aspect of the right to the city, and addresses this concept in terms of *oeuvre* and the claim to the city centre where one can inhabit and appreciate this *oeuvre*. With all its messages, with its unique narrative voice and wise foreshadowing, *Roman(i)* will always have a special place in modern Turkish literature as a key novel about Istanbul.

Berji Kristin: Tales from the Garbage Hills and Heavy Roman(I): A Comparative Analysis

p. 153–154 In terms of form, the two books are completely different from each other. *Hills* is a highly experimental novel with an episodic structure, while *Roman(i)* has a simple and linear structure. However, they are similar in terms of narrative voice. In *Hills*, the narrator uses words from folk speech, and in *Roman(i)* he uses Kolerite slang. The resulting effect is the sound of an insider, someone from the community they describe. Thus the insider feeling is not only in the content but also in the form of the novels.

p. 154 In *Hills*, the Hill folk, by some extraordinary alchemy, turn concepts of urban culture into a language of their own in their magical universe. Urban elements enter Flower Hill in a distorted form, as if in a phantasmagoria. This fictional place is a semi-rural and semi-urban amorphous setting, semi-realistic and semi-surrealistic. At the centre of this setting is the oral tradition of rural people. In *Roman(i)*, however, slang, which is an urban phenomenon, is the essence of the novel. At certain moments, through the protagonist's mother's beliefs and traditions, references to rural oral culture emerge, but they do not leave their trace in the book. The face of *Roman(i)* is turned to urban culture, while *Hills* is mainly about rural culture's transformation in the city.

The community in Flower Hill are all first-generation migrants, while in Kolera, many of the characters, including the protagonist Gıli, were born in Istanbul as children of migrants. Additionally, while in Flower Hill the Hill folk are migrants who have very recently arrived in the city, the first-generation migrants who live in Kolera, like Gıli's father Ali, have been in Istanbul for a long while. In addition to this, while Flower Hill is a closed circuit isolated from the rest of the city, Kolera is at the centre of the city. This difference has a profound effect on the characters' distinct processes of urbanisation in the two novels.

In *Hills*, Tekin portrays the Hill folk in utter perplexity, completely unfamiliar with the life going on around them as if they have arrived from another planet. They try to make sense of a union, a strike, the way men and women socialise on the picket line, protests and so forth. In contrast with that, Kolerites (i.e., the people of Kolera excluding the peasants, the *softas* and the housewives living indoors) feel at ease in the city.

p. 154–155 Since Tekin does not focus on a specific character in her novel, it is not possible to observe a character's dynamics as regards urban identity, while in *Roman(i)* the urban identity of being a Kolerite is central to Gıli's and Reco's characterisation. Being a Kolerite is being urban, yet the way Kaçan presents this through Gıli's way of life is somewhat nihilistic, distinct from the urban identity expected by the progressivists. Gıli commits suicide in the end, and his father starts drug dealing to finance a new life in a wealthy neighbourhood. On the other hand, when it comes to Reco, Kaçan does not equate the Kolerite identity with nihilism and an edgy life style; in Reco's case, urbanity of the Kolerite is quite in line with the progressivist perspective. Reco, as a Kolerite, taking full advantage of living in the city centre, meets people from various parts of Istanbul with different lifestyles, and gets involved with culture and the arts, and leftist politics. However, as he does this, he leaves Kolera. After a while, he comes back to his neighbourhood, and opens a cartoon library there which presents Kolera's youngsters with an alternative way of being, a gateway for self-realisation instead of killing time in the gambling den. The novel's message on Reco is ambivalent. Does he keep his Kolerite identity and enlarge it in a way that includes his new lifestyle and interests? Or does he simply replace his Kolerite identity with another sort of urban identity? Once he moves out, he no longer belongs to Kolera in the way he used to in the past, this is clear. Still, this does not mean that Kolera punishes him because he left the place. Additionally, there are no remarks in the novel indicating that Reco feels himself superior to the Kolera community. At the end of the book, he is the only character in the family who does not have a tragic ending. We do not know the rest of his story, it might well be a positive one, a fact that brings a spark of hope to the work.

p. 155–156 At this point it might be meaningful to make a few comparisons between the two novels as regards the politicised atmosphere of the late 1970s and class struggle. In *Roman(i)*, Kolerites who are labourers have high visibility. They are not workers in factories but apprentices under masters of various crafts. In *Hills*, the Hill folk are mostly unemployed at the beginning, picking over the garbage to survive; yet, after a while they start finding jobs at workshops and factories.

Neither Kolerites nor the Hill folk are class-conscious members of the proletariat. Both *Hills* and *Roman(i)* seem to be set during the highly politicised era of the 1970s, and the discourse of the radical left groups loaded with Marxist terminology appears as a comic element in both of them. While in *Hills* Tekin develops this theme as a criticism of the Left for not being able to find a mutual language with rural migrants, Kaçan does not dwell on this point in his novel: in *Roman(i)* it appears only once with a humorous effect, when teenagers of Kolera get completely lost as they are listening to a group of radicals' tirade about capitalist exploitation (Kaçan 1999, 62). However, in *Roman(i)* the leftist discourse does not confuse all Kolerites. As the political polarisation of the country arrives in the neighbourhood, some Kolerites, such as Gıli's father, develop sympathy for the Left. On the other hand, the Flower Hill folk have a much more problematic relationship with the Left, as discussed in detail in the analysis above. The ways these themes appear in the two novels are in line with their disparate messages in terms of migrants' urbanisation.

In *Roman(i)* we see strong women described as "respectable senior sister revellers" (Kaçan 1999, 94) whose presence in the neighbourhood accentuates the urban culture in Kolera. In *Hills* there are no such women, apart from one, Tirintaz Fidan. In fact, Fidan in *Hills* and Puma Zehra in *Roman(i)* are very similar to each other, as both of them at one point feel a responsibility to educate the women of their neighbourhood. However, at the end of their mission, the women they inspire face quite opposite destinies: the women of Flower Hill enlightened by Fidan's teaching face the hostility of their husbands when they manifest expectations such as intimacy, while the women of Kolera for whom Zehra becomes a guru start to be treated equally with men in certain respects. This is a small group of Kolerite women, but still, the way Kaçan develops this theme suggests an inherently urban progressive potential in gender roles in Kolera. p. 156

Murat Belge, as referred to above, stresses that Flower Hill is the protagonist of *Hills* (1994a, 224). Similarly, Yıldız Ecevit emphasises that in *Roman(i)* the neighbourhood of Kolera is "almost like an organic being which breathes" (2001, 215). However, while in *Hills* Flower Hill is *the protagonist*, in *Roman(i)* Kolera is *a major character*. In *Hills*, there is no hero, no person as protagonist, and this enforces Flower Hill's position as the protagonist of the novel; while in *Roman(i)*, despite Kolera's significance as a major character, Gıli is the protagonist. Somewhat in line with that, in *Hills* the reader follows Flower Hill from the day of the first shanties until the day it falls from grace; while in *Roman(i)* Kolera is illustrated as a mature neighbourhood.

It can be useful to remember that both Flower Hill and Kolera are fictional settings inspired by actually existing neighbourhoods. However, while in *Roman(i)* the inspiration of Dolapdere and adjacent neighbourhoods in the creation of the fictional Kolera is direct and explicit, this is not the case with Flower Hill in *Hills*. Although both Flower Hill and Kolera are neighbourhoods where migrants and the poor live, they have considerable differences from each other. Flower Hill is a shanty town away from the city centre, while Kolera is a poor neighbourhood in the centre of the city. The lifestyles experienced in the two places are almost entirely different from each other. In Flower Hill, the Hill folk are isolated from the city centre and its urban atmosphere, while Kolerites have a very close connection with Beyoğlu, the heart of culture and the arts, as well as the nightlife of the city. The cosmopolitan heritage is a central aspect of the life in Kolera where people from various religions and backgrounds live side by side. Put simply, a considerable number of Kolerites have adopted urban identities, with their lifestyles and perceptions, unlike the Hill folk who have yet to start their process of urbanisation. These central differences constitute the basis for the dissimilar elaboration of the concept of the right to the city in the two novels as discussed below. p. 156–157

In both works, there is a fight for place. In *Hills*, the right to housing is at the centre of this fight: Hill folk battle against the forces of the state (i.e., demolishers) to be able to stay in their shanties. In *Roman(i)* there is a fight for place, too. This one is the fight of the good people of Kolera against the mafia who try to rule the neighbourhood. In the former, Hill folk are deprived of the minimum physical conditions to be able to live in the city. In the latter, Kolerites had long before reached these minimum standards, some of them poor, some of them with moderate means, but they all have a place to live. Their existence in the city is not limited to being able to survive there, it is more than that. Through Gıli's life and inner world, Kaçan illustrates a way of being in Kolera which is close to what Lefebvre describes as "to inhabit", that is "to take part in social life" (1996, 76). Gıli perceives his neighbourhood and by extension the whole of Istanbul as an *oeuvre*, as something created by all its inhabitants. His admiration of old buildings is a perfect manifestation of this perception, as discussed above. In *Hills*, however, the city is very far from being a place inhabited by the Hill folk in this sense, they simply try to stay alive in it; a deeper connection with the city is not yet on the horizon. p. 157

The absence of a human protagonist in *Hills*, such as Gıli in *Roman(i)*, reinforces this message of the novel: the city is not a place where migrants can develop their identities in the way the anonymity of the urban context requires. They live as a community, as in the rural context, they are not in search of individualisation. In *Hills*, the community soul is akin to the rural context. There is community in *Roman(i)* too; however, the cosmopolitan solidarity of this community is compatible with individuality. When Gıli, on the way to individualisation decides to become a *bitirim*, he simply moves to the gambling den in the neighbourhood. Kolera is the right environment in the search for individuality. When Gıli's father Ali left the community neighbourhood to live in Kolera, this was also a step towards individualisation.

p. 158 The two novels have considerable differences as regards their ways of addressing the otherised groups. In *Roman(i)* the Romani people create the soundscape of Kolera. They are primarily the musicians of the neighbourhood, yet they are not a homogeneous category; there are also thieves among them, as we see in an early passage where two Romani men steal carpets from balconies. Their portrayal as a heterogeneous category, some as petty criminals others as musicians enriching the atmosphere of their neighbourhood, is a realistic perspective that negates the stigmatising discourse against the Romani people. Being simply realistic about these people sounds sympathetic because the de facto perception of them is negative, not only in Turkey but globally. Such discriminatory discourse appears in *Hills* when the former Çiçektepe becomes a centre of drugs and prostitution after the Romani people start ruling the place.

When it comes to minorities, with *Roman(i)'*s characters, story and narrative voice Kaçan praises, without nostalgia, the non-Muslim inhabitants of Istanbul as a central aspect of the cosmopolitan fabric of the city, whereas in *Hills*, minorities are presented with only one character: Mr Izak, who is most probably Jewish and is portrayed as a greedy factory owner. There is no reference to Alevis in *Roman(i)*, while in *Hills*, as discussed above, their portrayal is slightly on the discriminatory side. The two works are also quite dissimilar regarding the way they address drugs and prostitution. While in *Hills*, Tekin portrays those involved in such 'activities' solely as symbols of degeneration, in *Roman(i)*, Kaçan refrains from depicting them as a homogeneous category, and presents both negative and positive characters involved with drugs and prostitution.

The differences in the approaches of the two novels to the possibilities of urbanity are in line with the way they address the concept of the right to the city. In *Hills*, migrants who are trying to figure out the urban context are fighting for the material necessities in terms of the right to the city, whereas in *Roman(i)*, the right to the city means the right to inhabit the city, to experience the city as *oeuvre*. In short, while the two works are similar in their use of an authentic language by the narrator, therefore abolishing the superiority of an urban narrator over migrant characters, they convey distinct messages about the struggle for the right to the city and the process of adopting an urban identity.

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p. 119

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CHAPTER 7 Istanbul's Threshold: Alienation and the Experience of the Periphery

On the Periphery (2003) by Ayhan Geçgin and *It Takes All Kinds* (2008) by Hatice Meryem are two novels considerably different from each other: *Periphery* is a sober and rather grim novel; *Kinds* is a highly humorous and light-hearted one. However, both have the concept of the periphery at their centre, as a theme and as a setting. Therefore, issues of alienation and isolation are central to both works. This similarity, despite their differences in terms of plot as well as style and other formal characteristics, serves as an inspiring ground of comparison as the two books take the life of first and/or second-generation migrants living in former shanty towns of Istanbul as their subject matter. p. 163

On the Periphery: Existence in the Grim City

In Ayhan Geçgin's debut novel *Kenarda* (*On the Periphery*), published in 2003, the protagonist's memories as well as his family's and extended family's stories of migration to Istanbul and their struggle in this city are told through a grim atmosphere. Its title implies poor neighbourhoods (*kenar mahalle*) as well as the periphery (*kenar*) as the edge or outskirts of the city. The title also indicates being on the periphery of life existentially. In his novel, Geçgin addresses the right to the city both in terms of material necessities and the need for opportunities for migrants' social and cultural development in the urban setting. He treats the themes of alienation and isolation in connection with the lack of such opportunities, reinforcing them by grim imagery. p. 163–164

The novel, which lacks an explicit plot, is set in the late 1990s, yet earlier decades also appear through flashbacks. The first pages include the depictions of the train station on the Sirkeci–Halkalı railway line, which the protagonist uses. Inaugurated in 1955, this line was also called the Istanbul commuter railway.[1] The train stopped at the neighbourhoods of Cankurtaran, Kumkapı and Yenikapı on the Sarayburnu shore of the city, continuing to Kocamustafapaşa and Yedikule, which included the historic city walls, then at Kazlıçeşme, Zeytinburnu, Yenimahalle and Bakırköy, before continuing to Halkalı, stopping at seven more stations before terminating there. Throughout the book, the railway line's stations in the Kazlıçeşme–Bakırköy area appear at various instances, depicted in a depressing timbre, as is the case in the first instance: "the train was running forward and backward by the coast from Halkalı to Sirkeci connecting numerous, almost identical quarters from the morning until the night. As the years passed by [...] the city was expanding, poverty was leaving here and intensifying there, shanties were [...] leaving their places to buildings with a few or many storeys" (Geçgin 2003, 12). The narrator adds: "misery was running [...] from one neighbourhood to the other" (12). p. 164

Depictions of the neighbourhood where the protagonist lives as well as impressions about the city appear in this first chapter, introducing all the main themes, as well as formal characteristics of the work: long and complex sentences giving detailed descriptions of the setting and a grim atmosphere reinforced by visual and olfactory imagery. There are references to the protagonist's family members and relatives in this chapter which stress that they are rural migrants.

Geçgin does not disclose much information about the protagonist. Through Hortlak's (Ghost's) question we infer that he is male.[2] There is no information regarding his physical appearance, education or occupation. Passages about the members of his family and relatives, both on his mother's and father's side, as well as various other figures from related villages or neighbourhoods, appear throughout the book. This is the way characters enter the work, not as figures acting in a plot line but within separate stories that surface through memories. p. 164–165

In the novel, there is no information regarding the location of the village where the protagonist's parents come from. This village is near the town of Dağcık, which is mentioned a couple of times (78, 119); however, this seems to be a fictitious place, since there is no record of such a town in the official town database of Turkish municipalities (Belediyeler). A couple of details imply that they come from a Kurdish and Alevi background. In the passage about how Grandfather and his close and distant family migrated to Istanbul, the narrator explains: "villages either got empty gradually or they have been evacuated" (35). In the modern history of Turkey, depopulation of villages is chiefly something that has happened to Kurdish villages due to the low-intensity war between the PKK and the Turkish army. Added to that is the Kurdish word "*bıra*" in Ghost's question. Here, it might be useful to note that Ayhan Geçgin is an author writing in Turkish although his mother tongue is Kurdish (Üstündağ 2019, i). p. 165

Geçgin reveals the Alevi identity in an expression Hasan, a relative of the protagonist's grandmother, uses in a conversation when the protagonist, his mother's brother Seyid, and Hasan go to visit Binali, the husband of the protagonist's aunt. Talking about an experience he has had, Hasan expresses his shock in the following words: "I was very surprised [...], I said 'ya Muhammed ya Ali', started walking back" (91). "Ya Muhammed ya Ali" is an expression Alevis use to express faith when in a state of shock or fear. The use of the expression implies that Hasan is an Alevi. Since Hasan is related to the protagonist's mother's family, if he is an Alevi then she would also be an

[1] It is now a part of the Istanbul Metro, therefore does not carry the identity of a railway any longer.
[2] "Bıra, you are studying, right?" (33). In Kurdish *bıra* means brother.

Alevi. As Alevis, especially rural ones, generally marry Alevis, this would mean that the protagonist's father and his family are also Alevis.

p. 165–166 The migration stories we hear throughout the book are remarkably similar. The first one of these is Grandfather's story, which appears in the final section of the first chapter. As he migrates to Istanbul, he leaves his two sons in the village in charge of his land. One of his older sisters would be responsible for taking care of his sons. In Istanbul, Grandfather works in factories in the daytime and as the watchman of an inn at night, where he has a tiny, dark room to stay in. His older son, the protagonist's father, gets married and migrates to Istanbul, without his wife, where he starts staying in his father's room. Grandfather's ill health forces him to leave his job at the factory and, after a while, he starts running the tea shop at the inn, combining his savings with his son's. When he rents a shanty with a garden, his son's pregnant wife joins them. In the meanwhile, Grandfather gets married. His younger son leaves the village and joins them. Grandfather's younger brother and his older nephew also move to Istanbul. The process is explained as follows: "not only they but their wives, sons, daughters, daughters-in-law, sons-in-law also came" (35). Their close and distant relatives also move to Istanbul in due course: "Some of them moved in here some of them in other quarters. In those quarters, they lived in specific neighbourhoods in houses close to each other. Some lived in other big cities, multiplied there. In villages, very old people stayed, and once they died nobody was left there. Towns and cities became bigger and overcrowded" (35). The mechanical style in this passage, summarising the rural–urban migration phenomenon in a couple of sentences is worthy of note.

p. 166 The third chapter of the first book presents the migration story of the protagonist's mother's family with a focus on İs, his mother's brother. After his father's death, İs leaves the deeds at the village to his three sisters and one brother, all of whom are younger than him, and comes to Istanbul, which is described as a simple and smooth process: "he walked off from the village and came here" (62). Eventually, all his siblings, together with their mother migrate to Istanbul and rent "a semi-complete house in an area at the periphery of the city" (62). His sisters start working in textile workshops and his brother in a factory.

Gülistan, one of the sisters of the protagonist's mother, is married to Binali, who is her uncle's son. When Gülistan is pregnant with their second daughter, Binali decides to follow his brother, who has migrated to Istanbul. So Binali, his wife and daughter come to the city and stay with Binali's family in their shanty for a while. During this time, Binali works in Grandfather's tea house and then finds a job in a leather workshop, and the family rent a shanty. Their four daughters start working in textile workshops and only one of them is allowed to study. Another story of migration belongs to Grandfather's younger brother, Uncle Hüseyin. He comes to Istanbul four or five years after Grandfather and starts living near Halkalı. He gets a job as a worker in the white goods factory there, where he works until his retirement. Their brother's son as well comes with his wife and is employed at the same factory thanks to Hüseyin providing a reference. He also retires there.

p. 167 The realism in these passages on the migration stories of the protagonist's family and relatives is noteworthy. With their compatibility with actualities, these stories addressing the central aspects of the migration phenomenon—such as the significance of kinship relations in migration, chain migration from the same home town, women's position in the migration process, and shanty housing—sound like case studies in a piece of sociological research on rural migration to Istanbul. The following excerpt about Grandfather's two relatives who work in his tea house is a good example. When these young men first arrive, they stay with a relative; they work and save money, then get married, and move to their own home. The narrator realistically stresses that the rest of their story depends on how much they can integrate into the urban economy: "some of them would spend all their lives as workers, some would sometimes be a worker sometimes unemployed, some go-getter might go into trade after working for a while, start a business, and if he lands on his feet he would also be an employer whose relatives would come and work for him" (31).

The insight into the dynamics of working-class migrant life in the city also attracts attention in these passages. In one example, the narrator describes migrants as people who "have worked all through their lives, adopted work as a virtue, built all their values on this" (60). The tone of the narrative voice is neutral in these explanations, it does not particularly bless hard work. Here, there is the implication that upward economic mobility was possible during the 1970s, when the number of steady jobs for migrants was higher than the following decades: both Hüseyin and his brother work in the same white goods factory all through their lives and retire from there. There is also a reference to the increase in shanty owners' living standards as a result of the shanty amnesty, allowing them to build apartments replacing their shanties.

Geçgin does not problematise the social and cultural development of migrants. He portrays the protagonist's family members as having a social network mainly comprising their relatives. There is not sufficient information about Binali's daughter who is a university student. Hüseyin's son, who becomes an engineer, turns out to be an anti-social figure who almost never leaves his room. The protagonist also studies, yet it is unclear at which level (34). Information on İs's social life is rather detailed, as discussed below.

p. 167–168 In *Periphery*, stories of men prevail over women. Some of the men, such as the protagonist's father, İs, and Dağiçili (the one from Dağiçi) have been involved with alcohol and nightlife. However, the majority of men who came to the

city have worked hard and saved money. Within the context of the migration stories of Gülistan and Binali, and Hüseyin and his family, the theme of girls' education briefly enters the novel. Binali sends his daughters to primary school simply because it is compulsory (82). He allows one of them to study further, while the other three girls work in textile workshops. Similarly, Hüseyin does not send his daughters to school. Geçgin implies in his novel that not much changes in women's lives upon migration. Textile workshops, which come to the fore as an important motif, seem like the counterpart of fields in the rural areas of the country: women living in villages work in the fields all day and in the evening they come home and do all the housework, childcare and cooking; in other words, in the city, workshops replace the fields. "Textile workshops in the basements where hundreds of young girls work" (18) is a simple yet powerful description of the working-class women's environment. The indifferent tone of the narrative voice in such descriptions attracts attention. In the novel, Geçgin does not hint at any sort of awareness of women's mentality as they become members of the working class, and makes no mention of migrant women who are not allowed to work by their husbands. Neither does he address the changes in perspectives of women due to migration.

The Other Istanbul

The primary setting of the novel is the neighbourhoods of İncirköy, where the protagonist and his family live, that of Taşlıbağ where members of his family used to work, and that of Bakırkule which is a more developed area and therefore the centre of social and cultural life for the adjacent neighbourhoods. Taşlıbağ is a representation of the Kazlıçeşme neighbourhood of Zeytinburnu district. It was a centre for the leather industry until the 1990s when the factories were moved to cities in the Istanbul region: Kocaeli and Çorlu. "The tomb" (129) refers to the Ali Baba Tomb and the "defunct fountain" with figures of a goose (130) refers to the Kazlıçeşme (The Fountain with a Goose) which gives the area its name. p. 168

İncirköy, "one of the neighbourhoods lined up like teeth along the coast at the periphery of a non-existent centre" (12), seems to be a representation of the residential parts of Kazlıçeşme. Fictional İncirköy is a typical former shanty town which undergoes a transformation as shanties are demolished and apartments are built on their site with shops on their ground floor. The narrator explains that "the neighbourhood took on an appearance that fits today's world, with a slowness that spread out through the years" and continues by describing other developments in the place which made it look "almost 'modern'" (12). p. 168–169

In the novel, Bakırkule seems to be the fictional counterpart of Bakırköy, as the train station and the boulevard imply.[3] Güzkonan, another shanty town on the periphery of the city, where some members of the protagonist's family live, might be inspired by one of the neighbourhoods of the Gaziosmanpaşa district, because of the following clues: İs and the protagonist go to Güzkonan using minibuses from Topkapı, and the place has a stream "where sewage waters flow with intolerable smells" (79). The narrator describes the houses in the area by saying they "have become the typical architecture of the neighbourhood with their incompleteness, half-finished appearance" (72). However, these clues about the factual counterpart of Güzkonan are not as strong as those for İncirköy, Taşlıbağ and Bakırkule. p. 169

In addition to the above-mentioned settings, there are two more fictitious areas of Istanbul in the book. One of these is Tozkapı, which represents a neighbourhood on the Sirkeci–Halkalı railway. In the case of Tozkapı, within the same sentence a factual neighbourhood and a fictitious one appear together: "in Kumkapı and Tozkapı, a tightly packed group of workers would be waiting for the train impatiently" (25). The other fictitious area in the work is a place called Düzgöl, described as near the factual area of Halkalı (118).

So, the question arises: why are some neighbourhoods disguised in the novel? As Geçgin includes them in the book but also disguises them, he may be implying the ambivalent position of the periphery neighbourhoods as being both in and out of the city. However, the areas of Kazlıçeşme, Bakırköy and Gaziosmanpaşa which appear under fictitious names in the book, have their own characteristics and are difficult to categorise together. Moreover, various neighbourhoods of the Bakırköy district belong to socioeconomically privileged inhabitants, and Bakırköy Square is an important social and cultural hub. In conclusion, there is not sufficient evidence in the book to answer the question.

With the Bosporus, the Golden Horn and numerous other sights, as well as its fascinating historical heritage, the general opinion is that Istanbul is a stunningly beautiful city. Geçgin refutes this claim. Doing this by spotlighting the unsightly areas of the city, which are abundant, would not be difficult. However, in his novel Geçgin does not confine himself to depicting the ugliness of former shanty towns or industrial areas on the outskirts; he finds bleakness in the city's most admired parts. For instance, as the protagonist sits in Karaköy and stares at Galata, a sight that is fascinating for almost everybody, what he sees is described as follows: "deadlock was expanding as far as the eye can see" (152–153). Similarly, the aura of historical heritage is entirely absent in the narration of his gaze at the Topkapı Palace whilst sitting on a bench (156). The magnificent Galata Tower is depicted as "rising with a wizened pride [...] with its darkness which kept appearing and disappearing" (160). At various moments, historical heritage and artefacts p. 169–170

[3] Literally, Bakırkule means copper tower, while Bakırköy means copper village.

enter the book as imagery illustrating the city as a ghost town: “a grand building in ruins and a five-hundred-year-old historic building was rendering this feeling of desolation even stronger” (20); a “defunct marble fountain with a dome which is not worth noticing despite its largeness” (192); “far away run-down fortifications, with their walls cracked, towers eroded or destroyed, would extend to the coast like a rusty saw” (67); “old structures of Galata with their plasters, ornaments fallen down” (98).

p. 170 It should also be added that in the descriptions of all these places the homeless, tramps, glue sniffers, children selling tissue paper or miserable people come to the fore as the dominant figures of the environment. Various kinds of beggars appear, especially in the city centre, and pathetic stray animals are also in the picture. In the novel, Geçgin depicts Istanbul as a city comprising an ugly and sombre periphery, and a chaotic and grim centre. These depictions imply the way the ‘beautiful’ city appears for the poor, the homeless and all those who are pushed out to the periphery of the city. John Freely, the co-author of the acclaimed *Strolling through Istanbul* describes this city as “the ugliest beautiful city of the world” (1999, 29). In *Periphery*, Geçgin constantly accentuates the ugliness of this beautiful city.

Life in Taşlıbağ

p. 170–171 Geçgin addresses life in the urban space in a multifaceted manner. The lack of municipal services and infrastructural problems enter the novel mainly through imagery, rather than as themes. There is an extensive use of visual and olfactory imagery in the novel for drawing attention to the condition of this place neglected by the municipality. The description of Taşlıbağ in this sentence: “he was walking past [...] muddy waters running through the gutters alongside the street, mice that were coming out from one hole and disappearing in another, the smell, the dense dust that was falling down like fog, greyness [...] and entering the inn” (49); or the reference to the smell of the sewage waters in Güzkonan (79) and the sewage rats in Taşlıbağ (130) are only a couple of examples. At one moment, a reference to the sewage appears directly after the depiction of the strolling area beside the shore (150). In Taşlıbağ, at the exit of the park, there is an underpass which is described as follows: “the underpass [...] smelled of faeces, as if the whole quarter, all of this city smelled the same way” (45). Here, it is possible to find a double meaning. This entire area smells this way and so does the entire city: because for the dwellers of this part of the city, the neighbourhood they live in means the whole city; or it might imply that the whole city smells this way, perhaps metaphorically.

p. 171 As explained above, Taşlıbağ is a representation of Kazlıçeşme. As Turgay Gökçen acknowledges, “the first shanty in Istanbul was spotted in Kazlıçeşme, Zeytinburnu in 1945” (2011, 196). By 1947, the area became the first shanty settlement in Istanbul (Akbulut 2011, 210). Throughout the novel, shanty housing appears as the norm for migrants of the time. To have a shanty of one’s own is depicted, realistically, as an objective for rural migrants such as Gülistan and Binali: “The whole house having worked for a long time this way, having saved up money for years, have achieved the thing they valued the most, have accomplished their goal just like others who have migrated to the city, they have become homeowners, bought a small house in one of the neighbourhoods in the upper part” (82). As Kemal Karpat emphasises, the shanty town was a “‘rural’ enclave in the city” (2009, 36). Living in one’s own house rather than a rented one would result in a stronger attachment to the shanty town, where a sense of cosmopolitan solidarity is present, and therefore to a stronger attachment to the city.

p. 171–172 In the novel, Geçgin has a positive approach to shanties as shelter, perceiving them to be in harmony with nature owing to their gardens. On the other hand, he accentuates the ugliness of the semi-built buildings and lack of infrastructure in former shanty towns where apartment buildings for profit have replaced the shanty houses. For the protagonist his neighbourhood is one such place, simply an eyesore. He does not feel any cosmopolitan solidarity, if there is any left after the transformation of shanty towns. He does not socialise with fellow inhabitants of the neighbourhood, which is certainly not an enclave for him. He is isolated in the neighbourhood, and he is isolated in the city. His individuality seems to be gained at the expense of isolation.

p. 172 As mentioned above, both the former and the current Taşlıbağ appear in the novel. The former Taşlıbağ as an industry area is described as “a vast neighbourhood comprising only male workers”; “a place very different from the houses, neighbourhoods they return to in the evening or the outside world where they go on some weekends to visit and have a stroll” (22). The life outside of the factory is the “outside world”. Minimum contact with the outside world under these working conditions means minimum contact with urban life. Individualisation of workers is a remote possibility implied in the following depiction of workshop workers waiting for the train in Kumkapı or Tozkapı: “they were identical with workers in the leather factories in Taşlıbağ years ago or with those workers who work in the factories which have now come together in Çorlu or Gebze, living in their ghettoes established around factories under the control of military areas. With the same faces, same postures they were multiplying as if one and the same” (25). The narrator describes the workers as “an indistinguishable mass consisting of bodies working and existing only to work” (25). There is no reference to class here, workers are not members of the proletariat with the potential to change the economic system. On the contrary, in an almost cynical manner the narrator compares them to robots; according to him the workers “existed as long as they worked, and to exist they had to work” (25). There

seems to be a correlation between this mechanical way of existence, a lack of class consciousness, and a disconnection from urban life: “they were working in the factory, taking the train and coming back home, sleeping, the next morning waking up and coming to work, completing the same cycle [...] a huge world other than theirs was neither meaningful, nor significant nor certain enough” (25). David Harvey explains how Haussman “deliberately engineered the removal of much of the working class and other unruly elements from the city centre [of Paris], where they constituted a threat to public order and political power” (2008, 33). Geçgin does not address this fact, he simply implies the disconnection of workers from the city centre but does not express an opinion on what would be different if the working class were at the city centre. Would “a huge world other than theirs” be “meaningful” or “significant” or “certain”? There is no answer to that in the book.

Karl Marx explains that “the more powerful becomes the alien world of objects which [the worker] creates over and against himself, the poorer he himself – his inner world – becomes, the less belongs to him as his own” (2009, 29). In the novel, workers’ definition of factories as a “semi-open prison” (32) is an impressive description of this process. A similar connotation can be found in the following explanation as well: “children who would start working as apprentices behind small machines [...] would then go behind looms after a couple of years and would stay there until the end of their lives” (29). p. 173

The harshness of the working conditions and workers’ acquiescence before it finds expression as the narrator explains that in the leather factories “nicknames such as Armless Hasan, Fingerless Veli, Cripple Süleyman were very common” (29). The depictions of the leather workshops and factories (26–29, 51) and textile workshops (76) stand out in the novel as vivid and impressive passages containing realistic pictures of proletarian life rendered in fine detail.

The deindustrialisation of Taşlıbağ is one of the central markers of the difference between the past and the present; and the demolition of the Kazlıçeşme factories enters the book in a poignant passage. Before looking at this passage, it might be useful to briefly remember the historical context.

Kazlıçeşme had become an industrial neighbourhood by the end of the 1940s, and in 1949 it was officially announced as a “heavy industry area” (Akbulut 2011, 207). From 1955 to 1973, 325 factories and workshops in the leather sector were established in this area (208). In line with a plan dated to 1982, by the end of the 1980s these factories started to be transferred to Tuzla, which brought an end to the 500-year-long history of the leather industry in the area (209). The final demolition of the remaining factories in the area was in 1993 (Kürkçüoğlu 2020).

In the related passage, the protagonist walks by the historical city walls until he arrives at the last remaining street of Taşlıbağ. There he sees the ruin of a building with only the outer walls remaining. He observes that the homeless now live in this building having put a plastic roof on top, brought a chair and a table, and made a stove from stones. The imagery of ruins is intensified as he continues his walk: “[he] was walking on the road, both sides of which were covered in debris, piles of stones and dust, with the howl in his ears ascending” (129). With a vast empty space in front of him he continues walking, trying to grasp the memory of the city erased by urban transformation: “with a desire rising from the rustling grass, he was trying to recall the former site of the inn, entrance gateway, narrow streets covered in leather dust between factories, the site of the shops, the tea house” (129). He remembers how the demolition was expected by the neighbourhood dwellers with curiosity: “The thing talked about for many long years [...] was over and done with at an unbelievable speed, the demolition was completed with machines in a couple of weeks. Nothing was left behind, except stones and sewer rats” (130). The vast empty space is a powerful motif in the passage, stressing the harsh severing of the history of the neighbourhood. The deindustrialisation of the area wipes away the working-class culture, while the demolition erases the memory of it. It should be noted that the space in Kazlıçeşme left after the demolition of the leather factories, which was intended to be utilised as a recreation area, has never been properly transformed for such a purpose by the municipality (Akbulut 2011, 209). p. 173–174

Idling in the City

In the book, the themes of personal isolation and being isolated on the periphery of the city get enmeshed as the periphery acts both as a setting and imagery. The protagonist is an idler. When he was younger he used to idle with his uncle İs: “they were hitting the road to idle like a spirit inside the city” (79). The protagonist learns idling from İs who is always comfortable outside: “İs was walking relaxed, straight, confident, as if the streets belonged to him, with his body leaning to the side with each step” (86). İs does not work, and those around him seem to accept İs the way he is. He knows the owners or waiters in the tea gardens or beer houses where they take their breaks. İs and the protagonist walk endlessly in the crowds until they are exhausted and stop in a park: “İs [...] felt at home in the park” (65). They idle in the streets in and around İncirköy where they live, on the coast, in tea gardens and beer houses there. They sometimes take the minibus to Güzkonan to visit their relatives, and sometimes go to Bakırkule. These memories of idling with İs dominate the childhood and adolescent memories of the protagonist. In the present time he idles solo. However, this idling is different from *flânerie*. p. 174

p. 174–175 Variants of *flânerie* outlined by Keith Tester were discussed in Chapter 2. The Baudelarian *flâneur* strolls through the city searching for objects "which will occupy his gaze and thus complete his otherwise incomplete identity; satisfy his otherwise dissatisfied existence; replace the sense of bereavement with a sense of life" (2006, 7). In the Sartrean variant of the *flâneur*, as depicted in *Nausea*, which Jean-Paul Sartre wrote in 1965, however, "[p]ublic spaces can be places of an immense existential fear" and the *flâneur* becomes "the victim rather than the prince of his own freedom" (10). When Tester analyses Robert Musil's *The Man Without Qualities*, written from 1930 to 1943, he observes that in this novel "devices of *flânerie*" are connected "to global problems of existence in cities" (10).

p. 175 Tester points out that Musil "brings the figure [*flâneur*] into the twentieth century" (11). He adds that Musil "generalizes the *flâneur* and turns him into a generic rather than a Parisian figure" (12). Yet, at the moment when Musil achieves that "the *flâneur* begins to disappear", because "the idle and considered strolling and observing which is the essence of *flânerie* has become doubtful in universal Vienna" (12–13). In the Vienna of the twentieth century, against *flânerie* lies "the problem of traffic", and the city is no longer that enigmatic place (13). Additionally, the "domination of rationality and of an order which is imposed on the city" makes *flânerie* "less and less likely" (13).

The protagonist of *Periphery* is an isolated figure, who seems to be experiencing what Seeman describes as alienation in the form of "isolation" (1959, 789). His inner world is characterised through this isolation and concomitant depressive feelings: "he was feeling a deep sadness, the reason for which he didn't know" (170). He feels disconnected from his family and relatives, from the working class whose members are portrayed mostly as hard-working people full of life (25, 32), and from the city as well: "he was feeling like someone in exile in an unfamiliar land" (144). Such a depiction might function both on a literal and a metaphorical level. Despite this feeling of exile, however, he takes refuge in his long strolls in the city. It is difficult to describe these long walks as *flânerie*: what Tester describes with reference to Musil as factors bringing *flânerie* to its end are present here in a much more intense way. Traffic, loss of the urban enigma and the hegemony of "rationality" and "order" that are against *flânerie* in Musil's Vienna of the twentieth century (Tester 2006, 13) are present, in extreme proportions, in Geçgin's Istanbul of the twenty-first century. Pointing out this fact throughout the novel, Geçgin links the motif of idling with the theme of access to recreational areas and activities as a right to the city.

p. 175–176 Parks and shores keep appearing in the book as a shelter from the grimness of the city and to a certain extent from existential fear (45, 96–97, 125, 144, 150). The protagonist and İs very often find themselves in the park in their neighbourhood. The touch of nature there means a lot to İs who calls it "the best thing in life" (65). The coastline close to İncirköy is also a significant setting in the novel: there are tea gardens and beer houses, and it is also possible to stroll (68). Similarly, the main square of Bakırkule is an important location for the pair as they are idling: "They were getting off as they come close to Bakırkule. They were walking past the square, those who crowd in the square, sitting on concrete benches in the sunshine, those seeking freshness in the shade, those who stand leaning on a column or a tree, those idling in the square, joining the afternoon crowd who are out for shopping or wandering aimlessly, and walking down the street where arcades, magazines, shops line up towards the seaside" (85). As is clear in the text, the urban space does not offer them activities or opportunities for socialisation, but simply offers spaces to wander around.

p. 176–177 The fifth chapter of the first book of the novel starts with a long passage describing the area around the old city walls, the small patches of green used as a picnic area (125–126). The narrator also adds that in the hills near this area, tramps and the homeless sleep at night. Small tracts of nature appearing within the city are oases for poor migrants living on the periphery. In the unwelcoming city centre, the public spaces of parks and the seaside are the only sites for those who cannot afford recreation activities. Gezi Park and Maçka Park have a prominent place in the setting of the final chapters, as the protagonist takes a long walk over two days from Karaköy to Eminönü. The description of Maçka Park in this part of the novel is a perfect manifestation of the function of parks in a metropolis where the opportunities for recreational activities are scarce for low-income inhabitants: "Usually people from back quarters, from poor neighbourhoods of Şişli, from further away were coming to the park, they were filling the park especially at weekends [...] those who can't go indoors to sit down, broke people who can't go to the cinema, poor people were hanging around here. Parks wherever they are belonged to them" (184). He then adds: "Young boys and girls from poor neighbourhoods came here for their dates, they met each other here. The homeless stayed here as long as the police did not spot them and send them away, or if they ignored them. The unemployed spent their daytime here" (184). This novel was written before the Gezi Park Protests of 2013.[4] It is striking to see in the lines quoted above a foreshadowing of that historical moment: the economic rent creation in the globalising city leads to the invasion of parks, the only space in the urban area that welcomes the poor. It should also be noted that various points of the shore in Zeytinburnu area, where İs and the protagonist idle in the novel, have been occupied by building companies in the last decade.

p. 177 As mentioned in the previous section, the narrator describes İncirköy as located "at the periphery of a non-existent

[4]The protests that started on 28 May 2013 in Istanbul against an urban development plan that would result in the demolition of the Gezi Park in Taksim. The protests soon took the shape of a revolt, spreading around the country, against the anti-democratic rule of the AKP government. For an analysis of the protests see Göle (2013).

centre”(12). This emphasis on the city without a centre is clear in the following extract as well:

Or on a public holiday, leaving their own turf, hundreds of teenagers were going to Taksim or another central part of the city to benefit from the blessings of urban life, in a deserted city centre encountering those similar to themselves, they were turning right back, going down from Yüksek Kaldırım and mixing with the maddening crowd of Eminönü. There was neither a place nor a thing to reach. There was no city centre. Maybe there was even no city. (12–13)

Inhabitants of the periphery in their visit to a central area of the city encounter those who are similar to them, but there is no interaction between them. They go to the city centre with the expectation of and desire for experiencing urban social life, described in the above excerpt as “to benefit from the blessings of urban life”. What are these “urban blessings”? What would teenagers from the periphery expect when they go to a place like Taksim? They would probably expect to socialise with city inhabitants of their age, for friendship and for flirtation. They would expect to spend a pleasant time strolling around, sitting in a cafe, to watch a sports match or maybe participate in one, to see a movie in a cinema, and for those who are interested in cultural activities, see a play or a concert. The extract underlines the impossibility of such an integration of the dwellers of the periphery with urban culture. Such integration is a right to the city. In an ideal urban setting, even teenagers who have a small amount of pocket money to spend on pleasure could afford most of the activities listed above, made available through urban amenities. Social recreation centres and similar areas would be available for the youth, where they could get involved in sports or culture and arts, or find space for hobbies in clubs. These would also serve as a venue to socialise with other teenagers. The extract above indicates that in the absence of such social/welfare organisations the city centre becomes a void, which might be the reason why the narrator describes the centre as “non-existing”. The absence of a city centre is almost equated with the absence of a city: there is no way of feeling the presence of the city if one cannot be a part of its social and cultural life. p. 177–178

The narrative voice in the passage on the position of poor inhabitants of the city living on the periphery might at first sound neutral and without any sympathy for them. But this is not the case. Rather than an outsider’s sympathy expressed in words of compassion, the resentment of an insider is visible in the narrative voice, manifest in word choices such as “leaving their own turf” or “turning right back”. p. 178

In the story’s current time, the protagonist is idling in the globalising Istanbul. The resulting multiculturalism appears almost as a phantasmagoria in the following passage on the central and touristic area of Karaköy: “he was diving into a river of sound, made up of those selling little ornaments on the cloth they spread out on the floor, little objects made of leather, birds’ nests (these were usually from the place called the Turki Republics), clocks, perfume, little statues, masks (and these were usually youngsters from Africa), those selling foreign cigarettes, hand-rolled tobacco from Van or Urfa, amid bellows, voices talking, screams, ships’ horns, ferry noises”(102). This is a city where migration is no longer limited to internal rural–urban migration; it receives external migration as well. The emphasis on this is clear in the following excerpt: “in the streets, Russian, Moldavian, or Romanian women, young boys working in lowlife nightclubs and bars, and staying in bed & breakfasts or rented rooms, prostitutes, idlers, Arabs, Blacks, those looking for any kind of a job, alcoholics, thieves, hoodlums, vendors, those who have migrated from every part of the country were walking around”(107). In the novel, multiculturalism appears to be an addition to the chaos inherent in the city. There is also a reference to gentrification in the passage as Geçgin depicts the protagonist in Galata, observing the square as tourists pass by:

Upwards stretched buildings whose plaster had fallen off, and reliefs had faded, that were rented room by room, used as shops, workshops or depots, where families with many children lived. Actors and actresses, painters, musicians, journalists, lovers of historical places, moderately rich ones, foreigners, who fool around in bars all night long were also renting, buying houses around here, thus the neighbourhood was like an animated Arabic picture where all motifs enmeshed in a disordered way. (160) p. 178–179

Although gentrification is addressed only in this passage, it is an important indicator of the transformation the city is going through in the 1990s. p. 179

In *Periphery*, the motif of idling is skilfully tied to the theme of the right to housing in the context of homelessness. In addition to idlers like İs, without a steady job but with a home, idlers without a place to live are also visible in the novel. They are either men who are able to find temporary places to stay, or those completely homeless living in the streets; they keep appearing unexpectedly in the depictions of the city at any moment, as in the following examples: “the homeless, outcasts, or lunatics who were themselves a sort of garbage”(11); “a winter in which a couple of the homeless had frozen to death [...] has passed”(146); “on the coast there was no-one except for a couple of early walkers and the homeless sleeping on the benches”(149). In the novel, the line between being an idler and a homeless person seems to be very thin, especially for those who have migrated to the city and lack a network support based on kinship relations: “the homeless were taking shelter in deserted inns, dilapidated rooms; the unemployed, fallen ones doing temporary jobs, those who are new to the city were staying in cheap, dingy hotels and rented rooms”(161). In the second book of the novel, the protagonist encounters an acquaintance from the past. This person, named Engin, stays “either in a flat, in a room or at a hotel depending on his financial situation”(164). The protagonist treats him

to lunch. As Engin talks about his plans to leave Istanbul, "a beggar woman covering her face with a scarf" (166) gets expelled from the door of the diner. Engin complains about the city, says that he cannot stay there any longer, and mentions an event of assault he experienced a couple of days before, as an example of how terrible a place it is. He adds: "I will go back to my hometown" (167). As he leaves, he asks for money to pay for the room in the hotel he is staying at. This passage, about three and a half pages long, appears as a way of bringing the focus closer to the story of one of the idlers in the novel who is on the verge of being completely homeless: a person who is rejected by the city, has no means to survive in it, so does not have any other option than going back to his hometown.

p. 179–181

Beggars, children selling tissue paper and glue sniffers also keep appearing in the picture of this city of urban poverty, unemployment, exclusion and homelessness. All these appear both in the first book, which mostly focuses on the past, and the second book which is set in the present time. At one point on his long walk, the protagonist stops at a tea garden at the bottom of the Galata tower, and the depiction of an ordinary afternoon there is noteworthy for bringing together all these issues as they intertwine with each other: "In the small space, a group of glue-sniffer children were playing a football match with a burst ball they had found. Most of them were swinging at the ball where they stood, like a sleep-walker hitting the ball that comes to their feet with their cross-eyes, every now and again sniffing inside the palms of their hands made into fists" (159). He adds: "street vendor children and beggars were chasing tourist groups. A bit further away, a couple of children were looking at the sky lying on benches; a couple of unemployed people were sleeping" (159–160). He continues his walk on İstiklal Street at evening time: "Children selling tissue paper, chewing gum or flowers and shoeshine boys were walking around; in front of shops or doors, those without arms, feet, the blind, cripples, oldtimers, those with swollen feet, those with irregular, flawed organs, those with half bodies, deaf mutes, the hungry, the ill, and children were begging" (162–163). In one instance, in Gezi Park the protagonist gives some change to glue sniffers; and then a man who asks him for money. In another similar moment, the setting is Maçka Park, where a glue-sniffer boy plays with a dog who is being walked by its upper-class owner. After a couple of minutes of allowing the boy to play with his dog, the man rudely tells him to go away. So the boy goes under the trees and continues watching the dogs at a distance. As the protagonist walks by him, the boy asks for a cigarette, he gives it to him and continues walking (186–187). In such instances, in the "metallic language" of the narrator, to borrow Hüseyin Kıran's description, depictions are purely objective and neutral.[5] They sound as if in a metropolis all these are ordinary instances. As Georg Simmel explains: "the metropolitan type [...] creates a protective organ for itself against the profound disruption with which the fluctuations and discontinuities of the external milieu threaten it. Instead of reacting emotionally, the metropolitan type reacts primarily in a rational manner" (2002, 12). However, the content of such passages implies that the nameless protagonist of *Periphery* is not that immune to what Simmel calls "the fluctuations and discontinuities of the external milieu". He has compassion for outcasts, while the majority of urban inhabitants do not even notice them. Owing to this compassion of the protagonist, such figures are prominent at many moments of the book.

p. 181

As discussed above, the title of the novel can be translated as "on the periphery". In the work, the periphery appears on various layers: on the first layer, there is the overall theme of the protagonist being on the periphery of existence. On another layer, there is a more direct and literal existence of periphery: the neighbourhoods which are on the periphery of the city. As Ameel, Finch and Salmela aptly observe, "when urban peripherality is considered, scholars should 'always assume a relative perspective', containing 'the awareness that a shift in point of view may turn a geography of domination of subordination on its head'" (2015, 8). As a matter of fact, even thirteen years after the publication of *Periphery*, Zeytinburnu's peripheral status has changed considerably: as the city keeps expanding, this area 'approaches' the centre day by day. On yet another layer, as illustrated in the examples above, those who are stuck on the periphery of the social, economic and cultural life of the urban setting enter the novel. The way Geçgin illustrates these people is compatible with Walter Benjamin's approach to outsiders in the city.

Geçgin presents us with a face of the city that belongs to idlers, outcasts, tramps and the homeless. Graeme Gilloch lucidly explains that Benjamin strives "to give voice to the 'periphera', the experience of those whom modern forms of order strive to render silent and invisible" and adds: "the sauntering *flâneur*, the self-conscious dandy, the loud-mouthed beggar, the suffering prostitute, the wretched rag-picker: marginal, disregarded figures inhabit Benjamin's pages on the city" (1996, 9). Gilloch describes Benjamin's objective as "empower[ing] the marginal and the oppressed" and "to this end, the cityscapes offer a phenomenology of the marginal figures of the metropolitan environment. They relate the experiences of the child, the prostitute, the beggar, the rag-picker and others" (15). Such "marginal, disregarded figures" are constantly present in *Periphery*. Their existence as a leitmotif brings issues such as the right to housing and the right to work to the pages of the novel.

Conclusion

p. 181–182

At one point in the novel, the narrator stresses that the village of the protagonist's family no longer exists, since all

[5] Kıran observes that "the language of Periphery is cold, distant and metallic" (2006, 19).

the remaining population there have moved to the town (116). In another instance, villages are described as “either emptied by themselves or were depopulated” (35). The protagonist’s grandfather spends his last summer back in his village and gets buried there. This is a powerful symbol of his ties with his village, with his rural background, with the Anatolian soil. It is also symbolic for the protagonist’s father: Istanbul is not the place where he can visit his father’s grave, a metaphor for roots. When he dies, however, he gets buried in Istanbul. So, for the protagonist, Istanbul *is* the place where he can visit his father’s grave. This subtle detail poignantly manifests the shifting symbolic meaning of the city between different generations of migrants.

The protagonist always ends up in Maçka Park: “he was walking back and forth and eventually finding himself in this park” (185). As discussed earlier, for the city inhabitants who do not have money to spend for recreation, parks have great importance. There is not sufficient information in the novel as to whether this is also the case for the protagonist. However, his deep connection with parks, green spaces and the sea seem to imply a multidimensional motivation. His fondness for green might, to a certain extent, imply a heritage from the rural background of his parents; and the lack of green space in the city might be one of the reasons for his detachment from the city. In this respect, Gezi Park, which appears in a long passage (179–182) in the final chapter, appears almost as a foreshadowing of the Gezi Protests of 2013 which took place ten years after the publication of *Periphery*: an unforgettable moment of urban inhabitants’ fight for their right to green space, in other words for their right to the city. p. 182

The sea is a significant imagery in the novel. It carries a feeling of infinity, something which calls for contemplation on existence. It is also an accessible beauty of the city for most of its inhabitants; simply sitting on a bench or strolling on the shore makes it possible to enjoy it. The novel ends with that imagery, as the protagonist sits at the Beşiktaş harbour observing the scenery. This is a moment when contemplation of existence meets with daily life in the city. There is a couple sitting on a bench holding each other, three people are having their beers and speaking in whispers as they stand by the boats, and at the other end there is one person watching the sea. Today the tea gardens next to the Beşiktaş harbour are no longer there, and the area is full of police buses, since the president took over the former mayoral office there. The park in its yard, which used to be called the Mayor’s Park by the dwellers of Beşiktaş, is now closed to the public. Images of urban spaces that were once open for the enjoyment of all and which are disappearing one after the other, as shopping malls and luxury hotels are invading the best parts of the city, find a poignant expression in the book. Geçgin draws attention to the right to recreational areas and activities as a right to the city in addition to basic needs such as municipal services. The novel paints a gloomy picture of the globalising Istanbul and reads like a warning on the devastating effects of this process. Interweaving stories of migration, working-class life, periphery neighbourhoods, deindustrialisation and homelessness, Geçgin offers in this book a kaleidoscopic look at the realities of the neoliberal city through the lens of its inhabitants’ unacknowledged rights. p. 182–183

It Takes All Kinds: The Istanbul Forgotten in the ‘Varoş’

İnsan Kısım Yer Damar Damar (*It Takes All Kinds*) by Hatice Meryem, published in 2008, is another novel set on the periphery of Istanbul, this time in the 2000s.[6] It is about the lives of two sisters living in a former shanty town. The book’s title is an adage which can literally be translated as: humans have many kinds, soil has many veins. The title being an adage, an element of oral culture, signals the significance of the oral tradition in the protagonist’s outlook on life. The title, combined with the work’s narrative technique, implies the separateness and a lack of communication amongst people even within the same family. p. 183

In the novel, themes directly related to the right to the city appear in terms of material necessities, particularly services of the municipality and infrastructure. Meryem skilfully connects the themes of isolation on the outskirts of the city in a former shanty town and its inhabitants’ unawareness of their rights as members of the city’s population through the setting of her novel. The intensive use of free indirect discourse enables her to refrain from an authoritative attitude and depict life in a former shanty town through the eyes of those who experience it.[7] In her novel, which displays a sharp satirical edge, Meryem extends the themes without sliding into agitation and invites readers to question the dominant discourse on the so-called *varoş* neighbourhoods and their population without being assertive. p. 183–184

The power of speech and possessing language, which is a central theme of the novel, appears at the very beginning where Elmas, the younger of the two sisters, is described as the exact opposite of Zümrüt, the older sister who is the protagonist. Elmas’s incompetence in language repulses Zümrüt, since “one thing she [Zümrüt] could not stand was a person who does not speak” (Meryem 2008, 20). While Zümrüt can use words like weapons, “Elmas was scared of words” (24). p. 184

[6] The English translation of the book’s title is that of İdil Aydoğan and Amy Spangler (2013, 139).

[7] Suzanne Keen lists “the three modes of representation of consciousness” as follows: “psycho-narration, narrated monologue (also called free indirect discourse), and quoted monologue (also called interior monologue)” (2003, 60). She defines psycho-narration as “the narrator’s discourse about a character’s consciousness” (60).

In the fifth chapter of the book, the narrator mentions a language: “this was such a language that perhaps it was only good for speaking” (36). She explains that its speakers utilise their language in many ways and adds: “however [speakers of that language] had never thought of writing even one line down. Neither had it ever occurred to them that a grudge would be borne against their language, which served so many purposes” (37). One day fires start in the place where this language is spoken. Unable to extinguish the flames, the speakers of the language flee to other cities. Elmas’s mother is one of them, who refuses to talk about this event. She no longer uses this language except for cursing when she is angry.

There is vagueness if not an actual contradiction, here. While the narrator explains that Elmas learned this language from her mother, she also explains that Elmas’s mother is disconnected from this language: “since she assumed a pose as if she left her mother tongue behind intentionally among all those things which burnt furiously, she looked like the final representative of a people which has lost everything apart from their pride” (37). It is obvious that this unnamed language in the story is Kurdish. Elmas’s mother and fellow villagers having to flee the place because of the fires is an explicit reference to the depopulation of Kurdish villages in Eastern Turkey, a process in which villages were set on fire by official order (Cengiz 2013). Elmas’s perception of the unnamed language as being only spoken and never written is a clear reference to the illegality of publishing in Kurdish in Turkey in the past. That is why she has never read anything in this language.

p. 184–185

There are a couple of points worthy of analysis regarding this unnamed language. Although Elmas and Zümrüt are sisters, therefore the woman who speaks that language is the mother of both of them, it is only Elmas, the more silent of the sisters, who is identified with this language. The reader almost forgets that the mother who had to leave her native tongue behind is also Zümrüt’s mother. Zümrüt is a master of the Turkish language, with all sorts of adages, idioms and sayings. The novel does not include any information on whether Zümrüt, like Elmas, learned that unnamed language from her mother at one point. Whether she did or not, this does not seem to have any importance. Zümrüt, who has been in Istanbul for a long time, is associated with the Turkish language. She speaks endlessly in a rich Turkish. Elmas, who is associated with the other language, has recently migrated to Istanbul, and she is always silent. This silence of Elmas can be interpreted in terms of the connection between migration and the assimilation of the ethnic minority. On the way to an urban identity, the migrant from the ethnic minority has to, first of all, leave her or his native language behind. Otherwise, she or he is excluded and cannot survive in the city. Meryem implicitly addresses this correlation between assimilation and migration through the characterisations of the two sisters.

p. 185

In the novel, Meryem looks at life in a former shanty town called Kozluk through a female lens. This fictional place is an isolated neighbourhood on the outskirts of the city: minibuses, a central means of transport in such areas which connects them with the city centre, never appear in the book. Zümrüt, the protagonist, has four sons whose birth years she cannot remember. She is not happy with her husband Cavit’s high libido, and much of the time tries to find excuses to avoid sex. The way Coşkun, Cavit’s brother, perceives Zümrüt is a significant aspect of her characterisation. He does not approve of the way she treats her husband Cavit and is very much annoyed because she does not cover her cleavage. In Kozluk, like all the poor periphery neighbourhoods, patriarchal norms continue the rigidity of rural perception to a certain extent. The concept of ‘honour’, akin to that in the rural context, can easily be manipulated and used against women. Cansın from the neighbourhood, whose mother was killed by her husband as a matter of ‘honour’, for instance, slanders domestic worker women for doing ‘other’ things than cleaning (145). According to Zümrüt, the men of Kozluk all beat their wives and the women think they deserve it (153).

p. 185–186

The correlation between consumerism and urban identity is a central theme in *Kinds*. Kozluk Centre, the shopping mall of Kozluk, which dominates the visual imagery in the novel, is the main symbol of this correlation. In this imagery there is also a reference to the artificial urban look that shopping malls give to poor areas such as former shanty towns like Kozluk. In several instances, there is an implicit reference to a secret connected with this shopping mall, in which Elmas is also involved (100, 237). This is perhaps not prostitution, but might be some sort of flirtation in exchange for material benefit. Since shopping malls are the ultimate symbol of consumerism, the setting of this prostitution-like activity at the Kozluk Centre is worthy of note.

Urbanity Through Consumption

Side by side with the former shanty town of Kozluk are the gated communities of the urban middle class. The women of Kozluk witness the lives in them when they go there as cleaners. Back in the beginning of the 1980s, Tansı Şenyapılı describes the encounter between shanty town women and urban middle-class women, whose houses they clean, as follows: “[they] entered middle class houses and observed middle class living closely” and this “stimulated new cravings, hopes and aspirations which remained unsatisfied thus causing further unhappiness among gecekondu [shanty] women” (1981, 208). Meryem depicts a similar situation in the Istanbul of the 2000s, where the divide between the wealthy and the poor is much deeper, addressing the issue of class with a strong spatial dimension. p. 186

As discussed in detail in Chapter 3, for migrant women, urban consumption patterns signify urbanisation. “For the migrant family ‘consuming like urbanites’ is the first condition of being an urbanite and women organise this” (Kıray 1999, 174). While doing that, women keep their consumption for basic family needs at minimum, but for goods that will be seen by others they implement “conspicuous consumption” (174). Kıray adds that “itinerant merchants and instalment selling” make this possible (174). As Tansı Şenyapılı observes “T.V. and simple reading material which penetrate the socially hungry gecekondu environment, effectively impose a consumption oriented value system which leads to needless cravings, unsatisfied desires, alienation from one’s own class, and consequent unhappiness among women” (1981, 207). The novelist realistically addresses such desires through the portrayal of Zümrüt, the protagonist.

In the introduction she writes to her novel, Meryem states that a high number of Kozlukite women have been following “the fashion” of giving birth in private hospitals “which have been mushrooming on every street” in Kozluk (9). This description also alludes to the period in which the novel is set, which is the 2000s. The chapter which chronicles the development of Kozluk ends with the information that the year Elmas moved to Kozluk was also the year when the women of the neighbourhood put guipure lace curtains on their windows, became acquainted with women’s programmes on television, some of them even went to television studios as audience members on these programmes, and got used to using mobile phones (34). There is an entire chapter on Borcam, a glassware dish that can be put in the oven, which Zümrüt regards as a fancy piece of kitchenware (78). She regards it as a highly precious item and excitedly awaits the day she will possess it. She eventually purchases one, to be paid in instalments, from the local street market. As she holds her Borcam in her hands, she is depicted as having “changed into an entirely different woman, one who lives very far from Kozluk” (80). Unfortunately, this story of conspicuous consumption ends sadly since the Borcam is accidently broken by Elmas after a while. p. 186–187

The effort towards urbanisation through consumption and the great extent to which consumerism has reached in today’s world both multiply each other’s effects. The intertwinement of the two phenomena is present in various instances in the novel. For instance, Kozlukites use laminated flooring, satin paint and PVC window frames when they are replacing their shanties with apartment buildings, although they cannot afford the basic needs of buildings, such as banisters and stove pipes (70). The two themes merge in a highly humorous chapter entitled “Another Life’s Dream Is Hidden in Guest Rooms” (94). In Zümrüt’s flat, the door of the guest room is only opened when they have visitors. The room is full of goods bought and kept by Zümrüt but never used: Duralex tea cups, an electric coffee grinder, a hoover, fake silver saucers, nesting tables, plastic flowers and so forth. When Zümrüt enters this room, even the way she walks and sits changes (95). The narrator humorously describes the room as “having transformed into the depot of a store which sells household goods” (95). According to Zümrüt, the goods in the room are for those who are worth it and none of her family members are (95). This depiction in the novel is a direct expression of what Kıray describes as “roomfuls of unused goods” in migrants’ houses (1999, 174). p. 187

Like her sister Zümrüt, Elmas has dreams about a middle-class life. One day she finds a couple of books in the street on her way home: an English book, a cookery book, and a book about motherhood and raising children. These books thrown away by someone living in the gated communities offer Elmas a few glimpses of the urban middle-class life which is in walking distance yet as remote as another planet. Elmas takes the cookery book home. She reads all the recipes in it and fantasises about opening the cupboards in the picture on the cover of the book, taking ingredients whose names she has never heard of before and cooking them in those bright cooking pans. In the next chapter, she brings the book to the kitchen. As she and Zümrüt start stuffing the vine leaves for the evening picnic, Zümrüt decides to hear Elmas read out the recipe in the book, although she actually knows how to cook it. However, this recipe, with olive oil and some other expensive ingredients in it, annoys her, and Elmas regrets not anticipating this. Looking at the book, Elmas starts daydreaming about “that beautiful day” (44). She has no idea as to what she will do, wear or eat on that day, but she knows that she will be very happy. She also reminds herself that she will never go to the Kozluk Centre after that day. p. 187–188

In the novel, the Kozluk Centre was built around the time Elmas moved into the neighbourhood. The women of Kozluk like strolling through it, even if they cannot shop there. This is where Coşkun and his friends go pickpocketing. According to a friend of theirs, it is the right place to do that because people without money have become “shopping maniacs” (178). The narrator describes them as “this crowd who would get into debt bigger than their bodies, with p. 188

the credit cards in their pockets" who "want to touch nothing but money and fancy new stuff" (178). The Kozluk Centre appears as the ultimate symbol of consumerism, which is sharply criticised in the novel.

p. 188–189 Kozlukite migrant women's admiration for urban middle-class life is different from Anatolian women's fascination with the lives depicted in the soap operas they view. The women of Kozluk do not see this life on television, but live side by side with it. Consequently, their situation is much more than simple admiration: it is an issue of identity, with the spatial element at its core: Zümrüt looks like a woman "who lives very far from Kozluk" as she carries the Borcam (80), the item of her conspicuous consumption. For migrant women living in shanty towns or former shanty towns, the aspiration to a life of the higher classes not only derives from their desire for a life of luxury, but also from a search for an urban identity, since their only role models for this identity are women from these wealthier groups. They are not familiar with women who are urban yet close to them in terms of socioeconomic strata, such as progressive members of the proletariat or women working in different sectors and levels who are active in unions or other progressive causes. When no such role model exists for them, being an urban woman becomes equated with being an urban middle-class woman since the shanty town women's perception of the urban woman is limited to the examples of this category. Meryem realistically addresses this dilemma and skilfully depicts the consequent consumerist aspirations of Zümrüt and Elmas.

Identifying Kozluk

p. 189 The book does not include any explicit references to the location of Kozluk. However, this fictional setting seems to be inspired by neighbourhoods in the district of Arnavutköy, since the factual neighbourhood of Hadımköy, which is also in this district, appears in the novel (164). The mention of Bakırköy (184) and Yenikapı (202) supports this probability. Jean-François Pérouse describes Arnavutköy as a district on Istanbul's "riven fringe belt" (2018, 34).

p. 189–190 The thirteenth chapter of Part I focuses on Zümrüt's views on Kozluk, but before that, in an earlier chapter, she makes the following comment on her neighbourhood: "all Kozluk and whoever lives in Kozluk were wastrels. [...] if the whole of Kozluk flew away, nobody would feel it" (50). Her observations in the later chapter are much wider in scope. Here, Elmas reports Zümrüt's speech on Kozluk: "with her sister's colourful description, this was a place where layabouts and loafers, stony-brokes and hoodoos, sauceboxes and thieves, down-and-outs, bad lots, hangdogs and the barelegged settle down" (67). Elmas continues by saying that according to Zümrüt, "the women of Kozluk with their mannish faces" (67) are concerned about what to cook for the evening and deflect their stress onto their husbands and children. For her, the men of Kozluk can be divided into "those with a job and those without" (67), and there is a considerable number of the latter in the neighbourhood. The women of Kozluk regard their husbands as "half-formed men" (68). The children are without any warm clothes and suffer from the cold in the winter, but they have a great time in the summer making some money by selling water, tissue paper and bus tickets, and playing until late at night. On the youngsters, Zümrüt speaks negatively: "almost none of them would mend their ways, they would become either thieves or rascals" (69). She compares the early days of Kozluk, when they lived in shanties, with today. Although they used to have water and electricity cuts, and after every rainstorm the streets would be muddy as they had no asphalt on the roads, today many women long for their shanties, which they looked down on in the past. At least they had some chickens and they could grow some vegetables in front of their homes. Besides, all of the open pieces of land in Kozluk have now been turned into junkyards (70). Nostalgia for old Kozluk, before the shanties were replaced with apartment buildings, is a central feeling in Zümrüt's psyche. In a later example, when she goes to visit her new neighbours, she tells them stories about the neighbourhood's past, longing for the green Kozluk with animals such as chickens and sheep, despite the frequent electricity and water cuts (103). The positive approach to shanty housing in the novel becomes clear through these comments by Zümrüt, in terms of two central tenets of the pro-shanty argument: first, inevitability of the shanty as shelter in the absence of welfare housing policies; second, its harmony with nature. Once again, the message is conveyed through the comments of the characters rather than through a narrator speaking with authority.

p. 190 Meryem uses dialogues, free indirect discourse and psycho-narration to introduce the characters' feelings about Kozluk throughout the novel. Towards the end of the book, Coşkun comes across his friend Sami, who has not been around for a while. When they start chatting, Sami says "Goddamn Kozluk" and "in agony" he says that "he will never set foot here again" (264). At the end of their chat, Sami tells Coşkun: "you too, run away from this hell!" (265). Sami's fear of Cansın, who plans revenge, makes him talk this way, but his words also manifest his feelings about his neighbourhood. Similarly, for Elmas, Kozluk is a terrible place she is stuck in: "she [...] understood that there was no door opening to a 'beautiful day' from the Kozluk hell" (270). Within the scope of Cansın's relations with theatre circles, there are a couple of references to Beyoğlu, the centre of Istanbul's culture and arts as well as nightlife. It enters the conversations of Coşkun, Cansın and Sami as a remote place, a world completely distinct from where they live.

p. 190–191 When Coşkun becomes a very different person whilst in prison, he wants to show everyone that he has changed,

and wants to become a role model for the children of Kozluk: “there were even times when he thought that he would be a role model, a year zero for Kozlukite children struggling against impossibilities” (112). In the same chapter, which focuses on his inner world, we hear the psycho-narration of his thoughts on Kozluk. For him Kozluk is “a place of cowards” who never trust each other and who are scared of everything: “would be scared of their next-door neighbour, their mother, their father, their own child, their best friend, with whom they walk arm in arm [...] the forces of security, the municipality [...] scared of one and all” (116–117). Echoing the title of the book, these thoughts of Coşkun accentuate the separateness of Kozlukites. This is an important point about *Kinds*’s messages which separates it from numerous neighbourhood novels set in earlier decades where a sense of cosmopolitan solidarity can be felt. In *Kinds*, as implied in its title, there is particular emphasis on the lack of such cosmopolitan solidarity.

Another passage on Kozluk comprises the narrator’s comments which appear as a viewpoint from outside. Kozluk is a place which would in a pejorative manner be described as a *varoş* by those living in the central areas of the city. Writing about the concept of *varoş*, Pelin Tan stresses that “theft, murder, prostitution, drugs, radical leftist tendencies and terror are the discursive codes the state and the media use to criminalize the varoşes” (2008, 410). Islamist fundamentalism might also appear in this list of discursive codes. As discussed below, the narrator’s approach is different from the dominant discourse otherising neighbourhoods like Kozluk as *varoş*. Before analysing this, it would be useful to have a look at the introduction. p. 191

In the introduction to her novel Meryem describes Kozluk as “a little past [Istanbul], a little before it, a little to the right of it and a little to the left –but by no means in the centre” (9); and she refers to the dwellers of Kozluk as Kozlukites. Rather than an implication of the neighbourhood identity as, for instance, that of Kolerites in *Roman(i)*, here this description seems to indicate the Kozluk inhabitants’ outsider position in the city, a contrast between Kozlukites versus those living in the central areas, whom she describes as Istanbulites: when “Kozlukite children” swim in the Bosporus, “Istanbulites who travel on intra-city ferries and live tender lives” (10) react negatively towards them.

The introduction which is full of bitter-sweet humour starts with observations on trends among Kozlukite women, such as giving birth in private hospitals. The subject moves from here to the babies and children in Kozluk and the author tells us about how Kozlukite children do not hesitate to swim in inappropriate places such as polluted streams, channels and the Bosporus. The author explains that Kozlukite mothers send their children to learn the Koran or how to sew in their free time; however, children dream of “judo and taekwondo courses and the glossy windows of large shopping malls” (10), an observation indicating that aspirations to middle-class urbanity with consumerist desires start at childhood in Kozluk.

The author continues by stating that the children of Kozluk start working at a very young age and cannot go to school, and adds that some of these children turn to crime while some become policemen and soldiers. As mentioned above, in the public perception, so-called *varoş* neighbourhoods are usually associated with crime. Although certainly not hubs of crime, it is possible to find people connected with crime in these places which is not surprising given the pessimism and scarcity of opportunities for a better life in them. Melvin Seeman’s “third variant of alienation” (1959, 787) offers a useful explanation for such cases. Seeman states that this type of alienation is “derived from Durkheim’s description of ‘anomie,’ and refers to a condition of normlessness” (787) where the individual would incline to think “that socially unapproved behaviors are required to achieve given goals” (788). As discussed earlier in Chapter 3, sociological research proves that in the shanty towns of Istanbul alienation and anomie did not emerge (Kıray 1982, 173–174). Shanty dwellers were hopeful about their future and upward mobility. However, in the former shanty towns of Istanbul of the 2000s (i.e., times of extreme income inequality) urban poverty was a grim reality with high unemployment rates as well as in-work poverty. The absence of cosmopolitan solidarity which could offer the dwellers of shanty towns a feeling of attachment to their neighbourhood and the city makes this picture darker. Meryem addresses these facts realistically with the emphasis she puts on the potential anomie in Kozluk. Consequently, some readers might regard her comments in the introduction on Kozlukite men’s tendency to crime, or on Kozlukite children’s disinclination to study, as reproducing the discriminatory *varoş* discourse. Yet, when we evaluate the introduction in its entirety and interpret it together with the overall position of the novel, the message becomes clear: although there are some cases of anomie (i.e., people involved with crime) in Kozluk, this is, by all means, the reality *of a minority* in this neighbourhood. p. 192

The majority of Kozlukites are simply the poor finding it hard to make ends meet. As told in a sympathetic and humorous manner in the introduction, they get married, have children and grandchildren at a very young age, and then simply feel that this is all there is in life. What is noticeable in the introduction is the accent on their way of life as a struggle for survival. The introduction does not portray Kozlukites in a way to motivate pity for them. On the contrary, the use of humour calls attention to their ability to survive, despite all the hardship they suffer from. This message of the novel is particularly visible in its ending, as discussed below. p. 192–193

The narrator has a sympathetic approach to the protagonist and other major characters, as well as to Kozlukites in general. The narrator’s presence is at its strongest in the chapter entitled “Where Is Kozluk, Who Is Elmas?”, where the neighbourhood’s foundation by rural migrants is explained. The chapter includes a passage on the history of Kozluk, p. 193

comprising realistic details that reflect the similarity of shanty towns with each other. Similar to the introduction, the picture Meryem paints here does not show Kozlukites as people to pity and Kozluk as a depressing place. On the contrary, in this humorous passage she depicts Kozluk as a highly dynamic neighbourhood. The shops that were opened in the first years of Kozluk is a good example. The narrator lists the names of the shops in one breath, in a manner reflecting the way they were opened one after the other within a short time. Listing their wide range, she carries the atmosphere these shops bring to the neighbourhood into the depiction. It is possible to infer from the passage that the dwellers of the place have a certain income and standard of living, since this is before credit cards were widely available. Put simply, the narrator's perspective on Kozluk is much more positive than that of Kozlukites described in the above section. The dynamism and energy of Kozluk in these descriptions are in line with Henri Lefebvre's comment that "working-class neighbourhoods have a 'liveliness' that makes them interesting and which we would like to find elsewhere" (2003, 157). The narrator also emphasises that physical conditions and infrastructure in the neighbourhood have been improving throughout time. In some parts of the chapter, the reappearance of the crime topic carries the implication that some criminals live in the place, or that life in Kozluk may result in a disposition to crime. However, again, the novel's message that the majority of Kozlukites do not have anything to do with crime or rough ways is explicit.

p. 193–194 The infrastructural and environmental issues in Kozluk deepens the difficulty of life in this former shanty town. Meryem develops the theme of the right to the city in her novel primarily through these problems. At one point in the book, the narrator satirises the widespread perception of areas like Kozluk as follows: "modern urban planners who regard having been born in this city as bad luck keep organising forum after forum, discuss over and over again that these structures, which partly look like a shanty and partly like an apartment building, destroy the silhouette of the city" (33). The object of sarcasm here is the experts' preoccupation with the unsightly appearance of these neighbourhoods instead of their severe infrastructural and environmental problems, and the rights and needs of their inhabitants.

p. 194 Introducing these problems through free indirect discourse, or dialogues of characters, Meryem manages to address the issues of the right to the city from the standpoint of the characters via their experiences; in other words, through the eyes of those who suffer from these problems. In one instance, Zümrüt summarises the two fundamental issues of Kozluk as "the junkyard and the shitty stream" (36). People throw metal junk into an empty site in Kozluk, and Kozlukites' attempts to stop this fail to yield any results. They apply to the municipal authorities; they even talk on television programmes; but they cannot get results. Similarly, a stream mixed with sewage water is a long-standing problem in Kozluk. As the novel proceeds, it comes out that, at one point, when the candidate for municipal mayor is in Kozluk, Zümrüt complains to him about this. Referring to this encounter, she explains that the mayor does not have time for the problem since he is too busy making rich people's streets look nicer (63). She adds that this stream carries the sewage water of the expensive gated communities nearby (63). She expects fellow Kozlukites to appreciate her rebellious behaviour. However, they fear that if this man becomes mayor, he will cut off their water. Therefore, they are worried and do not appreciate Zümrüt's courageous behaviour. Such a worry is a crucial detail stressing the Kozlukites' perception about their existence in the city: they consider even the most basic municipal services as a favour rather than a right. Unsurprisingly, on the other side of the favour they see punishment, which they expect as a result of even a minor complaint.

p. 194–195 The other dimension of the right to the city theme in the novel comprises access to recreational areas. The novel starts with the preparations for and the experiencing of a family picnic. As the time for this activity approaches, Zümrüt is concerned that they will not be able to find space in the front area of the park on the seaside. The narrator explains in detail how much change this park has made in Kozlukite women's lives who enjoy having picnics there in the daytime with their daughters (209). In the evenings, they go there together with their husbands. In Istanbul, where public green space is scarce, some city inhabitants even use the little green patches next to roads for picnicking when the parks are all full. Picnics in 'inappropriate places' disgust elitists who regard it as an act in conflict with urban manners. Instead of criticising the lack of access to green spaces in the city they attack these picnickers, claiming that they are unaware of urban civilities. In the novel, Meryem illustrates the need for green space as an issue of the right to access to recreational areas by showing it through the characters' viewpoint.

p. 195 The novel is almost entirely set in Kozluk and the most important exception to this is the chapter entitled "The Man Who Is Larger than Palaces" (202–208), which is about Cavit's friendship with a sophisticated fisherman called Hicabi, who eventually commits suicide. Moments from this friendship enter the novel via flashback within the frame of the story of Cavit's blue pickup, which he inherited from Hicabi.

Cavit first meets Hicabi at a coffee house in Yenikapı. They instantly become friends and have a walk on the shore from Yenikapı to Çatladıkapı. Here, Hicabi points out Topkapı Palace and asks Cavit if he has ever seen a palace. Then he invites him into an imaginary palace and they both pretend to be in Topkapı Palace. After that little game, as they continue their walk, Hicabi tells Cavit stories about the Bosporus, as well as about fishing boats. Hicabi is nostalgic about old Istanbul. Cavit cites his words on the city: "those were the times when Istanbul was Istanbul" (204); "*if you put together the whole Istanbul of those times, a peddler would be able to carry it on his back*" (205). Hicabi invents stories about those days with a powerful imagination. As their friendship deepens, Cavit learns that in the past

Hicabi was an avid reader, and engaged in a theatre group. This surprises Cavit who has never been to a theatre. The pair drive around Istanbul in Hicabi's blue pickup: "One day they were going to Eyüp and praying before the holy men buried there, one day they were tossing back their wine bottles with the fishermen in Sarıyer, thanks to this pickup. They were either swerving round the bends over the remote rocks of Şile, or chatting with peasants in the coffeehouses of villages around Çatalca" (206). Owing to his friendship with Hicabi, Cavit experiences a different face of Istanbul. In other words, he develops a certain attachment to the city, through its sights and history, during the time he spends with Hicabi.

Hicabi is a minor yet crucial character regarding the novel's messages about urban identity. In the novel, he is the only character who has an attachment to the city. It is an important detail that this person strongly attached to the city is nostalgic about its former days. Meryem, in a unique manner, develops the theme of nostalgia for a past Istanbul through a character like Hicabi, who is a man of the people. As discussed various times previously, nostalgic discourse about Istanbul is widespread among the elite and targets the migrants in the city. Through the character of Hicabi, Meryem stresses that it is possible to long for the disappeared beauties of Istanbul without blaming migrants for the loss, which is what Hicabi does. Introducing this character, Meryem challenges the dichotomy between Istanbulites and 'non-Istanbulites' over its two fundamental clichés. First, it is not only the elite who are sad about the negative changes in the city. Second, inhabitants who were not born in the city can develop a strong attachment to it by appreciating its beauty and heritage and feeling a responsibility to help preserve it. p. 195–196

Conclusion

In the earlier pages of *Kinds*, the narrator comments that after feeling insecure in the city at the beginning, migrants "were able to challenge Istanbul" (32). Such a wording might first sound slightly on the side of the anti-migrant discourse: migrants arrive and after a while they become demanding. However, when we consider the book in its entirety, it becomes clear that this phrasing is a reference to the way migrants struggle and fight for their rights in the city. Meryem draws attention to the hardship rural migrants face in the city. She creates the characters in her novel with emphasis on their will to survive in the urban setting rather than a call for pity. The ending of the book is particularly powerful in this respect. p. 196

In the final chapter, entitled "Life Flows like the Water of the Bosporus" (284), it is the time of a religious holiday and Kozlukites are in their best outfits to visit their relatives and neighbours.[8] Zümrüt, Cavit and their children are in the blue pickup on their way to their visits. In the final scene of the novel, the pickup is in the middle of the Bosporus Bridge. Cavit dives into his thoughts as he drives over the bridge: "Cavit was content. At one point, he took a glance at the mansions, each glittering like a piece of jewellery in the sun, the palaces and again the still waters of the straits of the city of Istanbul, which expanded on the two sides of the two gigantic continents" (285). He remembers hearing that even when it seems calm there is always a strong current under the Bosporus and this resembles the flow of life to him: "was not life running like the waters running through the straits?"

After presenting Cavit's thoughts and feelings through free indirect discourse and psycho-narration, it is the narrator's turn to share her thoughts. She explains how people like Cavit and Zümrüt visit family members on religious holidays and behave respectfully "melt[ing] cheap mint or cacao-flavoured sweets on their palates" (286). She adds that: "they were exhibiting that they could stand up against that tide, all that distress, aside from all that nuisance and worry [...] rather than life prevailing over them, they were prevailing over life, well, they were sort of defying each other a little bit" (286). After this explanation comes the final sentence of the book: "Cavit stepped on the gas" (286). p. 197

As the narrator describes Cavit's contemplation on the Bosporus Bridge she uses the Ottoman phrase of "şehr-i İstanbul" (the city of Istanbul) (285). This word choice seems to imply Cavit's pleasure at that moment: he is enjoying an amazing view in a historical city which served as the capital of the Ottoman Empire for almost five centuries. The two central tenets of the novel intertwine in its ending: Kozlukites' isolation from the city and the hardships they face to survive in it. After all their struggle in the city, in the isolated former shanty town of Kozluk, there are times they can enjoy Istanbul with its views and historical heritage, at least on a special occasion like a religious holiday. The bridge here sounds like a metaphor for the connection between the centre and the periphery of the city: central areas, historic buildings, palaces and mansions, as well as former shanty towns on the outskirts of the city, they all together constitute Istanbul. Consequently, the city belongs to all of its inhabitants wherever they live.

Throughout *Kinds*, there are a couple of instances when the humour might sound slightly as if it is leaning towards an anti-migrant and/or elitist discourse. As mentioned earlier, the passages about Kozlukite children's disinclination to study and the youngsters' tendency towards crime are the main examples of this. The narrator's word choice of "*karikatürize*" (caricatured) while describing the hair style of Kozlukite brides has a similar tone (11). However, given the overall position of the novel, this humour appears to stem from the intention of laughing *with* Kozlukites rather

[8] It is not specified whether it is Eid or the Feast of the Sacrifice.

than laughing *at* them. Addressing the life of migrants in remote corners of the city, Meryem is realistic and objective, yet sympathetic, and calls for empathy rather than pity.

p. 197–198 Kozluk is an illustration of neighbourhoods looked down on and stigmatised as *varoş* in public opinion. The final passage of Meryem's introduction to her novel comes to the fore almost as a poetic depiction of the lives of those city inhabitants constantly humiliated as *varoş* types: "once Kozlukite mothers and fathers also have the grandchildren whom they were looking forward to, they start talking about the next world like they are talking about the next street" (12). She adds: "when they silently die under their heavy wool duvets or in the dim corridors of state hospitals, no one will be any the wiser. This story is theirs" (12).

p. 198 In *Kinds*, Meryem does not idealise Kozluk nor portray its people as heroes or angels. She simply approaches them with empathy, without sacrificing a realistic perspective about the negative aspects of life in this isolated former shanty town, the banal sides of its people, and the degenerate ways of the lumpen proletariat. She addresses these issues without being judgemental, while maintaining an empathetic perspective with the skilful implementation of humour. She intelligently treats the themes of the right to the city by pointing out all sorts of deprivation the people of the so-called *varoş* experience: from basic municipal services to the needs regarding recreation and socialisation. Consequently, she invites her readers to view the amorphous looking former shanty towns dismissed as *varoş* and their poor, mostly uneducated people from a different angle free of prejudice.

On the Periphery and It Takes All Kinds: A Comparative Analysis

p. 198 *Periphery* does not have a plot in the usual sense of the word: Geçgin focuses on states of mind rather than events. The perspective of the protagonist dominates the novel. This is a man, probably an intellectual, who comes from a rural migrant family. He is an introvert who does not keep close contact with his family and relatives. He feels alienated in the city, which he perceives as a chaotic and depressing place. The reason for his alienation does not stem from his migrant family background. He belongs to the centre as much as he belongs to the periphery; or rather, he lacks a belonging to the centre as much as he does to the periphery. The work enables readers to see the city from his perspective as a claustrophobic place. The narrator is detached throughout the book, creating a feeling as if the protagonist, who is an aloof and objective person, is speaking about his own experiences in the third person and thus giving access to the actual city. There is neither an outsider's empathy, nor obvious prejudice in this narration.

p. 199 *Kinds* has a well-defined plot with central and kernel events, developed in a non-linear structure with flashbacks and digressions. Meryem introduces the perspectives of all the major characters, and the narrator also has a distinct presence throughout the novel. With the perspectives of sisters Zümrüt and Elmas at its centre, the book opens a gateway to life on the periphery through the eyes of women.

A comparison of the class positions of the characters in the two works might clarify the mechanisms of isolation and exclusion in these two versions of periphery. In his novel, Geçgin does not equate periphery with isolation. İncirköy and various other working-class neighbourhoods on the same railway route seem to be connected with each other and with the city, since their inhabitants are an active part of the labour force: they produce for the city. In *Kinds*, in a place such as Kozluk, the labour potential is redundant and this results in the isolation of the neighbourhood and its inhabitants. For the most part, the city does not need Kozluk and its dwellers, therefore they cannot connect with it, since they have no role in it. The men find odd jobs in the vicinity, the women go to houses in the gated communities nearby as daily cleaners, and that is all.

Kazlıçeşme, the model for İncirköy in *Periphery*, is around ten kilometres from the central areas of the city, such as Taksim or Beşiktaş, while Kozluk in *Kinds* is implied to be much more remote. Kozluk seems to be a representation of neighbourhoods near Hadımköy, which is about forty kilometres from Taksim, and can best be described as the periphery of the periphery.

İncirköy in *Periphery* is close to Bakırkule, inspired by Bakırköy, an important centre of social and cultural life; while in *Kinds* there is no such urban centre Kozlukites can be a part of. In *Periphery*, there are various references to the Byzantine and Greek past of Kazlıçeşme, the model for İncirköy. With a rich history and the legacy of a cosmopolitan heritage, this is a place with an identity. Kozluk, inspired by former shanty towns nobody except for their dwellers know about, does not have a history that can connect it with the history of the city.

p. 199–200 Geçgin and Meryem differ in how they treat the theme of urban identity. In *Periphery*, Geçgin depicts migrants mostly as members of the working class, while the migrants in Meryem's novel belong to either the precariat or the lumpen proletariat. While both İncirköy and Kozluk represent former shanty towns of Istanbul, where shanties were replaced with apartment buildings in the 1980s, they bear considerable differences between their fabrics as neighbourhoods. İncirköy, one of the primary locations of the setting in *Periphery*, is an old working-class neighbourhood mostly inhabited by workers who have been employed in the factories of Taşlıbağ. Eventually, these factories get removed from this area, but this does not change the identity of İncirköy as a working-class neighbourhood. In other words, the

majority of İncirköy's population comprises migrants who have managed to establish a life in Istanbul with steady jobs as workers in the formal sector. In Kozluk, the setting of *Kinds*, on the other hand, inhabitants are poor people who can only find precarious work. At one point in the novel, we learn that there is only one woman in Kozluk who has a "documented" (*kağıtlı*) (Meryem 2008, 245) job, which means her employer pays her social security taxes. Kozluk's men are usually unemployed and when they have jobs these are mostly temporary. In brief, İncirköy is a neighbourhood of the proletariat, while Kozluk's community is a combination of the precariat and the lumpen proletariat. Consequently, the norm for the inhabitants of İncirköy is working hard, and idlers, like İs, are a deviation from this norm; while the norm for Kozluk is either temporary work or unemployment, thus idlers are almost standard.

This difference between the profiles of the two neighbourhood communities is of fundamental significance as regards the issue of crime. In both novels, idlers seem to have a tendency to crime, mainly petty crime. In *Periphery*, Geçgin addresses this theme briefly in the story of İs. He does not disclose the details of İs's crime, but we can infer that he was never part of a gang, either inside or outside of the neighbourhood. His crime does not seem to have any connection with the place he lives in, it is rather a deviation stemming from his eccentricity. However, in *Kinds*, crime has an important presence in the story, since Coşkun, one of the major characters, has recently been released from prison. His closest friends are also involved in petty crime, a detail that implies a tendency amongst the youngsters of Kozluk to form gang-like groups. In brief, both works are realistic about the conditions that prevent, or lead to, anomie. In *Periphery*, Geçgin portrays shanty towns realistically as places where anomie did not exist, while in *Kinds* Meryem points out the potential for anomie in former shanty towns in the absence of hope of upward mobility and cosmopolitan solidarity. p. 200

In *Periphery*, Geçgin presents various father and son stories, and depicts family ties and kinship relations as the central solidarity network of migrants in Istanbul. The protagonist of the novel, however, has the life of an individual, very much in line with the urban setting. No story of conflict or separation between him and his late father appears, he is simply a solitary urbanite. In *Kinds*, instead of the father and son conflict, we have the tension between older and younger siblings: Zümrüt vs Elmas; Cavit vs Coşkun. In the end, Elmas and Coşkun run away together; but it is rather vague if this is an act of individualisation. p. 200–201

In *Periphery*, Geçgin somewhat ignores the gender aspect of migration: he simply hints that women's lives do not change much with the shift from the rural to the urban context. In *Kinds*, Meryem depicts women's obsession with consumerism as the only way, to their mind, of adopting an urban identity. p. 201

Despite all their differences discussed so far, the similarities of life in the settings of the two works as regards the unimplemented right to the city are significant. In both of them, limited access to municipal services comes to the fore as an important theme. Related to that, water and electricity cuts, as well as pollution problems, appear as motifs in *Kinds*. Geçgin uses similar motifs in *Periphery*, such as sewage problems and rats, to develop this theme as well as to reinforce a depressing atmosphere. In short, *Kinds* contains this theme in line with its humorous, sarcastic tone and with an accent on migrants' struggle for survival; while in *Periphery* such details appear as central elements of the novel's dark imagery.

The right to access to urban recreational spaces, such as parks, is another aspect of the right to the city theme which the two authors treat similarly in their novels. The opportunity, or the absence thereof, to benefit from public space, particularly green areas, is a major theme in both works. In *Periphery*, parks have a central place in the protagonist's daily life. In *Kinds*, Meryem underscores the need for parks and similar areas, both through the incident of the picnic and by locating the Kozluk Center, a shopping mall, as the locus of free time activity in the neighbourhood, especially for youngsters. In both works, the lack of community centres where city inhabitants, especially the young, can meet and socialise with their peers without spending money, where they can be productive with hobbies or acquire new skills, comes to the fore as another dimension of the limited recognition of the right to the city. Thus, idleness appears as an important motif in both novels, also connected with the theme of the right to work.

It might also be useful to add that various motifs related to the neoliberalisation and globalisation of Istanbul enter the two works, inevitably, since they are both set after the end of the 1980s. The economic rent creation in the globalising city is one such theme appearing in both of them: in *Periphery*, the removal of the leather industry from Kazlıçeşme implies it, while in *Kinds*, in a rather direct expression, Zümrüt explains that after the Kozluk Center was built, the apartments of Kozluk became more valuable (Meryem 2008, 104). In this novel, gated communities appear as a motif related to both economic rent creation and urban fragmentation. In *Periphery*, Geçgin briefly addresses gentrification by describing the changes around Galata in the Tünel neighbourhood, as the protagonist walks around the area (Geçgin 2003, 160). Geçgin also introduces foreign migrants and a large number of tourists as motifs, in his novel, related to the globalisation of the city. Urban poverty, another aspect of the neoliberal city's economic and social ills, is also visible in both books. This enters *Periphery* via the presence of children selling tissue paper, glue-sniffers, beggars and the homeless throughout the story. In *Kinds* it becomes clear in the Kozlukites' overall standard of living. p. 201–202

Both novels end in the centre of the city rather than on the periphery, which is an interesting similarity. Furthermore, in both endings, the characters contemplate life as they watch the Bosporus, the ultimate symbol of Istanbul. In p. 202

Periphery, the protagonist arrives at Beşiktaş after a long walk and just as he is about to go back home, he changes his mind and stays. He starts gazing at the pier, the sea and the people around. The narrator explains in detail what he sees, rather than what he thinks, inviting the reader to enjoy this view with him as the waves hit the shore, emphasising a connection between the inhabitants of the city as they gaze at the same view and contemplate life. At the conclusion of *Kinds*, Zümrüt, her husband and their sons are in their pickup on their way to visit relatives for a religious holiday. As they are driving over the Bosporus Bridge, Cavit, mesmerised by the way the water runs in the Bosporus, contemplates life with optimism, thinking that despite all the difficulties, he and his family are still standing. The novel, which is almost entirely set in Kozluk, with emphasis on its disconnectedness with the centre of Istanbul, ends at the very centre of the city, on the Bosporus Bridge which links two continents, a powerful symbol of integration. As she brings her book to a close, Meryem seems to imply a connection between the centre and the periphery, bringing her characters from Kozluk to the Bosporus Bridge. Although in the two works the theme of centre and periphery are developed in quite dissimilar ways, in their endings they convey a similar message: the people of the periphery belong to Istanbul and Istanbul belongs to them as much as it does to the inhabitants of the centre.

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p. 163

CHAPTER 8 Changing Migrants, Transforming Istanbul: *A Strangeness in My Mind* as a Love Story of a Man and His City

p. 205 Orhan Pamuk's ninth novel *Kafamda Bir Tuhaflık* (*A Strangeness in My Mind*), published at the end of 2014, tells the story of the idiosyncratic street vendor Mevlut from his migration to Istanbul as teenager until he is a man in his fifties, covering a timespan from the early 1970s to the late 2000s. Pamuk reveals Mevlut's strangeness slowly, which he implies in the title, by depicting his inner world at the centre of which lies his attachment to Istanbul, the city he lives in.

In *Strangeness*, Pamuk addresses the concept of the right to the city in various ways. In "the quiet encroachment of the ordinary" (Bayat 2013, 80), to borrow Asef Bayat's term, as a survival strategy of migrants, the right to the city is at the centre of the novel. Yet, this evolves into the quiet encroachment of the unordinary in the book, through the Lefebvrian notion of the city as *oeuvre*, owing to its sophisticated protagonist. In the setting of the novel, Tarlabaşı, a so-called deteriorated neighbourhood on the verge of urban transformation, is in a prominent position. Certain themes related to the right to the city, such as the right to live in the city centre, are treated with reference to this place. With his unique approach to the narrative situation, where characters share the task of narration with the narrator, Pamuk invites his readers to look at the novel's issues through the eyes of migrants rather than follow the authority of an urban narrator.

p. 206 The ending of the first chapter, particularly with the tone of the narrative voice, gives clues about the central themes of the novel:

Rayiha had already been to Istanbul once for her elder sister's wedding. But still she humbly asked, "Is this Istanbul now?"

"Kartal counts as Istanbul, I suppose," said Mevlut, with the confidence of familiarity. "But there's still a way to go." He pointed out the Princes' Islands ahead of them and vowed to take her there one day.

Not once during Rayiha's brief life would they ever do this. (Pamuk 2015, 13–14)

Words such as "humbly" and "confidence of familiarity" imply the prestige of having spent time in Istanbul. The emphasis on Rayiha's humbleness here, which indulges Mevlut with the opportunity to demonstrate his knowledge about the city, is a foreshadowing of the way their relationship will evolve: Rayiha as a good-natured and supportive person will make Mevlut feel loved and supported. The setting at this point is Kartal on the outskirts of the city. The Princes' Islands, one of the most picturesque areas of Istanbul, appears just across the sea. This picture functions like an imagery hinting at the different faces of Istanbul. Living in Istanbul might mean commuting for hours every day from a remote area like Kartal to the centre of the city, yet it might mean the pleasure of visiting the Islands. The city contains them all, as living in Istanbul can mean endless challenges as well as unique pleasures. The last sentence in the excerpt is an indication of Rayiha's early death. The sentence might also hint at a counter-argument to the anti-migrant discourse which suggests that migrants, because of ignorance, do not go sightseeing or visit historical places in Istanbul. Here, the sympathetic tone in the narrative voice implies the economic and other factors preventing Mevlut and Rayiha from ever visiting the Islands. This tone is a sign of the book's stance regarding the new inhabitants of Istanbul.

p. 206–207 As discussed in Chapter 3, survival strategies such as building shanty houses or vending on the streets are described by Asef Bayat as "encroachment" (2012, 120), as well as "quiet encroachment of the ordinary" (2013, 80). Bayat stresses that "through this encroachment, the dispossessed are constantly engaged in struggles in and about the urban space" (2012, 120). Vending on streets, a form of quiet encroachment, is a central motif in *Strangeness*. Experiences and emotions related with working as a street vendor are central to the psyche of Mevlut, the protagonist. He is a rural migrant, a poor man trying to survive in Istanbul, yet a unique fictional character portrayed as a sophisticated individual. In an interview, Orhan Pamuk argues that authors do not write the novel of the poor person *as an individual* (2014c). Metin Celal, responding to this claim, asserts that various authors from different parts of the world including Turkey, particularly those who follow a socialist realist tradition, have successfully depicted the individuality of their poor characters (2015, 10). It is impossible to disagree with Celal. However, Pamuk does not really claim to be the first person in literary history to have written the novel of the poor person as an individual. He is rather trying to make a point about the idiosyncrasy of his novel's protagonist which is discussed below.

p. 207 Towards the end of the book, at the beginning of the seventh part, there is an epigraph from J. J. Rousseau: "I can only meditate when I'm walking" (561). Throughout his life, Mevlut feels better when he is working outside rather than indoors. He works as a street vendor, selling yoghurt or rice in the daytime, and goes out to sell boza at night as an extra job.[1] Selling boza at night is not something Mevlut simply does to earn money, as the pleasure aspect is predominant. In fact, selling boza is not such a profitable occupation. When he is stressed, unhappy or melancholic, selling boza soothes Mevlut's soul, since to do that he walks in the streets of the city for hours. During these long

[1] Boza is a traditional fermented drink made from different types of grains.

nights, he feels that the city is speaking to him. Either in his daytime jobs, or at night selling boza, he enjoys the freedom of being outside. Mevlut resembles a *flâneur* in this sense.

As Murat Belge points out, in terms of culture and income it would not be possible to describe Mevlut as a *flâneur* (2014, 21). However, no matter how far he is from a *flâneur* socially and culturally, he is close to one psychologically. It is striking to see how Keith Tester's words describing Baudelaire's poet, probably the most characteristic *flâneur* in cultural and literary history, are also valid for Mevlut: "a man who is driven out of the private and into the public by his own search for meaning. He is the man who is only at home existentially when he is not at home physically" (2006, 2). Unlike the *flâneur* who strolls through the city for pleasure, Mevlut is out on the streets as a vendor. This is the outer reality. Where the inner reality is concerned, Mevlut carries the soul of the Baudelairean poet. Tester emphasises that "the Baudelairean poet" has "an ability to make for himself the meaning and the significance of the metropolitan spaces and the spectacle of the public" (4). This is also the case for Mevlut, the vendor. On his walks, Mevlut perceives the world around him with a sophisticated outlook, in a manner many educated urbanites would not be able to do. It is unlikely that parallels between Mevlut and the *flâneur* are simple coincidence. As Belge acknowledges, it is difficult to assume that an author like Pamuk, who has a vast knowledge of world literature, would not be aware of the resemblance between Mevlut and the *flâneur* (pers. comm., 26 November 2015). Embodying Mevlut, the poor migrant with the outlook of the *flâneur*, a somewhat elite figure, Pamuk blurs the distinction between the elite urbanite and the rural migrant.

p. 207–208

Mevlut's Endless Walks

Pamuk accentuates Mevlut's passion for Istanbul through the motif of his walks in the city. Selling boza at night is a way of life for Mevlut: "his long nightly walks weren't just part of his job anymore; they were something he felt he *needed* to do" (350); and when he is working at the Binbom cafe, he feels a sort of claustrophobia: "he may as well have been chained to the shop" (362). The narrator conveys Mevlut's feelings about selling boza at night as follows: "he sensed, now, that the streets on which he sold boza in the night and the universe in his mind were one and the same" (363). The psycho-narration continues with the meaning of the streets for him: "of course the only antidote to the loneliness of the streets was the streets themselves" (373). The narrator adds that working at Binbom for five years has made Mevlut a melancholic person. At one point, he tells his friend Ferhat that he would always want to continue selling boza (382).

p. 208

The historical heritage of the city nourishes Mevlut's rich fantasy world. The narrator explains with empathy how traces of history remind him of the existence of "another realm within our world" (391). While other migrants in the novel are proud of their material achievements in the city, Mevlut is engrossed in connecting with the soul of Istanbul. All the remnants of history—enigmatic artefacts reflecting the rich historical heritage of the city, such as "a mossy old wall" (271) or a gravestone "dating all the way back to Ottoman times" (273)—appeal to him. All of these excite Mevlut the 'non-Istanbulite', details which many Istanbulites would not even notice, or simply ignore as usual and ordinary elements of the city fabric, maybe because they are too accustomed to them. To a large extent, Pamuk develops Mevlut through his relationship with the city. If we go back to the argument above, certainly authors such as Sait Faik or Orhan Kemal created characters from the poor who were individuals with an urban identity like Mevlut. With his words quoted above, Pamuk might simply be referring to the scale of his project of creating Mevlut, the poor man, with his idiosyncrasies in great depth, as a unique individual in love with urban life.

p. 208–209

With a character like Mevlut, we can look at Bayat's conceptualisation of "quiet encroachment of the ordinary" (2013, 80) through a new dimension. Pamuk addresses the quiet encroachment of the poor migrant in the city, in his shanty, on the streets with his stall. However, in Mevlut's case, the quiet encroachment not only makes it possible for the migrant to survive in the city, but also enables him to develop an attachment to the city. Mevlut the migrant is not simply a person who chooses to live in the city to earn a living there. His ties with the city are based on passion. He is in love with the historical heritage of the city, with its *oeuvre*. Pamuk constantly emphasises this dimension of Mevlut's inner world in the book. Consequently, Pamuk does not address the right to the city simply in terms of material needs. The right to the city in Mevlut's case involves a social and cultural connection with the city which can be explained in terms of the city as *oeuvre*. He loves the city as *oeuvre*. He possesses neither the income nor the social circles to be a part of the high culture and art world of the city, or to go sightseeing like a tourist. He never does this kind of strolling through the city. However, as he pushes his stall or carries his boza basket in the centre of the city he enjoys old buildings, graveyards, crowds, simply the soul of the city. He invents his very own lifestyle which enables him to experience the city as *oeuvre*.

p. 209

Bayat draws attention to the urban poor's potential to find alternative ways to survive, as opposed to those who regard them as simply passive. In his novel Pamuk underlines this point, and takes it to a further dimension: that of individuality. The migrants struggling to earn their living can develop an urban identity and become individuals though

their experiences in the city. In Mevlut's case, the quiet encroachment of the ordinary seems to take the form of the quiet encroachment of the unordinary.

A Home in the City

p. 210 As in most works which address the rural–urban migration phenomenon, the shanty, both as a setting and as a theme, has a strong presence in *Strangeness*. The shanty setting also has a central function in the representations of Mevlut's feelings of solitude and isolation during the first phase of his time in Istanbul. The third part of the novel covers the period between 1968 and 1982, from Mevlut's arrival in the city until his marriage with Rayiha. The second chapter of this part is entitled "Home: The Hills at the End of the City" (46). The chapter opens with the following sentence: "Home was a *gecekondu*, a slum house" (46). The narrator explains that Mevlut's father most of the time refers to home as "*gecekondu*" (shanty) and rarely as home. The shanty has one room with a dirt floor, and a primitive toilet outside (47). There are only the following pieces of furniture: "an old table, four chairs, two beds (one with bedsprings and one without), two cupboards, two windows and a stove" (47). The atmosphere of the shanty is grim. Shanty housing and being on the periphery are intertwined in these initial descriptions: "their house was at the edge of the city, on the lower part of a balding, muddy hill dotted with mulberry trees, and with a fig tree here and there" (49). Mevlut's father takes him to the highest point in the area to show him around:

> From here, you could see the slums that were rapidly taking over the surrounding hills [...], the city's biggest cemetery (Zincirlikuyu), factories of all shapes and sizes, garages, workshops, depots, medicine and lightbulb manufacturers, and, in the distance, the ghostly silhouette of the city with its tall buildings and its minarets. The city itself and its neighborhoods –where Mevlut and his father sold yogurt in the mornings and boza in the evenings, and where Mevlut went to school –were only mysterious smudges on the horizon. (50)

Living in such an atmosphere on the periphery, Mevlut is not an unhappy person feeling that he is living in misery, in a shanty on a hill at the edge of the city. He is rather a self-sufficient person, always capable of finding entertainment for his mind owing to his rich imagination.

p. 210–211 The narrator explains the informal procedures for building a shanty in detail (57–59). In the related passage he stresses the difference between those who build shanties for shelter and those who build them for rent. The fragility of shanty dwelling life with the constant threat of demolition is also present here. The narrator describes the shanty as "four walls and a ceiling" (281). Pamuk accomplishes the difficult mission of painting a realistic picture of the evolution of shanties without praise or condemnation. His standpoint on the shanty phenomenon is one of empathy for those who build them for shelter. Readers who are unfamiliar with shanty housing get a glimpse of this life through its realistic depictions. The comments of Samiha, Rayiha's sister, on the shanty where she lives with her husband Ferhat (278) are also included for elaboration of the theme. Towards the end of the novel, the narrative voice rendering Mevlut's feelings as he watches the demolition of their shanty, where he lived with his father in his first years in the city, is full of empathy: "When the time came for his own one-room house, Mevlut felt his heart breaking. He observed his whole childhood, the food he'd eaten, the homework he'd done, the way things had smelled, the sound of his father grunting in his sleep, hundreds of thousands of memories all smashed to pieces in a single swipe of the bulldozer shovel" (559).

p. 211 In the earlier decades of migration, the majority of migrants lived in shanties, while some migrant families lived in run-down apartments of poor neighbourhoods in the city centre which are pejoratively called deteriorated neighbourhoods. Another group of them lived in the basement flats of the apartment buildings where they worked as caretakers. While shanties and poor neighbourhoods have a strong presence in the book, the life in these basement flats is mentioned only once, when Samiha is talking about her friend Zeliha's home as "the doorman's quarters, which were smaller than the room we lived in lacking even a window" (285). If it was the narrator describing the place in this way, it could sound like sympathy from above, but as the comment comes from an insider, the effect is effortless and warm.

p. 211–212 In the novel, there is one instance of comparison between living in run-down apartments in the city centre and living in a shanty on the periphery. At one point, Mevlut, expecting his cousin's visit, wants to open the windows because of the smell in the room. Rayiha, concerned that their daughters will feel cold, asks him: "doesn't their house in Duttepe smell exactly like this?" (263). Mevlut responds her: "It doesn't. They've got that huge garden, they've got electricity and running water, it's all like clockwork. But we're much happier here" (263). These words reflect Mevlut's resentment towards his uncle for his selfishness in the past during the conflict over the shanty. However, it also has a connotation of satisfaction about living in the city centre: the challenging conditions of apartments in Tarlabaşı seem to be the cost of living at the heart of the city. As a vendor Mevlut is always out in public spaces. "The neoliberal city is a 'city-inside-out,'" according to Bayat, "where a massive number of urban residents, the subaltern, become compelled to operate, subsist, or simply live on the public spaces –in the streets, in a substantial 'out-doors

economy’” (2012, 113). If Mevlut did not live in a central neighbourhood like Tarlabaşı he would not be able to sell boza at night in the old neighbourhoods of the city.

Stigmatised Neighbourhoods: Between Fiction and Factuality

Two of the most stigmatised neighbourhoods in Istanbul are in a prominent position in the setting of the novel: Tarlabaşı and Gazi. While in the earlier parts of the book, the fictional shanty towns of Kültepe and Duttepe are central to the setting, this changes with Mevlut’s moving out of his father’s shanty. As he rents an apartment in Tarlabaşı, a so-called deteriorated neighbourhood in the city centre, this area becomes the locus of his life, therefore of the novel. The representation of this place has a function in more than one context in the work: Tarlabaşı as a stigmatised neighbourhood, and the urban transformation in Tarlabaşı.[2] p. 212

Tarlabaşı, an area near the Grand Rue de Péra, was a place where almost only minorities dwelled and ran businesses until the 1930s when Muslim families started to move in.[3] In the 1940s, there was an increase in the number of Muslims moving into the area; yet, in this period, Pera and Tarlabaşı were still dominated by minorities and Levantines. However, with the implementation of the Wealth Tax (1942–1943), a significant amount of business and property was transferred from them to the Muslim population.[4] With the Riots of 6–7 September 1955, many non-Muslim inhabitants of the city, particularly Greeks, left the country, selling some of their properties (Üsdiken 1995, 218). With the enactment of the 1964 Decree, 35,000 to 40,000 Greeks were expelled from Turkey (Demir and Akar 1999, 157–158). Since they had to leave the country within a very short period of time, they could not sell their properties, and eventually these started to be rented to third parties by unauthorised people. These developments had a direct and massive impact on Tarlabaşı: “Especially after the 1960s Tarlabaşı and surroundings became an area inhabited by low income groups due to internal migration and the changes in the property structure. Low-income migrants from Anatolia, the unemployed and so forth started to move in as renters or squatters, into low-standard residences of Tarlabaşı, some of which were abandoned” (Akbulut 1995, 219). M. Rıfat Akbulut adds that the dilapidation of the buildings, the moving in of people working in the nightlife of Beyoğlu, and illegal activities here pushed Tarlabaşı into “complete deterioration” and caused discomfort in public (219). As a result of the ‘rehabilitation’ project to turn Tarlabaşı Street into a boulevard, a massive and controversial demolition programme was implemented in the area in 1986–1988. A total of 368 buildings, 167 of which were registered as historical heritage, were demolished (219). p. 212–213

In March 1982, Mevlut comes back to Istanbul upon completing his military service and moves to Tarlabaşı, renting “a second-floor apartment [...] in an old Greek house” (197). In a passage depicting his cousin Süleyman’s visit to him at his place, in 1987 during the demolition programme, there is a long section where Süleyman explains, with great enthusiasm, how following the 1980 military coup, the new mayor pushed carpenters and mechanics out of Tarlabaşı and shut down the bachelor dormitories, and comments on the current situation: “In the last five years, this whole place has been overrun by drifters and castaways, and there are so many poor rural migrants, Kurds, Gypsies, and foreigners who have settled on these streets that the neighbourhood is worse than Duttepe was fifteen years ago. Only another coup could clean this place up now” (264). In Süleyman’s comments, discrimination against ethnic minorities and rural migrants is clear, although he is also a rural migrant. Süleyman also adds that the Vural Holdings, the building firm which has a monopoly in the Duttepe and Kültepe area, has attempted to purchase a couple of precious buildings here for a low price, but then cancelled the plan because of title deed problems. His discriminatory discourse concludes with a wish for a forceful, inhumane transformation of the neighbourhood which will, as a matter of fact, serve capitalist interests. The argument of the public officials about the neighbourhood, given as indirect discourse, in the excerpt below, is even harsher than Süleyman’s discriminatory words. Here, the case is not only discrimination but also stigmatisation that justifies the demolition: p. 213–214

The program of demolitions was announced as an effort to clean up and modernise the city, an approach that appealed to everyone. Criminals, Kurds Gypsies, and thieves currently squatting in the neighbourhood’s vacant buildings would get kicked out; drug dens, smugglers’ warehouses, brothels, bachelor dormitories, and ruined buildings that served as hubs of illegal activities would be demolished, and in their place would be a new six-lane highway taking you from Tepebaşı to Taksim in five minutes. (317) p. 214

The narrator’s viewpoint about Tarlabaşı is neutral. In an early paragraph in the twelfth chapter, he describes the situation in the neighbourhood as follows:

As the conflict in Eastern Turkey grew more violent, Mevlut watched the streets of Tarlabaşı fill up, one family at a time, with Kurdish migrants. These newcomers were tough people, nothing like easy-going Ferhat. Their villages had been evacuated and burned to the ground during the war. They were poor and never bought any boza, so Mevlut rarely

[2] For those who are not familiar with Istanbul, it might be useful to note that Dolapdere, which is mentioned numerous times in the analysis of *Roman(i)*, is a neighbourhood adjacent to Tarlabaşı.

[3] ‘Minority’ and ‘minorities’ denote the non-Muslim minority population (i.e., Greeks, Armenians, and Jews).

[4] For the Wealth Tax and the Riots of 6-7 September 1955, see Chapter 4.

went to their neighbourhoods. He stopped going altogether when drug dealers and homeless, glue-sniffing young men began to frequent the area. (310)

It might be useful to explain a historical detail here. The excerpts above are taken from the passage set in 1987, shortly before the opening of the Tarlabaşı Boulevard in 1988. However, Kurdish families whose villages were set on fire by official orders migrated to Istanbul almost a decade later, in the mid-1990s. So, this seeming confusion in the excerpt might be an authorial decision to enmesh the atmospheres of Tarlabaşı in different periods, or Pamuk might have simply overlooked this historical fact. In the quote above, the narrator first describes the Kurds' arrival in Tarlabaşı then mentions the existence of drug dealers and outcasts in the neighbourhood. This is a realistic illustration of the place where poor dwellers of the neighbourhood, who live there because this is all they can afford, have to cope with the difficulties of being around dangerous people.

p. 214–215 At a later point in the book, in the 1990s Ferhat tells Mevlut: "you can't live in this neighbourhood anymore unless you've got a gun" and adds: "drugs, prostitutes, transvestites, all kinds of gangs" (442–443). The comments of Ferhat, who is an Alevi, are not based on ethnic and/or sectarian prejudice; he simply observes the dangers in the neighbourhood, without wishing for an iron fist to change it. He may or may not be exaggerating the situation, this entirely depends on which streets and alleys of Tarlabaşı he refers to. The public perception about the area enters the book through such comments.

p. 215 Towards the end of the novel, in the early 2000s, about a decade before the start of the massive Tarlabaşı urban transformation project, rumours about this plan pervade the neighbourhood. At this point, the narrator explains that Mevlut has always felt like an outsider in Tarlabaşı, and now, with the recent changes in the place, this feeling grows stronger. He realistically describes the downward spiral in the neighbourhood: "the old carpenters, blacksmiths, repairmen, and shopkeepers trained by the Armenians and the Greeks had all left, as had those hardworking families ready to do any job to survive, and now the Assyrians were also gone, replaced by drug dealers, migrants moving into abandoned apartments, homeless people, gangsters, and pimps" (524). After this explanation the narrator gives information on the rise of gangs in the neighbourhood through a neutral tone reflecting an objective stance.

In the novel, Pamuk's general approach to Tarlabaşı is against a stigmatising discourse. He stresses that there were and are those engaged in minor or major illegal activities in this neighbourhood. However, most of the inhabitants of the place have nothing to do with such a lifestyle, just the poor trying to survive in the city. He also draws attention to the benefits of capitalists in the two transformation operations in the neighbourhood, and that the stigmatising discourse is employed as a vehicle for legitimising these operations.

p. 215–216 Gazi, another neighbourhood with a solid presence in the work, is worthy of discussion in the way Pamuk fictionalises it. As mentioned earlier, the novel includes numerous events from history adhering faithfully to historical data. In an interview, Pamuk explains that "in the novel Turkey's, particularly Istanbul's transformation in the last forty years is told" (quoted in Parla 2015, 121). The fact that the shanty towns of Kültepe and Duttepe are fictional is surprising in a novel which resembles a chronicle. However, Kültepe (Ash Hill) and Duttepe (Mulberry Hill) are representations of neighbourhoods such as Kuştepe (Bird Hill) and Gültepe (Rose Hill), similarly located near Mecidiyeköy and Zincirlikuyu, and obviously the hill (*tepe*) in their names is an open reference to these factual neighbourhoods. Celal argues that Pamuk's decision to give fictional names to these realistically depicted shanty towns might be simply because he did not want to encounter discussions of precise compatibility with reality (2015, 10). However, when it comes to the appearance of Gazi in the novel, the situation is unique. In the book, Gazi, a factual neighbourhood, appears semi-fictionally. Before discussing the results of this, it might be useful to give brief information about Gazi, a periphery neighbourhood of Istanbul.

p. 216 Jean-François Pérouse acknowledges the "mythology" about the Gazi Neighbourhood based on "catastrophism" and "sensationalism" (2011, 72). He asserts that this mythology has three main constituents: Gazi is an Alevi, leftist and Kurdish neighbourhood (73). Pérouse stresses that within such a framework, "Gazi is a dangerous [...] 'stigmatised' neighbourhood" (73), and adds that the events in March 1995 contributed to this perception of it (73–74).[5] Depending on his research in the register office archives as well as his fieldwork in the area, Pérouse observes that Gazi is not a Kurdish neighbourhood (82). He adds that, although Alevis are the majority, there is a considerable Sunni population in Gazi (85). From his conversations with Gazi inhabitants, he emphasises that "Gazi can neither be described as a 'leftist neighbourhood'" nor as a "liberated area", as the majority of the residents are far from supporting the armed radical leftist groups (91). However, he asserts that constant psychological agitation by the police in Gazi, both before and after the events of 1995, led to a "consciousness of difference stemming from a mutual feeling of 'oppression'" (92).

The Gazi that appears in the work is an amalgam of the Gazi Neighbourhood and another neighbourhood in Istanbul called the 1 Mayıs Mahallesi (1st of May Neighbourhood). As Şükrü Aslan explains in detail, the 1st of May Neighbourhood was established under the leadership of leftist groups in the second half of the 1970s (2004, 87–115). Its

[5] "In March 1995, Sunni radicals opened fire on several coffee houses" in the neighbourhood, and as a result of the consequent unrest "some thirty people died" and the government had to send soldiers to the area to maintain order (Zürcher and Linden 2004, 130).

story is attributed to Gazi in the novel. This substitution raises two important issues: What is the reason for it? What is its effect on the overall message of the novel?

In an interview, Pamuk clarifies that, in connection with Ferhat's story, the Gazi Neighbourhood was one of the places he visited during his research for the book (Pamuk 2014c, 23). In Part IV, in Chapter 9 entitled "The Ghaazi [Gazi] Quarter" (274), we read a lengthy passage on the establishment of the neighbourhood. However, factually Gazi was not established in this way; the establishment story included in the chapter belongs to the 1st of May Neighbourhood. In another interview, Pamuk replies as follows when asked whether the story of Gazi in the novel is true: "Yes, but this is the story of 1st of May Neighbourhood. There had happened a sort of a socialist uprising." (Pamuk 2014b). p. 216–217

Put simply, Pamuk combines the identities of the Gazi and 1st of May Neighbourhoods in the novel to create a fictional Gazi. This causes confusion in a work which is rather faithful to historical facts. Interestingly, the way Pamuk fictionalises Gazi in the novel is very much in line with what Pérouse describes as the mythologies about this neighbourhood: that it is a Kurdish, Alevi and left-wing neighbourhood. Most probably, the majority of the book's readers will not check whether the story of Gazi in the book is factual or fictional. It is very likely that they will assume it is based on historical facts. Consequently, Pamuk, probably unintentionally, contributes to the reproduction of the mythologies about the stigmatised neighbourhood of Gazi. p. 217

Men and Women in the City

Pamuk refrains from problematising the gender aspect of the migration experience. This tendency attracts attention, particularly in Mevlut's development, who comes to Istanbul as a young man from a village in Anatolia. Pamuk superficially addresses the changes in Mevlut's perception of gender issues when he, around the age of twenty, falls in love with a woman he keeps encountering in the street. He names this woman Neriman, and after a while starts following her. In a passage where the narrator conveys Mevlut's thoughts on this, via free indirect discourse, we observe the changes in his mentality as regards gender issues. Here, Mevlut imagines a scenario where his sisters were followed by a man in the village, the way he is following Neriman right now. While he accepts that he would feel rage about this, he does not find a moral problem with his own act since "Istanbul was not a village" (106). Here, Pamuk confines himself to imply Mevlut's awareness of the fundamental differences between the country and the city as regards gender issues. Yet, he does not take the next step of making Mevlut question how he would react if a man *in Istanbul* followed his sisters on the street. p. 217

While Pamuk does not explicitly demonstrate the extent of Mevlut's progress on gender issues, we can infer that he is at least a step further on than rural perceptions, for instance, when he admires his daughter for her relaxedness when socialising in the city. That said, Mevlut never encourages his wife Rayiha to be a part of urban life. Rayiha is not out in the public sphere, alone or with her husband; she is always at home, in the domestic, private sphere. Mevlut's daughters, as second-generation migrant women, have much more connection with the city than their mother has. p. 218

While Pamuk portrays Rayiha as a woman disconnected from life outside home, he emphasises her sisters', particularly Samiha's, admiration for the city. In fact, it is an important detail that these two women, rather than any men, are the only characters, apart from Mevlut, with strong positive feelings for the city. Samiha explains hers as follows: "the crowds, the people dodging buses as they run to the other side of the road, the girls in skirts, the horse-drawn carts, the parks, the big old apartment buildings; I love it all" (252). The resonance of the city as *oeuvre* in Samiha's words, especially in her inclusion of old apartment buildings, is worthy of notice. The way she describes how and why she loves the city also reflects her desire to be liberated as a woman in the city, challenging the male hegemony on what to wear and how to behave. The feeling of freedom is an important reason for her attachment to the city. In fact, in the Turkish original, she says she likes "*özgürce* etek giyen kızları" (girls wearing skirts *freely*) (Pamuk 2014a, 208), a nuance lost in the translation above which simply renders it as "the girls in skirts" (2015, 252).[6] After marrying Ferhat, Samiha works as a domestic worker in apartments in the city centre, and enjoys being in central areas of Istanbul. Like Mevlut, she thinks that the city talks to her (237). She admires Ferhat for having grown up in Karaköy: "it was nice to think that Ferhat had spent his childhood in Karaköy, right in the middle of the city, and when I got home I would ask him to tell me about those days" (289). Vediha, the oldest of the three sisters who is married to Korkut, also loves travelling in the city, as mentioned by Süleyman when he describes their visits to seek out eligible girls for his marriage: "Vediha loved being out of the house so much" (299). Vediha explains that visiting candidates for Korkut is the easiest way for her to get permission from her husband to go out in the city (300). Eventually, Korkut has a relationship with a singer woman, but his family does not approve of this. Other than these minor instances Pamuk does not address the gender dimension of migrants' life in the city. p. 218–219

[6] Emphasis added.

Conclusion

p. 219 *Strangeness* is a novel set within a timespan of about forty years: from 1969, when Mevlut migrates to Istanbul, to 2012. The changes that took place in Istanbul in that period of time have significance in relation to the setting as well as to the treatment of various themes in the book. Early in the novel, there is a long passage on Mevlut's perception of the changes in the city after he has spent twenty-five years there. The narrator begins with the changing streets and houses, and when it comes to people, he makes the following comment: "the quiet, brownbeaten folk in gray and drab clothes who used to populate the streets had been replaced by rowdy, energetic, and more assertive crowds" (19). This depiction, together with Mevlut's thoughts on the new migrants of the city quoted below, appear as an expression of the good migrant–bad migrant opposition: reasonable good migrants of the past as opposed to the intimidating bad migrants of the present.

For a long time, Mevlut welcomes the new in the city: "He didn't see the city as a place that had existed before his arrival and to which he'd come as an outsider. Instead, he liked to imagine that Istanbul was being built while he lived in it and to dream of how much cleaner, more beautiful, and more modern it would be in the future" (318). Feeling himself a part of these changes strengthens Mevlut's attachment to the city and his identity as a member of it. However, as the novel proceeds, his views on that start to alter and evolve toward the opposite direction. The differences he observes all around leads to unsettling feelings in him: "the city was no longer an enormous, familiar home but a faithless space in which anyone who got the chance added more concrete, more streets, courtyards, walls, pavements, and shops" (509).

p. 219–220 Pamuk addresses Mevlut's discomfort about the changes in Tarlabaşı at the beginning of the 2000s, which leads to his decision to move out, in the chapter entitled "New Quarters, Old Faces" (517). Mevlut feels apprehension with the increasing presence and visibility of gangs, drug dealing and prostitution in Tarlabaşı. He is displeased with the new inhabitants of the neighbourhood, be they natives or foreigners. As he observes the rise in the number of foreigners, most of whom are transit migrants, his perception of the neighbourhood alters: "by now he was getting used to the idea of Tarlabaşı as just a temporary stop on so many longer journeys" (526). He is also irritated by the increasing number of street stalls in the neighbourhood, and he does not like the new street vendors running them.

p. 220 Some aspects of Mevlut's discomfort illustrates how each generation of migrants sees the next newcomers as outsiders. In other words, while former migrants feel the right to live in the city, they tend not to 'grant' migrants who come after them this right. As Mevlut lives in Tarlabaşı, a neighbourhood directly affected by migration, he becomes an early and insider witness of the changes in the city as regards the migrant population and related social dynamics. In a free indirect discourse, we hear what Mevlut thinks about the new migrants in Istanbul: "Istanbul was crawling with Ukrainian women smuggling contraband in their suitcases, African migrants, and shady operators who sucked people dry; the city had become a hotbed of corruption and bribery" (395). Although the focus in this sentence is foreigners, the expression "çeşit tuhaf insan" (all sorts of strange people) (Pamuk 2014a, 322) which appears in the English translation as "shady operators", obviously includes all newcomers, foreign or native. In comments like this, the boundary between the narrator and Mevlut is vague. The way Mevlut views these new inhabitants of the city is similar to the way Istanbulites viewed migrants in former decades, when many of them, such as Mevlut, first arrived in the city. The psycho-narration following the above quote accents the divide between the old and the new migrants. Mevlut notices "a new category of poor people" (481), who picked up the rubbish on streets which were "changing [...] very fast. There were too many words and letters, too many people, too much noise" (481). He also identifies "a new class of tougher, angrier hawkers" (481). He sadly witnesses that "the older generation of street vendors had been swallowed up in the tumult of the city" (481). In the globalising Istanbul which Mevlut observes, migrants' upward mobility is less likely than it was in the earlier decades; a fact that makes them almost aggressive in their struggle in the city.

p. 220–221 The urban transformation changing the face of the city has direct influences on Mevlut's life. These are the early 2000s, just before the Tarlabaşı urban transformation project was announced. Mevlut is concerned about the increasing rent. He feels that Tarlabaşı is becoming a more and more awkward place with each passing day: "he also suspected that these gangsterish types –his so-called landlords (who changed every five or six years) –might suddenly pull out and leave the house to real-estate brokers, property speculators, developers eager to build hotels, or to some other gang, as had happened elsewhere over the past two years" (525). He observes how Tarlabaşı becomes a focus of economic rent creation (i.e., capturing speculative gains without any productive investment): "after having been largely ignored for so many years, the whole neighbourhood had suddenly become a magnet for all the misery and destructive appetite that the city could muster" (525). These are all entirely realistic depictions of the situation in Tarlabaşı, portraying the vulnerability of migrants living in poor neighbourhoods, targeted by economic rent creation. This point is closely connected with the right to the city, as urban transformation projects result in violations of inhabitants' rights. In *Strangeness*, Tarlabaşı's approaching urban transformation is implied to be imminent but its implementation is not mentioned.

p. 221 The process in Duttepe and Kültepe in the context of urban transformation is another important motif in relation

to Mevlut's feelings about the changes in the city. Towards the end of the book, we follow him on his way to Kültepe. He walks through apartment blocks that replaced former shanties, with their unlicensed storeys added over the years, making them all the more ugly. The tone of the narrative voice is clearly negative in its description: "hideous *gecekondu* homes, six or seven stories high" (555). The passage continues with a paragraph of Mevlut's thoughts on the incredible growth of the city:

Throughout the happy years of his marriage to Rayiha [...] he'd always thought that Istanbul would never change, that all his hard work out on the streets would gain him a place of his own someday. All this had happened, to an extent. But ten million other people had joined him in Istanbul over the past forty years, latching on as he had to anything they could find, and the city had emerged transformed. Istanbul's population had been only three million when Mevlut had first arrived; now, they said there were thirteen million people living there. (556)

This penultimate chapter of the novel ends with a wave of nostalgia that engulfs Mevlut as he watches the shanty he grew up in be demolished, to be replaced with an apartment building by Vural Holdings.

Mevlut's estrangement from the city is at the centre of the final chapter and, therefore, of the ending of the novel. He reflects on his feelings, trying to find the reasons for them: "Was it because of that unstoppable, swelling flood, the millions of new people coming to Istanbul and bringing new houses, skyscrapers, and shopping malls with them? [Mevlut] began to see [...] demolished not just ramshackle houses in poor neighbourhoods, but even proper buildings in Taksim and Şişli that had stood for over forty years" (574). He thinks about the old buildings and their dwellers: "As those old people disappeared along with the buildings they'd made, new people moved into new buildings – taller, more terrifying, and more concrete than ever before. Whenever he looked at these new thirty- and forty-storey towers, Mevlut felt that he had nothing to do with any of the new people who lived in them" (574). As the passage indicates, the changes in the city are consequences of neoliberalisation and Istanbul's new identity as an emerging global city. The capture of economic rent by politically connected elites, urban transformation, urban poverty and international migration are concomitants of this historical conjuncture. p. 221–222

On the following page, through an instance of psycho-narration, we hear Mevlut's thoughts about the new migrants in Istanbul, intertwined with his dismay caused by the city's changing landscapes: "a new class of strange people had moved into the old *gecekondu* homes [...]. But the newest destitute multitudes mostly lived in the farthest reaches of Istanbul, farther out than the second ring road around the city, where even Mevlut had never set foot" (576). His observations on the landscape that changes as fast as the social fabric follow his thoughts on urban poverty: "What amazed Mevlut even more were the strange new buildings that had begun to rise from these quarters like phantoms, so tall that you could see them from the opposite shore of the Bosporus. Mevlut loved to watch these buildings from afar" (576). The use of the adjective "strange" (*tuhaf*) twice, which is also included in the title of the novel, is noteworthy here. The strangeness in Mevlut's mind seems to be connected with the strangeness in the city with its people and its landscape. p. 222

The location where Mevlut thinks about all these is his cousin Süleyman's top floor apartment in the tower block in Kültepe. This was built by Vural Holdings on Mevlut's shanty's land; in return he got an apartment in the building. His cousins Korkut and Süleyman also live in this block with their families. That night the three cousins and their wives have dinner together. Afterwards, Mevlut has a seat on the balcony to enjoy the view, a moment described as follows: "he felt dizzy for a moment, both from the height and the sheer expanse of the landscape before him" (577). As he gazes out over the buildings, he recollects the past of the hills around there: the city looks extremely changed now and the massive number of buildings around shocks him. The view in front of him creates mixed feelings: "Istanbul could still make him flinch, but even now at fifty-five years of age, he still felt the urge to leap right into this forest of staring buildings" (578). The minutes of looking at the view from the balcony turn into a moment of contemplation which enables him to define what lies behind his passion for selling boza: "walking around the city at night made him feel as if he were wandering around inside his own head" (579). Later, he goes out to sell boza. p. 222–223

The narrator explains that recently Mevlut has been seeing Rayiha in his dreams, in an old mansion, the door of which he cannot open. In these dreams, he walks endlessly in the streets and opens the doors of different mansions desperately trying to reach her. The narrator adds that in recent years imagination had been intermingling with reality in Mevlut's mind. As he walks in the night's darkness, he starts thinking what he would like to tell to *the city which has been talking to him* for all these years. At that point, a customer hails him. Mevlut goes into the building, hands over the boza, and as he is about to leave, the female customer compliments him for doing his job. "I sell boza because it's what I want to do" (584), Mevlut replies. These words make the woman even more sympathetic towards him: "Don't ever give up, boza seller. Don't ever think there's no point trying among all these towers and all this concrete" (584). Mevlut replies with the following words: "I will sell boza until the day the world ends" (584). He continues walking along a street "toward the Golden Horn, down a road that felt as if it were descending into oblivion" (584), and finds what he wants to tell to the city: "I have loved Rayiha more than anything in this world" (584). The novel ends with these words. p. 223

Mevlut's feelings of estrangement give way to a dreamlike lament to the past in the ending of the book. The motif p. 223–224

of boza, a tradition from the past, inevitably brings a considerable nostalgia to the book, from the first page to the last, which should not be confused with the elitist nostalgia for the city before the arrival of rural migrants. The nostalgia here is for the lost traditions and ways of life that were once components of the urban life, and that could be shared by all members of the city regardless of class and status. The focus on the motif of boza in the closing pages of the book intensifies this nostalgic atmosphere. In these final passages, Pamuk brings the act of buying boza, which is as nostalgic as selling boza, to the fore as the final dialogue in the novel is not between Mevlut and one of the major characters, but between Mevlut the boza seller and an anonymous boza buyer. The two communicate almost in a special code, that of love and nostalgia for an almost lost Istanbul: an Istanbul where vendors would walk around the streets and have many customers. For the woman buying boza, Mevlut with his boza basket is a symbol of the beautiful old days of the city. "Don't ever think there's no point trying among all these towers and all this concrete" (584) she tells Mevlut, referring to the changing urban landscape. Imagery based on towers and concrete dominate these last pages of the novel.

p. 224 There is one more element of nostalgia here. The timing of these final passages is the night of the Eid holiday. As Mevlut is at one of his customer's doorstep he sees that a group of family and friends who have come together for the holiday are drinking raki together. The way the Ramadan and Eid holidays were celebrated in the past is a bygone tradition in Turkey, a strong motif of nostalgia. The description of this setting and Mevlut's feelings about it are important in this regard: "he saw loving aunts, dignified fathers, gregarious mothers, grandfathers, grandmothers, and an indefinite number of children" (583). The atmosphere leads to a moment of introspection: "these people's happiness pleased Mevlut. Human beings were made to be happy, honest, and open" (583). Thus, the nostalgic passage ends with a degree of optimism.

p. 224–225 The imagery in Mevlut's dreams is another detail reinforcing the nostalgia in the ending of the novel. As mentioned above, in his dreams Mevlut sees Rayiha in an old mansion, which is one of the ultimate symbols of the picturesque old Istanbul. He cannot reach her in the dream, as the streets he walks keep changing. In these motifs of constant change, and the impossibility of finding the beloved, it is possible to find a reference to his love for an Istanbul which has mostly faded away. The setting of the very last scene of the book is a street around Feriköy which extends to the Golden Horn. These streets are at an intersecting point where Muslim and former minority neighbourhoods meet. They are places which have not been completely destroyed by urban transformation yet, and still have a touch of the old Istanbul. Mevlut's final words, which are also the final words of the novel, are his declaration of love for Rayiha, who is no longer in this world. The book ends with a longing for the past: lost happy times with Rayiha, in a lost Istanbul. The Istanbul Mevlut shared with his wife has almost disappeared; however, he is tracking its remnants in the old streets which are still, albeit barely, alive. This is not the Istanbul where Rayiha once lived; or, Rayiha no longer lives in this changed Istanbul. It is difficult to dissect which comes first.

p. 225 As Pamuk ends *Strangeness* with depictions of Mevlut's great love for Istanbul, he lays emphasis on the concept of the right to the city. The city belongs to those who are able to appreciate its beauty and heritage; and the right to the city does not simply comprise material necessities, it also includes the right to experience the city as *oeuvre*. The first condition for this is to be able to establish a life in the centre of the city. If the city centre is invaded with more concrete, more towers, hotels and plazas, there will be no way for the poor to live and spend time in the city centre; in other words, to inhabit the city, and to experience the city as *oeuvre*.

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p. 226

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p. 205

CHAPTER 9 Conclusion: Reading the Right to the City Novels in a New Istanbul

p. 227 I have argued in this book that a certain vein within modern Turkish novels can be identified as right to the city novels. These novels all have migrant protagonists in Istanbul and their philosophical underpinnings are compatible with the right to the city, a concept developed by Henri Lefebvre just before the Paris riots of May 1968. I have argued that these works in harmony with the concept of the right to the city can be accepted as a counterpoint to the vein of nostalgic Istanbul novels in Turkish literature. In other words, this vein exists only with the presence of its antithesis which is the nostalgic Istanbul novels. Therefore, novels with migrant protagonists cannot de facto be classified as right to the city novels, they must stand as a counterpoint to nostalgic novels. Consequently, the term cannot be applied to novels with migrant protagonists in other cities of Turkey as there are no identifiable veins of nostalgic novels set in them.

The city is a living entity which is always in a state of flux. Likewise, the concept of urbanity is not written in stone, it also evolves through time. Therefore, as I analysed the related themes in the novels, I discussed the changes in Istanbul and concomitant perceptions about it, and the evolving perspectives on the meaning of urbanity.

p. 227–228 Lefebvre describes the right to the city as "a superior form of rights: right to freedom, to individualization in socialization, to habitat and to inhabit" (1996, 173). For a person whose right to habitat, in other words whose legitimacy in the city, is even questioned, inhabiting it in the Lefebvrian sense sounds almost utopic. For migrants, legitimacy in the city is the prerequisite for inhabiting it. The problem of legitimacy has two dimensions.

p. 228 The first dimension is the migrant's urbanisation. For a migrant to be regarded as a legitimate member of the city she or he should be able to integrate into the city, adopt an urban identity. As long as the urbanites of the city perceive a migrant as a peasant in the city, they will treat him or her as an outsider if not an unwelcome visitor disturbing the urban atmosphere. The urbanisation of the migrant thus comes to the fore as an important theme in all the novels I have analysed in this book.

The second dimension comprises migrants' ways of meeting their needs in the urban context. If one constituent of migrants' questioned legitimacy is the perception that they are not urbanites, the other one is the discomfort they cause with their informal strategies of survival which Asef Bayat describes as a "quiet encroachment of the ordinary" (2013, 80). This is the point where the two dimensions form a vicious circle: the migrant needs to become an urbanite to be a legitimate member of the city. However, in her or his life based on informality, integrating into the city and adopting an urban identity becomes even more challenging.

This dilemma is intensified by the rigid, normative understanding of urbanity by the elite establishment. However, as Kemal Karpat observes, while the migrants integrate into the city and adopt urban values and ways of living, the city also adopts some elements of migrants' culture, such as when folk culture brings dynamism and colour to the urban atmosphere (2009, 137–164). Appreciating this fact would result in flexibility in the 'prescription' of urbanity towards new possibilities that encompass multiple, alternative urbanities.

p. 228–229 The authors of the seven novels analysed in the previous chapters were addressing these problematics through a wide range of themes. In her periodisation of *gecekondu* (shanty) studies, Tahire Erman describes the 1950s and the 1960s as the era of "'the rural Other'" (2001, 3). This perception is explicit in both *Birds* (1962) and *Oxen* (1973). Their messages are also compatible with what Erman describes as the tendency of the 1970s: "the disadvantaged other" (2001, 3). In *Birds*, Orhan Kemal focuses on the question of urbanity within the framework of the good migrant–bad migrant opposition. The stereotype of the opportunistic, immoral migrant striving 'to make it big in the city' is present in the novel, together with the decent, hardworking migrant who is trying to adopt an urban identity. The process of urbanity Kemal envisions is compatible with the expectations of the elite establishment: it is based on what Murat Belge describes as "the rationalism and enlightenment of a Westernist-progressivist stance" (1994, 223). If we apply Karpat's terms, Kemal follows the formula where the migrant changes in the city, yet the city does not change with the migrant. That said, the novel's messages differ from the elite view in a crucial way. Within the hierarchical perceptions of the class-based society, the elite establishment will see the migrant as an inferior member of the city even after she or he is urbanised. Kemal takes a clear stance against this perception, placing strong emphasis on the migrant's potential to be an equal member of the city as part of the proletariat.

p. 229 Urbanisation of the migrant is not a major issue in *Oxen* where the protagonist is in the city temporarily. Muzaffer İzgü concentrates on the relationship between peasants and that entity called 'the state' through the question of citizenship. He does not give a prescription for urbanisation, nor does he present any ideal migrants: the migrant characters in the novel who stay in the city fit the corrupt migrant stereotype in various ways. As İzgü does not propose urbanisation as an ideal, he does not question the definition of urbanity, hence the novel's unclear message on whether it is possible for migrants to integrate into the city without losing their values. The migrant characters in the book learn to be selfish if not cunning in the city. The city takes the positive aspects of their feudal values but does not really offer new values in response. When this fact comes together with İzgü's positive approach to life in the countryside despite all its challenges, it is possible to find in this work a preference for rural over urban life for the peasants of the country (i.e., potential migrants).

When we come to the 1980s with *Hills* (1984) we are able to see what Karpat summarises as a mutual change between the migrant and the city as well as the implications of alternative urbanities such a process might lead to. Latife Tekin does not reflect this stance simply through characterisation or story but by utilising elements of folk culture such as laments, riddles and songs of the oral tradition. With such a style, as Saliha Paker points out, Tekin writes this novel in "'a language of the deprived', one that gives expression not only to their way of life but also to their outlook on life, perception of reality, sense of humour and dreams" (2004, 12). Doing that, Tekin accentuates the possibility of alternative urbanities where migrants can preserve various elements of their folk culture. She does not offer a prescription of urbanisation, just invites her readers to think beyond the existing paradigms and the prescriptions regarding urbanity. p. 229–230

Roman(i) (1995) is a novel where the issue of urbanity is central and problematised in a highly unique manner. In this work, Metin Kaçan, who can be regarded as a second-generation migrant, depicts an opposition between migrants who could become urbanites and those who could not. Kaçan makes it clear that migrants or children of migrants are urbanites as long as they appreciate what the city offers to them. This message of the book is notably connected with its setting: Kolera, a 'deteriorated neighbourhood', a 'slum' or the 'inner-city' for those who prefer this euphemism. Kaçan creates this stigmatised poor neighbourhood, just a two-minute walk from the Pera district, as a universe where diversity is at its highest. The legacy and the remnants of the non-Muslim minorities, to whom the neighbourhood belonged in the past, is a central characteristic and value of Kolera. Dwellers who enjoy the diversity here have a strong attachment to their neighbourhood. The cosmopolitan solidarity in Kolera encompasses prostitutes, drug addicts and petty criminals as long as they are loyal to the Kolerite identity and the values of the community. The elaboration of the Kolerite identity as an urban identity is at the very heart of the book through the portrayal of its protagonist Gıli: a (second-generation) migrant who, in his own way, appreciates the city as *oeuvre*, admiring its old buildings, churches, cobblestoned streets at every turn, and the diversity it offers. Gıli lives in a state close to what Lefebvre describes as inhabiting the city. p. 230

During the period from the middle of the 1980s to the middle of the 1990s, as Erman observes, shanty dwellers were perceived as "'the urban poor Other(s)' versus 'the undeserving Other(s)' and 'the culturally inferior Other(s) as sub-culture'" (2001, 3) in shanty studies. References to this perception are clear in *Hills*. Since *Roman(i)* is not set in a shanty town, Erman's observation is not entirely relevant to it. Yet, the perception she observes is in many ways valid for migrants in poor neighbourhoods of the city centre, such as Kolera, as well.

In *Periphery* (2003), which is mainly set in the late 1990s, the early decades of migration and shanty life are illustrated through flashbacks. In the 1990s, when the story is set, the urbanisation of the migrant is no longer a widely discussed topic. As the shanties no longer exist, the tendency for describing them as villages in the city, and migrants living there as peasants in the city, is no longer present. As poor-quality apartments replaced the shanties after the Amnesty Acts of 1984–1987, in the public perception the former shanty towns became the *varoş*, a pejorative term used to describe periphery neighbourhoods. Erman, writing in 2001, defines the perception in shanty studies in the late 1990s as "the threatening/*varoşlu* [*varoş* dweller] Other" (2001, 3). In other words, the problem of legitimacy hidden in the divide between urbanites and rural migrants becomes more explicit at that period as those living in the periphery are almost de facto denied legitimacy, since they make those at the centre of the city feel threatened. In *Periphery*, Ayhan Geçgin lays emphasis on the lack of opportunities for migrants, mostly second-generation, to be a part of the life of the city centre. He illustrates how migrants living in the peripheral former shanty towns feel disconnected when visiting the city centre due to the lack of social networks and mechanisms such as leisure centres, cultural and sportive associations, and community centres that could incorporate them into the centre. When migrants living in the remote parts of the city try to experience life in the city centre by their own means they are worried about being perceived as "the threatening/*varoşlu* Other". Although Geçgin focuses on the periphery inhabitants' need for opportunities to socialise in the city centre rather than this problem, in the way he depicts the city as a grim and unwelcoming place it is possible to find reference to such discriminatory discourses as well. p. 230–231

In *Kinds* (2008), set in the 2000s, we see references to the "threatening/*varoşlu* Other" with migrants as members of the lumpen proletariat. In her novel, Meryem problematises the imposition of consumerist values on these poor people isolated on the periphery. The protagonist is a realistic portrayal of a shanty-town woman, now living in an apartment that replaced the shanty, who strives to urbanise through consumption. p. 231

Consumerist aspirations of women in shanty towns as a way of adopting an urban identity was a significant phenomenon during the shanty period. Female shanty dwellers suffered from being subjected to "a consumption oriented value system which leads to endless cravings, unsatisfied desires, alienation from one's own class" (Şenyapılı 1981, 207). During that period, female shanty dwellers got a glimpse of the lives of the middle class in the houses they went to clean. In the former shanty towns of today, however, they are constantly exposed to the middle-class apartments that are within walking distance. In the Istanbul of the 2000s when the novel is set, shanties exist no more and gated communities border on many of the former shanty towns on the fringes of the city. In addition to that, income inequality is greater today than it was during the shanty period in the earlier decades of migration. All these render the mentioned cravings much more difficult to handle. p. 231–232

p. 232 Hatice Meryem places a shopping mall at the centre of *Kinds* as a symbol of consumerism, and of urbanity. This mall is used by the youngsters of Kozluk as a place for socialisation. There is no neighbourhood soul, no cosmopolitan solidarity. Yet Meryem does not depict this as leading to nihilism; instead she accentuates migrants' and their children's perseverance to survive in the city against all odds. As she ends her novel at the top of the Bosporus Bridge with the migrant characters enjoying the stunning view, she brings them from the periphery to the centre of Istanbul; and revering all the hardship they endure she implies their legitimacy in the city with their own modes of urbanity.

In *Strangeness* (2014), the final novel of the corpus, we meet a migrant protagonist who tries to inhabit the city in his own unique way. Mevlut is an idiosyncratic character, a migrant who is in love with Istanbul. He does not have a concept of strolling through the city like a *flâneur* does; however, he does spend his life strolling through the city as a street vendor. He enjoys these strolls so much that even when he has other occupations to earn a living he continues vending for pleasure. Pamuk portrays Mevlut as a character who adopts an urban identity that is not prescribed, and probably would never be imagined, by the establishment. He is a migrant who values the beauty and heritage of the city to the extent that many of the old urbanites would never be able to do; in this sense he is more of an urbanite than those who claim the right to decide who is an urbanite and who is not, and who is a legitimate member of the city and who is not. The author Orhan Pamuk, a member of the elite segment of the established urbanites of the city, who until this work depicted the lives of people with similar backgrounds to his own, sometimes with a tone of nostalgia, sometimes not, places a deep devotion to the city at the heart of his output. Presenting this devotion to the city as it is felt by a migrant in *Strangeness*, Pamuk suggests the possibility of alternative, multiple urbanities; and by doing that he approaches the legitimacy issue in an inspiring manner.

p. 232–233 However, in the novel, Pamuk does not disclose his stance on newcomers to the city like internally displaced Kurds or foreign migrants. These new arrivals encounter a much more hostile atmosphere where life is far harsher than it was for the rural migrants a couple of decades previously. In the contrast between the migrants of the past and the migrants of today an implicit exclusion of these new migrants can be felt in the novel. Mevlut, who is portrayed as a migrant who becomes an urbanite, therefore a new Istanbulite, feels alienated when he sees the new migrants who have come to the city after the 1990s and the 2000s at a time when shanty towns with a cosmopolitan solidarity are only a memory, and gross income inequality is worsening each passing day. Pamuk ends the book where its protagonist observes these unfamiliar people with concern, yet without implication as to their potential to be legitimate members of the city. As the reader looks at them through Mevlut's eyes, they seem almost destined to be the outsiders of the city no matter how much they strive to get out of the urban poverty trap.

p. 233 Before moving on to the correlation between the problem of legitimacy and migrants' survival strategies, a brief note on the gender dimension of the urbanisation process might be useful. The closure of *Birds* is set during the demolishing of the shanty town where the protagonist Memed and his wife Ayşe live, ending with Ayşe's words to her devastated husband as he stares at their shanty in ruins: "we will build again, we will build another one!" (372). It is an important detail that, in the novel, these words manifesting migrants' determination to stay and survive in the city are uttered by the migrant woman, very much in line with Berktay's description of women as the "locomotive of migration" (2019, minute 93). In *Strangeness*, Mevlut's daughter, Fatma, is the one who has a higher education rather than her male cousins. Again in this novel, we are introduced to a migrant woman who admires the rhythm and liveliness of the city which she experiences on her way to the middle-class houses she cleans. In *Roman(i)* some women in Kolera are outdoors as much as men. These are women with Kolerite identity, which is an urban identity, while the wives of first-generation migrants who are 'locked' indoors are portrayed as peasant women. In *Periphery*, Geçgin emphasises that, in the urban context, not much changes in the lives of migrant women who must exert themselves to the utmost to meet the expectations of patriarchy. Tekin realistically illustrates in *Hills* how urban life encourages women to be vocal about their needs, for instance emotional needs such as love and sensuality, and how difficult it is to achieve any sort of gain in this regard. She also addresses consumerist obsessions in the urban context, accentuating women's vulnerability in this respect. Similarly, in *Kinds*, Meryem successfully depicts migrant women's manipulation by the apparatuses of consumer capitalism in their aspiration to adopt an urban identity.

p. 234 As outlined above, on the other side of the problem of migrants' legitimacy lie their survival strategies. During the mass migration era, rural migrants in the city predominantly met their needs such as housing, employment and transport through informal methods. As discussed earlier, Bayat defines such strategies as "reclamation, by the poor people, of public space through encroachment" (2012, 120). Migrants also made pragmatic use of politics (Karpat 2009, 44). They were well aware of the value of their votes which they utilised to access resources, such as obtaining municipal services for their shanty towns. A third way for the migrants to meet their needs in the city was urban movements. The shanty movement was a perfect example of that. As Şükrü Aslan explains, there were shanty towns formed by left-wing groups in addition to those where the radical left was strong (email comm., 2 July 2016). However, their number was quite low, considered from the macroscale. Shanty dwellers chose radical action with the support of leftist groups only when their usual methods yielded no result (Karpat 2009, 200). As Karpat observes, the migrant population of shanties did implement collective action, but this was mainly by using networks and political participation (43–44). Kıray describes this utilisation of networks as "clientelism" and stresses that it was a significant tool for migrants in

meeting their needs (2007, 185). Consequently, migrants were labelled opportunists. However, Karpat contends that strategies labelled as such were inevitable given the hostility of the security forces, established residents of the city and, at times, the media against migrants (2009, 43). Informality and concomitant clientelism and opportunism made the problem of migrants' legitimacy more complicated. This was a vicious circle: the more hostility migrants faced, the more they had to adhere to opportunistic strategies, and the more they did that, the more hostility they faced.

This issue of migrants' survival strategies in the city is realistically addressed in the right to the city novels. Factually, migrants predominantly followed the strategy of quiet encroachment; they made use of political participation and clientelism; and sometimes they became involved in urban movements when these channels were blocked. The authors of the analysed novels depict these strategies in line with the real experiences rather than creating alternative scenarios that could be read as a call for action.

In *Birds* (1962), informal housing comes to the fore as an important theme. In this book, there is a realistic depiction of shanty demolitions. Here, in the shanty town dwellers' resistance to the demolition, a reference to historical shanty movements can be found. Shanty housing appears in *Oxen* (1973) as a setting without much elaboration of the issue as a theme. In both books, informal employment on building sites is the main form of work for migrants. In *Hills* (1984), Tekin creates the shanty town as a parallel universe through a magical realist style. Here, the collective action of the shanty dwellers in their demands for municipal services has weight in the story. In the novel, Tekin sarcastically illustrates the radical left's interest in and approach to the shanty dwellers with the intention of incorporating their collective action into an organised political movement. She lays emphasis on the Left's failure to find a language that would not alienate the shanty community. Like *Hills*, *Roman(i)* (1995) is set during the highly political 1970s, and contains references to the left-wing groups' efforts to politicise the inhabitants of Kolera. Some members of the neighbourhood sympathise with left-wing views, yet these tendencies do not culminate in radical action. In *Periphery* (2003) migrants who arrive in the city during the mass-migration period are employed formally in the industrial sector. Yet, since these factories do not supply their employees with workers' estates, the housing need is met informally through shanties. In *Kinds* (2008), formal employment is almost a dream for the characters: in the entire Kozluk there is only one person whose employer pays her social security taxes. In this work, Meryem realistically addresses shanty dwellers' belief in democratic participation in the protagonist's brave encounter with a politician visiting the neighbourhood, as she complains to him about the infrastructural problems. Vending on the streets, the most common form of informal employment and a perfect example of quiet encroachment as conceptualised by Bayat, is at the centre of *Strangeness* (2014). Shanty-building and shanty life are also depicted in detail throughout the work. Pamuk realistically addresses the political polarisation between shanty towns in the 1970s, particularly with the portrayal of the clash, in April 1977, between the imaginary shanty towns of Duttepe and Kültepe: the former dominated by right-wing Sunnis, and the latter by left-wing Turkish and Kurdish Alevis. In the work there is also a reference to the 1st of May Neighbourhood, a shanty town established under the leadership of leftist groups in the second half of the 1970s in Istanbul.

p. 234–235

Consequently, the novels do not convey the message that migrants in the city are a potential force who can change urban life through urban activism. In all the works in the corpus, informal strategies based on quiet encroachment—primarily, encroachment on land by building shanties—are at the centre of migrants' lives. Such strategies complicate the legitimacy question: as migrants rely on illegitimate means of survival, they are regarded as illegitimate members of the city. This point is present in all the analysed novels with varying degrees of explicitness.

p. 235–236

The legitimacy issue took a more complex and problematic form after the 1990s. As Erman observes, the inhabitants of the former shanty towns started to be regarded as "the threatening/varoslu Other" (2001, 3). This stigmatisation becomes stronger with each passing day as the increasing income inequality worsens the isolation the poor experience. The times that Nurdan Gürbilek describes as "the climate when urban poverty was not yet associated with danger or crime, but with innocence" (2005, 64) are long gone.

p. 236

In this book, I have attempted to explore a certain philosophical concept, namely the right to the city, in the space between art and life, tracking it in the selected corpus of novels. As Marc Augé points out, "art has to express society [...] but it has to do it deliberately. It cannot be simply a passive expression" (2008, xxi). Augé adds that if art aims to show something beyond what people see in their daily lives and through the media, then "it has to be expressive and reflexive" (xxi). Meeting these migrant protagonists and following their experiences in their respective story worlds offer us insights which we cannot gain by direct observations in daily life or by following the news. Augé adds that the artist tries to "manage this gap between expression and reflexiveness" (xxi). Analysing these novels, I have tried to dissect how each author attempted to achieve managing this gap in her or his work.

Finally, I would like to add from a cultural materialist perspective that, while the social context influences cultural and artistic products, the opposite is also true: these products also influence the social context. While a concrete analysis of reader response would require surveys and in-depth conversations with a representative group of readers, it is possible to have some ideas on reader response simply through observable facts. These facts can give us an idea on how literature mediates reality.

p. 236–237 In *Hills* and *Roman(i)*, two powerful novels based on insiders' experience, migrants speak for themselves. Latife Tekin and Metin Kaçan, writing these acclaimed books, proved that migrants were not simply the labour force in the city, that they could also be part of the urban social fabric as novelists, or as other types of artists, who could paint a unique picture of urban life. In this sense, they proved the possibility of multiple/alternative urban identities with their work as well as with the way they are as individuals. *Periphery*, which is also based on insiders' experience, is an intriguing work in this category. *Hills* and *Roman(i)* are the voice of the voiceless, with their characters inspired by people with no formal education. The knowledge of life in these books comes from experience. In *Periphery* we see a combination of this insiders' perspective with knowledge that comes from formal education.

p. 237 *Birds* has always been one of the most popular texts about rural–urban migration in Turkey. *Oxen* has also been received with interest: it has been reprinted eight times over the course of thirty-five years, and was adapted into a television drama in 1979, six years after its first publication.[1] Both books offered an opportunity for readers to empathise with rural migrants. In *Kinds*, Meryem brought the subject of '*varoş*' to the literary agenda. Telling the story of two women living on the periphery, she invited her readers to question the dominant stigmatising and discriminating discourse about the so-called *varoşes* and their people.

Strangeness, like all Pamuk novels, has aroused interest both at the national and the international scale. Until this work, Pamuk was an author who wrote about old Istanbulites. With this book, he made an unexpected move by putting a new Istanbulite, a rural migrant, at the centre of his work. The primary message of the book is that rural migrants, who were despised by old Istanbulites for having invaded the city, could love and appreciate and therefore belong to Istanbul in a way that many old Istanbulites would never be able to. Certainly, one with a cynical perspective can find a 'snobbish modesty' in this gesture, and argue that Pamuk, as a genuine Istanbulite, finds in himself the authority to decide who belongs to Istanbul and to whom it belongs. To defend Pamuk against such an argument is beyond the scope of this book. In any case, whichever way one views it, the participation of a character such as Mevlut in the pantheon of Pamuk's fictional characters is an important step in the fight against anti-migrant prejudice.

p. 237–238 In sum, addressing the migration experience from the perspective of migrants, authors of these novels render them visible and encourage feelings of empathy in their readers by depicting why, how and under which conditions migrants try to cling to the city. They also invite their readers to question the nostalgic discourse which correlates all urban problems with the arrival of migrants.

p. 238 Rural migration is no longer a social phenomenon in Istanbul, but the city today attracts migration in different forms. Towards the end of the 1990s, Istanbul started to receive international migrants: from the Turkic Republics, from Africa, Armenia and so forth. Since 2013, the arrival of Syrian refugees in the city has become the most important topic related to the issue of migration. In other words, today there are new 'non-Istanbulites' in the city facing harsher conditions than those experienced by rural migrants in earlier decades. If reflecting on the right to the city novels can help us view contemporary urban life through the perspective of the right to the city, it will be rewarding not only for those who face these increasingly harsh conditions but for all of us.

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[1] The television drama series *Uncle Halo and Two Oxen* was screened on Sundays on TRT (1979), to the great interest of televiewers. Kamran Usluer acted the role of Halo, while Rüştü Asyalı acted the role of İdiris in the series (Vardan 2004).

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p. 239

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p. 227

Index

p. 241
A
Ağır Roman (*Heavy Roman(i)*), 134
alienation, 14, 16, 23, 27–31, 50, 51, 163, 164, 175, 186, 192, 198, 231
anomie, 30, 51, 192, 200
Aslan, Şükrü, 55, 56, 127, 216, 234
Augé, Marc, 236
B
Bakhtin, Mikhail Mikhailovich, 83, 89
Bayat, Asef, 53, 54, 205, 206, 209, 212, 228, 234, 235
Belge, Murat, 122, 123, 125, 156, 207, 208, 229
Benjamin, Walter, 23–26, 181
Berci Kristin Çöp Masalları (*Berji Kristin: Tales from the Garbage Hills*), 119
Berger, John, 126
C
Çiçekoğlu, Feride, 95
citizenship, 15, 23, 37, 38, 74, 87, 102–104, 107, 112, 113, 229
consumerism, 23, 24, 185–188, 201, 232
cosmopolitan nostalgia, 1, 2, 76
cosmopolitan solidarity, 51, 143, 157, 171, 191, 192, 200, 230, 232, 233
cultural materialism, 10
D
deteriorated neighbourhood, 150, 151, 205, 211, 212
E
encroachment, 54, 205, 206, 234, 235
  quiet encroachment, 54, 56, 205, 206, 209, 228, 234, 235
p. 242
Erder, Sema, 4, 5, 7, 13, 14, 66, 67, 69, 70
Erman, Tahire, 53, 56–58, 60, 65, 68–70, 74, 82, 123, 125, 129, 228, 230, 231, 236
Ertan, Kıvılcım, 55
existentialism, 27, 31, 36, 175
F
flâneur, 14, 26, 27, 174, 175, 181, 207, 208, 232
G
Geçgin, Ayhan, 16, 163–165, 167–172, 175, 178, 181, 183, 198–202, 231, 233
gender (women), 14, 99, 107, 114
Genette, Gerard, 98
Goonewardena, Kanishka, 31, 35, 36
Gurbet Kuşları (*The Homesick Birds*), 81
Gürbilek, Nurdan, 236
Güvenç, Murat, 3
H
Halo Dayı ve İki Öküz (*Uncle Halo and Two Oxen*), 103
Harvey, David, 7, 24, 25, 31, 34, 172
Higgins, John, 10

I
informal employment. *See* vending
informal housing. *See* shanty housing
informality, 14, 17, 72, 228, 234
inhabiting the city, 13, 135, 230
İnsan Kısım Kısım, Yer Damar Damar (*It Takes All Kinds*), 16, 163, 183
internally displaced Kurds, 14, 70–72, 232
İzgü, Muzaffer, 15, 81, 103, 104, 106–109, 112–116, 229
K
Kaçan, Metin, 15, 119, 134–136, 138, 139, 141–146, 149, 150, 152–158, 230, 236
Kafamda Bir Tuhaflık (*A Strangeness in My Mind*), 205
Kemal, Orhan, 15, 81, 82, 86, 90, 99, 113, 116, 152, 209, 228, 229
Kenarda (*On the Periphery*), 163
Keyder, Çağlar, 65, 66, 68–70, 72–76
Kıray, Mübeccel, 46, 51, 54, 57–59, 186, 187, 192, 234
Koçak, Orhan, 86
L
Lefebvre, Henri, 6, 7, 14, 23, 30–36, 38, 39, 82, 145, 157, 193, 227, 230
M
magic realism, 121, 122
Marcuse, Peter, 7, 10, 36
Marx, Karl, 6, 29–31, 173
Merrifield, Andy, 6, 33
Meryem, Hatice, 16, 163, 183–186, 189–202, 231–233, 235, 237
N
narratology, 13
nihilism, 51, 155, 232
O
oeuvre, 6, 17, 31–34, 39, 145, 153, 157, 158, 205, 209, 218, 225, 230
Öncü, Ayşe, 3, 65, 66, 72
oral culture, 15, 52, 86, 87, 105, 115, 121, 123, 124, 133, 139, 154, 183
Orhangazi, Özgür, 45, 47
Örs, İlay, 2, 76
Özbek, Meral, 51, 123
P
Paker, Saliha, 125, 229
Pamuk, Orhan, 17, 205–209, 211, 214–220, 223, 225, 232, 233, 235, 237
periphery, 4, 7, 13, 16, 51, 73, 74, 136, 146, 163, 166, 168–170, 174, 176–178, 181, 183, 185, 197–199, 202, 210, 211, 216, 231, 232, 237
Pérouse, Jean-François, 3–5, 189, 216, 217
R
radical left, 14, 55, 123, 126, 127, 129, 134, 155, 234, 235
right to housing, 55, 83, 102, 115, 127, 129, 157, 179, 181
right to the city, 5–7, 9–17, 23, 31, 32, 34–36, 39, 53, 56, 61, 82, 83, 102–104, 107, 113, 116, 119, 121, 127–129, 134, 135, 145, 153, 157, 158, 163, 175, 177, 182, 183, 193, 194, 198, 201, 205, 209, 221, 225, 227, 236, 238
right to the city novels, 1, 7, 10, 11, 13, 17, 227, 234, 238
Ronneberger, Klaus, 6, 32
rural to urban migration, 103

p. 243

S

Sassen, Saskia, 37, 38, 44, 48, 53, 56, 112, 135

Saunders, Peter, 28, 29, 43, 44

Schmid, Christian, 31

Secor, Anna, 113

Seeman, Melvin, 30, 175, 192

Sennett, Richard, 5, 29, 30, 53, 120, 133, 151

Şenyapılı, Önder, 49

Şenyapılı, Tansı, 46, 47, 49, 58, 59, 186, 231

shanty housing, 44, 65, 69, 73, 167, 171, 190, 210, 211, 235

Simmel, Georg, 14, 27–29, 180

socialist realism, 93

T

Tekin, Latife, 15, 119–134, 154, 155, 158, 229, 233, 235, 236

Tester, Keith, 26, 27, 174, 175, 207, 208

Tuğal, Cihan, 73, 74

U

urbanisation, 12–17, 43–46, 49, 52, 54–56, 60, 82, 89, 96, 100, 101, 103, 104, 114, 116, 121, 123, 126, 129, 133, 134, 139, 144, 154, 156, 157, 186, 187, 228–230, 233

urbanity, 5, 15, 29, 43, 44, 51–53, 103, 109, 121, 123, 125, 133, 138, 155, 158, 186, 191, 227–230, 232

alternative urbanity, 134, 138

p. 243–244 urban transformation, 1, 12, 15, 17, 33, 66, 75–77, 92, 102, 149, 150, 153, 173, 205, 212, 215, 220–222, 224

p. 244 **V**

varoş, 16, 74, 120, 184, 191, 192, 197, 198, 231, 237

vending, 53, 54, 206, 232, 235

W

Williams, Raymond, 10, 11, 29, 102, 142

Wilson, Elizabeth, 43, 44, 59, 96

Wittgenstein, Ludwig, 86

women, 14, 16, 47, 52, 56–61, 71, 85, 87, 92, 94–97, 99, 100, 103–107, 110, 114, 115, 132, 133, 137, 139–141, 154, 156, 167, 168, 178, 185–189, 191, 194, 199, 201, 218, 220, 231, 233, 237

Z

Zürcher, Eric Jan, 65, 67, 216

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